All She Gives (Not Enough)

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by n7punk

Summary

Catra made it through undergrad with a night job, but now that she is in law school, she has expenses she can't keep up with. It will be worth it once she gets her degree, but in the meantime she has to find a way to pay for her tuition. Escort work is risky, but it pays well. Retiring from music hasn't given Adora the privacy she was hoping. Between fans and gold diggers, she constantly has people *throwing themselves at her*. The idea of paying a stand-in just to avoid the rumour mill and come-ons from guys seems like it could be a viable solution - and then she runs into her childhood best friend at an event.
(Escort Catra/Sugar Mommy Adora AU – Also kind of a fake relationship AU)

The Proposal

Chapter Notes

I did it, it's happening. I have 0 shame about this, so don't try. Normally I give some set-up details here, but for this one, everything will revealed with time.
SUNY is State University of New York. NYU is New York University.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora gets a text from her mom. She considers not checking it. The entire reason she gave Hope her own ringtone was so she could be forewarned to not look at a message from her on a day she couldn't handle it. With a rough sigh, she pulls her phone out of her clutch, keeping her gaze fixed out the car window. Right before an event isn't an ideal time to have an interaction with Hope, but if Hope is texting her *now*, it might be important.

Have you left already?

Adora scowls at her phone, typing out a *yes*. She is twenty-five, she really doesn't need Hope still micro-managing her. This is part of why she *left* the music industry. Also the fact that she hated every second of the spotlight and the immense pressure was going to bring her an early grave, but her extremely-attentive manager and adopted guardian didn't *help*.

Mermista will be at the event, as will Hordak. Watch yourself.

Why Hope asked makes more sense now – she wanted to make sure Adora was already on her way before warning her. Even halfway to the event already, Adora considers telling Frosta to turn them around.

"Frosta, how far are we?" she sighs, looking up to the front seat of the Rolls Royce. Frosta pauses in the front seat, tilting her head back to listen to her.

"Twenty minutes to the press entrance," she tells her. She sounds a little apologetic, which is as close to coddling Adora as her personal assistant ever gets. Adora sighs, glaring at her clutch as she slips her phone back inside.

"Huntara waiting there already?" she confirms. Frosta nods in the front seat. Adora slumps in her seat. She can't bail on a charity event anyway, but considering they are almost there and her bodyguard is waiting, she just feels trapped. It will be good to see Mermista again, but the rumours about the two of them were *just* starting to calm down. With her and Sea Hawk

broken up – *again* – she doesn't doubt the top story in Hordak's unscrupulous tabloids will be about how they are making eyes at each other.

Five years retired, but the rumours never stop. Adora is still glaring at her phone when Hope's next message comes in.

Have you given any more thought to my proposal?

Adora turns her phone on silent and slips it back in her clutch. She has, and she has decided for and against it at least a dozen different times. Tonight is definitely going to put her back in the *for* column.

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Catra has been an escort for three years now, but this is her first hate-client. She isn't sure she can even call it that as she watches Mermista's gaze catch on her ex's back. Despite the small *ugh* of disgust she releases, her eyes light up and her scent is clearly interested. Mermista had been blunt when she hired her, saying she wanted someone to keep her company and show her ex the kind of person she wanted to date – someone responsible, who knew how to behave in polite society, apparently.

If they aren't back together in two weeks, Catra will return her fee. Well, no, she would never do that – but she won't have to, because she is *right*. When Sea Hawk spots them, the actor's eyes light up and he hurries over towards them. Mermista tightens her grip on Catra's arm and Catra pointedly turns them to walk a few feet over to the gaggle of people that has cropped up around Mermista's latest producer.

Mermista gives off a satisfied air as Sea Hawk stops in the middle of jogging over to them, looking crestfallen as he finally registers that Mermista is hanging off someone else's arm. The arm of someone significantly shorter than her, sure, but Catra is dressed nicer than Sea Hawk and she knows for a fact he is a *millionaire*, so she considers it a power move still. She turns her attention away from him as Mermista's producer greets her and begins introductions with the group.

He doesn't bother introducing Catra. Wearing a full suit and real tie instead of the *bandana* Sea Hawk is sporting doesn't make her actually matter. She is here as a buffer and a distraction – and as another attempt by Mermista to affirm to the public that she is in fact bi, even if she has been dating a man long-term. The rant she gave Catra in the car had been long, but also relaxing. Catra has to pretend to be a lot of things for her job, so it is nice when she can just relax and be herself a little with a client, and especially be *queer*.

Mermista seemed to enjoy her bitchiness, at least. Catra figured she would, or she wouldn't have busted it out. She hasn't been doing this for three years for *nothing*. She has a good eye

for what a client wants. Being an escort has, without a doubt, made her a better lawyer. She has learned to read people, a skill she already had but has *perfected* since she began the work, and she has grown comfortable in a variety of situations.

Mermista taps on her arm, prompting Catra to push up her shirt sleeve so Mermista can glance at her watch.

“Hm, she should be here by now. You know Adora Grayskull?” Mermista questions, raising her line of sight to meet Catra’s eyes. Through years of training, Catra does not let her eye twitch, expression impassive as she nods. “She probably got trapped at the front door. Go fetch her for me. Tell her you’re with me,” Mermista tells her, clear dismissal as she drops Catra’s arm. Catra nods, giving a short bow before she turns to find *Adora*.

Catra didn’t look up the event before agreeing to this job – she knew if Adora wasn’t going, she could take it comfortably, but if she *was*, Catra wouldn’t have been able to make herself accept the job. Catra is in her final year of her J.D. She needs the paycheck from this event to pay for her tuition. She has done some uncomfortable things for her job before, and running into her ex-crush shouldn’t rank that high on the list, but of the uncomfortable things she knew about in *advance*, it is pretty much at the top.

There is always the chance Adora won’t recognize her, Catra comforts herself as she slips through the crowd. If she hadn’t known for the last fucking *decade* that Adora had forgotten about her the moment she got adopted, that thought wouldn’t be a comfort, but she already knows she was unimportant to the girl she was in love with. What she wouldn’t be able to stand is Adora recognizing her and still putting on a PR smile.

Mermista’s prediction was accurate. Even with the rich and famous attendees at the charity gala, Adora draws a crowd. Being the youngest person to win *Album of the Year* kind of makes her a big center of attention, even with her retirement five years ago. Catra draws herself up, projecting uninterested confidence as she walks past the gaggle forming around Adora. She ignores every single one of them, focusing in on Adora as she sweeps up to her side.

Adora spots her a half-second before Catra meets her eyes, raising an eyebrow in challenge as she offers her arm without greeting. It is a powerplay – everything *is* with crowds like this. Adora’s eyes widen slowly, her pupils blowing out even as confusion clouds her expression. Some part of her recognizes Catra, which honestly *floors* her considering the decade of radio silence and the coloured contact she is sporting. Clearly she isn’t sure of her recognition, though. Catra clears her throat as the dozen people surrounding them watch on in interest.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra greets, because if Adora can begin to recognize her even with two yellow eyes, then maybe her voice will be enough to push her over into realizing who she is. The moment Catra echoes her old flirtation, Adora’s eyes widen further, her breath hitching as she takes Catra’s arm without hesitation.

“Excuse me, gentlemen, I have an old friend to catch up with,” Adora says, almost as an *afterthought*, not looking at anyone but Catra. Catra manages to keep her tail from lashing, throwing the group a smirk to show just how *collected* she is as she pulls them away. Adora follows, still staring at her. Catra doesn’t know *why*. Yes, her appearance here is undoubtedly

surprising, but Catra doesn't know why Adora bothered to even remember what she looked like.

"A contact?" Adora asks, her voice low, as Catra leads them. Catra's fur wants to stand on end for some reason as she glances over, intending to make quick eye contact but catching Adora staring at her pupil that should be blue. Adora nods, seeming to have confirmed to herself that she is right. Catra knows if you look close enough at her eyes it is possible to spot the ring of blue peeking out from the edge of the contact, as well as the slight difference in shade and texture from her truly yellow eye. Catra clears her throat, looking forward again.

"Yes, and it's *Cyra*, okay? Mermista sent me to fetch you," Catra tells her. Adora startles a little, turning to stare at her, but Catra has caught sight of Mermista again, so she ignores her. Mermista didn't stay put, and she is talking to her *ex* now. Catra is glad Mermista didn't even question her policy of being paid at the beginning of the night. Letting her get cornered by the ex she is trying to teach a lesson – even if she sent Catra away first – is the kind of thing a bitchy client would call a *failure of services*. Catra has her policies for a reason.

At her side, Adora lets out a long breath as she spots Mermista.

"Thanks for not saying her name in front of the crowd. She's a good friend, but – there's rumours about us," Adora says, a little sheepishly. Catra flicks an ear in acknowledgement. Yeah, she knows. Unlike Adora, she kept up on what her *best friend* was up to after Adora got adopted and Catra was left to flounder in the foster system on her own.

Mermista spots them, glancing down at their intertwined arms and looking *amused*. She raises her eyebrow as Catra drops Adora's arm and returns to Mermista's side. She sends Sea Hawk a challenging look as Mermista takes up her arm again. Sea Hawk looks a bit deflated, but at least Mermista looked like she was having fun before Catra showed up to rescue her.

"I fetched her for you, darling," Catra tells her, in the sweet voice she perfected in high school that Adora *used* to know meant fuck you, but who knows, because it is convincing as hell at this point if she says so herself. Adora is a little flushed, her gaze still locked on Catra, though she looks *calculating* rather than wide-eyed now.

"Figured you were getting swarmed. Thought I'd send rescue, but I didn't think you'd take my escort for yourself," Mermista tells Adora, seeming amused. Her voice is low so as not to be overheard, but Catra still feels a ball of dread in her stomach. She can't take watching Adora realize what she does. It is a fucking charity event, but she isn't a charity *case*. It is a job. *Her* job.

Adora's eyes go wide at the same time that Catra narrows hers at Adora. She looks away, not wanting to see whatever *pity* blooms there. She knows the perception of her night job, but she makes good money, enough to pay for law school. She doesn't need Adora, with all her unlimited money and fame, suddenly feeling sorry for the girl she left behind without a care.

"Rule number two of hiring an escort is not telling people that's what they are," Catra points out to Mermista, her own voice low. Mermista snorts with amusement, sending Catra a glance.

“Adora helped me put my *bush* out when it caught fire. She’s cool,” Mermista says. Catra blinks, because *what*, but part of her job is not asking questions, regardless of how badly she wants an explanation for all that. She could also point out Sea Hawk is, at best, five inches away from her and definitely heard that, but he also doesn’t seem *surprised*.

Catra was hired after he embarrassed Mermista one too many times in public, meant to be an example for the kind of behaviour she was “actually interested in”, but apparently Mermista meant for him to quite literally watch and learn. Catra moves up her mental timetable on them getting back together to the next forty-eight hours.

In front of them, Adora clears her throat. Catra has undergone a lot of training, largely under trial by fire, in remaining impassive, but she can’t hide her slight wince – at least not to Adora. Her ex-best friend zeros in on the twitch of her ears and tail immediately.

“Where are you seated, Mermista?” Adora asks, despite the way she is still looking at Catra. Mermista seems amused, glancing between the two of them. She probably just thinks her friend has the hots for her date – she couldn’t be more wrong. Catra puts on a stunningly impassive bitchface. If she has to deal with Adora for the *entire event*, this is going to be the hardest she has ever had to work for a paycheck in her life.

“Near the fountain in the middle. Not all of us get front row,” Mermista says, with a vague wave of her hand. Adora deflates and Catra barely bites down on her sigh of relief.

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Adora should be more subtle, probably. It is going to be all over the tabloids how she couldn’t keep her eyes off Mermista, but the truth is Adora has hardly looked at her friend *once*. No, she has been far more focused watching Catra – or *Cyra*, tonight. Adora had recognized Catra immediately and felt a bit *insane* given her eyes and hair were wrong. It wasn’t until she was able to look closely and see the contact that she truly knew.

Adora hasn’t seen Catra since she was fifteen. The day Hope came to the foster home, looking for the orphan who went viral for a sixty second clip of her singing, Adora was swept away into another world. Despite not realizing her true feelings for her friend until they were apart, Adora has been hung up on her ever since.

She barely gets a few minutes with Catra - impassive and polite, not acting like *herself* - before they are being called away for the ceremony. It is Adora’s own fault for showing up so late, but she hadn’t wanted to socialize. She only steps into the limelight again for charity events like this and she wanted to minimize her exposure. She intended to show up, greet a few people, sing her song, and leave.

Instead, she spends the entire ceremony taking any excuse to glance back in Mermista’s direction. Catra is professional. Adora can tell because there is hardly any trace of *Catra* in her as she plays the perfect gentlemen for the entire night, chatting with Mermista during the

lulls and intermissions, casually fending off others attempting to make conversation with the bored actress, and maintaining an engaged expression throughout the entire night.

Her ears aren't twitching as people talk. She isn't actually interested, but only someone versed in magicat behaviour would be able to tell that. *Adora* knows – the only times Catra's ears twitch with interest is when Mermista makes a comment. True smiles ghost across her face then. Catra *would* get along with Mermista – at least the Catra that Adora knew ten years ago would – but seeing it causes a painful pang in her chest.

When it comes time for Adora to stand up and sing her slow ballad that earned her the Grammy for *Song of the Year* – the song in the style of her entire discography, and the absolute last thing she would include in her personal musical taste – Adora has to keep her eyes fixed on the front of the crowd. If she saw Catra making that faux-interested expression in the face of her performance, no matter how much she dislikes the music herself, Adora doesn't think she could take it.

She looks when the song is finished though, as she takes her polite bow and reminds the audience the importance of the cause. Catra's ears are pricked forward, though Adora can't see her expression from here. Adora swallows as she departs the stage. The rest of the night is *torture*. As part of the ceremony, she has to hang back and give one last endorsement to the cameras. When she is finally free, she can't spot Mermista or a pair of familiar ears amongst the crowd. Adora deflates, but she hurries towards the entrance now she has confirmed that Catra is already gone.

"You look even worse than I was expecting," Huntara greets when Adora rejoins her event bodyguard. Huntara doesn't give a shit and that is why Adora likes her. Huntara has said she may be her favourite client because she never has to coddle her. She's a lot like Frosta in that regard. Adora has been careful to cultivate an group of people who are more likely to avoid her for her status than seek it out.

"The tabloids are going to be terrible," Adora returns, already opening her clutch to pull out her phone as Huntara escorts her back out to the limo. There are reporters waiting, there always are, but Adora ignores them. Huntara just grunts affirmation. Her entire job is protecting Adora from the reporters and fans. She knows just how rabid they can be.

Adora doesn't dare to pull up her conversation with her mother until Huntara has seen her into the limo, waving goodbye to her through the window as Frosta peals away from the venue. She doesn't need anyone catching a photo of what she is about to send and printing it.

I've thought about the proposal. I'll do it.

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Catra peals out her suit the moment she gets back to her dorm. Stupid mock trials and fucking *archaic* legal precedents that haven't been used in decades would absolutely get overturned in a real courtroom, but *no*, Mr. Simmons lets it stand in the classroom and declares her case lost. Catra is growling to herself as she changes into sweats and doesn't even bother with a shirt. She is so *frustrated*. She knows what she needs right now, but she wouldn't even be thinking about it if it weren't for last weekend.

She hasn't crawled into Adora's lap after a long day to receive pets and scritches behind her ears in a decade, but one stilted conversation with her ex-friend and Catra is craving it. She puts her hair up in a ponytail and flops down on her bed, yanking her laptop into her lap and ignoring the itching under her fur. Checking her website while she is already in a bad mood is probably a bad idea, but right now she actually *wants* a handsy client, if only to feel some contact, even if it won't be real affection.

No one has ever had affection for her, though. She *thought* Adora might feel the same when they were kids, but the second she got swept off to the glamour of NYC, she didn't give enough of a shit to even call Catra. Sometimes handsy clients make her skin crawl – other times she just accepts it as the closest thing she is ever going to get to feeling wanted. *Loved* is a dream that died a decade ago. She knows these thoughts aren't healthy, but even with her night job, she can't afford fucking *therapy*.

She can hardly make her tuition payments as it is. Her website is subtle and understated. It is possible to look at it with an innocent eye and not realize what she truly does. Well, it would be if the majority of her clients weren't referred to the site by the agency she pays to list her in a private database, where clients know the truth. Publicly, she advertises minder services for events, offering to watch and corral clients who might get swarmed by others or get a bit too drunk for their own good.

Until you get to the booking form, there isn't even mention of her one-on-one services. She is an escort, but she doesn't need *creeps* coming to her, and if what she does becomes public knowledge, it risks undermining her legal career before it even gets started. She covers her most defining feature and uses a fake name, but she still has to be *careful*. It is a balance between advertising enough to get work and not getting caught. She hasn't gotten any new offers since the charity event a week ago.

The best part of her job is how well it pays – the worst part is how *sporadic* that pay is. She kind of needs another client in the next few days, or she might not have enough for her tuition payment, even with the ridiculous amount Mermista paid her. Catra made a nice profit, but NYU is expensive, and having to pay for the terrible salon treatments to tame her mane to human hair standards for the press cut into what she banked. Hell, Catra is willing to take DT again at this point, and she turns down half their bookings.

Catra opens her inbox and breathes a sigh of relief when she sees an offer there. A one-on-one, which won't pay as well as an event, but it will be lower stress-

She catches sight of the name on the booking.

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Part of Adora wonders if Catra is even going to show up. She hadn't seem interested in talking to her at the event, and despite Adora purposefully leaving parts of the booking form blank, she never reached out for clarifying details before accepting the appointment. Granted, she had less than two days to do so, but Adora still left a lot of blanks barring her phone number and heard nothing. She already put two hundred dollars down as a deposit, and even though that is only a tenth of the full price waiting for Catra should she show, it might be enough.

It would certainly be a clear *fuck off*, and Catra always loved dramatics. Adora got her contact information from Mermista the day after the event while Mermista ridiculed her mercilessly for getting hot for her escort, but that was far from the truth. Well, okay, Adora has been hot for Catra *always*, but she also never thought she would get to see her again. She can't let this opportunity slip through her fingers.

Despite Adora's worries, Catra arrives exactly ten minutes before their "date" is supposed to start. She seems wary as she is led into Adora's private room in the back of the restaurant. She is wearing suit pants and a black satin button down, a bowtie undone loosely around her neck. At the event she had been wearing shoes – a red flag to Adora - but now she merely wears formal black stirrup socks.

It makes Adora relax a little, to see Catra in something closer to what she used to be comfortable in. She is dressed appropriately fancy for the restaurant, a slate waistcoat buttoned over her shirt, but one of the blanks Adora had left was *Desired Attire*. She smiles hopefully as she rises from her seat, the hostess giving a short bow as she quickly backs out of the room to give them a private moment.

"It's good to see you," Adora tells Catra, cautiously stepping forward within *hugging* range. She has no idea what the protocols are for this. Catra is wearing her contact again, though her hair is merely tamed with a brush and not thoroughly *treated* like it had been at the event. Adora can see calculation in her gaze as Catra appraises her before she raises her arms.

Adora breathes a sigh of relief as Catra hugs her. It makes warmth flood through her chest, a relief she hasn't known in years.

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The restaurant is stupid fancy, Catra figured that out from a quick google – a search she had to do given that Adora provided *no dress code*. Adora has one of the private rooms with a fucking *balcony* overlooking the street below. The door to the balcony is firmly closed and the gauzy privacy curtain is drawn over it. Someone on street level might be able to tell there are people inside the room, but that is about it.

Catra has no idea what to *do*. She hasn't felt this unsure since her first client. It isn't just because she is meeting with Adora – she has been given next to no instructions. Adora lit up like a goddamn Winterfest display when she saw Catra enter the room. She went to *hug* her. Catra allowed it, partially because Adora is paying her *two grand* just to have dinner with her, and partially because, alright, she *missed* it.

No one has really hugged her without the pressure of watching eyes or trying to grope her since undergrad, when she actually had friends. She still keeps up with Scorpia over the phone, but they are in different cities now, and Catra misses true affection. Adora pulls back from the hug beaming, all innocent happiness.

Catra has no clue why Adora would hire her after not attempting to reach out for a decade, but from the plainly joyful expression on her face, she suspects that Adora just wants to catch up. It was the only theory that really made sense anyway. They were friends before Adora became richer than god. She is probably sick of the way people treat her now and looking for something *down to Earth* or some bullshit.

"Please, have a seat. Take a look at the menu. We can catch up once we've ordered," Adora tells her, confirming Catra's suspicions. Catra straightens her shoulders a little, nodding as she slips into the appropriate persona for the evening – herself, dialed back a few degrees. Catra may be bitter, but she can bury her feelings and work for her paycheck. She can pretend to be whatever vague recollection Adora has of the "friend" she left behind. Adora, to her surprise, *frowns*.

"Don't do that. I want it to be us. No bullshit," Adora tells her as she returns to her own seat, a plush chair directly across from Catra's at the table for two. Catra, despite herself, feels her tail twitch. She could keep it up. If she drops the persona, she might end up just cursing Adora out, and she can't risk that before she has collected her fee. Adora continues to surprise her, sending Catra a pleading look when she doesn't relax for her.

"Why the fuck did you hire me, Adora?" Catra has to ask as she slides into her seat, unable to hold it back any longer. It has been *ten years* with no phone call, no lyrics vaguely directed at her, no allusion to missing someone in the press. Catra would watch interviews hoping for a hidden sign Adora never *gave*. She can guess that Adora is sick of fame leeches and shit – she basically said as much in her retirement announcement – but Adora isn't ready to deal with *no bullshit* Catra anymore.

No bullshit Catra is hurt and *angry* at being utterly abandoned by the one person she thought actually gave a shit about her, much less saw her for who she was. She raises an eyebrow, expecting Adora to take back her *no bullshit* immediately. To her surprise, Adora lights up, smiling as she relaxes back into her seat.

"For *that*. How has your week been?" Adora asks, smiling easily. She is *really* smiling, not the fake PR smile Catra usually sees her give. Catra shifts a bit uncomfortably as she flips open her menu if only to have something to do. She is good at this because she is a good actress and liar – she hadn't anticipated Adora wanting honesty, and she is not sure she really remembers how to *give* it.

"*Good*," Catra finally responds, despite how it is a lie. Adora frowns, deflating a little. Catra sighs, looking away. That was supposed to be a test – and Adora was supposed to fail it. She was not supposed to actually want honesty, or to be able to tell that Catra wasn't giving it.

Catra accepted a long time ago that fame had changed Adora – she never reached out to Catra after she got adopted, she gave fake smiles to every camera, and she dressed in clothes that cost more than a *car*. Catra isn't sure what to do with the knowledge that despite everything, Adora still knows her. She wasn't willing to call, but she apparently hung onto the knowledge of her tells for some reason.

"What do you really want from this? The request was *blank*, Adora. I know you must have no idea how this works, but usually I'm an unlicensed therapist for my clients that will also stroke their egos," Catra tells her, carefully looking to the left at a gently swaying plant decorating the corner of the room. It is an orchid, healthy and vibrant. Fuck, this must be the most expensive restaurant she has ever been in.

There is a moment of silence.

"I want to catch up. I never thought I'd see you again. We can talk business after," Adora says, softly. Catra's eyes snap to Adora. There is a lot to unpack there. What *business* Adora wants to talk probably should be at the forefront of her mind, but *I never thought I'd see you again* is ringing far too loudly in her ears for any other thoughts.

"You know there is a solution to that, and it was trying to reach out even *once* before I turned eighteen. You knew where I fucking lived, Adora," Catra tells her, slumping back in her seat a little. Adora's eyes go wide and Catra flinches. She hasn't even collected her fee yet, despite her policy being upfront payments, and she let her bitterness get the best of her.

At least the deposit will more than cover her cab ride back – she is probably going to be forced to call one in the next five minutes when Adora decides this isn't what she wanted. She already decided she didn't want Catra once anyway. Catra wasn't really expecting things to be different this time around. Adora swallows, staring at her with blatant surprise.

"I *did*," Adora protests, her voice a little weak. Catra stills, her gaze boring into Adora's as she searches for the lie. She doesn't find it. Adora just looks *sad*. "A few weeks after I got adopted, Hope let me call Shadow's. She told me that you got in trouble after I left and were transferred to a home for *troubled youth.* She couldn't legally give out details because you were a minor," Adora explains, her voice a little unsure, almost like she doesn't believe the words she is saying anymore.

That absolutely sounds like a lie Shadow would tell, but Catra can't believe that Adora just accepted it unless she *wanted* to find a reason to leave Catra behind. Catra never did anything to earn the vitriol that Shadow directed at her. She broke Shadow's rules, but so did Adora, and she never broke the *law*. She started off as a good kid – it was the unearned punishments that turned her into a *problem child*.

"You fucking fell for that? I was there until I aged out at eighteen, Adora," Catra asks, despite how she knows it isn't *fair*. Adora was always gullible. Adora's expression crumples, and

Catra's breath stops short when she sees tears have pricked at the corner of Adora's eyes. She forces herself to draw in a deep breath and blow it out slowly.

They were fifteen. Adora didn't really have any choice but to believe Shadow. It is just easier to *stay mad* than to deal with the fact that both of them were powerless back then. Adora had a family, money, and fame after she was adopted, but Catra has suspected for a long time how much – or rather, how *little* – agency Adora gained when she got out of Shadow's group foster home.

"I assumed she pinned something on you so she could get rid of you. She went on a racist rant about how she was glad she didn't have any hybrids in her house anymore. Hope wanted me to put everything behind me. Sell the *rags to riches* story the tabloids were already eating up. She let me call because she knew I missed you, but once she heard you were gone, that only made things easier for her. Everybody was telling me you were gone," Adora tells her. Catra blinks at her across the table as her tail *thunks* heavily against the seat.

It still hurts – it is going to keep feeling raw for a long time, Catra suspects, but Adora did *try*. Adora thought about her, *wondered* if she would get to see her again. Catra has been mad at Adora for loving and leaving her for ten years. Not an ounce of that anger dissipates with Adora's words, but Shadow is really the one to blame, and she is who Catra should be angry with. Catra swallows, sitting forward in her seat.

"Let's try this again?" she asks, her voice quiet. Adora looks a little heartbroken still, but she nods. The damage has been done – it would be hard for it to go away in one conversation after a *decade* of feeling this way – but the hurt is a little eased, and now she knows Adora reached out, she wants to take the chance to talk to her again. She can work on shifting her anger to the appropriate target later.

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Catra's attitude towards her makes a lot more sense now they have cleared the air a little. There is definitely more to catch up on there, but Catra has actually *relaxed* now. They pick out their meals together. When they have both chosen something, Adora trying to subtly encourage Catra towards the lobster and feeling satisfied when she agrees to try it despite cringing at the price tag, they ring the bell for the waiter so they can deliver their orders.

As the waiter leaves with their menus under his arm, Adora pulls out her phone, laying it on the table so Catra can see her screen without asking as Adora sends the rest of the payment over using her banking app. Catra flushes as she does so, but she nods and leans back in her seat as Adora slides her phone away into her pocket.

"Tell me what you've really been up to the last ten years?" Adora requests, trying to move past the awkwardness of how she set up this meeting. They are going to get there eventually – even worse, they are going to get to her proposal eventually – but for the moment she really

just wants to meet the girl she lost a decade ago. Catra's ears twitch, her cheeks dusted pink, but she launches into an abridged explanation.

"I was at Shadow's for most of high school. I turned eighteen before graduation and ended up in a homeless shelter until college, but I was able to go to a SUNY upstate for free. I fell into the political science program somewhere along the way," Catra explains. Adora nods, their conversation falling into a lull as their waiter arrives with the complimentary opening dish for while they wait for their real meals. Catra's eyes goes wide when she realizes it is crab cakes.

Adora specifically picked this place because of its amazing seafood, in addition to the privacy. She grins at Catra as she pops one in her mouth. Catra rolls her eyes, but she practically *melts* when she takes a bite herself, a purr beginning in her chest that has Adora gasping and Catra blushing furiously.

"*Not a word*," she hisses, flustered, even as she takes another bite. Adora mimes zipping her lips shut, but she can't help and *stare* at Catra, relaxed and purring with contentment across from her, eyes blown out as she blinks slowly, looking between the food on the table and Adora. Adora knows that happiness is for the delicate crab cakes, but she is willing to let herself have a brief delusion.

"Tell me about undergrad," she requests, because she certainly doesn't want to ask about Shadow's, and Catra's website mentions she is a law student under her *conversation topics* header. Catra pauses, taking another bite as she considers it.

"The SUNY was kind of miserable, but my roommate turned out to be my best friend. We roomed together all four years and keep up over the phone. I took an obscure political elective freshmen year and somehow that just turned into my major. By junior year I was looking into law school after graduation since political science doesn't have a lot of job opportunities, but, well, I needed money to pay for it," Catra explains with a shrug. Adora nods, trying to keep her expression neutral. From the way Catra shifts uncomfortably and looks away, she knows she fails. Adora leans back in her seat. She had begun to lean on the table as Catra talked, naturally swaying closer to her.

"You're comfortable? And safe?" Adora has to ask. Catra scowls a little, still looking away as she folds her arms, her tail wrapping around herself. The tip of it is twitching.

"I can more than defend myself, Adora. I have rules, and if a client doesn't respect them, that's why I make them pay up front," Catra tells her. Adora hates that answer because it means that clients *haven't* respected them in the past, but she already knew that was an inevitability in this line of work. Catra's claws are extended and catching the dim mood lighting in the room where she is gripping her crossed arms. Adora sighs.

"Some of the charities I work with are dedicated to supporting sex workers, Catra. I know it is a job, even if I worry about the risks," Adora offers, as diplomatically as she can. She doesn't know if Catra even goes that far with clients, but she would bet some clients have *tried*. Besides, if Catra is willing to agree to her proposal at the end of the night, it won't matter. Catra sniffs, her tail thudding once against her chair.

“I know you, Adora. I don’t need *saving* or whatever else you’re thinking right now. This line of work has the best pay for the lowest time commitment, and the hours don’t conflict with my classes. I don’t want pity. I’m happy with my job,” Catra tells her, shrugging a little with her arms still crossed. Adora winces. The thing is, yes, part of Adora is trying to get Catra to quit, but she also very much *isn’t*.

Adora has been miserable for the last decade, but she has more money than she knows what to do with, and she feels guilty that Catra has had to deal with unwanted come-ons from clients while Adora was settled in her penthouse. She feels *worse* knowing Catra thought Adora had just forgotten about her the moment she was adopted. Still, she isn’t coming at this from a place of a judgement. The idea was there before she even met Catra again.

“I never said you weren’t happy? Look, I didn’t exactly know how else to get in contact with you. This isn’t- I’m not trying to *save* you, Catra, I’m trying to hire you,” Adora returns. She knows the judgement Catra has to have faced about her job, but she would have thought the fact that she had *already* hired her for the night would make it clear she wasn’t judging her for that.

Catra’s ears and tail twitch. She finally turns her head to look Adora in the eye again, her expression *confused*. Adora can see the disbelief written across her face.

“I don’t believe you,” Catra tells her, expression challenging. It isn’t ideal, but Adora feels herself smiling as she relaxes in her chair again. Despite not believing her, Catra is not defensive now, although she seems confused by Adora smiling.

“I missed the hell out of you,” Adora explains, shaking her head a little, all *fondness* but she doesn’t care how obvious she is. “We’ll catch up, eat dinner, and then we can talk about what I actually want to hire you for, okay? If it makes you uncomfortable, you can just leave then,” Adora offers, gesturing at the table between them. In truth, she couldn’t stand scaring off Catra so soon, but she also doesn’t want to make Catra feel trapped. Catra considers her for a long moment.

“Fine,” she agrees with a sigh, like she is doing Adora a favour. Adora just beams at her.

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There is no reality in which the Adora she knew would actually be okay with defining Catra as a sex worker in her head, but it *has* been ten years. Catra thought fame had changed Adora, but even if it turns out Adora isn’t a stuck-up prick who forgot her, there are still differences. As they talk, Catra sharing stories from undergrad and law school while Adora gives anecdotes of the moments from her life that didn’t make it into the tabloids, Catra discovers a more disillusioned Adora than she once knew. She is far from cynical, but the absolute innocence she had at fifteen is gone.

Maybe that should be expected, but her innocence managed to hang on through all the abuse they endured as kids, so it still surprises Catra. None of the stories Adora offers have anything to do with her three albums. Only one even takes place at the studio. Just as Catra doesn't mention her night job, Adora doesn't mention her *day* job.

"Tell me about what you do now," Catra prompts softly, as dinner is winding down. Adora blinks in surprise, pulling out of the reverie of the story she was telling about the day she did a photoshoot on a farm. No part of the story is about the photoshoot – she was mostly gushing about all the animals she got to pet that day. Catra remembers that photoshoot. Adora was about nineteen when those photos were published and Catra felt jealous over the *goat* Adora was holding in a more candid-style shot.

Adora pauses, glancing out the covered balcony doors. The lights of the city at night can still be seen through the thin curtain. Eventually, she sighs.

"I don't want to complain, so I'll just say – I hated it. I was on a ten-year contract, split into three and seven years for when I turned eighteen. I didn't want to sign the seven-year one. Hope managed to change it to an overall five-year contract since I was a minor when she signed the ten-year contract for me. The idea was that I could finish my third album and then decide. Back then, I worried Hope might turn me onto the street if I rejected it," Adora tells her, shrugging. Her expression is conflicted, bitter and guilty.

Catra's entire job is to comfort and assure clients, even when she just wants to tell them to go fuck themselves. She comforted a manager on a dinner date once when he was upset because an employee that he fired called him a *bloodsucking leech*. Catra agreed with the employee, but she needed her paycheck, so instead she slid a hand onto his chest and purred to him that he was doing what was good for the company. In this moment, though, she doesn't want to offer empty comfort, because she is *angry*, and not at Adora.

"That Hope bitch exploited the hell out of you," Catra tells her. She has thought it ever since the manager showed up looking for the orphan going viral, especially seeing how miserable Adora seemed over the years, but now she has it *confirmed*. Adora startles, turning to look at her with wide eyes. After a moment, Adora relaxes into her seat again, shrugging a little, but at least the guilt is gone from her face. She didn't want to complain about being famous.

"Maybe. She knew what she was doing when she set up my earnings trust to release at twenty-one instead of eighteen, but- she was a decent mom, even if the industry sucked. She could have easily kept the money for herself. I mean, she made plenty off of me, don't get me wrong, but so many child stars get *nothing*," Adora tells her, shrugging. Catra scoffs, but she doesn't push it. It is still exploitation, but Catra knows there are far worse ways Adora's life could have gone. Still, she has a realization looking at the resigned expression on Adora's face.

"I didn't ask what you used to do, Adora. I want to know what you do *now*. What makes you happy," Catra settles on saying. Adora lets out a breath, sending Catra a look bordering on thankful before taking another bite of her food, stalling as she thinks her response over.

"The part I *did* like was the charity work. I also gained a lot of experience from managing my own career, especially over the last two years when I was able to set boundaries with Hope.

Now I work for an organization that helps private companies and large donors find charities to work with. We help them decide who donate to and how much of the donation budget they get, arrange event organization, do their PR promotion, that sort of thing. The charity gala last weekend was one of ours," Adora tells her, shrugging.

Catra knew Adora's official job title, it made its way into the tabloids, but it was the *why* she wanted to know. Adora released a public statement saying the charity work she has managed to do over the years impacted her and lead her to this career change, but Catra knew there was a deeper story to it. Adora finding it as the one bright spot amongst all the stress makes sense.

"I fell into political science because of what we went through in the system. I wanted to change it," Catra says, quietly, offering a piece of herself in exchange. Usually when she does this it is carefully curated and not necessarily truthful, but this is Adora. Adora's expression softens as she nods at her from across the table.

"And now? What do you want to do with your law degree?" Adora prompts her. They have shared plenty of stories, but they weren't really talking about the future, just how they ended up where they are now. Catra pauses, looking down at her empty plate. Adora's is basically empty too – they are just talking now, all courses finished with the possible exception of dessert. Technically, dinner is over. It doesn't feel like stalling, but it probably is.

They have relaxed a lot over the course of dinner. Catra has suspected in the past that Adora wasn't given a choice in contacting her, either by Hope or by Shadow, but often she pushed it aside in favour of bitterness. It was easier to be mad than to acknowledge how hopeless their positions had been. Now she has it confirmed, she finds talking with Adora surprisingly easy, despite her bitterness and the matter of *business* hanging over them.

"At first, I wanted to fight the system from the inside, but those cases don't pay well, and they're depressing. I switched to focus on civil suits. I graduate with my J.D. in May, but since I changed focuses, I want to go for an extra year to get my Master of Laws degree so I can really focus in before taking the bar," Catra tells her, shrugging. She expects it to go flying over Adora's head, but she seems to follow well enough, nodding along as Catra speaks. Catra shifts a little in her seat. They could keep talking all night probably – which is the *last* thing she expected when she walked into the restaurant a few hours ago – but Catra has a question still.

"What is the business you wanted to talk about?" she asks. Adora immediately winces, looking off to the side. Her eyes catch sight of the bell to call the waiter and light up.

"Do you want dessert?" she asks, already leaning for the bell. Catra scoffs.

"No, and you're stalling," Catra returns. The fact that most desserts are heavy in sugar and thus *inedible* for her hardly registers on her list of reasons for declining. Adora sighs, dropping her hand to instead fidget with her fork.

"You know I get proposed to a couple times a year? And the amount of guys who hit on me thinking they'll be the *exception*- just don't get me started. The tabloids are the worst part. I can't have lunch with a friend without there being all these predatory articles written about us

together," Adora rambles, waving her hands vaguely. Catra cocks her head, looking between Adora's waving hands and her pinched brows. Adora catches her expression, flushing and looking away. She draws in a deep breath.

"I want to pay you to be my girlfriend," she finally admits.

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Catra is staring at her. Adora flushes harder, hunching down in her seat a little. There are a thousand ways to word it that don't make it sound like *that*, but Adora kind of got caught up in herself this evening. It sounds like she means it because she *does*. She and Catra still click the way they used to. The whole thing was supposed to be fake, at least it was when Hope proposed it, but now Adora is envisioning more than a few public dates.

Now, the idea of Catra kissing her because she is *paid* to is almost bad enough to outweigh how badly she wants to kiss Catra – but it isn't, and she is still making the offer. Catra is just *staring* though, all but gaping at her in surprise.

"Like, a sugar mommy thing? I can't date anyone – I have yet to find someone who actually gave a shit about *me*. I know the speculation about my love life will never stop entirely, but it is starting to affect business now. There were rumours about a charity getting a grant because I was sleeping with their director. I've never even *met* her, but the media found out she was a lesbian and decided she was my type. That was an uncomfortable meeting with my boss," Adora explains, slumping a little in her seat. Catra is still staring at her. Adora bites her lip.

"I'm *not* trying to save you, that's not what this is. The idea of hiring someone was floated during a PR meeting, and then I ran into you, and- I wasn't comfortable with it, but I could be with you. I'd pay you each week and you would still have plenty of time to focus on your studies," Adora tries. All she knows to do is dig herself deeper into a hole as she waits for Catra's reply.

Catra finally manages to close her mouth, which had fallen open in shock. She is still staring at Adora though. Adora fidgets with her napkin, laid across her lap to cover the expensive dress she is wearing. Looking down is easier than looking at Catra. All she can hope is that when Catra says no she is still willing to talk to her again. Maybe they can go the rest of their lives without mentioning the time when Adora was so desperate to stop the media from hounding her that she tried to pay Catra to kiss her in public.

"You can't act to save your life, Adora. You barely manage a PR smile. How the hell do you think this would work?" Catra asks. Adora flushes, chancing a glance up to find Catra still staring at her, but at least the shock seems to be wearing off now, even if the confusion hasn't faded.

"I *know* I can't act, that's why it has to be you. Someone I actually click with. I would be dating *you*, not Cyra with a contact lens and whatever the hell you did to your hair at the

charity gala. You would have to take down your website or the media would find it, but I know a hacker who can take care of it," Adora explains, still fidgeting, but watching Catra's face closely. Catra flushes, her ears twitching as she quickly looks away. Her tail thuds once against the side of her chair.

"You know this just sounds like a ploy to get me out of sex work, right?" she returns. Adora pauses. At least Catra doesn't sound mad.

"You know I'm hiring you *for* sex work, right?" Adora shoots back. Catra huffs, sending her an annoyed glare. For some reason, seeing Catra's ears pin back in defiance relaxes Adora. Catra isn't calling her a creep at least, even though she is having to dig this hole even deeper just to get Catra to believe her. Catra bites her lip, narrowing her eyes out the window.

"I'm not saying yes tonight," she settles on saying. Adora lets out a slow breath, nodding and forcing her body to relax. It isn't a no, and moreover it isn't a *get out of my life*.

"You have my number. Think about it. If you're interested, we can meet up at my place to talk details. And-" she cuts off, her gaze darting away as she takes a breath to rally herself, "- I've missed you a lot. I want to be friends again, even if you don't want to do *that*," Adora tells her, looking back at Catra sheepishly. To her disappointment, Catra's ears fall.

"I use the contact and the fake name to avoid people knowing about this once I start practicing, Adora. If I was spotted with you, people might still find my website no matter how I'm dressed. I'd be ruined before I even took the bar," Catra tells her. Adora does her best to stamp down on the heartbreak that flares at that, but she knows she fails from the way Catra winces.

"Right, of course. I don't want to do anything that endangers your future," Adora manages to agree, though she has to force it out in her business voice, which only makes Catra's ears pin back. Adora looks away, glancing towards the clock on the wall as she does so. She kind of wants to go to her car to cry now. They have had dinner, she said her piece, and it might break her heart to know this could be all she gets, but Catra has right to worry. The stigma about this kind of thing can be career ending.

"Adora, I do want to talk again, it's just- hard with the media," Catra tells her, softly. Adora lets out a slow breath, her gaze still fixed on the clock.

"Trust me, I know. That's the whole reason I ended up here. I can't trust *anyone* to actually want something to do with me. The best I have is other celebrities, but even then you don't know if they're just trying to boost their own careers until it is too late," Adora returns, bitterness in her voice. Catra is *right*. She forces down her unwarranted hurt. If Catra can get over thinking Adora abandoned her, she can accept the real reason Catra is turning her down.

After a moment more of gathering herself, Adora looks back to Catra. Catra looks unsure and conflicted. Adora sighs, reaching for her purse to pull out her phone.

"Let me call you a cab and walk you out? It's getting late. My driver has probably been here for the last hour," Adora offers. Catra relaxes, nodding a little as they both stand.

Adora follows through, paying for Catra's cab as it pulls away and waving her off with anxiety rioting in her chest. She knows *a* way to get in contact with Catra now at least, and Catra has her number.

Adora just has to hope she will call.

Chapter End Notes

I promise Hope doesn't totally suck, Adora just has a complicated relationship with her adopted mother, which will be explained more throughout the fic. Everybody is an unreliable narrator in their own way lmao.
I'll be updating like 2-3 times a week I think.

The Arrangement

Chapter Notes

> Adora's stupidly fancy penthouse, though she has repainted/redone the wallpaper to make the space brighter. No I didn't spend an hour on youtube watching penthouse tours, what are you talking about. Pretty sure Youtube thinks I'm trying to move back to NY now.
> Also Adora's birkenstocks. Birkenstocks dyke gang rise up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra is supposed to be sleeping. She has class at eight in the morning, AKA in *six hours*, and yet she is staring at the ceiling of her dorm, wondering how the fuck she got *here*.

She relaxed a lot throughout dinner. Shadow lying about her being transferred away makes perfect sense – Catra can practically hear her sneering about how Catra couldn't be kept in line without Adora around to *tame* her. She is bitter, but she can direct that energy at their old guardian. Forgiving Adora for that shouldn't be too hard given how much she has clearly hated fame. It didn't change her, not really – but it *hurt* her.

Which brings Catra to the thing actually keeping her awake. The *proposal*. The worst part is that on the surface it makes *sense*. Adora's love life has been the center of massive tabloid attention ever since another celebrity – a rising star looking for a way to boost her name – got close enough to earn her heart and then sold pictures of them kissing to the tabloids. Adora was dragged out of the closet in front of the entire world, and though homophobia may be an old and dying mindset, it was still violating.

Hiring a stand-in to always be there, someone the tabloids can photograph leaving her apartment, could work as a way to exert some control over the rumours, even if nothing will stop them completely. Adora choosing *her* makes sense, even if part of Catra felt like she was being slapped in the face when Adora said it. They knew and trusted each other before all this, they were best friends and clearly still click well, and Catra is *already* a sex worker.

The part where it all falls apart is the fact that Catra has been in love with Adora since she was eight. That's where the metaphorical *slap* comes in. She was totally in love with Adora, then left by her, and now Adora is asking Catra to fake a relationship with her. Catra is *trying* not to be mad about the radio silence, even if she knows she wouldn't have accepted Shadow saying bullshit like that if she had been in Adora's position. Just because Adora didn't want to abandon her doesn't make it easier to kiss the love of her life knowing it means nothing.

How much does Adora even want from this? Press photos, a date to events, and Catra changing her relationship status? She said *sugar mommy*, and Adora may have always been naïve, but Catra refuses to believe that Adora doesn't know what that means. Fuck, if Adora

wants to pay Catra to *actually be her girlfriend* just because she doesn't think she'll have something genuine with anyone else-

That might be beyond her capabilities, both to go through with and to *resist*. Catra stares up at her ceiling, her eyes watering, and realizes she never took out her contact lens. She growls at herself, giving up on sleep at least temporarily to flick on her lamp so she can take it out in the mirror. Her roommate doesn't even stir at the light as Catra pads over to their small mirror, her eye stinging. If her feelings for Adora make this whole plan fall apart, *this* is where it starts to put itself back together again.

Catra has had to claw a client before, though only once. She has had to *threaten* to use her claws more than that once. She does this as safely as she can, and she is confident it is the only job she could have that would cover the expenses of law school without putting her in massive debt, but that doesn't mean she hasn't been put in uncomfortable situations before, such as *every job* for a male client she has taken.

Catra has a sliding scale of how much she allows a client to have contact with her or how far she will go with them, based entirely on how comfortable she is with them, but she can already picture the relaxation of being able to throw that scale away. She certainly wouldn't need it with Adora, regardless of what she ends up asking of Catra.

Catra lives in fear of someone recognizing her and exposing her night job. She changes her hair and covers her most distinctive feature, but she can't do much about her face or the rarity of magicats in this country, even if the city is big enough to have a small population of them. She is already worried about being discovered as is. If she doesn't take Adora up on her offer but tries to have her in her life again, she doesn't know how she would function around the paranoia of the paparazzi finding her site.

Unless, of course, she *does* take Adora up on her offer. She could take down her website and not have to worry about it haunting her in ten years. There will always be the clients who could attest to what she used to do, but it would be hearsay. She could hang out with Adora without fear, and she would have consistent income without having to worry from one week to the next. She knows Adora could pay for her tuition comfortably.

Catra sighs as she drops her contact in the solution without much thought. The idea of never having to put it in again – it is so fucking *tempting*. She only has a year and a half left if she commits to her Master, plus actually taking and passing the bar. She has been comforting herself with how all this is almost over, but two more years isn't all that *almost*, and if it could be over today-

It would be worth kissing Adora, even fucking her, and having it mean nothing to her. Catra groans as she drops back down into her bed. She already knows what she is going to do, damage to her heart not an effective enough deterrent to turn the offer away. Sometimes she hates how fucking pragmatic she can be, but this isn't even pragmatism – part of her just wants to feel Adora against her, no matter how Adora feels about it.

Now to just *try* to sleep until it is a reasonable hour to call Adora.

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Adora gets a call from an unknown number on her lunch break and almost doesn't answer it. It is to her personal phone – her *actually* personal phone, that maybe a dozen people have the number to. She shouldn't be getting unknown calls to it. Part of her heart says *Catra*, but it has barely been twelve hours since Adora saw her off in a cab, so she kind of doubts she is reaching out so soon. Adora sighs, putting down her fork, and answers the call. She can't risk it.

"Adora?" is the unsure greeting that has Adora drawing in a sharp breath. She has never heard Catra's voice over the phone before - they certainly didn't have the money for cellphones in high school - but all the airwaves do is flatten it a little. The voice is still familiar, engrained in her heart.

"Hey. I didn't think you'd call- well, maybe at all, if I'm honest, but certainly not so soon," Adora says, a little breathless and rambling, but she really *didn't*. Catra makes a light sound, one that is rather distorted by the phone speaker, but Adora would guess it is an embarrassed chirrup. Catra huffs as if to cover the sound.

"I would have to be crazy to say no. I just needed to convince myself of that. We need to talk about it though," Catra returns. Adora flushes, suddenly relieved she took her lunch alone in her office today instead of meeting up with Glimmer and Bow. She didn't want them asking what had her so preoccupied – she certainly isn't going to go around shouting *I found my best friend and she is an escort* – but now she is just glad no one can see her face for this, because she can feel it twitching. *Catra is taking the deal*. Adora feels hot all over, her hands a little shaky with the realization this is actually going to happen.

"My penthouse is secure. I can send a car to pick you up. The parking garage is private, and there is an elevator from there," Adora assures. Catra lets out a slow breath.

"As much as I want to say no to a *driver* – fine. I'll take my website offline during my next class break just in case, but it will still be there until we actually talk details and I delete it," Catra agrees. That knowledge definitely isn't helping Adora to calm down her body's weird reaction, but the show of faith makes her heart soar.

"Text me your address and I'll send it to my assistant. Frosta will pick you up. She's young, but you can trust her. Does a seven o'clock pickup time work for you? I'll have dinner ready for when you arrive," Adora offers, already shifting her phone from her ear so she can text Frosta she'll have another job this evening after she takes Adora home.

"Yeah, that works. Don't overdo it, okay? I really want to just be able to talk," Catra agrees.

Even over the phone, Adora relaxes.

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Catra hadn't known what to do when she walked out from the lobby of the grad student dorms to find a fucking *Rolls Royce* waiting for her. The girl driving only looks at her long enough to confirm she is picking up the right person and then blasts metal music for the entire drive. She takes them straight to SOHO, pulling into the underground parking garage of a building that looks a little unassuming, but Catra also knows the price tag has to be hefty given the neighbourhood and the *private elevator* Frosta calls down for her.

Adora is waiting for her in the foyer when the doors slide open, bouncing on her toes a little and beaming. Unlike the last two times Catra saw her, she is wearing jeans and a t-shirt, nice quality but nothing approaching the designer dresses she has been wearing. Her hair is down and she is wearing glittery metallic Birkenstocks. *This* is the Adora Catra remembers from high school.

Catra steps out of the elevator, already raising her arms. Adora lights up, moving to hug her firmly and just a *little* too long for a casual greeting, but – it has been ten years and Catra was definitely reluctant for their last embrace. When they pull apart, Adora doesn't step back, just dropping her arms and grinning down at her.

"I fixed us tilapia, because it's pretty much the only fish I know how to cook. We can talk while we eat?" she offers, peering down at Catra. Catra flushes, but she nods. She knows she shouldn't be *embarrassed* by this, she has been doing it for years and Adora already knows what she does, but it is getting into the details that is going to be difficult.

All those thoughts fly out of her head when Adora takes her hand and leads her into the living room. The room is bigger than Catra's entire dorm – the ceiling is at least two stories tall. Catra was already impressed with the foyer, but this is *ridiculous*.

"How much does this place cost?" she asks, stunned, as Adora leads her into the adjoining dining room. It feels small compared to the living room – probably because it is only *one story* – but the size that would be normal in any other city apartment just makes it feel intimate, which is borderline terrifying, especially considering the table for two set out in the middle of the room. Adora shrugs, looking a little sheepish as she drops Catra's hand and pulls out her chair for her.

"A few million? I bought it a few years ago, I don't really remember. All I cared about was the privacy. It has a lot of outdoor space, but it's all surrounded by fencing and plants so people can't peek in. And I can have windows overlooking the space without worrying paparazzi are going to film me naked," Adora tells her. Catra, a little stunned, sits down in the chair heavily. Adora hurries over to her side of the table, sending Catra a cautious smile as she sits herself.

"I can give you the tour after dinner," Adora offers. Catra feels her tail twitch, but she just nods.

"You said you cooked?" she prompts, because she can smell the fish in the air and it is *mouthwatering*. Catra's diet ping-pongs between fancy dinners and terrible college food. The latter ensures that she keeps up her appreciation for not only good food, but anything that is

just plain *decent*. The kitchen is behind Adora, and though Adora might not have confidence in her cooking skills, Catra wants whatever is making that smell. Adora beams, rushing to stand.

“Just a moment,” she promises, before hurrying back into the kitchen. She reemerges a moment later with two plates already prepared.

For most of dinner, they just do small talk, but Catra can feel the subject of why they are here looming over their heads even more than the vague idea of *business* from last night. Eventually, she has to just ask.

“What do you want from this? From me?” Catra asks. Adora almost chokes on her fish, but she manages to just cough a few times and then put down her fork. Catra feels a bit sorry for her as she takes a few steadying breaths, but not knowing is *killing* her.

“I don’t know if there is a standard set of rules for this, or what yours would be,” Adora admits once she has gathered herself enough. Adora set out a glass of water for both of them when she brought out their plates. Catra would kind of prefer wine in this moment, but she knows she should be clear-headed for talking business. She takes the water as a distraction anyway, reaching for it and taking a sip while she thinks.

This is so hard to talk about, not knowing what to offer and what Adora wants. Adora seems to equally cautious though, and Catra suspects she is worried about asking Catra for anything. Catra is the one with experience here, and Adora is watching her carefully. She sets down her glass with a sigh.

“You want me to be your sugar baby,” Catra prompts, as much as she wants to cringe at the term. It isn’t something that sounds pleasant in *any* context but Adora. Adora can either agree or protest, and it will at least give Catra a framework for how to proceed. Adora flushes a violent shade that tells Catra all she needs to know. Adora looks away, quickly coughing into her hand and shifting in her seat a bit uncomfortably.

She really isn’t cut out to be hiring someone for sex work. Catra is suddenly, *intensely* grateful she ran into Adora at the gala. Clearing the air is nice and all, but the image of having to see Adora in the press with someone else – someone who would very likely take advantage of her in some way or another – hadn’t occurred to her until now, and it makes an angry and jealous heat flare in her chest.

“Come on,” Catra decides, standing from her chair and crooking a finger to indicate Adora should follow her. Adora startles, still blushing, but she hurries to stand, practically tripping over herself to follow despite the fact that neither of their dinners are completely gone yet. When she comes within range, Catra fists her hand in the front of Adora’s shirt and pulls her back into the cavernous living room, pushing her down onto the couch.

A flash of panic crosses Adora’s face as she hits the seat, looking up at Catra with embarrassment and awe. This is what Catra meant by someone who would take advantage of her. Either all they would want from her would be to take her money, or they would push her into sex faster than she was ready for because they assumed it was what she wanted - or they just wanted *her*.

Catra, calmly, sits down on the couch beside Adora and then pivots, turning to lounge back against the arm of the sofa so she can both watch Adora's face and kick her feet up into her lap. She watches the nerves immediately melt away. Adora is still blushing and embarrassed, but she relaxes back into the seat as she drops her hands to rest on Catra's legs.

Catra blushes when Adora begins to massage her calves through her leggings. *That* wasn't in the plan, but she certainly isn't complaining, and a small smile is beginning to play at the corner of Adora's lips. It would be cruel to deny Adora this by telling her to stop.

"I know you aren't so innocent that you don't know what the *sugar* part means," Catra says, watching Adora immediately flush again as she studiously stares straight ahead at the coffee table and nods.

"Listen, this- is hard. I'm trying to walk the line of hiring you without ruining our friendship when we've just reconnected. And I don't want you to think this is a *pity* thing either," Adora admits, carefully not looking at her. Catra pauses, just observing her for a minute. Aside from embarrassment and nerves, Adora's body language doesn't give away much.

"Tell me what you would want if it wasn't me. If it was anyone else you trusted enough to hire like this. It isn't about us, so it doesn't necessarily mean you want the same thing from me, but it gives me something to work with," Catra prompts her. This is going to be like pulling teeth, but it isn't like she is making it easier. She could answer the question of if sex is on the table for both of them, but she *isn't*.

Adora frowns for a moment, finally looking over to her and tilting her head a little. Catra just waits. She can see the gears turning in Adora's head as she thinks it over. She seems conflicted, which only makes Catra suspect how *much* she truly wants. After a moment, Adora fixes her gaze firmly on Catra's ears, and Catra knows that she is finally ready to say it.

"Publicly dating and whatever amount of PDA was comfortable between us to sell it to the press. In private… what you *traditionally think of*, I guess. It would help us sell it, and I really can't date normally. At least at the penthouse, I can control it and know I'm not secretly being filmed," Adora explains, her cheeks steadily becoming redder as she talks. Catra's ears twitch and Adora winces, quickly looking away and then looking *back*, her expression a bit desperate.

"I'm not asking you to do anything you wouldn't with a regular-" Adora starts to assure.

"Shut up. Let me think," Catra returns, because she is having a bit of revelation that Adora really is a *client* just like any of her others. Adora can't have a relationship – usually that is because her clients lack the time or have personality defects, not because of fear, but the principle is the same – and she is *lonely*. She wants to be held, and kissed, and even touched, and she is willing to pay to experience that intimacy but too afraid of being hurt again to commit to a relationship.

What she really wants is to be friends again, with the added intimacy she can't get any other way. There is also the press thing, but Catra already knew what Adora wanted from her in that regard. It is a weird moment of realization that they have both been wanting the *same*

thing in their time apart. At least, they have after Catra falsely accepted that Adora didn't want her anymore.

Catra has missed feeling wanted without the fear of someone trying to take advantage of her. The entire reason Catra is stuck in this wasteland devoid of true affection is because she is and always *has* been in love with Adora, but even with all this is being platonic for Adora, she will still care about Catra as a person and friend, and that will be a far cry from the warm body she is to most of her clients. It will be true affection, not only directed at her, but given *by Adora*.

Adora has her head hung a little, her shoulders hunched as if to brace herself. Catra doesn't know how Adora expected to hire someone for this when she is so ashamed of it. Cautiously, Catra scoots closer on the seat, startling Adora as she shifts until her butt has hit Adora's leg, practically in her lap. Adora looks up to her with wide eyes.

"I'm comfortable with that, Adora. I'm not worried about doing something like this if it's with you. *PDA* is the kind of thing I usually do anyway," Catra tells her, watching Adora's eyes go wide. She is blushing again, but this blush is *different*. It isn't the burning shame from before. She looks a little awestruck as, cautiously, she raises one arm to wrap around Catra's back and support her position sat up.

Catra rolls her eyes and leans into Adora's arms. Adora, like a blushing virgin, gasps a little and then raises her other arm to wrap it around Catra. Fuck, she really is starved for it.

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"Is it too much to ask you to stay here a few nights a week? I've missed you so much, and I don't think I'll ever stop hating to sleep alone," Adora asks, her arm reached out to scratch idly at the side of Catra's jaw. Well, it would be idly if every part of Adora wasn't lighting up with joy at having Catra leaning into her touch like this. She has been worried about a *lot*.

Catra was angry with her last night until she found out the truth, and Catra knows how to hold a *grudge*. Adora didn't expect it to just go away like magic, and she still suspects it hasn't, but Catra seems willing to set it aside. Even after agreeing to this in theory, Adora wasn't sure how Catra really felt about the possibility of being at all intimate with her.

She honestly still isn't sure how far they are going with this, considering Catra agreed to *what you traditionally think of* for this type of relationship and then immediately brought up PDA as if trying to drop a hint, but Adora doesn't know how to bring it up without making it seem like- well, like she wants to touch Catra and always has.

What she does know is that they are going to be friends again, and that she can hold Catra, and that they can even *kiss* probably, so that is what she is going to focus on for right now, considering the very idea makes her giddy. Part of her wants more, but she shouldn't be

asking her friend for it anyway. On the couch beside her, Catra hums thoughtfully, the sound rolling a bit, *just* short of a true purr.

“I live in grad housing on campus. My roommate isn’t too bad, but the whole place is kind of miserable. I’m not saying *no* to being paid to live in a penthouse,” Catra teases, nudging her a little. Adora can’t help but chuckle. It is so *easy*, just like things had been last night once they got into their rhythm. A decade of wondering, and it turns out Catra is not only okay, but she is the same as Adora remembers her.

“How about we move some of your clothes over this weekend? I can buy you duplicates of anything you need at both places, but clothes are trickier,” Adora offers. Catra flushes, her ears twitching as she darts her gaze away to watch one of the plants gently swaying in the foyer through the glass wall separating it from the living room. Adora has a lot of plants that Frosta maintains for her. Catra seems to be a bit entranced by just watching them gently sway in the AC, but they did grow up in the inner city with very little greenery.

“Sure. I just need to know you’re sure about this. This is a big commitment for me. Taking down my website is losing my income, and you’re a *terrible* actor, Adora. What if the press doesn’t buy it?” she asks. Adora pauses, blinking at her.

“Then I still have you in my bed, so I don’t give a shit what they think?” Adora returns, confused. Catra flushes at the same time that Adora does. *Too honest*. She needs to pull it back. “You’re right that I can’t act, so- no acting. That’s why I called it a sugar mommy thing. The arrangement will be secret, but we don’t lie about us. What the public sees is what we are,” Adora corrects, her face a little flushed.

Catra is only a few inches away. She is curled up with her feet tucked up under her, knees brushing Adora’s side, and leaning against the back of the couch, her cheek pressed there as she flicks her gaze between Adora and the swaying plants. Her expression is seemingly open, but Adora can’t read it at all as Catra just *watches* her, seemingly searching for something.

“Have you even kissed anyone since-“ she starts to ask. Adora shifts uncomfortably and Catra cuts off. After a moment, Adora sighs, looking away.

“No. And I’d rather not talk about that. I was eighteen, and I trusted someone I shouldn’t have,” Adora says, her voice a bit monotonous, but she has been shutting down questions about what lead up to or *followed* those photos for seven years. In her periphery, Catra nods. She looks apologetic, shifting a little closer to lean into Adora’s side and provide her with some comfort.

“I won’t lie that it hasn’t been- lonely since, but looking back on it, it was lonely *during* too. She’s not even actually gay – she did it all planning to sell the story to the tabloids. She wanted the money and career boost,” Adora adds, though she doesn’t know why. She has never added anything to her initial cutoff statement before.

Beside her, Catra shifts, and then Adora is blinking up at her as Catra crawls into her lap, straddling it and looking down at Adora with searching eyes. Adora swallows, knowing her cheeks must be blazing as she hovers her hands awkwardly before placing them on the couch cushions beside her. Catra glances down at her hands, an amused smile tugging at her lips.

“Are you sure you actually feel okay with this, Adora?” Catra asks her, gaze questioning as she drops one hand to idly trace patterns with her fingertips onto the top of Adora’s hand. Adora feels like she is *dying*, the full-body flush from this afternoon returning and making her feel warm. Catra's expression is cautious as she grabs Adora’s hand and raises it to her waist. Her expression tells Adora all it needs to for her to know that Catra really is just trying to check that she isn’t going to panic the second she gets in a compromising position again.

Adora follows Catra’s lead, grateful for the guidance as she carefully places her hand on Catra’s waist, flexing her fingers if only to give herself something to hold onto. She is completely out of her depth here. It has been years since she touched someone else like this, and even then she didn’t go much further than what is already public knowledge. She was uncomfortable. She found out the next day *why*, but this is Catra, and it is different.

This is something that has been in her fantasies since she started having them when she was a teenager. In truth, the photos incident is only part of why she hasn’t dated since becoming a star. The rest of the reason was *Catra*. They may have just been friends before all this, but no one else has ever held a candle to her.

On the days when Adora couldn’t sleep despite exhaustion taking over her entire body, when her throat was raw no matter how much tea she drank, she would lay in bed and wonder about her first real friend. Sometimes she would fantasize about Catra finding out about her through the tabloids and reaching out again. Adora went as far as to tell her agent that if someone named Catra called for her, they shouldn’t dismiss it without talking to her first.

Catra is gazing down at her with soft eyes, an edge of nerves to her expression. Adora *knows* it is because she is worried about pressuring her, but that is also ridiculous considering Adora is the one paying her to do this. Adora has wanted to kiss Catra *many times*, but never as badly as this moment. She is kind of terrified, but Catra is right about her acting skill – they need to get used to this.

“Can I kiss you?” Adora asks, her voice barely above a whisper as she raises her other hand to frame Catra’s waist on either side. The tension in Catra’s gaze releases and she nods, leaning forward a little, but leaving a gap for Adora to close herself. Adora cautiously tugs on Catra’s waist, pulling their bodies together as she sways forward to meet her.

For half a second, Adora has no idea what she is doing, given the *seven years* since she last did this. Instinct and muscle memory take over though, and after a few moments Catra is releasing a soft noise of satisfaction as their lips slide together. The hairs on Adora’s arms are standing on end, her heart pounding from how *profound* it feels. She drinks down Catra’s sound gladly, just proud she could elicit any kind of reaction in the girl she has been dreaming about for so long.

Catra’s lips are soft, gentle as she kisses back. It is the opposite of Adora’s last experience, forceful and showy for the camera she didn’t know was *there*. Now, Catra rumbles slightly as Adora’s chest tightens with emotions she can’t name. Her hands on Catra’s waist tighten if only to keep them from *shaking*.

When they part, they don’t go far. Catra rests their foreheads together as they both just take a moment to breathe. Adora still has her eyes closed, but she is listening intently to the slight

rumbling quality in Catra's breath. She *did that*. She made that contentment vibrate in Catra's chest.

And she's going to get to do it *again*.

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Catra hadn't been sure what to expect really, but it certainly wasn't Adora being handsy for practice – even if Catra was the one who brought it up with *no ulterior motives* – as she leads Catra on a tour of her three-story penthouse. None of the rooms are terribly large except for the living room, but the entire space as a whole is beyond luxurious.

Catra has been in fancier apartments for her work – hell, the restaurant they were at last night was more luxurious in appearance – but they were definitely nowhere near this price tag. They didn't have three floors worth of outdoor spaces, all surrounded by wooden fencing decorated with plants and *grapevines* so Adora's windows can look out on the outside without letting anyone spy on her.

The whole place is kind of a cat's dream. Catra's current dorm doesn't even have a *window*. Here she will be spoiled for choice if she wants to curl up in a sunbeam to nap. When they reach the master bedroom, she takes one look at the memory foam bed and decides that quitting her job and falling into *debt* would be worth it if she got to sleep here. She crawls into it without hesitation, curling into a ball on top of the comforter and kneading absently as Adora watches her with a fond expression.

"So you don't have a problem sleeping here then?" Adora observes, following her to the edge of the bed and reaching her hand out. Catra rolls her eyes as she scoots closer, within petting range, and then tucks her face into the bed. The question is ridiculous, she already *agreed* to stay over, but she knows it was more of a comment on her behaviour than a genuine query. Adora immediately sets to petting through her mane, wild and untamed again now that the chemical relaxers have had time to wash out.

"You are not getting me out of this bed before noon on the weekends," Catra promises her, ignoring the way her words are rumbling again. Adora laughs lightly as she settles on the edge of the bed, continuing to carefully pet over Catra's mane.

"I'm okay with that. I've missed our cuddle sessions," Adora admits. Catra's tail twitches and her cheeks blaze, but she says nothing, just nudging up into Adora's touch. As she gave the tour, and even before it, Adora kept *saying* things like that – things that she missed, or that she thought about over the last ten years. Catra has had *some* time to get used to the idea that Adora really did try to reach out, but it hasn't been enough for it to really sink in yet.

As comfortable as she is, it is getting late, and Catra didn't get sleep last night. She can already feel her body wanting to doze. It is all well and good to decide to sleep here, but Catra isn't doing it *tonight*. She needs to go home and process the fact that she really has

agreed to be Adora's fake-except-not-*that*-fake girlfriend. Catra sighs, releasing the comforter and stretching out slowly on the bed. Adora's hand falls away as she shifts, but when she is done, Catra cautiously nudges up to Adora's side, leaning against her shoulder.

"I should get back. I have classes in the morning. I'll actually delete my website when I get home," Catra tells Adora, giving a raspy yawn as she nudges into her shoulder. Part of the reason she is being so touchy is just because they should get used to it, but a bigger part is because Catra is fucking *starved* for a touch that isn't laced with sexual intent. She hasn't had one since Scorpia moved to the west coast after graduation. Adora cautiously wraps an arm around her and lightly pets down her back.

"Wait to delete it, actually? I'll text Entrapta to remove it more fully, and she might need some data from it to do that. I don't really know how it works, just that Entrapta can delete what she sets her mind to. There's a reason it is a challenge to find any of those photos that outed me now. When she saw how difficult it was going to be to remove it all, she made it a personal mission. She's still at it now whenever someone reuploads a copy," Adora tells her.

Catra releases a breath, nodding against Adora's shoulder. The idea of finally not having to *worry* about this is almost an addicting rush of relief. Catra stretches up and kisses Adora's cheek. It is something she does with female clients often – she never kisses male clients, but this level of affection is fine with most women, and Adora has never been *just some woman* to her - but it is enough to cause Adora to flush, her hand on Catra's back spasming.

"Frosta will drive you back. I'll have a spare key for you by the weekend. In the meantime, I'll text you?" Adora proposes. Catra nods, sitting up and finally pulling away from Adora. Adora looks a bit disappointed, but she offers Catra her hand, and they walk together back over to the staircase. Adora pauses near the top of it, glancing down at Catra's hip like she is remembering something.

"I'm buying you a new phone, by the way. One with security. We won't discuss the arrangement over the phone, but there are some minimums I have to meet security wise, even after retiring. I'll get you a new computer, too," Adora tells her as she starts down the stairs. Catra's ears twitch, but she nods. Okay, maybe this isn't a *paranoia free* lifestyle, but Catra trusts that Adora has the money to keep them safe from the public. Adora pauses at the bottom of the staircase, turning to smirk at her.

"I'm pretty sure *this* is the sugar part, by the way. Me buying you nice things. Which I *am* going to keep doing," she adds. Catra flushes, not really sure how to respond to that or any of its implications. Adora eyes her for a moment, seeming satisfied with her reaction. "And I'm going to make your lockscreen an ugly selfie of me," she adds. That makes Catra snort, reaching up to loop her arm in Adora's and gently tug her towards the elevator.

"You're only hurting yourself when some paparazzi inevitably gets a picture of it," she points out. Adora laughs, shaking her head a little and shooting Catra a look with her eyes sparkling as she calls the elevator up.

"There will be an entire Buzzfeed article about how disgustingly in love we are, I guarantee it," Adora dismisses. Catra's fur stands a little on end.

Oh no.

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“Do you have anything you want to tell me?” Frosta asks, in one of her more condescending tones as she lets herself into the penthouse. Adora lifts her head only enough to raise an eyebrow at Frosta before dropping it down to faceplant into the couch cushion again. Adora didn’t call her, but Frosta lives in an apartment on the first floor and has ample access to the penthouse to do her job.

She doesn’t usually come up here unless Adora calls her, but Frosta is nosy, so Adora wasn’t all that surprised when she heard the elevator. She can lock Frosta out if she wants to, but she usually doesn’t arm her master security. It would interfere with Frosta bringing her shit on the days Adora can’t make herself get out of the apartment.

Frosta drops down into the armchair closest to the end of the sofa, the legs of the chair scraping against the floor. Adora grunts into the cushion. The meeting with Catra went just about perfect, but now Catra is gone, Adora is lying here, conflicted.

She doesn’t want Catra to leave. She feels like a creep for even asking this much of Catra. She doesn’t want to be just a *client* to Catra. She wants them to be friends again. She doesn’t know why she thought any of this was a good idea, but she also knows her jealousy would have struggled to watch Catra work for other people once they were talking again. Her guilt would have made her hate herself, knowing she had the money to take care of her but she was letting Catra go through that.

This kind of feels like the only solution – it controls the paparazzi, Catra won’t reject her money as *charity*, and she gets to have Catra in her life again – but Adora still feels shitty about it. Kissing Catra had been *amazing*, but Adora is terrified of pressuring her. Having to worry about overcorrecting and making Catra feel bitter about being pitied doesn’t make it any easier.

“I’m not going on condom runs for you,” Frosta says, because she doesn’t give a shit about anything, much less decorum. Adora chokes on her tongue, causing Frosta to cackle as Adora has a small coughing fit. She raises her head to glare at Frosta. Frosta is entirely unphased. She has faced down the law, she isn’t afraid of *Adora*.

“We don’t need condoms,” Adora returns, dropping her head to the seat again. After a moment of silence, she starts to doubt. “Do we need-“ she starts to ask, raising her head again. Frosta cuts her off with an *ugh* of disgust.

“Are you going to be exclusive? Then no, assuming she isn't going to get you pregnant. Have her sign an NDA, though. I’m just saying, you better be the kind to put out on the third date, because I’m not going to keep driving her back at midnight,” Frosta tells her. It isn’t even

midnight, and Frosta has been threatening to quit since the day Adora hired her. She isn't worried. They just have that kind of dynamic.

Adora may technically be Frosta's boss, but *no one* is the boss of Frosta. Adora met her while doing a not-at-all creepy amount of charity work for troubled youth homes in NY, looking for any lead on where Catra might have ended up. After her parents died, Frosta set down a path of rebellion that landed her in juvie. Adora managed to help her get emancipated at fifteen by promising the court she would employ her for the next three years at a minimum.

That time limit is up, and she has no intention of letting Frosta go unless Frosta decides she wants to wander somewhere else in life. Frosta may threaten to quit, but she also turned down Adora's offer to pay for her to go to college because she just doesn't know what she is doing yet. As far as interim gigs go, this one is pretty fucking cushy. Adora puts her up in one of the apartments downstairs, Frosta drives her around, keeps her on time, and runs errands for her. She also receives all of Adora's mail, because she can't risk having her exact address listed anywhere and leaking.

Frosta is young for this kind of job – for the first year, Adora was *teaching her how to drive* – but Adora doesn't mind having to buy her own alcohol still. Frosta doesn't give a shit about money, fame, or the elite, and she's a good kid. She reminded Adora of Catra a bit.

"We grew up together," Adora offers, still face down in the cushion. Frosta is kind of her friend, but mostly her assistant. She knows Adora has been looking for someone, but the only people who know all the details are Glimmer and Bow. Even Hope isn't aware of the full extent that Catra meant to her, but that is probably because Adora struggles to say it, and Hope is a lot like her, with difficulty picking up things unsaid.

To Adora's shock, Frosta rises from her seat and pats Adora's shoulder twice. It is a bit awkward, but they don't usually *touch* each other either.

"Glad you found her. But driving into NYU is miserable," Frosta tells her, already turning away to leave. Adora chuckles into the cushion.

"Brat," she tells her. She hears Frosta pause just outside the foyer.

"Bitch," she returns, and then she sweeps away. A moment later, the ding of the elevator sounds.

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Catra gets a text from an unknown number that simply says *delivery in the lobby from your bitch* on Wednesday. After staring at it for a solid twenty seconds, she screenshots it and sends it to Adora.

That's Frosta. I don't pay her enough to respect me, by which I mean there isn't enough money on Earth.

Catra snorts at the reply, gathering her lanyard and ignoring how Lonnie side eyes her when she goes to leave. Catra leaves at odd hours all the time, and she has successfully convinced her roommate she is just a big partier around her school work, but she is always here in the lull between classes she has on Wednesdays. They know a decent amount about each other's schedules just to ensure Catra doesn't walk in on Lonnie with her boyfriend and Lonnie doesn't walk in on Catra getting ready for an event.

Lonnie just thinks it is so she doesn't walk in on Catra getting off, but whatever. Catra ignores her roommate in favour of seeing what *delivery from your bitch* means. As she rides the elevator down, she texts Adora back.

And how is my bitch today?

She can't help but grin as she shoves her phone back into her pocket. She has only gotten to call one client a bitch to her face, and it was only because she was *into* it. Adora is going to be her best client ever. Her phone chimes at the same time that the elevator doors open. Catra ignores it for the moment, stepping out and scanning the lobby. It isn't hard to spot Frosta with her dyed-blue hair and stony expression of boredom. The fact that she is carrying a plain cardboard box done up with a giant blue bow also helps.

"What's this?" Catra asks her as she strolls up, ignoring the other students passing through that are eyeing her delivery. Frosta holds it out to her with a put-upon sigh.

"I'm probably supposed to just let you open it," Frosta tells her. Catra takes the box from her. It is only heavy by virtue of its awkward shape. Every single one of her law textbooks are heavier than this on their own, but they are also easier to carry.

"Thanks," she replies. Frost just grunts and turns to go. Catra can see a sleek black car idling outside. She tucks the box under one arm and returns to the elevator, pulling back up her conversation with Adora.

Your bitch is at work and would appreciate it if you didn't make her choke during her afternoon meetings.

No promises.

Do I have to worry about opening this in front of my roommate?

No. I'll warn you when I decide to send you something embarrassing.

Well, that's comforting. Catra puts her phone away so she can unlock her door. Lonnie immediately zeroes in on her package as Catra breezes back into the room. She can feel her roommate's calculating gaze on her back as she sets the box on her bed, reluctantly undoing the bow so she can cut it open.

Inside are two more boxes, for a laptop and cellphone respectively, and a sheet of paper. Catra picks it up, surprised to find it handwritten in one of the messiest scrawls she has ever seen.

Hello, Adora's friend! I've finished taking your website offline, and I've added some upgrades to the devices Adora requested…

The page goes on to explain the changes and how to transfer her information from one phone to the next. It is wholly unnecessary, Catra isn't an *idiot*, but the person who wrote this doesn't even know her real name, so she shouldn't be too mad. Catra sets the letter aside as Lonnie cranes her neck from her bed, nosy but not asking. She pulls the devices out, eyeing their expensive brand names and packaging.

Adora is really *serious* about this whole thing. None of these devices look cheap – Catra is pretty sure this cellphone model costs something like a *grand* – and Catra may have gotten some expensive or just plain weird gifts from clients over the years, but this definitely takes the cake. She puts the laptop on her bed and just stares at it, needing to take a minute to process.

Lonnie doesn't give her that minute.

"How the fuck did you get your hands on something like that? Rogelio has been lusting after one of their low-end models for like four years," Lonnie asks, seeming perplexed. Catra wants to wince, but she forces herself to hold still. Lonnie is a decent roommate – most of the time – but they aren't friends, and she can't risk Lonnie going to the press if she finds out the truth of the arrangement.

"Told my girlfriend I got a virus. Apparently she's taking matters into her own hands. She has a techie friend," Catra lies, the excuse coming to her easily as she starts to unbox the cellphone. That will be fastest to set up, and Catra is suddenly feeling overwhelmed by this whole thing. Getting one easy thing done will help calm her down. She isn't having second doubts or anything, it's just-

An entire decade of lusting after Adora, and she's somehow here, being bribed to sleep with her. Lonnie is gaping at her from the other side of the room. Catra doesn't know if it is the *free laptop* thing or the *girlfriend* part. It isn't like she is at the dorm all that often or she tells Lonnie anything about her personal life.

"Damn, Cat, you have to show me your moves if they're worth ten grand," Lonnie says. It's a joke, but it makes Catra's fur bristle. It is way too close to the truth. Luckily, she has an excuse to snarl at Lonnie. Not only was that vulgar, but she fucking *hates* it when Lonnie calls her that – which is the entire reason Lonnie does it. Lonnie raises her hands in fake surrender and turns back to her homework, but Catra can feel her eyeing her as she goes about setting the devices up.

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Adora calls Hope on Thursday, after she and Catra have texted some logistics about her moving back and forth between the dorm and the penthouse. Luckily, Catra is only a few minutes away, so it is really down to the convenience of what she knows she will need at both places. They haven't met in person again yet because she has been busy with school, but Catra is planning to come over tomorrow just to hang out.

"How are you doing, Adora?" Hope greets her. It is well into the night and Adora asked if they could call in private. Hope is on the west coast right now, doing business in LA, but she will be back from her business trip in a week. From the background of the video call, Adora can tell that Hope is in her office in her LA home.

"Good, I think. Kind of stressed about change, but – I'm feeling good otherwise," Adora admits, leaning back in her chair. She is up in her office-studio combination. Not that she records anything anymore, but she still likes to play piano sometimes, even if she was never good enough to take it live. The stress of live performances would always make her hands shake too much for them to even consider trying.

She was a singer at her heart. She couldn't play, she couldn't *write* – at least not like Hope wanted her to - but she could sing and carry a performance with ease, able to pick up the repetitive movements of her simple choreography without too much trouble.

Hope considers her, tilting her head a little as she watches Adora. Their relationship is *complicated*. Hope did care about trying to be a good mother, but most of the time it felt like she was Adora's manager first and her guardian second. Hope used to be married, but before she and Mara could have the child they wanted together, Mara was taken in a car crash. Adora can tell from the way Hope talks about *before* that she changed afterwards.

Hope had good intentions in seeking her out. It had been years since Mara died, and Hope had always wanted to be a mother. She believed she would find it fulfilling based on how she felt about mentoring those up-and-coming in the industry. Adora's singing voice reminded her of Mara, apparently. It wasn't all for the purpose of profit – that just got in the way sometimes.

Hope made sure she was taken care of, during and after, between providing for Adora herself and setting up her finance portfolio for her to have afterwards. Hope was a better mother than she might have ended up with, but Adora needed a lot more than Hope could give her. Hope didn't know she was dealing with a child absolutely bristling with trauma. Adora is pretty sure both of them are too emotionally constipated to ever really air it out.

"You are really going to commit to this then?" Hope asks. Adora lets out a slow breath, leaning back in her seat and looking up at the ceiling.

"Yeah. I found someone. That's why I finally agreed to it," Adora admits. Hope is quiet for a minute as Adora resolutely examines the ceiling. She didn't tell Hope anything when she agreed last week, and Hope told her they could talk about it when she got back to New York. She doesn't seem all that surprised by Adora's statement, though.

“Tell me about her,” Hope requests, because she may be *emotionally constipated*, but she still knows Adora. Adora blushes, but she looks back down to her screen.

“I found Catra. I met her again at an event. She became an escort a few years ago to pay for her law school. I get to have a public girlfriend and she can leave a high-risk career. It works for both of us,” Adora explains. She has told Hope a bit about Catra – enough to make Hope regret not pressing Shadow for more at the time – but back then Hope thought Adora “deserved” a clean break from the foster system.

“Are you sure you can trust her?” Hope asks, raising an eyebrow. Adora scowls, but Hope presses on. “This will look bad if it gets out, Adora. I only suggested it because of how much I know the press bothers you. I don’t want you to get hurt again because you have a blind spot for her,” Hope explains, completely *rationally*, but Adora doesn’t want to hear it, even if she knows Hope is just trying to look out for her.

Hope was the one to originally introduce Adora to the girl that fucked her over, and she has felt guilty ever since. It was just supposed to be networking. Hope already knew Adora was gay, but not how *lonely* she was. Adora was vulnerable, and her need to connect with someone else after three years alone was taken advantage of.

“It would ruin her legal career if anyone found out what she does. She was wearing contacts, changing her hair, and using a fake name just to keep people from finding out. We’re going to use the truth as our story – we grew up together, and we happened to reconnect. She was the first person I felt like I could trust since everything,” Adora explains. Hope still has an unsure edge in her gaze, but she nods.

“I want to meet her myself when I get back, but I know you’re smart, Adora. You’ve agreed on terms?” Hope asks. Adora relaxes a little, nodding as she fidgets with her mouse. She really doesn’t want to say what those terms *were*. Hope just raises an eyebrow at her. “I know this was my proposal, but are you sure, Adora? This *relationship* is going to be in your bios going forward, and you are giving her unparalleled access to you and your privacy,” Hope points out. Adora sighs.

“I’m sure,” Adora agrees. Hope nods, seeming as satisfied as she is going to get from Adora’s verbal assurances alone.

“Then I wish you luck. I will come by for dinner when I get back so we can meet. Don’t take her to an event before then,” Hope tells her. Adora rolls her eyes, but she agrees. She really doesn’t need Hope babysitting her and approving her choices, but she knows it is coming from a place of caring and guilt.

They turn to lighter topics – the industry and what Hope has been doing on her trip, even though that used to be the darkest topic they could choose before Adora got out – but like it has been all week, the arrangement remains on Adora’s mind. She can only hope this won’t ruin everything between them.

Chapter End Notes

Adora: I'm hiring you for sex work.
Also Adora: I can't say the word sex though.
I'll be posting a fic extra on Adora's penthouse and Catra's dorm on my tumblr tomorrow.
Again, I really promise Hope did her fucking best as a mother, but even Adora doesn't know all her motivations and thought processes at this point – mostly because the two idiots refuse to talk about it.

New Territory

Chapter Notes

> Yellow is my favourite colour, but I don't know what would possess someone to paint a building pastel yellow, and federal architecture is some of the ugliest shit I've ever seen. Pretty Woman is a romcom about a businessman falling in love with a sex worker. It's well-liked, but I've never seen it and I doubt it is very sensitive at this point.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I'm staying right here all weekend, actually," Catra declares, stretching out on a chaise lounge in the middle of a sunbeam. Adora's third story is pretty much just a terrace, the attached conservatory, and the guest room she rarely uses. The conservatory has an entire wall of glass and lets in plenty of light. New York winter may be setting in as the year draws to a close, but this room has warm sunbeams year-round.

"You can do that," Adora promises her, cautiously sitting on the lounge beside her. Catra doesn't even open her eyes, just wiggling on the seat as she gets comfortable. Her tail is waving happily, hitting against Adora's thigh as she stretches out in the late afternoon sun.

Catra arrived an hour ago. She took the subway this time. Adora has given Catra a copy of the keys now, and they talked a bit about their weeks, Catra explaining to Adora what law school is like while Adora became steadily more appreciative of her legal team. Eventually, Adora realized they had been sitting on the sofa for a full hour and recommended they moved up here to watch the sunset.

Catra slits her blue eye open lazily, peering down at where Adora is watching her. Adora flushes, dutifully fixing her gaze on Catra's ears, but not looking away. She always has trouble meeting people's eyes, but Catra's ears can convey just as much information as her gaze if you know what to look for. Adora has been looking for a long time – she knows all her signals. Catra slits her other eye open, looking at Adora with amusement. The tip of her tail is twitching now. Adora's flush darkens.

"I pay to look. Go back to your sunbeam nap," Adora tells her, flustered. Catra's expression only turns more amused as a slow smile spreads across her face. Adora swallows as Catra sits up, grinning as she scoots closer until she is practically in Adora's lap.

"You pay to do more than that, hot stuff," she reminds, intent clear as she presses closer but waits for Adora's reaction. Adora is *conflicted*. She absolutely wants to pull Catra closer and hold her, maybe even kiss her if she seems in the mood, but-

"Don't call me that," she asks, wrinkling her nose a little. It isn't the words, really – it is the way Catra says them, familiar and casual, *practiced*. She has said it to clients before, and

Adora may be well aware of the nature of their arrangement, but she really doesn't like the idea of Catra thinking of her like she thinks of all her old clients, much less *treating* her that way.

Catra pauses, cocking her head as she blinks slowly at her, considering her. Adora watches concern begin to cloud her face and realizes she has begun to chew on her bottom lip. She hastily releases it. As much as she doesn't want to be called that, she also doesn't want to give Catra orders or anything. She explicitly told Catra she can always tell her no when they were deciding on the amount she would need each week, assuring her it would never affect if or how much Adora paid, but that doesn't magically erase the pressure.

"Adora, I want you to tell me when you don't like something," Catra assures, shifting closer to slide into her lap properly and cup her cheek. Adora flushes, a bit unsure at the sudden contact, but she nods. Catra gives her a small, encouraging smile, but she still looks calculating. "What pet names *do* you like, then?" she asks. Adora pauses. If it hadn't been for the way Catra said that – *meaninglessly* – she probably would have liked it.

"I don't know? Just something that fits us, I guess," Adora replies, well aware what she just said was meaningless considering there is no *them*. She just hopes that it is good enough without being overbearing. Catra nods, her expression thoughtful. She doesn't seem weirded out by the request, at least.

"Well, you're already my bitch, but I can't say that one in public," she jokes as she thinks, sending Adora a sly look. Adora snorts, taking a risk on raising her hands to wrap them around Catra's waist and hold her close – maybe close enough that she won't notice that Adora is blushing. It doesn't work. Catra *hm*s, gaze calculating as she narrows her eyes at Adora.

Catra's grin grows wider, the only warning Adora gets to brace herself before Catra practically purrs out, "*Princess*." Adora flushes a violent shade, suddenly struck with the urge to lean forward and bury her face in Catra's mane so she can't see her reaction. She didn't *know* that was a thing for her, but it might just be the way Catra said it.

If Catra had called her *hot stuff* in that tone of voice – like she wants to bring Adora to her knees – then Adora probably would have melted for her the same way she does now. Catra chuckles, leaning forward to nuzzle her cheek against the side of Adora's face as she uses the hand on her cheek to hold Adora in place so she can mark her. Catra being so happy, so *close*, is not going to calm Adora down.

"Wow, who knew you were so *easy*, princess. One word and you already look ready to get on your knees," Catra purrs to her. Adora is experiencing a blood rush that might actually make her pass out – she is at least going to have a headache after this. If Catra asked her to, Adora would kneel instantly, eager and ready despite her inexperience. The fact that Catra can tell that maybe would be a bit terrifying if Adora wasn't so certain that Catra can just smell her desire.

"You can move your hands, you know," Catra tells her, and that is all the warning she gets before Catra uses the hand on her cheek to tilt her face up so she can kiss her. Adora squeaks a little, but she leans into the embrace once her brain catches up with what is happening.

Catra leaned in slow, but even after agreeing to all this, it still felt kind of unbelievable that Catra was moving in to kiss her.

This may only be their second kiss, but Adora can confidently say that Catra is a *good* kisser. She presses forward, a solid weight in Adora's lap as she molds their bodies together. She kisses *slow*, like she is luxuriating in it. She takes the lead, tilting Adora's cheek to position her how she wants and carefully licking into her mouth.

Adora has to flex her hands on Catra's waist just to contain herself. She has no clue what she is doing or what she wants, just that she does *want*. With her ex, they got to tongue only because it was forced on Adora and she was too awkward to ask if they could slow down. It didn't feel anything like this – before, it made her want to pull away, but now her heart is pounding and every cell in her body is begging for *more*.

She is pretty sure there isn't more without getting into stuff she isn't sure if they are even doing, especially not yet. She doesn't want to be greedy anyway. The enormity of her desire at just a *kiss* really makes her suspect she is a bit repressed, but go figure, she hasn't touched someone else in seven years. Kissing Catra is everything she hoped it would be and more. It makes her blood pound, but it also has her entire body – except her hands, which are holding Catra's hips just a little too firmly because she can't seem to release them – relax beneath the attention.

The fingers of Catra's hand on her face flex, encouraging them just a bit closer as Catra shifts. She doesn't pull away, which Adora is grateful for, but she drops her free hand to place it over Adora's on her waist. The high Adora has been riding dissipates – well, it gets a spike of panic added to it, which makes for a very confusing cocktail of brain chemicals – as she hastily releases Catra's waist. Catra is *still kissing her*, so she doesn't seem too upset, but Adora was definitely being too forceful.

"You're okay," Catra assures, her voice soft as she pulls back just far enough to murmur the words to Adora before kissing her again. Her fingers lightly stroke Adora's cheek before she slips that hand around to cup the back of her head. Adora relaxes again – she doesn't know how she could *not* when Catra's voice sounds like that, so warm and assuring. Catra lays her free hand over Adora's hand, now resting a bit limply against her waist, and covers it so she can guide Adora's hand to slide down to her hips.

"Don't second guess so much, okay? I've got you. I just want you to relax and enjoy it," Catra murmurs to her, her words still quiet. Adora doesn't know why she is keeping her volume down. With Catra's nose nudging against her cheek, she is pretty sure there is nothing in the world except the two of them. Catra could shout out her insecurities and she wouldn't care, not when her breath is hitching as she cautiously follows Catra's lead and runs both her hands up and down Catra's sides, slowly feeling her out.

Catra sighs softly, a tinge of sound to it that Adora can almost classify as a moan – it is enjoyment at the very least. The sound sends a jolt straight through Adora, bolstering her confidence. The noise was tiny, barely a noise at all, but that is what makes it so profound – it was *genuine*, nothing Catra was putting on for show. Catra likes to be touched like this, and Adora likes to *do* it.

A bit cautiously, Adora nudges her nose against Catra's cheek, silently asking for another kiss. After a second, Catra complies. When she kisses her, she can feel Catra is smiling. Warmth is radiating off her, and it isn't just her body heat. She seems *proud* as she coaches Adora through kissing her.

"That's it. Slow and steady," Catra promises her between kisses, her voice sincere. Adora flushes, the embarrassment of being so clearly taught what to do suddenly hitting, but Catra notices without ever pulling back. Adora knows her body tenses a little, but Catra just quietly shushes her. "None of that. It's okay. I'm here to help you find what you like," Catra corrects her, kissing her again to punctuate her sentence.

Adora is still kind of embarrassed, but she knows she *definitely* likes kissing Catra.

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Adora doesn't even try to feel her up. Catra wasn't really expecting her to, but the warring instincts of what she expects when someone tries to touch her, the part of her that is still empathically convinced that Adora purposefully left her ten years ago despite the evidence to the contrary, and the knowledge that Adora hired her *explicitly* for this had still come out a bit surprised by the caution in Adora's touch.

At the same time, it is that caution that has Catra moaning softly and guiding Adora through touching her. That caution feels like *care*, and it is almost enough to make Catra shiver beneath Adora's hands. She knows a lot of it is Adora's lack of experience and probably a decent amount of anxiety – Catra can practically hear the gears turning in her head at every tiny movement – but it is the exact kind of intimacy she has been craving for herself.

Adora manages to relax. She doesn't touch Catra anywhere but her sides – and she clearly doesn't think to even do that much until Catra directs her to – but slowly she seems to stop worrying and just let herself relax into the endorphin buzz that comes from contact like this. Catra has no plans to push Adora. She clearly wants this, but she also needs to ease into it given her history.

Catra will guide her as best she can without pushing her further than she is ready for. She knows Adora is just worried about her, but Catra is just as worried about Adora. She wants but is afraid to *have*, despite paying Catra for exactly that. Catra finally understands why Adora really can't be in a relationship – if she is struggling this much when they have explicitly agreed to contact like this, she can't imagine how Adora would let this kind of thing *develop naturally*.

Eventually they kiss long enough that the kisses turn lazy. Adora is just holding her now, basically hugging her close and seeming content. Catra shifts to drop her head to Adora's shoulder, nuzzling into her neck and purring softly when Adora immediately sets to cuddling her, not a trace of disappointment in her.

Yeah, best client ever. Catra has never gotten as much as she has given from an embrace before – that is the whole reason she is paid to do it after all, but Adora *cares*, and she enjoys just holding Catra or talking to her in addition to getting to kiss her.

"Can I brush you?" Adora asks quietly, turning her head to press a kiss against the side of Catra's ear. Catra, to her own surprise, *trills*. In her defense, she has never let a client touch her ears before out of fear of them being too rough on her. Adora knows exactly how delicate her ears are though – or at least, she *used* to, and she has been proving over and over again that she has held on to a lot of her old knowledge – and the gesture is just sweet.

Catra flushes, grateful she is already tucked into Adora's neck to enjoy her scent. It lets her hide her blush without being too obvious, though she can feel her tail thudding against Adora in her fluster. She needs a distraction.

"Do you *have* a magicat brush?" she points out. She still sounds flustered, but it turns out it doesn't matter, because the words cause Adora to pause, clearly thinking about it. Catra is shocked when Adora shifts her arms around Catra, shuffling her over in her lap and disrupting Catra from her *very comfortable* spot so she can dig into her pocket.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks, sitting up properly and watching a bit incredulously as Adora pulls out her phone and begins to text. Adora looks up from her screen, furrowing her brow a little as if confused by the question.

"Texting Frosta to go to the store? You'll need one here anyway. Where do you usually buy them? I can have her go there and just get a full set of supplies," Adora tells her, like it is obvious and simple. To her, it probably is. Catra's clients *usually* aren't as rich as Adora, but she has had one or two with a PA before, and they were always having them do all sorts of things.

"She's not going to get it right. She's human," Catra responds, because the idea of sending someone else to buy her beauty care supplies is just *ridiculous*. It isn't a position she ever thought she would be in, and it just feels weird, despite how natural it seems to come to Adora. Adora pauses, scrutinizing her for a moment.

"I can give her a store name, list of products, and preferred brands if you have them. If not, the sales associate can help her as long as she knows what you need. It used to be that if I wasn't up to having a fan interaction, I couldn't leave the penthouse and risk it. Frosta is used to running out at all kinds of odd times for me. If you're uncomfortable with it, I won't send her, and I'll just give you my credit card tomorrow to do it," Adora says, matter of fact. Catra blushes. Somehow, that is *worse*. At least Adora pays Frosta to run out and buy shit for her – the idea of Adora just handing over her credit card and telling Catra to go for it is too much.

Catra huffs and takes the phone from Adora, finishing off the half-complete text with the store location, a list of the products she needs, and her preferred brands for the ones she remembers – which is pretty much just the stuff she has to replenish. She really doesn't care what brand her brushes are. She hands the phone back to Adora, her cheeks blazing. Adora scrolls through the list, merely nodding, before pausing at the end and scrolling back up through the list as if to check something.

“I’m adding a magicat toothbrush and toothpaste to this. Is there anything else you need to stay the night? Obviously you need to bring some changes of clothes over still, but if you really intend to spend all weekend on my chaise lounge, I want you to have what you need to be comfortable,” Adora tells her. Catra’s ears twitch, but she shakes her head. She didn’t *know* she was staying here tonight, that had mostly been a joke, but the idea of getting to spend the night in that heavenly bed – yeah, she’s down for that.

“I’ll need to go back tomorrow to get some of my textbooks. And I’ll need to do work over Saturday and Sunday. I cleared my Friday evening, but I have assignments,” Catra tells her. Adora nods, not looking up as she types out another message to Frosta. A moment later, the phone buzzes softly and Adora snorts, rolling her eyes as she tucks her phone back into her pocket.

“She’s in the middle of an online match, but she’ll go when she is done. And I already have brunch plans on Saturday with some friends, so I’ll be gone for the afternoon if you want some uninterrupted quiet. I’m not expecting you to drop everything for me. The whole point of this is so you can afford school, after all. That’s pretty useless if you can’t get your work done around me,” Adora assures her, raising both her arms again to wrap them around Catra and pull her back into their cuddling position.

Catra is a bit surprised if she is honest, but she just nods. She really wasn’t sure how deep any of Adora’s friendships were at this point. The caution she has around relationship-type intimacy is well-earned, but Catra was beginning to wonder if it extended even to friendships. Adora hasn’t really mentioned much about friends, and given how hard it must be to connect with someone when fame is in the way, Catra really couldn’t blame her if she didn’t have many that weren’t other stars.

Well, actually, Adora didn’t *say* she wasn’t going out for lunch with some other celebrity, but part of Catra just assumed Adora would bring her along for the press if that was the case. That would be kind of risky this soon, though. They need to get to the point where Adora can put a hand on her waist casually before they risk public scrutiny.

“My work is going to take several hours,” Catra cautions as she lays her head on Adora’s shoulder. Adora snorts even as she cradles her close.

“So will brunch, trust me, but that’s fine. Even if you’re busy, it will be nice just to have you around. I’ve missed you so much,” Adora tells her. Catra flushes, her tail lashing again. For a second, her heart cries out *no you didn’t*, but she forces it down. Adora did miss her, even looked for her, regardless of what she thought before.

Adora doesn’t lie – at least not *well*, not unless a prank is riding on it. If she says she just wants Catra to be in the same room, she means it. They used to hang out together silently all the time, both doing chores, or their homework, or taking a moment to rest between duties at the home. Apparently this weekend is shaping up to be like the old times that Catra has thought for years only she missed.

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Frosta doesn't show up with the shopping until over an hour later. The store is a few minutes away, but parking is always hard in New York, as is shopping for something you have no experience in or knowledge of. Adora also didn't tell her it was urgent – because it *wasn't*, no matter what Adora was in the mood for – so Frosta has no reason to kick it into high gear. She arrives at the penthouse while Adora and Catra are having dinner.

"Will you be needing me again tonight?" Frosta asks, pointedly raising an eyebrow at Adora. If Catra wasn't looking at her, Adora is pretty sure Frosta would have stuck her tongue out for good measure. As it is, Adora already knows what she is asking.

"No, you can have as many tournaments as you want," Adora waves her away, hoping to distract Catra from the fact that her assistant just asked if they were going to be sleeping together tonight. Catra raises a brow at her, but she says nothing as Frosta rolls her eyes and heads back to the elevator.

After dinner is done, Catra pokes through the shopping bags to make sure Frosta got everything – apparently she left off the claw balm because there were too many varieties even for the sales associate to narrow it down – but most of it is in order.

"This is the bougee shit," Catra points out as she pulls out the coat brush Frosta picked and eyes the logo on the handle. Adora doesn't recognize it, but the only hybrid product brands she knows are the dirt-cheap ones that were provided at state homes. Frosta getting the *bougee shit* certainly tracks – it is exactly what Adora would want her to do for Catra.

"Can I brush you with it or not?" Adora asks, rolling her eyes as she reaches out to take the brush from Catra. Catra snorts, immediately pulling her hand away to hold it out of reach.

"Not this one. The mane brush," Catra decides, tucking the brush back into the paper bag for now. Adora nods, waiting as Catra rummages through the other contents to find the brush she wants. She lets out a satisfied chuff when she finds it, pulling it out and handing it to Adora.

They end up settled on the bed, Adora leaned back against the headboard with Catra sprawled out in her lap, face down on her stomach so Adora can easily brush through her mane. It has gotten a bit mussed over the course of the day, so Adora is careful to work out the tangles slowly, and then she gets to just slide the brush through the dense mass of Catra's mane, luxuriating in both the sensation and the gentle purr beginning to rumble in her lap.

"Your hair has gotten so soft," Adora can't help but comment as she uses one hand to pull the brush through while she pets over the silky hair left in her wake with the other. Catra rumbles softly, nudging her face a little into Adora's stomach, but she doesn't say anything. Adora was worried she had somehow managed to forget how it used to feel when they did this as kids, but Catra's lack of protest leads her to believe Catra agrees.

"I have to take care of my appearance now. I put some of the money back into beauty products, nice clothes, all that. Helps me be taken seriously in the court room too," Catra mumbles into her stomach, making no move to leave, though she does arch into Adora's hands a little as Adora continues to brush and pet her. Not that Catra isn't pretty brushed out

at this point, but the point of this wasn't *actually* grooming. Adora just likes the feeling of Catra beneath her hands and always has.

Adora hums and continues brushing, letting herself relax into the sensation and the joy of having Catra utterly collapsed on top of her. Adora has pictured finding Catra again many times. The moment of finding each other again was always great, but the true focus of the fantasies was when Adora would invite Catra back to her apartment to catch up – and then Catra never leaves. Adora never pictured anything like *this*, but she knew that wherever Catra ended up in life wasn't going to be as nice as here. Catra would mention her shitty apartment and then Adora invite her to stay – much like she ended up *doing*.

They kissed in exactly none of those fantasies – okay, that's a lie, but it was always just a brief moment of weakness before Adora hurried her mind along to picturing having Catra in the same space as her again. She was really just picturing having her best friend back and being able to be there for her. She always felt so guilty knowing that Catra was put on Shadow's chopping block the moment she was gone. She couldn't be there for her then, but she could now.

She *can* now. Now, Catra borrows a pair of her sleepwear and makes fun of Adora's fancy rechargeable toothbrush before she realizes Frosta got her a similar model. Adora elbows her when they brush their teeth, just like they used to do as kids, and Catra retaliates by smacking Adora with her tail. Afterwards, they crawl into bed together. Catra admits she usually stays up a lot later than this working, but when Adora immediately drops the sheets she was lifting for her, Catra rolls her eyes and assures her she is tired.

"I'm not used to being social anymore," Catra says around a yawn. She doesn't hesitate to slide beneath the covers. "Do you still flail in your sleep?" Catra asks. Adora flushes as she lays down in the spot she usually starts the night in and nods. Catra just blinks at her slowly from the other pillow for a long moment.

Adora has never shared a bed with anyone but Catra, and even that has been ten years. Catra never had the room to lay beside her back then, and Adora doesn't know what she is *doing*. After a moment of watching her almost lazily, Catra scoots a bit closer, looking amused by the way Adora instantly stills.

"Want to cuddle? My only option for survival might be holding you down," Catra jokes, her voice warm, but it is a genuine *question*. Adora huffs to cut her blush, but she can't deny the answer is *yes*. She nods, watching the small smile that quirks at the edge of Catra's lips in the darkened room. There is still enough of the light from the city coming through the curtains that Adora can watch, a bit transfixed, as Catra scoots closer.

Catra drapes across her chest, wriggling a bit as she gets comfortable until she has settled on using Adora's chest as a pillow, an arm thrown over her hips. Adora *had* been lying stiffly in the bed, hardly daring to breathe for worry of disturbing Catra on the other side of the mattress. For some reason, it is easier with Catra on top of her.

It may have been ten years, but cuddling Catra is familiar and comforting. Adora feels herself relaxing as Catra sighs and rubs her cheek against the front of Adora's shirt, apparently content.

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Waking up to find herself totally curled around Adora and Adora returning the octopus-level affection in equal measure feels kind of shocking, even after laying in Adora's arms for upwards of an hour as she tried to sleep and couldn't stop thinking *I can't really be here*. She didn't think she would ever see Adora again, but she *definitely* didn't think she would ever be in her arms again.

Catra doesn't get up until much later in the day than Adora. Adora goes for a workout, comes back, and has finished cooking breakfast by the time Catra hauls herself out of bed and forces herself to pull on her clothes from last night.

"I'm going to head back to my dorm to get my stuff after breakfast," Catra tells Adora when they sit down to eat, mostly because she doesn't like waking up and putting on dirty clothes. Adora nods, seeming unbothered as she continues eating her food.

"I'm leaving in an hour probably to head over to Gracie Mansion. If you want, I can have Frosta drop you off at campus first," Adora tells her. Catra blinks at her over their meal. Why the *fuck* someone would be going to Gracie Mansion – well, ever – but especially for *brunch*, Catra doesn't know. She didn't even know that you could just go to visit the mayor's house.

"Isn't that, like, on the upper east side? I can take the subway, Adora. It's fifteen minutes and I'm not bringing much," Catra points out. She doesn't actually know where that ugly yellow cake of a building is, but she has some vague knowledge that it is on the upper east side, so someone probably said it to her once. Adora actually *pouts* at her as if Catra hasn't gotten along fine with public transit all her life. Catra sighs.

"Fine, I'll take a cab to go eight minutes instead of *fifteen* on the way back," Catra offers, begrudgingly. It is worth it. Adora instantly lights up with a wide smile, giving the bouncing nod of hers that didn't *used* to take Catra's breath away, but after ten years without seeing it, not even in interviews, it has Catra flushing. The nod means Adora is truly happy about something.

The press made Adora uncomfortable. She probably still did it plenty in private when she wasn't being recorded. Catra is startled out of her thoughts by a warning ding coming from the elevator on the other end of the first floor, announcing someone is on their way up. Catra's ears twitch and she turns to stare through the living room at the foyer, a bit incredulous.

"That's just Frosta. She comes up on Saturday mornings to water the plants. She brings in the shopping on Sunday afternoons, too," Adora says from behind her. It's just *weird* knowing someone is coming and going in Adora's private space – a space Catra is supposed to be sharing with her, in theory – but then again, Catra does have a roommate already. Lonnie is just as free to root through her shit as Frosta is, and she isn't even legally liable for anything she does to bother Catra in that regard.

“I assume she has signed an NDA?” Catra asks, turning back to the table to eye Adora. Adora rolls her eyes, but she nods.

“She told me to get you to do the same, by the way. She’s an asshole, but she’s a decent kid,” Adora assures her. Catra snorts, but she lets the subject drop, if only because she can hear the elevator approaching.

Frosta vaguely greets Adora as she walks into the dining room, eying Catra curiously but saying nothing. She continues on to the kitchen so she can fill the watering can she has in her hand. Catra is pretty sure the watering can was sitting in Adora’s foyer, but she has been kind of focused on *Adora* every time she has been in there, so she can’t be sure.

“I’ll probably be at Gracie for two hours, plus the trip back and forth. Honestly, it might be longer. I think Glimmer and Bow are going to interrogate me once I tell them about you. It’ll give you plenty of time to yourself, though,” Adora tells her, shrugging as Frosta continues to go back and forth between the kitchen and the other parts of the main floor to water the indoor plants.

Adora is clearly comfortable with the kid, but it’s weird to exist with someone else in her space. At least it’s only twice a week. Catra focuses on just finishing her breakfast until Frosta walks back from the foyer without the watering can, heading straight through the kitchen and out to the terrace to take care of the outdoor plants.

“She’s a good kid. Got chewed up by the system just like us,” Adora says, softly, apparently having noted Catra’s discomfort. Catra sighs, her ears pinning back, but she also knows she can’t hold out when Adora is looking at her with those soft eyes.

“What, missed having a stray around that bad?” Catra sends back, rolling her eyes and crossing her arms as she slumps in her chair. To her surprise, Adora flushes and quickly looks away, seeming ashamed. Catra doesn’t understand why. Shadow referred to Catra as a mangy stray more than once, but whenever Adora compared her to a cat, she just called Catra *kitty* or *kitten*. She has no reason to be personally ashamed by the term.

“Yes,” Adora admits, resolutely staring at the floor as her cheeks blaze. Catra pauses, her brows furrowing as she takes Adora in. “I met her when she was fifteen and fresh out of juvie. Angry at the world, but she still had kindness. She made me think of you. I couldn’t just leave her in the system. I got her emancipated and she’s been working for me ever since,” Adora admits, her expression making it clear she is afraid to look up and see Catra’s reaction.

Catra is *gaping* at Adora, absolutely floored. The cognitive dissonance is striking. She is doing pretty well on not being mad at Adora, but the fact that she was unwanted is ingrained in her *heart* and she isn’t sure how to begin dealing with it. Adora’s statement is totally at odds with that. Her heart can’t reconcile ten years alone with Adora missing her so bad she basically adopted someone who shared the shape of her shadow. Adora finally looks up. She still looks nervous, but less ashamed now.

“I know it’s, like, probably super creepy. But I couldn’t help you, so I wanted to help her once I was in the position to do something,” Adora admits. Catra still isn’t sure what part of this Adora thinks she is supposed to be ashamed of, but she manages to snap her mouth shut

and shake her head, rising from her seat to circle around the table. She forces herself into the space between Adora and the table so she can settle in her lap.

“You helped someone. You did a good thing, Adora,” Catra tells her, because if there is one thing she has trained herself to do, it is shove down her emotions and say what a client needs to hear. She also *wants to say it*, but she is still trying to process her revelation. She is pretty sure it is going to take a while, but she has all afternoon to herself it turns out.

Adora relaxes beneath her, expression softening until her primary emotion is *touched* rather than *worried*. Adora shifts in her seat, pushing it back from the table a little so Catra can settle more comfortably, and then wraps her arms around her back to hold her close. Catra allows herself to be drawn in. She isn’t all that surprised that Adora goes to bury her face in the soft fluff over her heart.

Only a small part of it is exposed by her shirt, but Catra wore a purposefully low-cut top last night. She decided to walk the line between her usual style and something revealing because she figured it was what would make Adora most comfortable. Adora lets out a satisfied hum and then presses a soft kiss into Catra’s fur, causing her to flush.

“I just can’t believe I get to hold you again now,” Adora says softly, lifting her face but not pulling away. They are only inches apart. Catra can’t hide the way those words make her breath hitch, her tail lashing behind her. Her cheeks are flushed, and Adora gives a small smile before she leans forward cautiously. When Catra merely tilts her chin down to meet her, Adora closes the gap.

It is the first kiss that Adora has truly initiated. It is slow and careful, soft and almost *delicate*. It is a hello, a cautious greeting and reacquaintance. It makes Catra’s heart *pound* as she pushes forward just a little. She isn’t used to being desperate for more. Sometimes she finds herself wanting and allows it when a client pushes, but she has never pushed forward for more just for *herself*.

Adora gives it to her. Adora kisses her more firmly, leaning forward so their bodies can be pressed together. Catra eagerly wraps her arms around Adora’s shoulders, holding her close-

Catra’s ears twitch as a door opens. She pulls back, her cheeks blazing. Adora’s brows furrow together for a moment as she opens her mouth, clearly about to ask until she notices Catra’s gaze fixed on the kitchen, her ears twitching. Catra sends her a sheepish look, leaning forward to give her one quick peck before she slides out of Adora’s lap. She has just managed to return to her seat when Frosta steps out of the kitchen.

Listen, the kid is a fucking *baby* and Catra doesn’t want her to walk in on her straddling Adora’s lap, NDA or no. Frosta sends her a side-eye that leads Catra to believe she isn’t fooling her about what they were up to, but she didn’t *see* anything, so Catra doesn’t care. Frosta takes the stairs up to the second level, and Catra listens to her exiting out into the bedroom on the second level. There are plants in there, but there are also stairs *outside*. She had no reason to come inside to head up there, but Catra didn’t need to be acting so desperate anyway.

“What does she think the situation is? I’m some escort you’re trying to *Pretty Woman*?” Catra asks, watching Adora immediately choke a little. Catra raises a brow at her as Adora collects herself, rubbing self-consciously at the back of her neck. Adora shakes her head a little.

“She knows I was looking for someone I grew up with in the system, and she knows that is you. And she thinks we’re dating. She doesn’t need details on how,” Adora shrugs, her cheeks still flushed. Catra nods. She really would prefer if the twerp remained in the dark on their arrangement. She would prefer if *everyone* did.

Catra doesn’t want to be treated the way people generally are once others find out they are sex workers. She also doesn’t want to *keep* being a sex worker. With Adora, it doesn’t feel like that – probably because Catra has been in love with her for years, and she knows Adora truly cares about her. Catra doesn’t even know if she *would* classify this as sex work, despite Adora technically being a client – and also likely the first to ever actually have sex with her.

“Um, speaking of that though…” Adora starts, cutting into Catra’s thoughts as she continues to look vaguely uncomfortable. Catra raises an eyebrow at her, forcing those thoughts from her mind for now. Adora flushes. “I don’t have a lot of people I trust. But Glimmer and Bow have both been my best friends for the past few years. And I’ve told them about you, because I felt like I was going to die if I kept holding it in forever. Like I’ve ranted about missing your little ear twitches to them before,” Adora admits, and suddenly her awkwardness makes *sense* because Catra finds herself flushing too.

It is another moment where Adora says something about missing her in a way that Catra previously knew to be impossible. Adora sneaks a glance at her, blushing as she does so, but at least some of the nerves dissipate when she sees Catra is equally flustered by her admission.

“I want to tell them the truth. Glimmer and Bow are the only people I’ll feel like I’m lying to if I don’t tell them what we’re doing,” Adora asks, shifting a bit in her seat. Catra draws in a breath, looking quickly away. She doesn’t want anyone knowing *anything*. Adora’s mom knows, but apparently this whole thing was her idea. Adora has already warned Catra that they are all going to be having dinner together next weekend.

“Who are they?” she requests, because all she wants to say is *no*. Not even Scorpia knows about her job. Catra *can’t* be labeled as a sex worker, it would ruin her.

“Glimmer is the mayor’s daughter. We met at an event when I was seventeen and Angella was running for the first time. We’ve been best friends since. Bow is her boyfriend. They’re already planning their wedding, but they’re waiting to get engaged until after Angella’s final term is up so there’s less scrutiny on them. Bow is trans and he doesn’t want people looking into his past. Seeing his deadname printed would hurt,” Adora explains.

Catra nods, not looking away from where she has her gaze carefully fixed in the distance. It does make her feel better that they know a bit about how vicious the press can be, but the idea of some rich politician’s daughter who she has never even *met* knowing about her past feels dangerous.

“It doesn’t have to be anything but this. Just our arrangement. That’s the part that feels like lying. They don’t need to know about your job,” Adora tells her. Catra feels herself relax, shooting Adora a grateful look. She can’t be known as a sex worker, but a sugar baby? That she can do. That isn’t *illegal*.

“If you’re certain they’re good people and not going to tell *anyone*, then okay,” Catra agrees, heaving out a sigh. Adora relaxes, visibly relieved and nodding quickly to accept her answer.

“They won’t. To everybody else, you’ll just be my old friend and new girlfriend,” Adora promises her. Catra flushes. They’ve kissed and yet Adora calling Catra her *girlfriend* threatens to send a jolt through her. Probably because it is devoid of all the context of the arrangement and just sounds genuine.

Catra needs to think about anything but that. She hurries to stand and collect her empty plate. It is about time she headed back to her dorm anyway.

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Catra leaves to take the subway just after breakfast. Adora pokes around to make room in her closet for any additions that Catra might bring and then does the same rearranging in her office. She leaves a few post-it notes around to encourage Catra to put her things wherever she likes and then decides she has killed enough time despite how she definitely hasn’t.

She ends up arriving almost an hour early, but she knows Glimmer won’t mind. Sure, she is cutting into her and Bow’s date time, but it isn’t like Adora hasn’t been doing that for years. Glimmer greets her joyously when she arrives, though she and Bow are clearly surprised. That surprise quickly turns to suspicion.

“Are you finally going to tell us what you’ve been up to all week?” Glimmer asks Adora as they all settle on the couch in the sitting room together. They are practically on top of each other, but their friendship is just *like* that. When they were kids, Adora and Catra used to be the exact same way. Adora opens her mouth and then closes it, suddenly realizing she doesn’t know where to *start*.

Glimmer is a bloodhound. She narrows her eyes at Adora, scrutinizing her for a moment. Adora knows she is blushing, but it still isn’t *fair* when Glimmer’s eyes go wide with realization and she gasps. Adora doesn’t know how it is so easy for her friends to read her when the press is so blind that they write love stories from a casual glance.

“You *met* someone, didn’t you?” Glimmer demands, turning her entire body toward Adora. Apparently this warrants her full attention. Adora flushes worse. She doesn’t even get to reply. Glimmer gasps with delight while Bow’s entire demeanor softens. He is sending Adora one of his *I’m proud of you* looks that it took her a year to get used to receiving.

“Tell me *everything*. Who is she? How did you meet? What did she do to break through your paranoia? Is she hot?” Glimmer demands, rapid fire, grabbing Adora’s hand with both of hers and squeezing it to contain the sudden spike of energy she is clearly cruising on. Adora blinks at her. Three out of four of those questions are easy, but the *how you met* one is going to be hard to swing. She can at least answer the rest with just a few words.

“It’s Catra,” Adora says. For a moment, Glimmer and Bow just stare at her as they process the words, and then the room *explodes*.

Adora loves her friends. She only has a handful of true ones, but Glimmer and Bow are the closest she ever came to forging a connection like she had with Catra again. She doesn’t think the same kind of bond would be possible with anyone else – they had over a *decade* together that Glimmer and Bow are only halfway through catching up on, and hopefully now they will never get the chance to outstrip Catra – but Adora is still incredibly close with them.

Glimmer begins squealing and launches herself at Adora, apparently unable to contain herself anymore as she hugs her and begins babbling about how she can’t believe it and she’s so *excited* for her. Bow joins in – on the excited chatter and on the hug, because he can never resist them. Adora finds herself laughing, her chest bubbling with the infectious happiness, but it is also fueled by the relief of somebody else *getting* it.

“She was my Bow. She was my best friend. My *everything*. And then Hope adopted me, and she was gone,” Adora told Glimmer when she was eighteen and trying to explain why she felt so *lonely* and had accepted the date offered by her now-ex despite feeling weird about it. Those words still felt inadequate. Adora had nothing and no one but Catra, and that was doubly true from Catra’s end given how the home was unreasonably hostile to her.

Now, Adora feels a weight that has been sitting on her heart ease as the *physical* weight of her best friends practically knocks her over when they hug her. Somehow, it is easier to breathe. The explosion of excitement is enough to draw Angella’s attention to the sitting room.

“What happened?” Angella asks, amused, as she leans against the side of the door frame with her head ducked to accommodate her height. Adora is a little too breathless for words, so she finds herself just looking up to grin at the woman. Seemingly reluctantly, Glimmer gets off of her, taking Bow with her as she clutches *him* instead. She has too much energy to not be attempting to crush something she loves, apparently.

“Adora found her girlfriend from middle school and she can finally stop *pining*,” Glimmer tells her, an almost-malicious glee in her eyes. Adora sputters on the couch beside her.

“I haven’t been *pining*, and it’s not- we weren’t- well-“ Adora sputters. The problem is she absolutely *has* been pining, but it still wasn’t like that. Catra is her best friend, and attractive as hell, and she may have been Adora’s gay awakening, but crushes aside- “We were never girlfriends!” Adora protests, earning looks ranging from pitying to *amused*.

“I’ll leave you three to catch up, then. I’m happy for you, Adora,” Angella says, her face settled firmly in the amused camp as she pushes off the door frame and heads back out of the room. Adora pouts at her retreating back.

“We *weren’t*,” she insists, turning back to Glimmer and Bow. Bow at least holds pity for her – Glimmer’s expression makes it clear she isn’t buying it. Unfortunately for her, Bow is smart, and he is watching her with a considering gaze.

“Moving a bit fast, aren’t you?” he asks, because anybody who says that Bow can’t be a shit is *lying* or just not his real friend. If nothing else, Glimmer had to rub off on him eventually. He’s sweet, but that doesn’t mean he can’t be devious when he wants to be. Adora stares at him. How does he *know*? “‘Weren’t’, Adora?” he questions.

Glimmer gapes at Adora as she turns crimson.

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“Ooo, walk of shame,” Lonnie calls gleefully as Catra walks into their dorm in yesterday’s clothes. Catra glares at her, snarling, though it is merely a warning. Lonnie, currently laying on top of her boyfriend along with *his* boyfriend as they all watch Netflix on the laptop balanced between their laps, merely raises an eyebrow at her. A lot of humans cringe when Catra does shit like that, but unfortunately Lonnie grew up with Rogelio, so she is pretty well-versed in hybrid behaviour. She knows when something isn’t serious.

“Do you want us to go back to our apartment?” Kyle pipes up from beside her, clearly wanting to steer the conversation into a friendlier direction. Kyle and Rogelio are in the fortunate position of sharing an apartment together, but the *unfortunate* position of having some noisy ass neighbours. They have both graduated, but they’re struggling to find jobs that pay well enough to move somewhere quieter, especially while they’re trying to help Lonnie through her law studies.

Catra sighs and turns her back to them, walking over to her side of the room and shaking her head as she does so.

“I’m not going to be here long. I’m just getting some things. I’m kind of moving in with my girlfriend, at least on the weekends,” Catra says, as casually as she can. She can practically hear the triad exchanging glances behind her as she bends down to pull the box her laptop and phone arrived in out from under the bed. She can put her school things in there and shove some clothes into her backpack. It will have to be good enough for now.

She still isn’t sure how much she is going to be living at Adora’s, but given how eager Adora has been, she suspects the answer is going to be *as much as possible*. Adora is lonely, clearly, and though Catra is still struggling with the instinct to say she is just a warm body, even if that is true, she would still rather *she* was the body than anyone else.

Catra had been intending to spend some time in the familiar territory of her dorm, but she isn’t doing that now that she knows that her real roommate, plus her two unofficial additions, are all here. The comfort of her dorm would have been nice for processing and relaxing, but *quiet* will be better.

Catra manages to get two changes of clothes, a pair of pajamas, and most of the school supplies she needs to do her homework into the box and her bag as Rogelio pointedly resumes the show they are watching. Catra appreciates him trying to give her privacy, but Lonnie only returns to watching it reluctantly.

Being nosy is a great quality in a lawyer – less so in a roommate. Catra hurries to pack up and then reluctantly takes her things down to the curb to get a cab. With what Adora is paying her, she can afford to take one – especially knowing that pay is coming *consistently* – but she has been dirt-poor her entire life and she doesn't like spending money.

The cab driver eyes her in the rearview when she has him drop her off outside the entrance to the parking garage, but he doesn't say anything as she pays and leaves. She sighs as she swipes her card into the elevator and takes it up to the penthouse she left less than an hour ago. Adora's scent is lingering in the air, so Catra cautiously calls out for her when she steps in the foyer, but she isn't surprised when she is met with silence.

She must have just left. Catra has plenty of time to drop her things and decompress some place soft before Adora makes it back.

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"Adora, I'm going to slap you," Glimmer says, gaping at her as Adora stumbles her way through explaining the arrangement.

"*Why*?" Adora asks, because she doesn't *deserve* it. She's kind of going through a lot right now what with all the change of Catra sleeping in her bed, and she would appreciate support rather than Glimmer gaping at her while Bow *cringes*.

"You're *paying* the woman you're in love with to be your girlfriend? You've invented a brand-new level of repression just to torture yourself," Glimmer exclaims, gesturing at her like what is wrong with her is written across her skin. Adora pouts a little, sending Glimmer her best frown.

"I'm not *in love* with her, she's just special to me, okay? I can't explain it if you weren't there when we were growing up. And it makes sense! The paparazzi will stop spreading lies, she can get her masters, and we get to spend time together!" Adora defends, listing off her points on her fingers. Glimmer looks incredibly unimpressed. Leaning forward, she takes one of Adora's fingers and folds it back down.

"If you *don't* feel for her, then they're still spreading lies," she points out, reaching for Adora's second finger and folding it as well, "she managed two years of school before meeting you," Adora glares as Glimmer folds down her final finger, returning her to a fist, "and you could catch up without making kissy faces at each other for the paparazzi," Glimmer finishes, raising an eyebrow at her. Adora glares back.

"… She wasn't doing fine," Adora mutters. Catra would slap her if Adora implied she wasn't handling everything by herself, but it is the closest Adora can come to alluding to the truth. Catra *was* doing fine, but it was far from ideal. Adora sighs, looking away as both Glimmer and Bow's expressions tinge with pity.

"Listen, she was making her payments on her own, but it wasn't great. I explained Hope's proposal to her and she agreed. She never would have accepted anything she deemed as charity, but a sugar mommy thing is compensation for giving the paparazzi the run around," Adora explains, awkwardly. If she told Glimmer and Bow what Catra *was* doing before, she knows it would all click in place for them and they would probably be more understanding, but Adora isn't going to violate Catra's trust.

Maybe she doesn't have to say anything to do that, though. Glimmer and Bow exchange a look, and Adora knows they suspect something. If they didn't know Adora so well, she might have gotten away with it, but she also knows that proposal or no, there is absolutely no way she would have offered this arrangement if Catra wasn't already doing sex work.

"I know you're trying to help her, Adora, but you need to take care of yourself as well," Bow tells her, gently. Adora stares at him incredulously.

"I woke up to Catra *purring* and cuddling me. I've better than I've been in ten years," Adora tells him. Bow gives her a thin smile, clearly trying to be encouraging, but he doesn't seem assured in the slightest. Beside him, Glimmer purses her lips.

"Okay, so she's your *everything*, but you aren't in love with her. Just tell me this: are you also attracted to her?" she asks. Adora blinks at her, confused. Of *course* she is, she would have to be blind not to be.

"When you meet her, you will briefly consider leaving Bow," Adora returns. Bow squawks while Glimmer sends her an exasperated look.

"Adora, you're a useless fucking lesbian," she returns.

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Catra is *pretty* sure she found all the notes Adora left her, but there were seven of them, and she knows Adora doesn't like that number, so she probably missed one. She looks for note number eight for ten minutes before she gives up because she really does have to do her work. The notes range from assurances she can put her things where she likes to simple encouragements. Adora leaves one on her desktop monitor that says *You can use this if you need to! PS: You're smart, you've got this :)*

The note makes her smile an unreasonable amount despite being simple and cheesy. Catra gathers the notes in the back of her casebook and settles at Adora's desk to work. The study

is a good place to work given it has a nice desk and a couch to collapse on when she needs a break, but it also has a good vibe to it.

It seems to be half study and half music room. Adora has an upright piano at one end of it that still has sheet music on its stand, as well as an acoustic guitar propped up against the wall, though the guitar is covered in dust that hasn't gotten the chance to settle on the piano. The room is decorated similarly to the living room, although given the bookshelves and loose sheets of music around, it wouldn't be a good idea for it to have as many plants that require watering here.

Adora still has a single rose in a water vase on the desk that Catra spends a moment poking to see if it is real, but given its scent, it would have to be the most convincing fake she has ever seen if it were. Catra likes having a dedicated space to work. On campus, she usually goes to the library if she needs to turn off her brain and just work, but there are the distractions of it being a *public place* that cut into her productivity still. She always has to be a certain level of aware of her surroundings, just in case.

In the study, Catra can turn everything off and just focus. Sometimes she gets thrown a curve ball, like when she realizes she forgot her binder clips and she doesn't know where Adora keeps them, if she has them at all, but they are all minor bumps in the road to her work. Adora comes home at some point in the afternoon, startling Catra from her concentrated hunch. Adora calls out cautiously from downstairs, as if unsure if she is home yet, so Catra calls back.

"In the study!" she calls before leaning over her casework again. She isn't anywhere close to being done. She usually spends all day on the weekends doing this, and her evenings all week. She pretty much only takes a night or two off a week to take a client, if she gets one.

Adora makes her way upstairs. Catra's back is to the door when Adora opens it. She wonders, for a brief moment, if she is supposed to stand and go greet Adora, like a housewife on TV greeting her husband after work. Adora answers the question for her by crossing the length of the room, placing her hands on the back of the desk chair, and bending to press a kiss to the top of her head as Catra blushes.

"Work going well?" she asks, her voice warm. Catra nods, shifting in her seat a little, though she doesn't know why.

"I'm still going to be at this for a while. It takes me all weekend usually, but I'm making good time," Catra adds, because she needs to temper Adora's expectations. Adora hums, standing on her toes a little to stretch over the back of the chair and kiss the base of Catra's ear. Catra feels her cheeks blaze.

"Sounds good. Well, sounds mind-numbing, but you've got the brain for it. Would it be too distracting if I read on the sofa?" Adora asks, dropping her arms to loosely hug around Catra's shoulders from behind. Catra is unreasonably flustered, so she just shakes her head. Adora releases a small sound of delight, squeezing her arms around Catra for a moment before letting go and retreating to the bookshelf. Catra's ears swivel to track her movement as Adora picks out a book and then heads to the couch, sprawling out on it.

The room falls into a comfortable silence. Adora hums to herself occasionally, but she is mostly quiet, letting Catra focus on her work. Adora used to struggle to sit still, so Catra finds it surprising, but after a few long moments of *waiting* for Adora to do something distracting and nothing happening, Catra's body begins to relax again.

She finds it surprisingly easy to return to working, getting back into the rhythm of her casework. Eventually, she distantly notes Adora coming and going – Adora even brings her a glass of water and sets it on the desk for her – but Adora's presence is so *familiar*, so known and established as safe, Catra finds her movements don't disturb her. She doesn't need to watch her surroundings as Adora's phone rings and she disappears for a while, not even when she eventually returns and offers Catra a plate with some salami before retreating again.

When Catra finally pushes away from her work to stretch and then wanders out from the office, she is surprised to find night has fallen. Adora is up in the conservatory. She looks up when Catra enters the room, a wide grin spreading across her face as she brightens.

"All done?" she asks, the excitement she has at the prospect obvious. The answer is *no*, but-

"For today," Catra promises her. She crosses the room and crawls into Adora's lap, feeling her entire body go limp as Adora immediately sets to massaging her ears. Within moments, the room is filled with the rumble of her purr.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter, dinner with Hope, and some small revelations.
Happy TDOV! Obviously, Bow is trans in this AU, but I also have a trans woman Adora AU for anyone interested! It's shorter than this chapter lmao

Meet the Parent (slash Manager)

Chapter Notes

> Adora did Adele-style music. She wrote exactly none of her songs and never wanted to be a musician, even if she enjoyed singing.
> Happy Autism Acceptance month! Adora is undiagnosed in this so you won't see the word in the fic, but she is 100% intended to be autistic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stays all weekend. Adora knows she was probably just joking when she said she would on Friday night, but when Adora jumped on it, Catra never corrected her.

Catra takes a break from work on Saturday night, but during dinner she starts feeling nervous about how much she still has to do and Adora encourages her to return to the study. She meant it when she said she still wanted Catra to have plenty of time to work around her. Adora googled a bit about the demands of law school and was floored by the hours per week of the workload.

Adora is a little in awe of Catra for managing it. She barely graduated high school, stretched thin by the odd hours demanded by her career. She knows how *hard* grad school must be, even if Catra's mind is built for it. Magicat's memories are different than humans, steel traps that don't let anything go, but she still has to learn it in the first place, and things like building a case are challenging regardless of memory.

Adora isn't sure if she should tell Catra when she is going to bed. It's still before midnight, which is apparently before Catra's bedtime, and she doesn't want to disturb her work. She also doesn't want to go to bed without warning her so she isn't surprised when she can't find Adora. On the *other* hand, she doesn't want to make her feel like Adora is asking her to come to bed with her.

It turns out she never has to make a decision. Catra opens the door to the study with an amused look on her face. Adora startles. Catra had been so focused earlier, she really didn't think she would notice Adora lurking outside while she made her decision.

"Let me reach a stopping point and then I'll come to bed, okay?" Catra offers, a smile quirking at her lips. Adora flushes and nods quickly, clasping her hands behind her back and bouncing on her toes a little as she nods. Catra's expression softens and she steps forward, reaching both her hands up to place them on Adora's shoulders and lightly pull her down to be resting flat on her feet again.

Catra takes a step closer, bringing them chest to chest, and Adora realizes what she is doing. She relaxes as she bends down the two inches it takes to meet Catra without Catra having to

stand on her toes herself. Catra kisses her firmly, a warm assurance that has Adora dropping her arms clasped behind her back to cautiously place her hands on Catra's hips.

She had intended to pull her closer, but all thoughts go out the window when Catra *purrs* in response. Adora has felt Catra's purr by extension while touching her many times, but *kissing* her for it makes it reverberate within her like it is her own. It also tickles a little, but overall, the experience is amazing. Adora parts her lips, eager to feel *more*, and feels her heart stutter when Catra pulls back. It kicks back up again when Catra chuckles softly and presses a kiss to her cheek.

"Let me finish, and then you can have me as long as you like in the bed," Catra promises her, taking a step back. Amusement dances in her eyes as Adora gapes at her, because *fuck*, does that sound like something it's not. Catra leaves Adora gaping in the hallway with a wink thrown in her direction before she closes the office door. After several seconds more of staring at nothing, Adora goes about getting ready for bed in a daze.

Catra isn't *actually* talking about having sex… right? She can't be. She's just making a joke. Adora feels like she is going to *combust* though. Her heart practically stops when she finally hears the office door open after a spiral of second guessing herself. A moment later Catra walks into the bedroom. She has a cocky smirk as she saunters in, but she draws to a halt, her entire expression softening when she spots Adora sitting up in the bed, dressed in her pajamas, awkward and stiff.

Adora draws in a sharp breath as Catra quickly crosses the room and climbs onto the mattress, crawling over the comforter to settle in Adora's lap, straddling it. Adora's blood pressure might not recover from this. She swallows, feeling the tension building in her body as she carefully places her hands on Catra's hips like she did while they were kissing yesterday.

"Adora," Catra prompts, her voice gentle. Her expression is still soft. Adora's heart is at war with her brain *and* her body right now, but she forces herself to meet Catra's eyes. She knows her panic and guilt must be written across her face. "It's okay to want me," Catra promises her, her voice a whisper.

All the air leaves Adora's lungs. She almost expects Catra's expression to turn amused or condescending, but it doesn't. If anything, it softens more as she reaches her hands down and takes each of Adora's wrists in her own. Adora lets her hands be repositioned and then feels her flush return full force when Catra raises them into the air just above her chest, holding them there.

"It's even okay to touch me. We *agreed* to it, Adora. I told you, I'm comfortable with you," Catra promises, and then she arches her back. It isn't enough to close the gap between Catra and Adora's hands, however infinitesimal that distance may be compared to what it feels like. The gap still disappears as Adora can't help but sway forward a little. It is *awkward*, just having her hands on Catra's tits, but Catra's expression never changes from the soft warmth.

"See? The world didn't end," Catra tells her, humour in her voice. That is what breaks Adora, letting the tension in her body release as she huffs out an unsteady laugh. The sound makes Catra's ears prick forward, her tail thudding once as a spark of happiness lights up in her

eyes. Cautiously, Adora squeezes her hands a little, totally unsure of what she is doing, but not wanting to do *nothing*.

“There you go. No burning fire. But Adora? It’s also okay if you aren’t ready yet. Most people *build up* to sex. I’ll be here whenever you’re ready. I really just meant making out,” Catra promises her. Adora’s heart is pounding, but she fights down the shame that wants to well up as she cautiously slides her hands down to the more comfortable position of Catra’s hips.

Catra leans forward and presses a light kiss to Adora’s forehead. Adora can feel her body relax again as the abject panic of the last few minutes eases. Okay, so Catra is apparently ready and *willing* to have sex with her, and if you asked her two days ago, Adora would have said she would jump at the chance, but now-

Now she knows the comfort of Catra guiding her forward inch by inch, outside of what is known and into what she *wants*. She likes it like that. She likes learning Catra’s moves one by one. She has been absolutely starving for contact with another person, but it turns out there are a lot of forms that contact can take, and she doesn’t have to dive into the deep end of her desires.

“Thank you,” Adora breathes, softly, her cheeks blazing. Catra purrs softly, nudging forward to rub her cheek against Adora’s, affectionately marking her. Adora’s heart is still pounding, but her body is finally relaxing. She has been so worried, knowing they are doing more than Catra usually does with clients and not sure where that *ends*.

Apparently, it doesn’t. Catra’s explanation was so soft and gentle, Adora knows she has to be genuine. Catra isn’t honest like that for *show*. She’s paying Catra to be her girlfriend, after all, and apparently they really are doing *girlfriend* stuff. Cautiously, Adora wraps her arms around Catra’s back and tugs her closer. Catra continues to nuzzle her for a moment more, soft fur pressing against Adora, before she pulls back.

“Let me get changed and ready for bed, and then we can cuddle,” Catra promises her. Adora nods, releasing Catra and watching her go, retreating to the closet. Adora lets herself slide down in the bed, finally laying down on the mattress. She has a bit of a tension headache after that, but she feels lighter all over.

She is still going to struggle with guilt over taking advantage of Catra for sure, and especially worry about ruining their friendship, but knowing Catra is completely prepared for this – to the point where she has even thought about and predicted Adora’s concerns with it – helps Adora feel more comfortable with the idea of touching her.

Catra returns, crawling beneath the sheets and draping herself over Adora. She doesn’t hesitate to nuzzle into Adora’s neck. Adora wraps her arms around Catra, rolling over to pitch onto her side so she can have her arms wrapped around Catra without having to hold them up. Catra lets out a small *mrp* as Adora repositions them, but once they settle again, she immediately cuddles into Adora’s arms.

Adora tucks her face down into Catra’s mane, breathing in her friend and letting Catra’s presence in her arms soothe the parts of her soul that her words couldn’t quite reach. Adora

has desires, sure, but at the end of the day, she could be happy with just this. It just so happens that she doesn't have to be.

--

Catra wakes up only briefly when Adora gets out of bed for her morning workout. She is aware of Adora kissing her ears and promising her she will be back soon, and the next thing she knows she is being pulled slowly into consciousness by the sound of the shower. Catra is still only half awake when Adora returns to the bedroom – and to bed, climbing in with her damp hair and fresh change of clothes. She cuddles up to Catra, nuzzling her hair and kissing her head.

Catra raises her head to nuzzle at Adora's cheek, breathing in deeply. The traces of Adora's shower products are on her skin, but even after all these years, Adora is using scentless products and the smell is faint. The traces of the gym are gone, so Catra is mostly left with just Adora.

"Are you even awake?" Adora asks, her voice soft and amused as Catra continues to rub against Adora's jaw just a *little* aggressively. She is still waking up, and she wants Adora to smell like her, especially after last night. Catra just rumbles in response, nipping lightly at Adora's jaw before she returns to marking her.

Adora's breath stutters. Catra is surprised when Adora raises a hand to press her fingers lightly beneath her jaw, encouraging Catra to turn her head. She follows the direction eagerly, eyes still closed but unsurprised when Adora kisses her. The kiss is soft, almost questioning, like she doesn't know whether or not to believe that Catra is awake. Catra pulls back, chuffing lightly, before she presses forward and kisses Adora for real.

Adora relaxes beneath her, apparently content that Catra is actually awake now. Adora hauls her a bit closer with the arm around her back, pulling Catra on top of her and parting her lips, an open invitation. Catra is kind of surprised by how forward she is after last night, but at the same time, she watched part of Adora's worry release as they were talking. Hopefully now she can just let herself want this and *enjoy* it.

She really wants Adora to enjoy having her. Adora has, truthfully, *always* had her. For a long time, Catra thought she was a passing novelty for Adora, and Catra still couldn't let her go. She thought about her, yearned for her, followed her in the press. Now that Adora has *asked* to touch her, she wants to know that Adora is enjoying it as much as she is, even if Adora can't be getting the same thing from it emotionally as Catra is.

Adora can still desire her, even if she feels platonically towards her. Clearly Adora *does* want her, because Adora carefully arranges her hands on Catra's back and flips them over, cautiously laying Catra out on the bed beneath her. Catra blinks up at her in surprise as Adora pulls back to send her a cautious smile.

“This okay?” she asks, her voice soft. Her heartbeat is pounding in Catra’s ears. Catra sends her an encouraging smile, her own heartrate picking up as she nods. As much as she wants Adora to want *her*, the way Adora asks makes her relax into the sheets. It is care, embodying the intimacy that Catra’s shallow touches with other clients have lacked.

Adora smiles a little, seeming encouraged, before she leans down to brace her forearm on the bed beside Catra’s head and kisses her again. This time it is open-mouthed from the start, just a touch hungry. Technically, the embrace isn’t anything different than what they have already done, but it *feels* different.

On Friday night, Adora was so cautious and anxious, she couldn’t take any initiative. Now she seems at ease, letting herself just enjoy running her free hand along Catra’s body as they kiss, firm and *slow* like Adora wants to luxuriate in every second of it. Friday felt like Catra was kissing a ball of nerves, so careful with her but also so *anxious* that she had Catra a bit concerned. Now Adora has done this once, she seems more confident and relaxed.

Catra’s fur stands on end a little as Adora cautiously skates her hand over her chest, not really trying to feel her up, just not obviously avoiding it on her quest to touch Catra. Catra can’t blame her for her caution – Catra has been dreaming about this for years, but Adora is just horny and fortunate to have a hot friend. Catra would be nervous kissing someone she only felt platonically for too, worried about ruining their friendship.

Add on the fact that Adora has hardly kissed anyone before, and Catra is just glad Adora is able to let herself have this much. She is still clearly cautious, but it feels like inexperience and not *fear*. Catra catches herself purring into the kiss, but given the way Adora is kissing her back hungrily, she doesn’t think Adora wants her to stop.

Catra raises one hand to bury it in Adora’s hair, sighing softly when Adora pulls back to kiss her cheek, and then her jaw, and then makes her way down to her *neck*. She hasn’t even done this for Adora yet, not wanting to push her. This is something Adora just *wants* from her. Catra feels her tail lashing beneath her as she arches up into Adora, tilting her head back.

Adora nips at the side of her neck, cautious and experimental. Catra gasps, desire sparking through her. She can’t help it. She’s a magicat – biting each other is kind of a big thing for them. She is purring, heat flooding through her body as Adora follows up with a gentle kiss against the spot.

“You like that?” she asks, her voice soft, but she sounds a little *smug*. Catra flushes, her tail lashing. Adora knows her signals and she knows the answer to that question.

“Shut up, princess,” Catra returns, tilting her chin down to kiss Adora. Adora huffs a laugh and shifts up to kiss her again, lips soft. This kiss is calmer, almost like Adora is trying to soothe her. Catra’s tail was lashing, but it certainly wasn’t from *irritation*. Adora kisses her slowly, careful and gentle with her in a way that really makes her body want to be *not calm*.

Adora pulls back, sending her a hopeful smile as she checks in. Catra’s cheeks flush, but she gives an encouraging smile back. Adora hums with delight, leaning forward again, but this time to squeeze Catra close in a hug. Adora kisses the side of her face, just a quick peck,

before she pulls back to smile down at her again. Apparently she has run out of stamina to push herself, but Catra is proud of her for even going this far.

Adora also opened the floodgates, even if she doesn't know it yet. Catra has nipped while kissing a female client before, but she has never wanted to *bite* like she does with Adora. She truly wants Adora and her instincts tell her to mark her lover, to *have* her. The next time they are kissing on the couch, Catra wants to finally taste Adora's skin.

"Breakfast?" Adora asks, completely unaware of Catra's dirty thoughts. Catra, still flustered, just nods.

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Catra stays all day on Sunday, even finishing her work in the evening. They cuddle, occasionally kissing as they talk. Catra ducks to nip at her neck, ruining Adora on the *spot*. Catra chuckles and jokes that she can't do that when they are trying to hold conversation. Which, unfortunately, means she *stops* after a few exploratory nips and kisses. They return to talking and slow kisses, and Adora forces herself not to be disappointed.

Catra said it is okay to want her, but Adora pushed herself as far as she could in a day already by kissing Catra this morning. She can't ask for something more now. Besides, she likes this too. Catra mostly talks about school while Adora tells her about her current job, including stories about Glimmer and Bow. She wants to make Catra feel more comfortable with the fact that they know the truth. The best way she knows to do that is tell Catra more about them.

"Not that I talk to more than one person in my free time by choice, but do you have anyone else?" Catra asks her, sprawled out beside her on the couch with her head in Adora's lap now so Adora can pet her. Adora is idly playing with her ears, just like she used to do when they were kids. She huffs, rolling her eyes, but she isn't offended.

"I met Mermista when I was sixteen. Glimmer and Bow introduced me to Perfuma. The six of us do things together when we can. Mermista only lives in New York for like a third of the year, and Sea Hawk has been living out of hotel rooms for as along as I've known him, but the rest are here year-round. Glimmer's birthday is this week, actually, so we're going to have a weekend trip to celebrate soon and you can meet them then," Adora promises her, tugging on Catra's ear a little just to communicate that she phrased that like a *brat*.

Catra's tail lashes when Adora tugs on her ear, so Adora does it again, because she is a shit. To her surprise, Catra lifts her head from where she had it buried in her thigh and glares at Adora, her face flushed and eyes blown out.

"*Stop*," she warns. Her voice is rough and a far cry from *annoyed*. Adora flushes and raises her hands in surrender, nodding quickly. She did *not* know the effect that has on Catra – it must be something that started with puberty, because Adora would tug on her ears or tail as a

kid without getting any reaction like *that* – but for some reason seeing it makes her heart warm.

Maybe it is just that Catra was comfortable with telling her to stop. Catra, clearly flustered, drops her head back into Adora's lap. Cautiously, Adora drops her hands to land in Catra's mane instead, petting over it. Against her thigh, Catra huffs.

"You can touch them as much as you want, just don't tug unless our clothes are already off or going to be *soon*," Catra orders her. Well, that's all Adora is going to be thinking about *all evening*, thanks. Their talk last night helped a lot. She isn't so worried about holding back now, especially not with Catra encouraging her like this. She wants badly, but she still needs a bit more time to battle her nerves.

Adora returns to petting Catra's ears, watching the tension in Catra's body release as she slowly relaxes again. After a few moments, Adora takes a risk on massaging the base of Catra's ears and gets purring in response. She decides to return to the previous topic just to break the silence. It isn't awkward, but it also isn't conducive to thinking about anything *but* how sexy Catra's voice sounds when she's turned on.

"Glimmer's birthday will probably be our first public event, unless something comes up last minute. Mermista and Sea Hawk will be there, and the paparazzi are always eager to follow them when they're together. They almost always do something headline-worthy," Adora tells her, watching Catra's ears swivel to listen to her. Catra nods against her leg, butting her head back into Adora's hands. Adora chuckles, but she takes the hint to scratch at the base of her ears.

"I should bring over my fancy clothes, huh?" Catra asks, tilting her head into Adora's hands so Adora can scratch her at the angle she wants. Adora draws in a breath and then nods. She poked around when Catra was working yesterday. She brought very little over, and Adora had done her best not to be disappointed. It was a few outfits and school supplies, mostly. Not that Adora expected Catra to have much in the way of knickknacks, nor for her to bring them over at this stage, but she has had her fantasies about Catra moving in with her for so long, she was really hoping to make them a reality.

"Hope wants to have lunch Saturday after her flight lands in the morning. How about you bring more stuff over on Friday and spend the night again? We can use the SUV to bring more," Adora asks her. Catra snorts against her leg.

"How many cars do you *have*?" she asks. Adora feels a small smile quirk at the edge of her mouth as she carefully presses her fingers against the outer base of both of Catra's ears and instantly watches her go *limp*, huff about the multiple cars forgotten.

"Three. Hope gifted me the Rolls Royce and then I bought the SUV and my Aston Martin. I rent a limo for events where the Rolls won't cut it," Adora informs her. Catra scoffs, turning over in her lap while somehow managing to push her head back into Adora's hands the entire time, making it clear she isn't allowed to stop yet. Catra sends her a mildly disgusted look that has her laughing.

“I needed a more subtle car, hence the Aston Martin, and I needed a car that could accommodate friends easily, hence the SUV. I have the money, Catra, it’s fine. I’ll even buy you a fancy swimsuit for Glimmer’s birthday,” she promises her.

Catra’s eyes go wide with horror.

“*Swimsuit?”* she demands.

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On Monday, Adora texts her asking for the mailing address of her dorm. Catra gives it to her, but she warns her that if she makes her think about this *mountain spa* shit before she has to deal with it, she is going to rip up her mattress when she comes over next. Adora texts her back to check the mail room at five, not acknowledging the threat. She has known Catra for too long to be fooled by her dramatics.

It isn’t a swimsuit or mountain gear for the weird fucking resort Glimmer apparently loves. Catra flushes when she steps into the mailroom and sees an entire vase of flowers sitting on the mailroom desk, a large yellow bow tied around the vase. Catra has never been *flustered* picking up her mail before, but her cheeks are blazing as she shows her school ID and collects the vase.

Adora didn’t go for roses – probably because even Catra knows that roses mean *love* – instead getting her a brilliant bunch of blue and white flowers that Catra doesn’t recognize. All of them are pretty, and it looks like there are three or four varieties in the bouquet, but Catra flushes with the realization that Adora likely got *this* arrangement because it doesn’t have any red flowers in it. Catra does like roses – she quite likes the grey she sees the flowers as – but the consideration isn’t helping her calm her flush.

Catra glares at Lonnie when she steps into their dorm. It doesn’t deter Lonnie from gaping her as Catra sets the arrangement on the counter of their kitchenette and pulls out her phone. She takes a quick picture first, but then she pulls up Adora’s contact.

“I will not be bribed,” Catra greets when Adora answers her phone. Adora laughs immediately. There is sound in the background, clear voices, so she is either at work or in the process of leaving it.

“Who said I’m trying to bribe you? I can’t exactly buy you jewelry, you don’t *wear* it. I know I’m taking you shopping next weekend, but I wanted to send something that could be a *surprise*,” Adora tells her. Catra’s tail lashes, thudding loudly against the kitchen cabinets. It only makes Catra flush worse as she physically grabs her tail to stop it from making the sound again. Over the phone, Adora pauses as Lonnie begins *cackling* at Catra in the background.

Catra huffs, glaring at the bouquet. Fuck her, she *likes* it. She has been given roses by clients before – two months ago she was gifted an orchid that had Lonnie raising her brows as it almost died a swift death before Catra let Rogelio rescue it and sweep it off to his apartment with a proper window – but it was always with the intent of wooing her. This is just Adora enjoying making her flustered, and likely trying to be sweet. From the way she phrases it, maybe she is just trying to be a good *sugar mommy*.

“Cuff links,” Catra sighs, dropping her tail to reach out and lift one of the flowers. She has always liked the way petals feel. They also taste good, but Catra has no clue if these flowers are edible, and she isn’t going to experiment.

“Cuff links?” Adora asks, bewildered. Catra flushes as she carefully strokes a blue flower, its wide petals spread out beneath her fingers.

“If you’re going to insist on hitting all the tropes, cuff links instead of jewelry. But seriously, you don’t *have* to give me gifts,” Catra points out. On the other end of the line, Adora hums, both happy and faux-innocent.

“I’ll take it under advisement,” she responds, her grin *audible*. Catra glares at the flowers. Adora isn’t taking *shit*.

--

Adora finds a magicat bakery and sends Catra sugar-free cookies that are actually edible for her on Wednesday. Glimmer complains that it is *her* birthday and yet Adora is sending sweets to someone else, but there is an entire cake waiting for her in the office fridge and they all know she is joking. Catra doesn’t even pretend to be upset by the cookies, she likes them far too much. Adora can’t send her chocolates, but just like she can’t send her jewelry, there are work arounds.

Adora doesn’t really know what she is doing, other than spoiling Catra. Gifts are definitely supposed to be a part of this kind of relationship, but she knows they pretty much have that covered with Adora’s weekly payments. She just wants to give Catra nice things, make her smile, and maybe fluster her a little.

Glimmer and Bow mock her *mercilessly* when they meet up for their lunches together in the break room, but they are somewhat limited in how badly they can roast her by the fact they are in public and Adora has made it clear to them that to everybody else this is just supposed to be a normal relationship. Well, at least as normal as anything can be with her. Catra comes over on Wednesday night, bringing over some homework and working on it in her study for nearly three hours.

“This room is good for my concentration,” Catra tells her with a shrug as she stands to stretch and then pads across the room to curl up on the couch beside Adora. Adora immediately wraps an arm around her shoulders and smiles to herself as Catra tucks down into her side.

“I would think I would be bad for it,” Adora returns, but she takes the opportunity of Catra’s break to press a kiss to her temple. Catra tilts her head back, clearly offering a proper kiss. Adora is happy to take the invitation.

They make out a little, until Adora is sprawled out on her back and cautiously roaming her hands over Catra, but eventually Catra pulls back with a reluctant sigh and warns Adora she has to return to her work. Adora kisses her one last time and then smiles as she watches her go. It is so *easy*, Catra wandering into her arms and then back out again to finish what she has to do.

It is like all her fantasies, only this one is real, and now Adora gets to *keep* her.

--

Frosta picks Catra up on Friday night so she can pack a few more outfits into the trunk, especially her things in garment bags. She leaves her suits on campus – she only has three, and she needs them for her program – but she takes all the dresses she has acquired for jobs with her, in addition to more clothes. She accidentally spent Wednesday night at the penthouse, working until late and then making out until Adora was going to bed anyway and asked if she would stay.

Frosta drove her home in the morning so she didn’t have to wake up too much earlier than usual, but Catra still had to run up to her dorm and change quickly before her eight AM class. She would like to have more options at Adora’s place. She lays the garment bags out in the backseat of the SUV and Frosta helps her carry the clothes up to the penthouse. Adora is waiting in the foyer and takes the bags in Frosta’s arms from her so she can help Catra the rest of the way.

As they are hanging things up in the corner of her closet that Adora cleared for Catra, Catra can’t help but notice Adora frowning.

“What? Not all of us have walk-in closets, much less the money to fill them,” Catra points out. She knows she still didn’t bring all that much, but this is half her wardrobe. Adora hesitates, but something is clearly bothering her. After a moment, she gestures to the six dresses Catra brought with her.

“I thought you didn’t like them,” is all she offers, peering at Catra like she is expecting to be corrected. Catra frowns. Amongst her clothes, she also brought her fake contact, not because she plans to use it, but so she has it somewhere safe when Lonnie won’t accidentally – or “accidentally” – find it. Now she doesn’t need these things, she likes the idea of tucking them away and forgetting about them.

“I don’t, but clients generally expect it. Two of those were gifts from clients, actually. I don’t like wearing shoes either, but sometimes I do it when formal functions call for it,” Catra

points out. Adora winces, looking away quickly and nodding, but she looks *pained*. Catra's tail lashes as she turns away, her heart pounding a little.

"You did plenty of uncomfortable things for your job too, Adora. Don't think I couldn't tell how much you hated every live performance. It was just something I had to do for work," Catra points out, shrugging despite how she feels anything but *casual*. Senior year of high school, Adora had a concert at the local venue. Catra had to deal with merch sporting Adora's *face* greeting her at nearly every turn between the t-shirts and tote bags and whatever other merch people bought at the concert for weeks afterwards.

Catra didn't go to the concert. She couldn't afford it - she was living out of a shelter after turning eighteen and being kicked out of Shadow's - and she couldn't stand to go watch Adora be miserable on stage anyway. Adora is lucky she sings ballads and people assumed she was getting into the music rather than hating her life. Not that Catra thinks Adora's emotions were as obvious to other people, but her tells never changed, so Catra knew even from footage alone. Behind her, Adora sighs.

"You're right. I just don't like thinking about you having to be uncomfortable. I- If I *ever* ask you for something you don't want, tell me, okay?" Adora requests from behind her. Catra blows out a breath. It *feels* like her reaction is just because of what Catra's job was, but she can let it go even if she is certain Adora wouldn't have reacted the same to Catra hating the uniform a *normal* job had given her.

She turns back around to find Adora looking at her imploringly. She rolls her eyes, reaching out and snatching one of the dresses off the hanger rod and dropping it to the floor, letting it crumple there to make a point.

"I've never let a client take advantage of me and I'm not starting now. I know I can say no with you," Catra tells her. Adora doesn't look completely comforted, but she nods. Catra turns back to hanging up her clothes, and after a hesitant moment, Adora returns to helping. Neither of them acknowledges the dress lying on the floor, nor the five others still on the rack.

If Adora asked her to put it on, she would have said no. It didn't make her uncomfortable enough to be worth fighting over, but she also knows she wouldn't have had to *fight* Adora on it.

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After they finish in the closet, Catra takes her hand and leads them outside. She wants to nap, apparently, settling on the outdoor couch and curling up in the late afternoon sun. Adora settles next to her, where she can easily rest one hand on Catra and pet her while she scrolls through the internet on her phone.

After Catra has fallen asleep, Adora get a text from Hope asking how things are going with Catra, and Adora responds by sending her a photo of Catra curled up in ball, soaking in the setting sun. The grapevines are trailing down the trellis above her, swaying lightly in the breeze, but the sun is pouring in from an angle. Hope texts back a *joke* about Adora adopting a cat rather than getting a girlfriend, and Adora calls Hope in response, worried she has been kidnapped.

"You don't make jokes," Adora hisses when Hope laughs at her demand to know if she is alright. Adora keeps her voice low so she doesn't wake Catra. The semester is wrapping up and Catra has been drowning in work. She needs her rest, even if Adora also knows for a fact Catra would be napping right now regardless of her workload. Magicats are just *like* that.

"I'm just happy you've found a solution. And maybe I've had a glass of wine. My afternoon meeting did not go to plan," Hope admits. Adora snorts, reaching over to flick a fallen leaf off Catra before she responds.

"Have a glass when you come over to meet her then. She is abrasive. Kind of ideal for fending off paparazzi, actually," Adora admits. Hope *hms*. Adora can tell from her tone that her attention is split – likely she is doing something on one of her other phones.

"My plane lands at eleven. I'll come over straight from the airport. I have an NDA for her to sign," Hope tells her. Adora closes her eyes and groans, entirely forgetting herself until the groan is met by Catra making a soft *mrrph*.

Adora sucks in a sharp breath, cracking an eye open to look down and find Catra blinking blearily at her, the ear she isn't laying on twitching about as she gets a handle on her surroundings again. Adora mouths *sorry* to her, standing and walking over to the door into the bedroom. The wall separating it from the terrace is glass, so she keeps going into her office so her phone call doesn't disturb Catra again.

"You know the things she knows about me could never fit in an NDA anyway? And it isn't *necessary*. It would ruin her career the same as mine if it got out," Adora points out. She really doesn't want to make Catra sign anything. Actually- *fuck this*. "No, I'm putting my foot down. It would make her uncomfortable. You didn't make Glimmer or Bow sign NDAs to talk to me. She's my friend," Adora tells Hope. The other end of the line is silent for a moment.

"It is just on the agreement between the two of you. It doesn't cover anything you might tell her in confidence, or-"

"*No*. I'm not having her sign shit. It's controlling," Adora returns. The silence stretches between them, Adora's heart pounding and her free hand shaking a little, though she isn't sure why. She almost always has this reaction when she rejects Hope though. Lingering trauma from Shadow's reactions to disobedience, probably, but Adora isn't in the mood to psychoanalyze herself.

"You're not abusive for protecting yourself, Adora," Hope says, softly. Adora scowls. She knows that, but Catra has been held down by people enough. Adora just wants to be with her

friend without all the bullshit of fame in the way, even if that is what brought them together initially.

“If you bring an NDA to lunch, I’m kicking you out of the penthouse. She is the one fucking thing I have that wasn’t touched by fame. Leave it. She isn’t going to tell anyone. She practically begged me not to tell Glimmer and Bow,” Adora returns. Outside her door, Adora hears a slight scrape in the deafening silence that follows her statement. She whips around in her chair, blinking at the office door.

Everything is quiet for a moment before there is an audible sigh and the door opens. Catra looks a bit sheepish, one arm wrapped around herself as she avoids Adora’s eyes, creeping into the room almost like she thinks she is in *trouble*.

“You left really quickly. I was worried,” Catra murmurs, her ears pinned back. Adora swallows, realizing she must have overheard a decent chunk of that. She clearly feels bad for eavesdropping, but she also looks generally uncomfortable. On the other end of the line, Hope sighs softly, drawing Adora’s attention back to her phone. Catra’s ears perk up, alert and listening, more than capable of hearing both sides of Adora’s conversation even across the room.

“Fine, Adora. But you have to realize I’m worried she is manipulating you using your past connection,” Hope says. Both Adora and Catra scowl at that, but before Adora can open her mouth to protest, Catra starts forward across the room. Adora draws to a halt, blinking at Catra as she approaches and then hovers uncertainly right in front of her. Adora leans back in her desk chair, shifting to make room, and Catra relaxes a little, crawling into her lap.

“What’s the NDA for?” she asks, even though Adora knows she must have overheard that part. On the other end of the line, Hope pauses. Catra said it softly, but now she is in Adora’s lap, she is definitely close enough for the microphone to pick it up. Adora must pull a face, because Catra rolls her eyes. “It’s not *controlling* if I’m not going to say something anyway. If it just says I’ll keep the arrangement secret, I can sign that. I’m a law student, Adora. I know how these things work,” Catra tells her.

Adora blinks at her. She can practically sense Hope lighting up from across the country but-

“No. I trust you. I don’t need it. Like you said, it wouldn’t matter if you signed it either way. I don’t want to keep living like this,” Adora insists. It is Catra’s turn to be surprised, but her expression softens and she nods, leaning forward to press a soft kiss to Adora’s forehead.

“Okay. We won’t. But I’m not insulted,” Catra assures her before slipping out of her lap, sending her one last encouraging smile before she pads from the room, carefully closing the door behind her to give Adora privacy. Adora sighs, still watching the shut door for long moment, even as she hears the terrace door thud shut as well, signaling Catra’s departure.

“Okay. No NDA. I’ll be over around noon tomorrow. I trust your decisions, Adora, I just don’t trust *people*,” Hope tells her. Adora sighs, running a hand down her face and nodding to the empty room.

“I know. I know why you’re worried. But I promise, we’re not like that. She isn’t. You’ll see tomorrow,” Adora promises her.

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“Who do you want me to be?” Catra asks Adora when she gets the text from Hope that she is on her way over. Adora blinks at her in utter confusion. Catra rolls her eyes. “My job is usually acting to a client’s expectations. I can be the sweet girl you knew once, or the hard ass law student, or-“

“*You*,” Adora cuts in, seeming bewildered. Catra raises an eyebrow at her. “Just you. I really don’t give a shit what she thinks, but she’ll probably be able to tell if you’re lying and that certainly won’t endear you to her,” Adora responds, shrugging. Catra purses her lips, but she nods. She doesn’t *like* being herself. If someone dislikes a persona, who fucking cares, but showing her true face leaves her open for judgement.

This isn’t a normal client event, though. She just has to remember that. Adora isn’t going to care if she says the wrong thing. She isn’t here to stroke anyone’s ego and keep them from being an embarrassment. For some reason, that knowledge leaves her worried about making a fool of *herself* instead. She practically interrogated Adora about what she should wear when they were getting ready this morning and Adora was wholly unhelpful.

In Adora’s defence, Catra chose to interrogate her by stalking out of the closet in just her underwear when she realized she didn’t know what kind of lunch this was going to be, but they used to change together in the group home and it was never a problem then. Apparently now Adora has touched her tits, she can’t look at them without turning bright red. Adora spent most of the conversation flushed and staring at the ceiling.

Adora is in ripped boyfriend jeans and a t-shirt for some shark-based horror movie. Catra followed her lead, wearing her black jeans and a navy jersey tee. She just has to hope that Adora isn’t off-base here and Hope doesn’t give a shit. Given how the last two weeks have gone, Catra is pretty sure that Adora won’t give a shit if Hope doesn’t approve of Catra as her fake girlfriend, but Catra is *worried*.

Hope scares her. It feels stupid, but it has always been true. For years Catra was worried that Hope was abusing Adora the same way Shadow was – part of her still isn’t convinced otherwise, actually – and she knows this woman has hurt Adora, intentionally or not. Then again, Adora has hurt *her* unintentionally, and Catra has forgiven her for that. Adora didn’t have a choice in leaving her, though – Hope is the one who forced her to do so.

“Hey, it’s going to be okay,” Adora assures, her voice soft as she wraps an arm around Catra’s shoulders and squeezes her close. Catra’s ears are pinned back in anxiety, but she nods. Adora leans over, pressing a kiss against the base of her ear. “Nothing is going to separate us now, okay?” Adora promises her, a soft whisper into her hair.

Catra relaxes a little, nodding and leaning into Adora's embrace. Hope was already responsible for separating them once. Catra couldn't take it happening again, not now that she knows what it is like to truly be in Adora's arms. She has no intention of letting that happen, though, and it seems neither does Adora.

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Adora takes one look at Hope, noting her expression and the fact that she flew in her suit on a *Saturday*, and knows she brought the NDA, though she doesn't bring it up. Hope bends down to hug her, which Adora accepts eagerly. Hugs from Hope are *fantastic*. Hope is a bit awkward about them, but she has gotten better over the years, and it's kind of like hugging a bear from size alone. Adora used to hide in Hope's arms before a performance that she was especially anxious for.

Catra hugs are still better, though. Catra clutches back like she doesn't want Adora to ever let her go, and it makes her entire chest warm. Catra is also *soft*, and every hug with her is a bit snuggly in a way Hope will never be. Hope's hugs are good by virtue of her size, but she isn't cuddly. Adora steps out of Hopes arms and gestures to Catra, wrapping a protective arm around her waist and pulling her in close. Catra flushes, but she allows it, giving Hope a bit of a cautious smile and wave.

"This is Catra," Adora introduces. In truth, she is putting her arm around Catra to signal to her that she doesn't have to worry trying to hug Hope just because Adora did. Hope is not, in general, a *hugger*. That is pretty much just a *them* thing. Catra also doesn't hug strangers, even if she is really touchy with those that she does like. There is no need for any of them to subject themselves to that awkwardness.

"Pleased to meet you," Hope offers, extending a hand to shake that Catra takes somewhat gratefully.

"We've actually met before. When you were taking Adora away. But I don't expect you to remember that," Catra corrects, shaking Hope's hand and then retreating into Adora's side again. Adora squeezes her arm around Catra, a silent *proud of you*. She knows this whole thing has to be awkward for her. Hope blinks in surprise, but then she just nods graciously.

"Ah, of course. I cannot say I recall it, but we were on a rather tight schedule then. I am glad you were able to find each other again," Hope returns. Catra's tail lashes once, smacking against the back of Adora's knees, but she just nods, her expression a little blank. Adora met Hope exactly once before she was whisked away from the home. Thirty minutes together, and then Adora was finding out the adoption went through and being told to pack her things. Apparently the whole process was rushed because Hope was about to fly out for LA again.

Hope reached the home, said hello while her driver loaded Adora's few things into the trunk and Catra lurked in the dining room, and then Hope was pulling her towards the car. Adora looked back at the house, saw Catra's face in the window, and realized that even though they

had been saying goodbye ever since they found out, she hadn't gotten to say *goodbye*. She sprinted back up the porch, right past Shadow. Shadow and Hope immediately began calling for her, but Adora tore into the dining room and threw her arms around Catra, hugging her close.

"I'll find a way to call you, okay? This isn't goodbye," Adora promised her as the adults rushed into the room. Catra clutched her back, nodding into her shoulder as silent tears soaked her shirt. Once Hope saw what Adora was doing, she assured Shadow that her flight could wait a *minute* for the girls to say goodbye. Sixty seconds wasn't nearly enough. Hope placed a light hand on Adora's shoulder, Shadow placed a bruising one on Catra's, and they were encouraged to part as Hope reminded Adora they were on a schedule.

It ended up being goodbye. Adora tightens her arm a little more around Catra's waist.

"How was your trip?" she prompts, because she needs to change the subject and bury the memory. Hope sends Adora her *you aren't bullshitting me* look, but she launches into detailing her past month as they make their way to the dining room. Adora only drops her arm from Catra to pull out her chair for her, and once they have sat beside each other, facing Hope on the other side of the table, Adora takes up Catra's hand beneath the table.

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Catra didn't know what to expect from Hope. She always seemed like a cold, hard statue when she occasionally ended up on camera. When she visited the home, she had been nice enough, but it felt *forced*. Catra was worried it was an act to hide an abusive stage mom personality.

It turns out affection really just is hard for her. Catra can see her *trying* all throughout lunch. She asks Adora to tell her about work, and chides her when she asks if Adora checked the tabloids after the event and Adora admits she did.

"Why do you keep torturing yourself? I'll let you know if anything happens with PR that you really need to know about," Hope tells her, expression slightly pinched. Her face is a bit immobile – Catra would guess Botox, because the entertainment industry is *like that* – but she seems genuinely distressed. Adora sighs, shrugging. She dropped Catra's hand to eat, but Catra has her left hand on Adora's knee so she can still anchor her.

"I know. I know it just makes me depressed, and it shouldn't even *matter* anymore, but- if I *know* there's going to be something, I have to check. I have to know what they said. You know half the articles made me out to be some predatory lesbian? They said I was the reason Mermista and Sea Hawk broke up, like Sea Hawk didn't set something on fire *three weeks before*," Adora says, slumping in her seat.

Catra's heart feels like it is being twisted out like a rag. She scoots her chair closer and leans into Adora's side. She can't help but wonder if shit like this is a contributing factor to

Adora's caution when it comes to actually touching her. Adora's scent could be laced with desire and hunger, but she would still keep her hands on Catra's hips, holding herself back. Catra is suddenly intensely grateful for their talk last week.

Adora hasn't brought up much about the industry and Catra hasn't asked, but she learns a decent amount over the course of lunch just from what Hope says. Hope brings up a story from when Adora was seventeen and on her first tour that has Catra both snickering and *aching*. It is funny to picture all the antics Adora got up to backstage, but heartbreaking to know they were distraction techniques to keep her from having a panic attack before going on stage.

"Why did you keep doing shows after that?" Catra asks softly, trying not to sound accusatory. That is why she asks Adora, who she isn't mad at and didn't have a choice, instead of Hope. She woudn't be able to keep the venom out of her voice if she was addressing Hope. Adora's expression turns a bit sad. After a moment of silence, Hope answers for her.

"We didn't know touring would be like that for Adora. At least, I didn't. I should have predicted it given how much anxiety she had then, but-"

"I hid it. Stop. We've had this talk. I didn't let you see me have a panic attack until after the tour had already started," Adora cuts in, heaving a sigh. Catra looks between the pair. Adora glances at her expression and winces, reaching a hand up to run it down her face. "Listen, Shadow… conditioned me. I thought if I ever said no, ever let a crack show, then Hope would suddenly react like her - *turn into* her. I told Hope things were okay because I thought she wanted to hear it, and she accepted it at face value. I didn't tell her I was abused until I was twenty-one," Adora explains, gesturing with her hand as she talks before dropping them into her lap, wringing them instead.

She says the word *conditioned* like she expects it to be surprise – and like she is *ashamed* of it. Her expression is pained. She is seemingly exhausted by the admission. Catra swallows, nodding, and then half stands a little in her seat so she can sweep her tail over underneath her. She drops it into Adora's lap as she settles back into her seat. Adora blows out a slow breath and takes up Catra's tail gratefully, running her fingers along it for something solid. On the other side of the table, Hope watches them silently. After a moment, she sighs.

"It was too late to cancel the tour. I canceled my business trips and the like so I could be there with her the whole way, but it was still hard. We had announced a world tour would follow if the initial tour sold well, and it did, but we weren't committed to it already, so we immediately dropped the plans. We made sure to only do small mini-tours after that. Small venues, extra time between, and only a few shows. She was still anxious, but they were much easier on her," Hope explains.

Catra still doesn't like it – that should have been the sign that Adora wasn't built for *any* of this, but both Adora and Hope look pained even discussing it. Adora has told her that she and Hope have cleared the air a bit, but that there is too much to ever get through fully. As much as Catra wants to chew Hope out, pushing it now isn't going to help. It's just bringing up bad memories.

Adora doesn't have to do any of that bullshit anymore. Catra hasn't heard her sing a single note since her performance at the gala. She hums still, but she always did that. It used to drive Shadow up the wall. Catra always liked it, but of course she would – it was Adora's way of purring. Across the table, Hope clears her throat.

"Please, tell me about your studies, Catra. Why law?" she requests. As much as Catra went into this dinner not wanting to discuss herself, now she is grateful for the chance to change gears.

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Catra talks about how she wanted to change the world before she realized she wouldn't be able to keep her lights on taking those kinds of cases.

"I wanted my name to be the next that pushed a case before the Supreme Court and forced a new precedent. I wanted to fight the cases that brought injustices to light and rallied people behind efforts for change. I didn't want anyone else to go through what we did," Catra rants, gesturing with her hands as her momentum builds.

Her claws are out, the surest sign that her emotions are running high. Her eyes are practically sparkling with dedication. The sight of her so riled up is enough to take Adora's breath away. Catra keeps using past tense, but nothing about her demeanor is *passive*. They only touched on this briefly in their first dinner. Now, Adora can see the passion never died, but was merely temporarily quieted.

"What changed?" Hope asks, because she still has air left in her lungs, *somehow*. Adora wants to do nothing but watch Catra lit up like this for the rest of her life. Catra pauses and then *deflates*. Adora's heart falls. She squeezes Catra's tail, still laid across her lap. There isn't much she can do to comfort her friend, though. Catra sighs.

"In order to get to that level, you have to fight hundreds of little cases first. Build up a reputation until you are trusted enough to be given *the* case that could make its way up through the courts. And those cases are depressing, with very little compensation. I couldn't *afford* to get to that level. I focus on civil suits now. At least I can still help people that have been wronged," Catra explains.

Hope looks thoughtful, nodding as Catra talks. Adora just hurts. All that passion, drained away. She gets the first part of the argument. She has done plenty of charity work that left her crying in bed that night after seeing people in such hard situations, eaten up by life. But the latter she could *help* with, if Catra was willing to let her. Hope's gaze is calculating as she looks between them.

"Adora is passionate about helping people as well, I suspect for the same reasons. I'm sure she would be more than happy to support her partner as long as you need. Money also affords

the ability to pay for therapy to assist with negative psychological effects," Hope points out. Adora and Catra both flush.

Hope is right – Adora would gladly support Catra for the rest of her life, and honestly they *both* should go to therapy – but it is the *her partner* thing that has Adora flushing. Catra coughs awkwardly, shooting Adora a *help* look. Adora squeezes her tail, sending Catra a sheepish smile back.

"I mean, she's right? I would happily have you here as long as you want, so you wouldn't have *lights* you needed to keep on, and it isn't like you wouldn't still be making money and contributing. This doesn't have to end when you graduate if you don't want it to. I like having you around," Adora offers. Catra's tail lashes in her lap, pulling it out of Adora's hands. She is visibly flustered as she quickly looks away, her cheeks blazing and her fur fluffing up just a little.

"I should get back. I need rest after so long away. It was a pleasure to meet you, Catra. I trust you'll take good care of Adora," Hope cuts in from the other side of the table, a small, secretive smile tugging at her lips as she goes to stand. The final part of her sentence Adora is certain would have been a threat if she had greeted Catra with it, but now she just sounds *sincere*.

"I'll walk you out," Adora offers, carefully pushing Catra's stiff tail out of her lap. She wants to give Catra some privacy after that. She is still very flustered, and Adora knows how Catra has always felt about being vulnerable in front of other people. Catra waves them off, but her cheeks are still red.

"I approve of her," Hope tells Adora, with a sparkle in her eyes, when they step into the elevator together, leaving Catra in the dining room. Adora smiles to herself, nodding a little too exuberantly as she bounces on her heels. Hope's lips quirk in a smile as she pulls out her phone to text her driver. Parts of lunch were definitely awkward – actually, a lot of it was – but Adora is feeling good. Catra doesn't seem to hate Hope, and Hope *approves*, so all things considered, it wasn't the dumpster fire it could have been.

"I'm glad," Adora returns, because she *is*. Her and Hope's relationship may be strained and likely always will be, but she wants Hope in her life, and she would like for her to get along with the single person who is most important to her. Adora sees Hope off in her Rolls Royce – a matching pair to the one that Adora has – and then turns back to the elevator. Now to hope that Catra is doing fine and lunch really did go as well as it appeared to.

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Catra insists she needs to work now both because it is true and because she needs the space. Adora is visibly concerned, so Catra backs her against the nearest wall and kisses her until she is breathless, and then she vanishes into the study.

Part of what made Catra choose law was her desire to fight for the justice she was never given as a child, and part of it was just that she needed *money*, but the rest of it was because law is fucking hard. Her brain is built well to remember cases, precedents, and legal loopholes, but every single case still requires brainpower, careful verbal jockeying, and charisma. It was a way to challenge and *prove* herself.

She isn't in the courtroom right now, and she still has room to think as she works her way through her homework. She can hear Adora moving about the house, and a few times she comes in the room reeking of anxiety, but every time Catra takes a break to kiss her on the couch until Adora's body is relaxed again and her worry has eased. It comes *back*, but it always does.

The thing is, Catra's job always had a very definite end date – when she paid her last tuition bill if she could swing it, but otherwise the day she had passed the bar and managed to get hired at a law office. When they defined the arrangement – how much Adora would pay, how often, and how *long* – they decided that the arrangement would last until Catra passed the bar. That way she could focus on getting licensed to practice without the extra anxiety of feeding herself. At that point, Adora said they would re-evaluate.

Catra never really considered that they might keep this *up*. She thought of the "revaluation" as being for if she hadn't managed to get a job by then. She didn't consider that Adora offered it because she wanted Catra to stay after. Catra figured that Adora would have been retired for long enough by then that the paparazzi would be long gone. There wouldn't be any cameras to fake for, the world moved on to the next hot young boyband or whatever.

Adora comes into the office again. She isn't as worried as she has been the last few times, but she is still nervous – nervous about Catra, and how she is doing. They never debriefed after lunch, Catra fleeing too quickly. Catra sighs, marking her spot and closing her casebook.

"Come on," she orders, standing and crossing the room to offer Adora her hand. Adora lights up, taking it and lacing their fingers together happily. She lets herself be led out to the bedroom so they can settle on the bed. Catra encourages Adora to sit and then crawls into her lap. Adora immediately wraps her arms around her, hauling Catra close and nuzzling into her hair.

"What Hope said. You would seriously want to still be doing this?" Catra asks, not looking at her. She doesn't mean for it to sound so accusatory. Adora winces at the same time that Catra does.

"It doesn't have to be this. I have a guest room, you know. I just – can't imagine living apart again. I already hate the nights when you don't stay over. I get that you don't want to- be a sugar baby forever," Adora winces again saying it, "but I would like for my best friend to stick around. You wouldn't have to pay for the expense of real estate in New York. If you think you would like to stay," Adora offers.

That makes Catra relax a little. She kind of already hates the idea of Adora moving on from their "relationship" to look for a real one, but if she could still be around Adora-

It would be so *hard*, being so close and seeing Adora move on with someone else, but it won't *necessarily* happen like that, and Catra knows she could never keep herself away from Adora regardless. Even when she thought Adora had carelessly abandoned her, she still followed her in the press and online. If she is going to torture herself with it regardless, might as well have front row seats, right?

Fuck, why does she have to be weak like this.

"You don't have to decide now. I just want you to be able to do what you really *want* in life. I'm so much happier now, working with charities and stuff. I want you to have that too," Adora tells her, pressing a soft kiss against her ear. Catra's heart pounds.

Yeah, there's another problem – so does she.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: Catra acquires a swimsuit.

Weekend Getaway

Chapter Notes

I have a meta page on my tumblr that has links to all the meta posts for this fic if you've missed any. I'll be posting more after Chapter 6 and Chapter 7, probably.
Picking up the Monday after dinner with Hope.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra spends all weekend at Adora's again, but she thinks it is safe to assume she is going to *keep* doing that going forward. When she gets an email alert on Monday that there is a package waiting for her in the mailroom, she rolls her eyes, well aware she didn't *order* anything.

You saw me yesterday.

So you're not coming over tonight then?

Adora never asked her to come over and she is just being obtuse *on purpose*. Catra scoffs to herself, earning Lonnie's attention for a moment. Catra quickly shuffles her position at her desk so Lonnie can't see her phone screen. Not like a human should be able to read it from across the room anyway, but just to be safe.

If you want me to have time to go shopping this weekend, no. But if you'd prefer I didn't have a swimsuit and can't come to the resort, then I'll be over in five.

You don't have to swim. Or come if you don't want to.

Catra sighs. They had this talk already. Glimmer's birthday was last week, on the first. Unfortunately, it was in the middle of the work week, there was some political event that weekend, and this weekend is going to be a Winterfest-themed charity drive that Glimmer helped arrange. As such, her resort getaway weekend is taking place on the third weekend in December – right after finals end, so Catra has no excuse not to go.

She actually *does* have some work to do over the break, but it won't take up much time. She can easily go away for the weekend, and honestly she would *like* to. She has never had a

vacation in her life, and the resort sounds nice except for the swimming part. Adora assures her they have services for magicats, but Catra is still going to end up swimming with the group at their private pool.

Help me move my stuff out and I'll come. What did you send me?

Open it and find out.

Catra sighs and gathers her keycard, setting out for the mailroom. Her last final is on Thursday next week and they are leaving that Friday afternoon for the resort. By Saturday, everybody has to have anything they need access to over break collected from their dorms. Adora promised to help her move out Thursday night. Catra usually takes just enough to get by while school is out and stays in the cheapest motel she can find for the month. When she told Adora that yesterday, however, Adora had been mildly horrified.

After her last final, Catra will be loading her life into Adora's SUV and living with her fake girlfriend for a month. She is, unfortunately, looking forward to it. She loves being able to *breathe* over the break, but she usually has to squeeze in as many clients as she can and live in dirt poor conditions. This time she will get to spend every night in the nicest bed she has ever encountered. She won't have to deal with clients - especially lonely from the holidays - groping her and trying to make a pass at her. She can just relax into Adora's arms and actually *enjoy* the touches she does get.

Catra is surprised to enter the mailroom and find only a small box waiting for her behind the counter. Curious, she slices it open with her claws while riding the elevator back up to her dorm. Inside is a small jewelry box, and it immediately clicks into place for her. She smiles to herself as she opens the black box to find a subtle pair of gold cufflinks in a triangular shape waiting for her. Knowing Adora, she doesn't doubt they are real gold.

She puts the lid back on the box, still smiling as she makes her way back to her suite. She passes the garbage cans on the floor as she goes, dropping the shipping box in. Luckily, she is wearing sweatpants. She easily slips the small jewelry box into her pocket to conceal it.

When Catra arrives back at the dorm, Lonnie glances at her, finds nothing of interest, and returns to ignoring her. The next time Lonnie gets up to use the bathroom, Catra uses the moment of solitude to stow the cufflinks away where she used to store her contacts. Not that she *has* to hide them – she could always say they are fake gold and it wouldn't seem like a big deal – but she kind of just wants to.

The very thought of the box is making her chest warm. She wants to keep it a secret.

--

Adora hasn't gotten to see Catra since *Sunday*. She knows she went ten years without her and survived, but she is certain she couldn't do the same now. Catra rolls her eyes as she climbs into the back of the Rolls Royce with Adora.

"I have more cufflinks than suits now, you-" she starts, cutting off when Adora immediately reaches for her upon the car door closing behind her. Yes, okay, sending Catra a set of cufflinks for every day of the week is a bit excessive, but right now Adora has other concerns. Catra trills with amusement as Adora pulls her by the hand into her lap. Frosta releases an *ugh* and Adora can hear the telltale sound of the divider between the front and backseat being rolled up, but Adora isn't looking away from Catra to *see* it.

Catra's eyes are dancing with amusement, the tip of her tail twitching as she settles to straddle across Adora's lap. Adora carefully wraps her arms around Catra's back and pulls her close. For a moment, she just nuzzles Catra's cheek, reveling in the feeling of her soft fur against her and breathing her in. It also gives Catra a minute to process. As badly as Adora has missed her, she doesn't want to *jump* her.

"Missed me that much, huh, princess?" Catra purrs to her, her voice low and seductive. Adora shivers a little, nodding against Catra's cheek. She wonders if Catra can see her flush this close, but she isn't opening her eyes to find out. Catra chuckles, but it sounds appreciative rather than mocking. Adora feels a lot calmer now she has Catra in her arms.

She was starting to go through separation anxiety like a fucking *golden retriever*. Glimmer and Bow were mocking her relentlessly at work, but though she and Catra have managed to text on and off all week, they have only called once and even that isn't the same as getting to hold her. Catra has a lot of work leading into finals, and she just hasn't had the time until now. Adora was hoping she would come over on Friday, but last night Catra texted her she hadn't gotten through enough of her work yet. If they didn't want to cancel their shopping trip, she was going to have to wait until Saturday to come over.

"One more week of school. Then I'm all yours, princess. I promise," Catra tells her. Adora groans, entirely unconsciously, as her hands flex on Catra's back and she finally tilts her chin up to kiss Catra hungrily.

"There are children present!" Frosta calls from the front seat, through the divider. Apparently she heard the groan, but all they are doing is kissing, and it isn't like she can see anything *anyway*. Catra snorts a little, but when Adora nudges against her cheek, she sets back to kissing her. Adora practically breathes a sigh of relief, her entire body feeling lighter with Catra in her lap.

She doesn't know why she was so nervous about not seeing Catra, except she totally does. She was worried Catra would somehow vanish like she did ten years ago, or that Adora had done something to make her uncomfortable over the weekend and Catra was avoiding her, even though she knew Catra had good reason to be busy. She feels at ease now Catra is sliding her hands down her body and kissing her back with just as much passion.

Catra breaks from the kiss, causing Adora to release a small sound of disappointment before she can stop herself. Catra chuckles as she ducks down to Adora's neck, reaching a hand up to pull the collar of her sweater aside. Adora flushes as she realizes what Catra is doing, disappointment thoroughly *gone*. Catra nuzzles against her neck, pressing a soft kiss there before parting her lips. Adora lets out a shaky sigh as Catra licks along the line of her neck, dragging her rough tongue along her skin *slowly*. It feels so good on its own, but especially because Adora knows what it is a precursor to.

"Bite your lip, princess," Catra warns in a whisper. The warning alone is almost enough to make Adora moan, but she quickly follows orders. She doesn't want Frosta to hear her moaning, even if she likely knows what is happening in the backseat. Catra licks against her neck again. Adora suppresses the sigh that wants to release, sliding her hands to Catra's hips and squeezing in a silent request.

Catra bites down on the join of her neck and shoulder. It is through *tremendous* effort that Adora doesn't moan, her grip on Catra spasming as Catra purrs with satisfaction, her tail lashing from her excitement. She releases Adora's neck, pressing a soft kiss against the spot as Adora does her best to resume breathing.

"Something to remember me by," Catra purrs to her, straightening a bit to kiss her again. Adora meets her gratefully, her skin feeling hot and the spot on her neck pulsing dully. Catra bit *hard* and Adora wouldn't be surprised if there was a mark left. Catra nipped her a few times the last time they made out – apparently she really likes to do it - and Adora was kind of disappointed that there weren't any marks left afterwards.

She didn't *think* she was obvious about it at the time, but given the pressure Catra just used out the gate, she kind of suspects she was. Luckily, the boutique she is taking Catra to is twenty minutes away. They have plenty of time to try again if that one didn't take.

--

Catra really doesn't understand the appeal of swimming outdoors, in the mountains, in New York, in *December*. She will never understand rich people, torturing themselves on their vacation for fun.

"It *is* fun. The shock of the cold when you're getting in makes the heat feel incredible, and when you get out, it gives you an adrenaline rush and a mini high. You'll see," Adora promises her as they wander through the racks of the swimsuit boutique. Catra has only owned a swimsuit once before, and it was a one piece when she was little. All the kids were taught to swim and then Catra never did it again.

Despite her instincts saying *more layers*, she wants a bikini. Peeling that one piece off her wet fur had been fucking miserable. Apparently you're supposed to have a bikini anyway to wear during treatments if you don't want to get naked – which she *doesn't*. When they were

planning this shopping trip, Adora admitted she normally wears rashguard tops to swim, but for the spa she switches to a sports bikini.

“You sound like a masochist,” Catra returns as she reluctantly picks a string bikini off a rack. As much as she doesn’t want to fiddle with the strings, they will let her get the suit off her fur as soon as possible when it is time to remove it. She suspects they are going to be her best option. Adora is silent behind her. Catra turns to raise an eyebrow at her. Adora looks away quickly, her face flushed.

“What? You saw me in less than this *last week*,” Catra points out, brandishing the bikini in Adora’s direction. Catra doesn’t subscribe to bras as a concept. She was in just her underwear when she stalked out of the closet to confront Adora on what she should wear for their lunch with Hope. That doesn’t seem to comfort Adora. She just flushes more, opening and closing her mouth a few times before she seems to *give up*.

Well, if it’s going to be like that, Catra is happy to play. Not that Adora *intended* to throw down the gauntlet, but now Catra is determined to leave her utterly speechless. She has her own comfort level to limit her, but as they work their way through the store, she picks up some of the tiniest bikinis she can find. When she adds one that has a thong, Adora gives up and sends her a desperate look, her face flushed.

“Mercy,” she requests. Catra snorts, but she puts the bikini back on the rack. She had absolutely no intention of buying it anyway, it looked uncomfortable as hell, but trying it on and teasing Adora with the possibility? Absolutely. The game dead and plenty of options acquired, Catra leads them over to the dressing room. The sales associate there advises her against two of her options based on them being known to cause problems with fur, but Catra gathers the rest and heads into a dressing room with Adora trailing uncertainly behind her.

There is an armchair in the dressing room. Fucking rich people stores. After the swimsuits are hung up, Adora hovers awkwardly by the wall, carefully looking upwards. Catra rolls her eyes. Adora has seen her naked many times, even if they weren’t recently, and it isn’t like she is taking her underwear off right now. She snatches out her hand, grabbing Adora by the front of her shirt and shoving her into the armchair. Adora flushes again, blinking up at her in surprise as she lands in the seat. Catra winks at her as she reaches for the hem of her shirt.

“I want you to *watch*, princess. Form opinions as I try things on,” Catra orders her. Adora flushes up to her *ears*, but she doesn’t look away. She doesn’t seem capable of speaking any longer, but as long as she doesn’t look away, Catra doesn’t care. Adora needs to get used to seeing her near-naked before they go to a public location in just their swimsuits.

Catra pulls her shirt off and then walks closer to Adora, watching the way Adora’s hands on the arms of the chair tighten at her approach. She smirks to herself as she folds her shirt and then bends to place it in Adora’s lap. Adora’s eyes are wide as she watches. Catra straightens and turns around to pull off her pants, listening to Adora’s pounding heartbeat with quite a bit of satisfaction. She folds her pants and turns to set them in Adora’s lap as well.

Adora is *very* flushed. She sends Catra a sheepish smile as she takes her things in her lap and immediately begins to fiddle with the hem of Catra’s shirt to help cut the tension building in

her body. Catra smiles to herself a bit as she turns away to pull the first swimsuit off the hanger.

“It’s okay to look, Adora. It’s okay to *touch*,” she reminds her, keeping her voice quiet. She doesn’t want them to be overheard, but she knows Adora likely needs the assurance. Catra hasn’t forgotten her use of the phrase *predatory lesbian* last week. As she fastens the first bikini top on, she listens to Adora blow out a slow sigh behind her. Catra turns around once she has pulled on the bikini bottoms and eyes Adora. Her flush is calming again, the shame quieted and leaving desire in its wake. Her eyes skate over Catra’s body before she makes it to her eyes, offering Catra a small smile.

“It looks good?” she tries. Catra snorts, glancing at herself in the mirror. It does, but it feels a bit loose. She turns back to the rack, pulling it off to try on another.

“It doesn’t fit. I’m not looking to have a wardrobe malfunction in a bikini. I’ll be naked in public,” Catra informs her as she hangs the swimsuit back up. Behind her, indignation *rolls* off Adora, making Catra snort a laugh as she pulls on her second option. “Don’t worry, princess. I don’t give free shows. That’s just a bad business model,” she tells her. Adora chuckles a little, but the sound quickly dies when Catra turns back to face her.

This bikini is a bit smaller than the last – both in size, and in coverage, at least up top. Adora flushes, her eyes dragging along Catra’s body, laughter suddenly silenced. Catra smirks to herself. *There* is that speechless she was looking for. She believes she just found her winner.

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The swimsuit boutique is just as much torture as Adora expected it to be. After making Adora endure every single option, each more revealing than the last, Catra returns to her second suit. Adora warns her it is red, but she is also grateful that Catra selects it regardless. She wants Catra to be *decent*, and she needs her more covered if she is going to function like a normal human during the getaway.

When they head back to the penthouse, Catra has to immediately disappear into the study to study again. Adora bums around on the couch, wanting nothing more than to pester Catra for attention but forcing the urge down. It is the homestretch of the semester. If she can leave Catra alone while she is over this weekend, maybe Catra will spend more of the next week studying here between her finals. Adora can hold herself back as long as she can *see* Catra. She feels infinitely better with Catra in the apartment than she has all week.

“Ugh, I need a shower. I’ve been putting it off to focus,” Catra complains when she goes to put her hair up in a ponytail and wrinkles her nose at the way it feels in her hands. Adora perks up, sitting up on the couch and sending Catra a hopeful look. Catra rolls her eyes, but she stands from the desk and crosses the room to climb into Adora’s lap.

“Yes, you can help me brush out afterwards. I need you to show me how to work your shower first, though,” Catra tells her. Adora lets out a small crow of happiness, immediately kissing Catra. Catra purrs with amusement into the kiss, but she meets Adora in kind as she runs her hands down Catra’s back, finishing the movement by wrapping her hand around her tail and petting down the length of it. Catra sighs and raises her tail into the attention, clearly enjoying it.

“Shower,” she reminds, even as she ducks down to nip at the side of Adora’s neck. There *are* marks there. The sight of them kind of set Adora’s blood on fire when she spotted it in the changing room mirror. She sighs, reluctant and dramatic, which causes Catra to pull back with a chuckle, sending her an amused look. Adora reluctantly drops her hands from Catra so she can slip from her lap and leads them from the office into the master bathroom, showing Catra how to work the hot and cold in the main shower.

“There’s an outdoor shower just outside, which I think you’ll prefer in the summer, but it’s way too cold for it now,” Adora tells her. Catra’s ears twitch and she turns to look out the glass bathroom door at the outdoor shower just outside of it.

“*That’s* what that is? Adora, that is some rich bullshit,” Catra tells her. Adora rolls her eyes, chuckling to herself as she wraps an arm around Catra’s waist and presses a kiss to the base of her ear.

“Will you or will you not vastly prefer it to being trapped in a glass box with water once it’s warm enough to use it?” Adora asks. Catra grumbles in her arms, turning her head to give a chiding nip to the edge of Adora’s jaw. Adora is right and they both know it. Hybrids don’t need to shower as often as humans, hence Catra not showering during the two weekends she stayed over before, but magicats in general have an aversion to water, which makes it worse for Catra.

“Unless you’re getting in with me, it’s time for you to go,” Catra tells her. Adora flushes, well aware Catra said that just because she wants to fluster her and not have to acknowledge that she is right, but it still *works*. Adora sends Catra a small smile and then scurries from the bathroom.

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Adora takes her suit shopping on Sunday, because apparently she *was* listening when Catra told her she has more cufflinks than suits now, she just had other priorities first. Adora sent her a pair every day of the week, which was both sweet and absolutely ridiculous. Catra thought it was just going to be the pair Adora sent on Monday.

Of course not. On Tuesday she sent over a pair of cufflinks shaped like C’s. Wednesday was a pair of regular gold cufflinks with two small diamond studs inset beside each other. Thursday’s pair was shaped like a miniature set of legal scales, and Friday brought another

solid gold pair, this time round and stamped with roman numerals. After a moment of squinting at them, Catra realized that it was the year she will graduate with her M.D.

“I know you, like, want to be a good sugar mommy, but my roommate is going to start getting suspicious if you keep sending gifts to my dorm,” Catra points out when they are up in Adora’s closet, hanging up her three new suits. Adora was, arguably, hornier when Catra was trying on suits than when she was just in bikinis. Probably because she felt more *allowed* to be turned on when Catra was clothed.

Adora does the exact same thing she did in the dressing room and backs Catra against the door, pouting down at Catra and sending her cow eyes. Catra wants to scoff, but unfortunately those eyes *work* on her. They are what convinced her to take a break from preparing for her final to go out and let Adora buy her something *again*.

Well, it was the eyes combined with the fact that having three suits when she has to wear them every day of the week wasn’t working great, especially once she is maintaining two places. She will keep her original three at her dorm and the other three at Adora’s. Catra looks away from the puppy eyes before they can break her. Adora sways closer, nuzzling against her cheek now Catra isn’t acknowledging her pout.

“What if I just left them here for you? And then you could choose what to bring back to the dorm?” she offers, nuzzling into the corner of Catra’s jaw. Catra, despite herself, catches herself smiling. She doesn’t know why she is charmed by Adora being so determined to give her presents, but she sighs dramatically and shrugs, as if acquiescing is a chore.

“*Fine*, but I promise I’m good on cufflinks. And you don’t have to get me so much, it’s ridiculous,” Catra tells her. Adora brightens, giving a small squeal of delight before she leans in to kiss Catra. Catra can feel her smiling. She chuckles as she reaches her hands up to thread them through Adora’s hair, only half-up in a small ponytail at the back of her head. Adora sighs happily, apparently enjoying the feeling of Catra’s hands in her hair.

Adora is getting a lot better at just being in the moment while they’re kissing. She’s getting more confident in her touches too, even if she keeps them largely respectful. She has been following Catra’s advice, easing into touch and letting Catra take the lead as they go. Once Catra introduces something new, Adora usually takes to it eagerly.

Catra breaks the kiss to duck down to Adora’s neck, kissing along it as Adora shivers a little and presses closer. Adora *loves* this, letting out a soft sigh when Catra latches on and sets to sucking a mark there. Catra has caught Adora admiring the mark she left there yesterday already. This is the last moment they’ll get together until next weekend and she wants to leave something for Adora to really remember her by throughout the week.

She also just wants to drink in the pleasure rolling off Adora as she marks her neck, kissing lightly against the spot once she is done. Adora moves her arms, previously pinning Catra in on both sides of the door, to instead wrap around her waist and pull her close. Adora kisses her again, the embrace *grateful* as she draws Catra in tightly against her chest. Apparently they are both having the same thought, because when they part, Adora lets her go with a sigh.

“I should drive you back now, huh?” she asks. Catra nods apologetically. Dark has fallen, she still isn’t done preparing her case for her practical, and she has her first final tomorrow morning.

“Don’t worry, princess. We’ll have time to make out in the car,” Catra promises her. Frosta probably won’t be happy about her offer, but Adora perks up, so Catra doesn’t care.

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On Wednesday afternoon, Catra surprises Adora by texting to ask if she can come over for some peace and quiet. She has three finals down, but more to come still and Adora really wasn’t expecting to see her before Thursday night. She says yes instantly. She is thrilled to come home from work to find Catra napping in her bed. Adora quickly changes and then attempts to sneak into the bed beside Catra without waking her.

“I was awake as soon as you called the elevator,” Catra informs her in a mumble against the pillow, causing Adora to freeze. She still sounds rather tired, but she nudges a little closer and Adora takes the invitation to cuddle up beside Catra in the bed. It isn’t even six in the evening, but Catra has always been a napper. Gently, trying not to rouse her further, Adora presses a kiss to the base of Catra’s ear.

“Dorm got too noisy?” she asks. Catra scoffs, nodding into her neck. The motion seems to trigger something in Catra, because she immediately sets to rubbing her cheek along Adora and scent marking her. Adora flushes, but she makes no protests. She likes when Catra does this.

“Neighbours started blasting classical music to focus. Figured I would get more done over here. Do you mind if I stay tonight? I brought all of my stuff. I’ll have to go back in the morning to take my last two tests, but then we can work on moving my stuff out in the evening,” Catra tells her, still nuzzling into her. Adora draws in a sharp breath, nodding eagerly and tightening her arms around Catra. She could point out that Catra is napping and decidedly not getting work done, but how much time can you dedicate in a day to studying anyway?

“I would love to have you,” Adora promises, kissing Catra’s other ear now. Catra purrs, her tail thudding in satisfaction as she nuzzles against Adora’s neck once more, and then she goes limp in the sheets, apparently ready to go back to sleep. Adora isn’t a big *nap person*, but there is no way she is getting out of this bed before Catra is. She happily curls around her friend, letting her eyes drift closed, determined just to soak in Catra’s presence.

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Finals are brutal. They always are. The stress was making it hard to sleep. Catra was worried that going over to Adora's would be a bad call, but it turns out she wakes up actually feeling rested, just like she was hoping. Thursday is still a slog to get through, but she is able to walk out of her last final feeling pretty good and immediately collapses facedown on her bed with a relieved sigh.

"Stop gloating, not all of us are done yet," Lonnie tells her, but there is humour in her voice. Catra might not be *friends* with her roommate like she was with Scorpia in undergrad, but they usually get on decently. Catra makes a big show of releasing a dreamy sigh of contentment and feels an eraser bounce off her back in response. Lonnie had no finals on Monday and *two* tomorrow. By the time she is done with the semester, Catra will already be in the mountains.

Speaking of, her phone dings with a text congratulating her on being done from Adora. Catra smiles as she texts back and then forces herself to get up again so she can start packing. Normally she doesn't trust the safety of the motels she is staying at and just brings the bare essentials and what she needs for her job. It leaves her missing a lot of comforts over the break. This time, she might have overpacked based on the raised eyebrow Lonnie gives her as she strolls out of the dorm to get dinner.

Adora arrives shortly after, coming straight to campus from work. Catra, despite being tired, has a bit of a bounce in her step as she heads down to let Adora into the elevator. Adora coming to campus is risky considering most of her fans are around college or grad school age now – at least, it would be if it weren't for the fact that they will probably make the tabloids tomorrow anyway.

Adora has a hoodie on over her clothes to be a bit incognito, at least. Catra feels a grin spread across her face when her eyes land on Adora. A moment later, Adora spots her and she lights up in turn. Catra flushes, rolling her eyes a little as she approaches and holds out her hand for Adora to take.

"How'd the finals go?" Adora asks, beaming, as Catra pulls her by the hand through the lobby and over to the elevators.

"Pretty sure I killed it, but I passed at the very least. My roommate is getting dinner, so we'll have some time," Catra promises her.

It turns out, Adora is determined to prove her wrong.

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Adora has, actually, *never been on a college campus before*. She's driven through NYU once or twice, and of course she has come here to pick Catra up, but she never even got out of the car then. Glimmer went to college, but she did it at Yale, and flying gives Adora anxiety.

Bow went to a school in Connecticut because it was his dads' alma mater. Adora only saw them in person during breaks, and none of her other friends went.

Adora was especially lonely and desperate during what should have been her college years. She had hoped to escape music at eighteen and go to school, leaving it all behind her, and that dream was yanked away when she signed the second contract. Adora spent a lot of sleepless nights imagining a better life, where she and Catra went to a SUNY together like they always planned.

It hadn't even been three years, and Adora really believed it would just work out and she would find her somehow, mostly because she couldn't imagine going on without her. She imagined them as roommates, goofing off together late at night and crawling into each other's beds enough times that eventually they shoved them together and made one big bed, where Adora could finally, *finally* hold Catra again.

Catra shows Adora around her actual dorm, and though it has a lot more amenities than Adora envisioned their dorm together would have back then, her eyes land on Catra's bed and she can't think about anything except how those fantasies often ended. Sometimes it was a chaste kiss with her childhood crush, both of them giggling. Other times, well-

In her mind, Adora had her first time in bed that never existed. She shoots Catra a hopeful look and Catra, ever observant, crosses the room and settles on the edge of the bed. She sends Adora a look of fond exasperation, but when Adora approaches, she merely wraps her arms around Adora's shoulders and lets Adora crawl over her until Catra is laid back with Adora draped over her.

Adora kisses her softly, her heart pounding like this really is their first kiss. She is kneeling between Catra's thighs, and Catra's tail hits against her knees as it sways slowly with content. Catra *likes* slow kisses, Adora figured that out after she stopped mildly panicking her way through every kiss. Not that Adora has gone too far yet, but she loves starting slow like this if only for the way Catra turns boneless in her arms.

Adora spends awhile just kissing her like that, arms braced on the bed so she isn't crushing her. Catra wriggles on the bed a little bit underneath her - a sure sign she is comfortable and relaxed – as she settles deeper into the mattress. Adora shifts above her, moving to brace her weight on one forearm so she can free her other hand to trail along Catra's body. Catra, relaxed and blissed out from the slow kisses, purrs and arches up into the touch.

Catra is wearing a sweater in preparation for making trips with her stuff out to the car idling outside, but right now Adora doesn't give a shit about if Frosta is wondering what is taking them so long. Right now, she is cautiously petting down Catra's front before slipping her hand beneath the hem of Catra's shirt and sliding her hand into the ridiculously soft fur on Catra's stomach.

Catra is still purring. She *likes* it. The next time they part for air, Adora blows out a relieved breath and then carefully settles back on her knees so she can lean her face down to Catra's stomach. She watches Catra's expression as she pushes her sweater up, being sure to leave her chest covered even as she exposes her entire midsection.

“Okay?” she asks as she drops her hands to Catra’s hips, squeezing as she awaits permission. Catra’s eyes sparkle as she nods, a small smile quirking at the corner of her mouth. Adora smiles in turn, just a touch relieved, before she ducks down to press kisses into Catra’s stomach. Adora groans, nuzzling into the softness that meets her there as she sets to kissing every inch of Catra she can reach. Each kiss is slow and careful, just like Catra prefers for them to start out with.

They may be *in* it now, but this is new for them, even if Adora has been dreaming about it for years. Adora has had plenty of fantasies starring Catra, but she has never come so close to stepping *into* one of them before, and she wants to fulfill it as far as is comfortable right now. Her mind keeps skipping ahead, imagining the quiet moans and whimpers Catra would give while Adora nipped her neck and slid a hand into her waistband, but as badly as Adora *wants* it in this moment, she also knows this isn’t the place for that.

It is kind of a revelation that the only thing holding her back from touching Catra is their *location*. If she were feeling like this back in the penthouse, she might have already asked Catra if she could take her shirt off. Actually, that much should be okay, right? Even if her roommate does come back, it wouldn’t be like she was walking in on something she hadn’t already seen.

The idea of somebody else having seen Catra naked is enough to spur Adora forward, trailing her kisses up from Catra’s stomach, to her ribs, to her sternum as Adora raises one hand for the hem of Catra’s shirt again.

“Can I?” she asks, softly, looking up to find Catra’s face flushed and her eyes totally blown out. Catra nods, wriggling a little on the mattress beneath her. She is *visibly* turned on, her tail thumping steadily against Adora’s knee. Adora grins, just a little excited, as she pushes Catra’s sweater up around her armpits and nuzzles into the fur above her heart.

Catra purrs with amusement, chuckling just a little. She drops a hand into Adora’s hair, threading her fingers through the hair at the nape of her neck and tugging gently. Adora moans despite herself, burying her face just a little more in the soft fur that haunts her as surely as Catra’s tits do whenever she wears something lowcut – which she does a lot more now than she used to.

Adora wants to touch her, but her confidence is also quickly running out. Catra is *content* right now, her eyes round and purr rumbling softly in the room. Adora doesn’t want to ruin it by pushing too far, especially not-

Adora is startled out of her thoughts by the door behind them beeping, both her and Catra startling as it is pushed open.

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Catra is infinitely grateful that Adora was feeling confident and was on top of her, putting Adora's broad shoulders between Catra and the suite's front door. Catra feels her cheeks blaze as she and Adora *both* hastily reach for the hem of her shirt and yank it down. Behind them, the sound of Lonnie shuffling into the room suddenly *freezes* as she realizes there are two people in her dorm.

Catra leans up and buries her face in Adora's neck, wanting to somehow hide her shame. Adora moves to wrap her arms around Catra, carefully sitting them both up as Catra curls into her and tries to disappear. She knows Adora is blocking Lonnie's line of sight of pretty much everything except Catra's arms and legs wrapped around Adora's back, but fuck, she feels *caught*.

"Uh, Catra? Everything alright?" Lonnie calls from the doorway, uncertainty obvious. The answer is *no*, but that's Lonnie's fault so Catra doesn't know why she is asking. She let her guard down in the face of Adora's gentle touch. Things were going *far* and some part of Catra's mind had already decided that this was it, and her first time really was going to be *good*.

Catra has been afraid of it for a long time. With her job, there was always the risk of being forced into something. Her body was realizing for the first time it could let that fear *go* - and then Lonnie had to get her fucking dinner to-go.

"*Fine*," Catra grits out. Adora winces a little, knowing that tone of voice from Catra. She tightens her arms around Catra for a moment. Catra, reluctantly, sighs and lets her go. Adora immediately sits back on the bed, offering Catra a sheepish and apologetic smile as she reaches out to fix Catra's sweater a little. She has nothing to apologize for. They both got carried away and Catra would have happily kept going if Lonnie hadn't showed up. With a reluctant sigh, Catra stands from the bed, gesturing at Adora with one hand.

"Lonnie, my girlfriend. Adora, my roommate. Let's finish packing," Catra introduces, praying to every god she can name that Lonnie won't say anything. Adora turns to give Lonnie a sheepish wave, finally giving Lonnie a good look at her under the hoodie. Lonnie's eyebrows climb into her hairline. Catra immediately glares her down, *daring* her to bring up the obvious.

"Nice to meet you! We'll probably just be a trip or two to get Catra's things and then let you study," Adora tells her, waving a little. Either she isn't picking up on the silent battle happening or she is trying to make things less awkward. Catra knows they are going to go public with their relationship tomorrow and this isn't much of a wrench in their plans, but she and Lonnie are in the same program and she would *really* like to avoid rumours spreading within it for the next semester before Lonnie graduates – if they even stopped with her departure.

There is no way Lonnie doesn't recognize Adora. Kyle likes her music – he *would* – and Catra just said her name. Adora has been out of the game for five years, but you don't get to be a lawyer with a shitty memory. Catra narrows her eyes at her roommate as Lonnie glances between the two of them.

"… Take your time," she eventually assures, edging into the room and heading over to her desk to put down her cardboard box of food. Catra releases a sigh of relief, some of the tension leaking out of her body as she turns to Adora and offers her a small smile. Adora, seemingly relieved, offers her a smile back and stands from the bed.

They manage to gather everything in one trip, mostly because Catra wants to get *out* of here. She has a suitcase from when she moved here, plus a duffle bag and her backpack. Half her clothes are already at Adora's penthouse at this point. She won't have access to anything she leaves behind for the next month and now she has somewhere safe to take it, she would prefer not to be without anything she may want.

She can feel Lonnie's gaze on her back as she shoulders her duffle bag, Adora sporting the backpack and carrying the suitcase because she *insisted* on it. Catra is just glad they met right *before* move out and not when she was moving back in. Hopefully Lonnie will get all her gossiping out over break and Catra won't come back to find her entire program talking about who she is sleeping with.

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Adora drives them up to the mountains. She doesn't like driving in the city, but she only has to do it for as long as it takes to get out of it, and then the drive is pretty scenic from there. It lets them have a private drive up and Adora can give Frosta the weekend off. Though Frosta actually ends up working a relatively low number of hours for a full-time job, she is on-call pretty much twenty-four-seven, so any days Adora can give her where she can just live her life without interruption she appreciates.

Adora tries to teach Catra about driving a car as they go, much like she did with Frosta, only Catra doesn't have any kind of license and just watches from the passenger seat. Adora mostly just does it to have something to pass the time on the long drive, but she also thinks it is an important skill to have in an emergency.

"I live in New York City, Adora. If there's an emergency, there will still be a cab running for the right price," Catra points out. Adora snorts, rolling her eyes as they finally get off the interstate to drive through the scenic mountain town near the resort.

"You won't *always* be in the city, case in point, right now," Adora points out, gesturing to the snow-covered town around them. The town is small and touristy. It mostly acts as the gateway to the resort. Adora's coat is in the back seat, but Catra already has hers on, even if it isn't zipped up. It really isn't cold enough to warrant it in the car, but apparently Catra just likes to snuggle into it, because she has been tucking down into its collar throughout the drive.

Catra has been kind of *grouchy* during the drive. She gets moody anyway, but it has been especially true for the last two hours. She grumbles a bit and turns away to stare out the window. Adora bites her lip, worried but not knowing what to say. Catra has been

complaining about this trip ever since she found out about it. Adora offered for her to stay behind and she even told Catra that if she does come, she doesn't have to do anything involving water, but her darkening mood throughout the drive has Adora worried.

She tries to fix her eyes on the road, searching for what she can say. There is a motel in town. It isn't as nice as the resort, but if Catra is really so uncomfortable with the resort Adora would happily put her up there for the next two nights. The paparazzi won't look there-

Oh. Is that why she is uncomfortable? This is kind of the point of no return on their arrangement. Once it is printed, Catra is going to be known – by only the few who still care what Adora is up to, but still to people all over the world – as the girl dating an ex-popstar. Adora tightens her hands on the wheel. Okay, if Catra really isn't sure about this, they need to *talk* about it before they get to the resort and it's too late.

Adora isn't really thinking as she immediately changes lanes and pulls into a Turkish restaurant's parking lot. Catra blinks, turning to look at her instead of out the window, seeming confused. When she spots Adora's determined expression, she freezes – except for her tail, which thuds heavily against the seat.

"Catra, if you're not comfortable with this whole ruse, I need you to tell me. The paparazzi will be up at the resort, but they won't be in town. If you're not ready-" she starts, gesturing with her hands. She cuts off when Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes and looking away. Adora's heart falls for a moment before she realizes Catra's tail is twitching. It is anxiety, yes, but the way the tip flicks also means amusement.

"Adora, it's not that," she assures. She sounds torn. Adora bites her lip, trying to catalogue the position of Catra's ears and tail, but the problem is she seems conflicted herself, so Adora is only getting mixed messages. After a long moment, Catra sighs.

"… Mermista and Sea Hawk will be there," she mumbles, crossing her arms and hunching down in her seat a little. Adora blinks at her. She feels the tension release in her body as she slumps a bit in her own seat. Okay, so Catra isn't worried about the arrangement, which is good, but she does have a point. Adora hadn't really considered the fact that Mermista would recognize her.

"I asked Mermista for your contact information. She roasted me, but she gave it to me and said she hoped it worked out. She probably figured out it was you as soon as she found out I was bringing my new girlfriend. Sea Hawk is a bit of an airhead when it doesn't come to acting or stunt bullshit, but he is a total sweetheart. He remembers everyone he meets, but he would never bring it up," Adora admits. She hates to say it – it makes Catra ball in on herself a little in the passenger seat, her entire body tense – but she isn't about to lie to Catra. Adora bites her lip.

"Mermista respects sex workers, and she's my friend. She saw how bad it fucked me up when I got outed as a lesbian. She would never do anything like that to someone. But if you want to avoid her, you could stay in the room, or I can get you a hotel in town. I didn't think about it before now and I should have," Adora tells her. Her heart beats heavily as she watches Catra stare out the passenger seat, her ears pinned back. After a long moment, Catra sighs.

“I assumed she would figure it out eventually anyway. That’s the reason I haven’t brought it up before now. I’d rather meet her in person and be able to intimidate her than have her run her mouth,” Catra tells her. She doesn’t sound happy about it. Adora knows Mermista won’t *need* intimidating, but she understands why Catra is worried. She blows out a breath, considering it.

“She isn’t going to say anything. If you won’t believe that it is to avoid hurting you, then at least believe she is my friend and knows it would hurt my image if it got out that I was paying an escort,” Adora tells her. Catra flinches and slouches down further in her seat.

“That story would sell well,” Catra says, vaguely. She doesn’t need to say more. Adora shakes her head, even if Catra can’t see it from where she is staring out the window.

“Mermista would never look into it to find out how much,” Adora replies. Catra scoffs in the passenger seat. She doesn’t seem very convinced. Adora pauses, thinking about what she can say. “The website is gone. Even if she did sell the story, there would be no proof, and I have my own PR people that can deny it and dig up the records from when we were in the foster home together to verify our version of the story,” Adora rationalizes. Catra snorts, but she turns her head to look at Adora.

“Adora, are you going to be okay if they print that you’re dating a sex worker?” she asks. Her voice is artfully blank, but Adora can tell there are *layers* to the way she says that. Adora blinks at her for a moment. Her immediate instinct is yes, of course, but she knows that Catra is looking for a particular answer, and she wants to give the right one. After a moment, she sighs. Catra’s entire body tenses in a way Adora hasn’t seen in ten years – a way that means she is holding back a full-body flinch.

“I doubt my work would care, but if they did, I could always leave to work for a charity that supports sex workers specifically. And I don’t give a fuck about what the press says about me. They don’t matter. You do,” Adora tells her. In the passenger seat, Catra releases a small *oh*. A moment later, Adora watches a tear fall from her jawline.

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Catra has known for a while that they were going to have to confront the *Mermista problem*, especially once Adora mentioned this getaway. The problem was that even if Catra avoided her, even if she and Adora decided to call off the fake public relationship and just stick to Catra’s private services, the paparazzi would find them eventually, and those photos and rumours would eventually make their way back to Adora’s friends, especially considering two of them know already.

Catra has no doubts that Mermista will know who she is the second they meet. They talked quite a lot that night, and Adora *got her site from Mermista*. She has been nervous for two weeks now about how Mermista would react, but she also knew it was ridiculous to call off

this getaway when Mermista would probably figure it out based on what is said about her during the weekend anyway.

She would rather meet Mermista head-on than run and hope the woman is a decent person. She had already decided that, even if her nerves built on the drive over. It is Adora's words that push her over the edge. She has been telling herself a lot of bullshit internally – mostly when she is alone, on the nights she spends back in her dorm – about how this is really just a sex thing for Adora.

Yes, Adora hired her like she would any other sex worker and *isn't* in love with her, but Catra's reminders to herself have still been wrong. Adora has always been her best friend, and she cares about Catra, even if it isn't in the same way. Adora's touches and kisses more than prove that Catra isn't just a warm body to her. This is closer to a *friends with benefits* thing than real sex work.

Adora undoes her seatbelt and practically climbs into the passenger seat to hold and comfort her as Catra has a long-overdue freak out. She is reluctant to return to driving once it is done, but Catra really just needed to cry and let it out. Is she still nervous to meet Mermista? Yes, definitely, but she feels a lot better, and right now she is more focused on the immediate problem of the paparazzi.

Nightfall is fast approaching, thanks to their detour pitstop. They still have time to check in, but if they want to get in some good photos, arriving before sunset is preferable. Catra spends the rest of the drive drying her face and getting her appearance in order in the sun visor's mirror. By the time they pull into the resort valet parking, you would never know that she was crying only half an hour ago.

The paparazzi are, predictably, waiting just outside the valet area. They immediately pay attention to the Aston Martin when Adora pulls up. The car might cost more than Catra's tuition, which is to say, *entirely too much money*. Adora gets out of the car, tossing her keys to the valet, and cameras immediately start flashing as a bellhop runs around to the trunk of the car to gather their suitcase for them.

One of the resort staff opens Catra's door for her as Adora circles around the car to do just that. Catra smirks at Adora's put out expression before reaching her hand out. Adora perks up, hurrying forward to take her hand as Catra slips out of the passenger seat. The paparazzi are kept back from the main entrance by a rope barrier, so from their angle they couldn't see Catra before she stepped out, but an explosion of camera flashes and, oddly, wolf whistles burst forth from her right as she stands.

Adora gives her a small smile, making eye contact so a thread can pass between them. *Focus on me*. Once Catra has stepped out onto the sidewalk, Adora shifts to wrap an arm around her back and guide her up the sweeping slop of the resort entrance.

"They whistle because it tends to turn heads and get better photos than yelling does," Adora tells her, voice low so the paparazzi can only *speculate* what they are talking about. The bellhop has gathered their suitcase, carrying it as he falls in step a few feet behind them. Catra swivels her ears back to listen to the sound of the valet pulling the Aston Martin away to the resort's private parking lot.

“Think they have realized who you are yet?” Catra asks. Adora snorts, tightening her arm around Catra’s waist.

“They wouldn’t have gone crazy taking photos when you got out if not. All it takes is one of them recognizing and doing it before all the others follow their lead and stare at their photos later to figure it out,” Adora assures her as the resort doors slide open before them. Right before they vanish inside, Catra throws a glance over her shoulder to get a good look at the paparazzi.

There are maybe a half dozen of them that have followed Mermista – or whatever other star has happened to come this weekend – here. Mostly human, aside from one lizardfolk, so there is no way they have been able to overhear. Before Catra can turn back to the wonderful heating pouring out the resort doors, multiple camera flashes go off.

Well, if they didn’t get a good look at her before, they have now. Catra is officially a known woman – and, to the world at least, Adora’s girlfriend.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter: resort shenanigans, a hot tub, and a confession 🤭
I’m aiming to update this fic twice a week btw!

The Resort

Chapter Notes

> For the majority of the world: 30 degrees Fahrenheit equals just below 0 in Celsius.
> Reminder from OTOS: Virginity is a stupid concept of Christian purity culture, but here the word virgin is being used to relate to the concept of someone having a "first time", without any of the obsession for purity or "saving" oneself or whatever. It is more about the more experienced partner having a duty to ensure their inexperienced partner has a good first experience – or a way to say "Hey, I have no experience with this."

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They check-in, go through the standard orientation about the privacy of their guests being of the utmost importance and thus photography being banned on the premises, and then head to their room to unpack. They have a single room together. Adora booked this trip over a month ago, before she knew Catra would be coming with her, but she would have gotten them the single king bed to share anyway.

The entire resort is supposed to be shaped like a lotus flower, with the spa at the center and the hallways containing the hotel rooms branching off like petals. The hotel rooms are in pairs, with a shared courtyard between two of them featuring a pool and hot tub. Their room shares a courtyard with Glimmer and Bow's room. Perfuma is in the unfortunate position of sharing a courtyard with Mermista and Sea Hawk.

Adora feels her heart swell when she steps out of the bedroom, having just finished unpacking, to find Catra pressed up against the glass door on the left side of the living room. Her ears twitch as she watches the steam rise off the hot tub, the lights in the water dancing as the surface gently rolls. Adora doubts she is lusting after the pool and likely is just entranced by the movement – she gets like that sometimes, just *watching* the reflecting pool on Adora's terrace.

Adora crosses the room, molding against Catra's back and pressing a soft kiss to the base of her ear. The only thing Catra does to acknowledge her is flick her ear. Her tail is twitching with interest. Adora nuzzles into her mane, sighing softly at the feeling of Catra pressed up against her, relatively relaxed. Her breakdown in the car really worried Adora, but Catra seems better now she has released her anxiety.

"Glimmer texted. Everyone is getting dinner in one of the resort restaurants right now, but afterwards they are planning to come here for a pool party to kick the weekend off. Want to order room service while we wait?" Adora asks her, kissing the other ear now. Catra's back rumbles softly as she tilts her head up into the attention. She *really* likes her ears to be played with and kissed, but Adora always tries to be careful with them. She kisses the same ear again before switching back to the other side to make it even.

“Sure,” Catra agrees. “You’re sure it’s saltwater?” she adds, still looking out at the hot tub. Adora nods.

“Chlorine would undo all the work of the spa treatments,” she points out. Chlorine was terrible for Catra when they were learning to swim together, leaving her fur simultaneously dry and greasy. It gave her coat an almost *stringy* quality. Part of Catra agreeing to this weekend – even the swimming – was knowing that everything that touched her fur would be good for it, or at least not damaging. Catra *hm*s softly and then finally turns away from the door.

“Alright, where’s the menu?” she asks.

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Catra was feeling better after the drive up and settling into the room. Dinner helps to calm her nerves as well, and the abalone is *incredible*, leaving her utterly relaxed and purring while Adora *coos* and films Catra on her phone. Catra doesn’t even protest when Adora’s phone starts buzzing a *suspicious* amount afterwards and Catra realizes she must have sent the video to one of her group chats with her friends.

Even after dinner, Catra makes it all the way through them both changing into their swimsuits for the inexplicable pool party in thirty-degree weather before her nerves come back at the sound of a *whoop* followed by a splash from the courtyard.

“Sea Hawk’s here,” Adora says, very helpfully, as Catra shrugs on her coat over her bikini and checks her ponytail is firmly in place. She doesn’t want to get her hair *wet*. Catra turns to raise a brow at her as Adora, the fucking masochist, merely wraps her towel around her shoulders in preparation for the cold they are about to brave. There are several heaters and a lit firepit scattered around the courtyard, but it still isn’t going to be enough to counteract the New York winter.

“Race you to the hot tub?” Catra returns, because a challenge will at least distract her. Adora immediately perks up and Catra takes off *running*. She isn’t one to wait for the fair call of *go*. Adora squawks, running after her. Catra has to slow down to throw the sliding door open and Adora almost catches up, right on her heels as Catra tears out into the courtyard.

It is fucking *freezing.* Suddenly Catra doesn’t care about the challenge anymore. All she cares about is getting in the hot tub as fast as possible. She flings her coat back off her shoulders as she bounds over the pavement, wanting it to be off by the time she reaches the water, and also throwing it in Adora’s path as an obstacle.

“Not fair!” Adora yells, but Catra doesn’t care because she already has a foot on the edge of the spa and is bounding inside gladly. The water is almost scalding after the burn of the cold, but Catra’s entire body feels *alive* as she sinks down into the water, steam rising around her. Okay, so maybe Adora was onto something with this. “You’re a little shit,” Adora informs

her, coming to a halt at the edge of the hot tub. She has Catra's coat flung over her shoulder, the towel still wrapped around her. Catra grins up at her.

"I *won*," she corrects, before sinking down in the water all the way up to her jaw. As Adora rolls her eyes and hurries to a nearby lounger to deposit their things, Catra's skin tingles, coming alive in the heat after the shock of the cold. It feels incredible, her heart still pounding but her entire body relaxing into the steaming heat.

Adora quickly joins her, stepping over the lip and settling inside on the bench beside her. The hot tub is large, able to sit their entire group easily, but though there *are* others out in the courtyard already, they are in the pool. Catra turns to eye them. Sea Hawk and Mermista are in the pool, which is heated too, but not as much as the hot tub, and Catra doesn't know how they can stand it.

Mermista has Sea Hawk in a headlock and may be waterboarding him. Catra really can't tell. He is calling for mercy, but he is also laughing, and there is no way a stuntman like him isn't strong enough to get out of a headlock. Not that Catra isn't aware Mermista is strong, she could feel her muscles throughout the night as she led Mermista by the arm, but Sea Hawk is one of those dudes you can just *tell* is secretly jacked.

Despite Catra and Adora's entrance not being *quiet*, Mermista and Sea Hawk are a bit too caught up to pay attention to them. On the other side of the courtyard, the sliding glass door to Glimmer and Bow's room is open. Catra can hear voices inside, but over Sea Hawk's sputtering and splashing, she can't make it out.

"They're cool. I promise," Adora tells her, voice soft, as she scoots closer and stretches an arm over the back of the hot tub behind Catra. Catra, reluctantly, sits up properly on the bench and sighs, leaning back to rest her head on Adora's arm. The heat was a bit too much on every inch of her body anyway. Adora's eyes sparkle – or maybe that is just the lights from the hot tub refracting in the water surface and reflecting in her eyes – and Adora shuffles a little closer so their sides are pressed together in the water and Catra's head is pillowed on her bicep.

Adora feels *weird* in the water. It has been about two decades since Catra was in a pool, and she hasn't touched a submerged human since. Catra drops her hand to stroke Adora's thigh, a little surprised by the change in her skin texture. Her fur feels different in the water too, but it doesn't feel that different from how it is in the shower.

Catra gets a little absorbed, stroking the softness of Adora's skin. In the hot tub, her scent signals are muted – most of her is *underwater*, so Catra can't really tell she is turned on – and it isn't until Adora coughs lightly into her free hand that Catra looks up and realizes Adora is bright red. Catra flushes, snatching her hand away and tucking it into her lap. She didn't *mean* to do that, and touching Adora in public probably isn't a good introduction to her friends.

"Heat too much for you, princess?" Catra purrs to her, because she *has* to, even if she isn't going to keep going. Adora rolls her eyes, but her flush is too much to deny. Catra chuckles, lolling her head back again. At her angle, she is staring out of the courtyard's one open side. Before darkness settled completely around them, Catra could see that out their back windows

there was a fantastic view of the mountain, but now that it's night she is just greeted with a shadowy forest.

It is picturesque, but also *dark*, and Catra's brain is wired for the city. She gets why rich people would enjoy the view, but her heart tells her it is danger. She is way too wound up for this. The trees aren't going to *hurt* her. The real danger is a few feet away, apparently done trying to drown her boyfriend and now turning back to Glimmer and Bow's room.

"Are you guys coming in or what?" she calls, sounding uninterested in the response. Catra feels her ears twitch despite herself. There is a distant call of *one minute!* and after a few moments a couple comes wandering out of the room. Adora has shown her photos of Glimmer and Bow, usually group shots of the three of them together, and Catra recognizes them instantly, even with Glimmer in a bandeau bikini and Bow wearing what may be the smallest pair of swim trunks Catra has ever seen in her life.

Glimmer zeroes in on them immediately. Catra's ears pin back as Glimmer grabs Bow's hand and pulls him through the cold to the hot tub. Behind her, Adora shifts her arm so she can still cushion Catra's head with her upper arm while draping her forearm over Catra's shoulder in a loose hug.

Catra blows out a breath, closing her eyes and focusing on the warmth around her rather than the approaching inquisition. Her ears twitch as the gentle rolling of the hot tub jets is disrupted by the water surface being broken as two people join them inside. Catra can practically feel the barely-contained energy from the other side of pool.

"Alright, I see your point," Glimmer acknowledges from the other side of the tub. Catra frowns, absolutely no clue what she is talking about. She twitches her ears, but she knows full well she didn't *miss* anything. Beside her, Adora chuckles. Bow laughs too. Catra can't help but feel like she is on the outside of a joke.

"Told you. Where's Perfuma?" Adora asks, her hand dangling down to Catra's shoulder stroking it lightly despite the wet fur sticking out of the water from her initial soak. The water is only up to her armpits when she is sitting up like this, but it turns out it is warm enough to counteract her head sticking out.

"Surgery was recent enough that she still can't swim. She'll meet up with us in the morning and just sit out the soaking pools," Bow returns. Catra feels Adora nod in return, her hand still stroking Catra's shoulder.

"I forgot how long that would take to heal fully. Hopefully she'll enjoy the rest of the spa still," Adora returns. Catra can *feel* the awkwardness hanging in the air around them, but part of her just wants to duck under the water and never come up. These people *know*. They about their current arrangement, and no one has ever known something like that about Catra before.

She didn't realize how much comfort the identify of *Cyra* gave her - or how afraid she was to be treated like what she *is*. A part of her felt that if she never had sex with her clients then she wasn't a sex worker *really* and she could ignore all the stigma and bullshit that came with that. Unfortunately, it seems like she has internalized some of it.

Her heart is arguing that these people don't see her as a *person*, just the collection of stereotypes they attach to sugar babies in their head. She hasn't even tried to say hello to them yet. Her brain is trying to argue it is just because Catra knows the general perception and not because she is ashamed of it herself, but she can be truthful enough with herself to know that isn't true.

With monumental effort, Catra opens her eyes and lifts her head off Adora's arm to eye their guests. She feels Adora perk up by her side, shifting her arm a little to properly drape it around Catra's shoulders now she is sitting up. Catra forces herself to give a casual smile in the couple's direction. Bow smiles warmly at her, as does Glimmer, but her gaze is a bit calculating in a way that makes Catra's ears pin back immediately.

"Catra. Happy birthday," Catra offers in greeting, leaning forward and raising her arm out of the water to offer a handshake- "Nope, too cold," she decides, hissing a little at the sting of the air as she quickly drops her arm back in the water and huddles into Adora's side. Adora chuckles, tightening her arm around Catra and turning her head to kiss the base of her ear. Bow and Glimmer both laugh as well, though not unkindly.

"Thank you. I'm Glimmer - Adora's best friend, at least until she found you again," Glimmer introduces, nodding her head to her instead of offering a handshake. Yeah, Catra *hates* that. She forces her ears still, though her tail lashes rather painfully against the side of the hot tube. Luckily, the movement of the jets in the water keeps that from being obvious, especially with it this dark out.

"Bow," Glimmer's boyfriend greets, raising his hand a little out of the water to wave before ducking it back down into the warmth. Catra just nods to him, not really sure what to say. She knows a decent amount of these two – she knows the harbor where they like to go *sailing on the weekends* – but she is nervous.

Mostly she is worried by the woman in the pool below who is still busy engaging in war with her boyfriend and hasn't acknowledged them yet, but having to introduce herself to two people important to Adora doesn't help either. Glimmer's gaze is assessing, her head slightly cocked as she thinks.

"You know, Adora told us stories about you over the years, but she never told us how you two met. Bow and I decided it had to be something embarrassing," Glimmer prompts. At her side, Adora makes a small sound of protest, seemingly flustered. She always got like that when someone brought it up before too. Catra doesn't blame her for not remembering it herself – she is *human*, her memory really can't compare to Catra's – but she is surprised that stopped her from answering the question.

Adora knows the answer, told it frequently enough by their first set of caregivers and later by Catra. She could have easily told it if she wanted to. Catra glances to her left. Adora offers her a small smile, a thread passing between them, and she *understands*. It was too painful before, but now they are back together, and it is a good opening for Catra – she can talk about Adora all day if she needs to.

"I wouldn't stop climbing into Adora's crib to stop her crying. I couldn't understand that human babies couldn't move as well as I did, so when meowing at her to come out didn't

work, I would just crawl in and let her hug me until she calmed down," Catra replies. Glimmer blinks in surprise for a long moment, but then she lights up and *squeals* at the same time that her boyfriend coos.

"That's so cute! You have to tell me everything!" she demands, apparently energized by the *cuteness* of it as she makes a grab for her boyfriend's hand and squeezes it in a death grip. Catra's ears twitch a little, but she launches into an explanation of how much Adora cried as a kid, getting overwhelmed easily. From a young age, Catra was the only thing that could calm her down, like a favourite teddy bear.

Their caregivers – and by extension, Adora, just echoing what the adults around them said – would refer to Catra as *her kitty* or *her kitten*. It lasted up until they were four, and transferred into Shadow's home. They were considered a bonded pair, only up for adoption together. Shadow didn't approve. She was against even *siblings* being "limited" in such a way since it made it harder to adopt them out, and she especially didn't like a human being paired with a hybrid.

Shadow decided the whole thing was Catra's fault and that she had conned Adora into crying whenever they were apart rather than accepting the fact that Adora really was worse off on her own. Luckily, their social worker wasn't as blind as Shadow and they remained paired, but when someone came along specifically looking for Adora and it *seemed* like her issues had lessened, nothing could keep them together.

"My *issues* never improved, I just learned to hide it better so Shadow wouldn't be mad at Catra," Adora says, wry and a bit bitter. Catra turns her head, nuzzling into Adora's jaw and purring gently for her. She can't summon a real rumble right now, but even the gentle buzz helps some of the tension slip from Adora's body as she tilts her head back to let Catra mark her more easily.

"It's birthday weekend, why are we getting all depressed over here?" a bored voice demands, close by and getting *closer*. Catra pulls back from Adora's jaw, blinking in surprise as Mermista slips into the hot tub just a few feet from Adora. She was so caught up in the story and Adora, she didn't notice the woman's approach. Adora snorts, tilting her chin back down from where she was lolling it back to give Catra access.

"The summary is our childhood was shit, but we had each other. There, depression done. We can talk about the fact that Glimmer still isn't old enough to rent a car now," Adora returns, squeezing her arm around Catra's shoulders. Glimmer squawks, indignant on the other side of the hot tub.

"I'm *getting* there, asshole. It's not like I know how to drive anyway," Glimmer returns, glaring at her friend. Catra watches her raise both her hands to the surface of the water, her ears pinning back as she realizes Glimmer is about to *splash* them-

"Don't," Adora intones, seriously. Glimmer pauses, surprised, before glancing at Catra tucked beneath Adora's arm and smiling sheepishly. She drops her hands though, mouthing *sorry* to Catra, which honestly has her shocked. The momentary panic of getting splashed with water distracted her from their new addition in the hot tub – temporarily.

“Glimmer trying to drive would be a bigger disaster than when Sea Hawk was filming the end of *Gunmetal*,” Mermista tacks on. The entire group chuckles. Catra doesn’t get it, but she also hasn’t seen that movie. She knows it is an action thriller, but that is about it. From the pool below, Sea Hawk squawks. Catra watches as he tries to haul himself up the waterfall flowing from the hot tub into the pool, laying in the middle of the pathway to lean closer to Mermista.

“Mermista, my dear, it was an *accident*, and I am very sorry for it,” he tells her, sending her a pleading look. He sounds utterly whipped, but Catra already knew that from their evening together. She searches her mind and, in the back of it, manages to recall an article about rumours of Mermista being injured while filming that movie. It was known that a fire effects scene Mermista was starring in went wrong.

“That was the flaming crotch incident, wasn’t it?” Catra asks, her voice as casual as she can make it. On the other side of the hot tub, Glimmer and Bow both burst out laughing, confirming Catra’s suspicions as Sea Hawk *wilts*. Catra’s body is alight with nerves as the corner of Mermista’s mouth quirks up. Catra is outright referencing their night together. Mermista doesn’t seem surprised, so she definitely remembers, but this is a test and Catra is terrified of her failing it.

“Adora told you? The stories were *so* exaggerated. I wasn’t even near the fire, but a piece of debris landed on my fucking *clit* and the crotch of my pants caught fire. My bush smelled like ash for a week, but I didn’t even have burns to treat,” Mermista tells her, casual if it weren’t for the light in her eyes. Catra manages to chuckle along with Adora, tucking into her side and feeling her entire body relax.

After a day of tension, it feels incredible.

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The impromptu pool party goes *well*. They laugh and joke, telling stories. Catra doesn’t ask Adora about their time apart usually, but it turns out that isn’t for lack of curiosity. With her friends here as a filter, already aware of what stories are funny and can be asked about, Catra subtly peppers them with questions.

The opposite is true as well, with Glimmer and Bow especially asking Catra for stories from when they were kids. After Catra tells a *particularly* embarrassing story involving Adora going to the school nurse because she got her period young and Shadow had never told them shit about it – Adora thought she was *dying*, but in her defense, so did Catra – Adora retaliates by telling the story of Catra climbing the fire escape and getting caught, requiring rescue by the fucking *fire department*.

“There weren’t trees to climb! It was instinct!” Catra hisses, only a little incensed, as she elbows Adora’s side. Everyone is laughing though, including Adora. The story is kind of secretly tragic – Catra never had access to the enrichment that magicats really *need* as a kid,

and she got punished harshly that night – but a lot of their stories are, so the two of them skate over it as Catra tucks down into her side with a huff, almost like she is trying to hide beneath Adora's arm.

Oh, she is *not* trying to hide. Adora feels her face flush as Catra's hand lands on her inner knee, able to reach now she is sunk down lower in the water, and her fingers begin to stroke an agonizing pace *up*, all in full view of the others should they glance down. The jets are causing the surface of the water to roll, distorting everything beneath it, and in Catra's defense, Adora hasn't looked at her friend's laps once since they all sat down here, but they *could* see it if they thought to look.

And yet the veneer of subtlety makes it feel thrilling without being outright dangerous. It is retaliation as Catra's fingers work slowly up her inner thigh. Adora is relieved when Bow jumps in with the story about Glimmer falling out of a tree, even though she has heard it a dozen times before, because it offers a distraction.

Catra is showing no signs of *stopping*. Luckily for Adora, it is getting late. After Bow's story, Mermista taps on Sea Hawk's shoulder and he shows her his watch. The thing is practically bulletproof, approved for diving even, but it has to be given Sea Hawk's profession and propensity for accidents.

"I'm still sleeping off the jetlag. I'm calling it a night. Go get my coat, babe," Mermista orders Sea Hawk. Sea Hawk immediately lights up, hauling himself out of the hot tub he has eventually come to rest in and hurrying over to the bench with their towels and coats. He seems unbothered by the cold as he wraps a towel around himself like a dress and then returns with Mermista's things.

Mermista stands to a chorus of goodbyes. Sea Hawk quickly works to dry her as she steps out of the hot tub, eventually wrapping the towel around her before helping her pull on a coat. Adora watches the routine with interest. She has watched Mermista and Sea Hawk do it while staying here before, but in the past she just thought *they're cute* and moved on.

Now, she is already planning how she will do the same for Catra. Mermista and Sea Hawk leave as Glimmer and Bow exchange looks. Glimmer turns to them rather *pointedly* with a smile on her face that Adora has learned to fear.

"We should head to bed too. We're going to the morning yoga class with Perfuma, and I need my sleep," Glimmer says. Adora can't help but feel there is some *signaling* going on here she isn't getting, because Catra's ears twitch back and then she tucks further into Adora's side. "It was nice finally meeting you, Catra," Glimmer tacks on, before standing and *squeaking*.

The posturing is over. Bow and Glimmer both hurry out of the tub, cursing and hissing at the cold as they bolt for the open doors of their room. Catra chuckles a little watching them go, relaxing into Adora's side. Adora watches Glimmer and Bow hurry to shut the door behind them and breathe a visible sigh of relief as they are left with just the warmth of the room before they move on to go find towels.

Adora turns her attention back to Catra, who seems to be trying to sink as low in the hot tub as she can go without getting her hair wet. Her hand is still on Adora's inner thigh, though it

is merely resting there rather than *stroking* like it was before. Adora bends down, pressing a kiss to the top of Catra's head and getting a slightly surprised *mrrp* in response. Adora chuckles, nuzzling her hair for a moment.

"They liked you. You fit in," Adora assures her. Catra blushes, rolling her eyes to cut her flush. She sits up straight again and turns, swinging herself into Adora's lap. Adora blinks at her in surprise as Catra straddles over her hips. Catra is still flushed, despite shivering a little as the movement rises her a few inches out of the water.

"Glimmer noticed my hand. She left to give us *privacy*," Catra informs her, her tail lashing behind her in the water as she watches Adora's expression cautiously. Adora flushes, raising her hands up to Catra's hips. Well, that explains the looks. Catra doesn't seem upset by it, and she did *start* it, so maybe she is just nervous for Adora's reaction.

"She already knew I wasn't pure, don't worry about it," Adora tells her, running her hands up and down Catra's sides. In her head, she is just trying to keep her warm and assure her, but Catra arches into the touch, watching her. Adora's cheeks are still warm, and she is hyperaware of Catra's bare legs against her own. They are both practically naked, and until this moment, they have only ever touched while fully dressed.

Catra apparently decides Adora is really okay with it, because she smirks a little and leans down, nipping cautiously at Adora's neck. Likely to avoid the saltwater that has reached her shoulders at certain parts of the night, Catra bites her higher up than usual, just beneath her ear. Adora moans and Catra purrs softly as she sucks against the spot, apparently determined to leave a *mark*.

Adora is wound up. Catra has been pressed against her, naked fur available for her to touch, for over an *hour* – probably, at least. Adora doesn't know how long it has been, really, especially not when her mind kept blanking out as Catra touched her. Adora *wants* her right now, and given that Catra has been the driving force of their contact tonight, she is fairly confident the feeling is mutual.

Catra pulls off of her neck, licking the spot once before Adora moves a hand to her jaw to encourage her up so they can kiss properly. Catra starts to chuckle, following her lead, and then cuts off with a soft moan as Adora kisses her just a bit roughly, her other hand sliding around Catra's lower back to urge her closer. Catra's moan is soft as she wriggles her hips back into Adora's touch.

Right, her hand is right above Catra's tail. Adora discovered it was sensitive back in high school by complete accident while scratching Catra's back. Adora slides the hand on Catra's cheek around to cup the back of her neck, and then she sets to properly rubbing at the base of Catra's tail. Catra practically cries out into the kiss.

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Catra can admit she teased Adora a lot tonight, but she still wasn't expecting *this*. Maybe it just takes her off guard because Adora isn't scenting like usual. Normally, if she were this turned on, Catra would be able to *smell* it, but she can't with Adora submerged in the water. She is kind of shocked when Adora sets to massaging the base of her tail, causing her to whimper into the kiss, needy and desperate.

"*Adora*," she manages to pant out, her rough voice the only real warning Adora gets. Catra doesn't know for sure that stimulation to her tail is enough to make her come, but fuck, it *feels* like it right now. Adora groans in response, kissing her back messily, but she gets the message. It is bizarre that Adora slipping her hand down to grab her ass instead is *safer*, but Catra's lower back is a huge thing for her.

Not that it *isn't* intense when Adora grabs her ass, squeezing it and pulling Catra closer in the process. All of Adora's soft skin is pressed against her, causing Catra to shiver a little. She is excruciatingly aware they are both practically naked. Adora is worked up, *clearly*, and Catra can't really blame her given the way she has been teasing her all night.

Adora nips at her lower lip, tugging on it and causing Catra to whine, her tail lashing as she tries to *follow* Adora's teeth pulling away from her. Adora quickly kisses her, soothing and gentle even as her hand on Catra's body slides up, cupping her ribs. Her fingers stroke along Catra's stripes there as they kiss and she can't help but arch into the touch.

"Catra," Adora breathes softly as they part for air, turning her head to nuzzle into her cheek. Catra purrs in response, properly rubbing her cheek against Adora to mark her. Adora lets out a soft, almost *dreamy* sigh. "Can I touch you?" she asks, her voice quiet and nervous. Catra blinks in surprise, realizing Adora's fingers are stroking just beneath the string of her bikini.

Oh. Adora really is turned on. Catra feels her breath hitch as she nods, a little too fast and eager, but fuck her, she *wants* it. She wants Adora to touch her, caring hands replacing the ghosting sensation of greedy groping that Catra never wanted from previous clients. She loves the way her fur *sparks* as Adora slides a hand beneath her bikini top and touches her chest directly.

Catra's breathing is unsteady as Adora cautiously thumbs over her nipple, seemingly hesitant. Right. She is beyond turned on, but Adora doesn't know what she is doing. This much Catra has been on the receiving end of before, even if it was over clothes. She can direct Adora and tell her what she likes regardless. Catra reaches up, covering Adora's hand with her own, and sets to massaging herself like she usually does for herself while getting off.

Adora picks it up quickly, groaning softly. She kisses her hungrily as she follows Catra's example and works her beneath her hand, pinching her nipple lightly. Catra whimpers, arching into the touch. She knows she is being needy, but when Adora just repeats the motion as she nips on Catra's lower lip, she can't be bothered to *care*. Catra moans, squirming in Adora's lap. Adora hesitates for a moment, but then she seems to realize Catra isn't trying to *get away*, and she sets back to touching her.

Adora breaks the kiss again, nuzzling against her cheek for a moment before leaning up to her ear.

“You like this?” she asks, her voice breathy and teasing, but Catra knows without a doubt it is a genuine question. She nods eagerly, whimpering a little again as the hand on the back of her head slides down and Adora scratches at her scruff with blunt nails. “Want me to grab it? Or would that be too much?” she asks, her voice soft.

Fuck. Catra is already squirming at the idea – or maybe it is just because Adora asked. No one has ever touched her scruff except for Adora. No one else would *think* to, usually focused on her body, but Adora knows how that helps all her muscles relax. She used to do it for her when Catra was stiff from injuries or dehydration. Catra nods, pressing back into Adora’s hand a little. Adora just keeps scratching her there.

“Can you say it for me?” she asks, her voice soft. Catra flushes, opening her eyes and leaning back a little to make eye contact with Adora. She wants to glare at her, but Adora’s gaze is soft, a gentle smile on her lips as she waits. Her expression is nothing but encouraging. She isn’t trying to make Catra admit anything, she just needs to be sure. As much as Adora grabbing her like this relaxes Catra, it has also made her snarl before when she wasn’t ready for it and felt like Adora was trying to force her calm.

“Please,” she manages, her cheeks blazing and tail lashing. Adora blows out a breath, uneven and a bit awestruck. She gathers Catra’s scuff up in her hand, pulling on it with steady pressure. Catra feels her entire body relax, just sinking into the warm bliss of the hot water and Adora’s hands on her, her other hand still massaging her chest. Catra is purring, she realizes as she squirms in Adora’s lap.

If she weren’t already in a hot tub, she would be fucking *soaking*. Adora has touched her in ways no one else has ever even *tried*, much less that Catra would allow, and her entire body is crying out for more. Catra tilts her chin up, releasing a small sound suspiciously close to a whimper, but it is the best she can manage right now.

Adora understands her regardless, bending down to kiss her. The embrace is open-mouthed and hungry, but that is Catra’s fault. She *wants*. She squirms in Adora’s lap again, unsure what to do. She doesn’t want this to stop, but she also wants more. At the same time, she doesn’t want to push Adora further than she is comfortable.

Adora nips at her lower lip as she drags the pad of her thumb over Catra’s nipple again, only this time she is tugging on Catra’s scruff as she does so, and it is too much. Catra mewls into the kiss, desperately rolling her hips down trying to find Adora’s thigh for some *relief* in the face of the heat building in her.

She has wanted this for so long – she has pictured moments *exactly* like this, with Adora caring to take the time to search out all her special spots and smother them with attention. She never thought it would be *real*. She never thought Adora would groan in response to Catra making desperate noises she would never let anyone else hear, pulling back from the kiss to shift up and-

Catra outright whines as Adora gently takes the edge of her ear, fur be damned, in between her teeth and *tugs*, just the right level of pressure mixed with delicate caution. Catra’s squirming finally lands her on Adora’s thigh, giving her something to rub herself down

against. Adora releases her ear and presses a gentle kiss against its base before slowly releasing the grip on her neck, easing Catra out of it.

Catra huffs in disappointment, forcing her hips still despite how she wants to grind and finally get off on Adora's touch – her *real* touch and not an imagined fantasy. She ducks her head down, hiding her face in Adora's jaw as Adora finally slides her hand out from Catra's bikini to wrap both arms around her back, cradling her close.

"Back to the room?" Adora asks, her voice barely above a whisper. Oh. Catra feels her ears and tail perk up. Her disappointment is gone.

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Adora doesn't know where her boldness came from other than her building desire from the last few weeks – and, truthfully, *years* – and Catra's own reactions encouraging her forward. Catra doesn't tell her to stop, she doesn't *want* her to. The only thing that makes Adora stop is a sudden crawling sensation on the back of her neck that reminds that they are, in a way, out in the open. The pool is private, but what happened the *first* time she was vulnerable like this rears its head again in her subconscious.

Catra is eager enough to return to the room at least. Adora gets out of the hot tub first, running over to their towels while hissing from the cold and quickly wrapping one around herself. She gathers Catra's coat and towel, and they go through a similar procedure as Sea Hawk and Mermista did, with Adora speed-drying Catra and then wrapping her in her coat before they *sprint* for their room.

When they get in the room, Adora slams their door shut and then sets to drying Catra properly, toweling down her body as Catra pulls the coat tight around her shoulders. Adora dries her legs, then her torso, and then cajoles Catra into slipping off her coat so she can dry her arms, shoulders, and the back of her neck. When she is done, Catra immediately throws herself forward into her arms, beginning to purr as she plasters herself into Adora's warmth.

Adora has largely air-dried on her own as she helped Catra. She wraps her arms around Catra, holding her close as she leads her into the bedroom. The hotel rooms here are all outfitted with smart technology, and Adora simply has to press the night mode button on the wall panel for all the lights in the room to dim as shutters come down over the windows, blocking out the moonlight. After a moment, all that is left is the softly-glowing end table lamp, easy to shut off when they are ready for sleep.

Catra nuzzles into Adora's arms and Adora holds her close, able to feel the minute tremors beneath her coat that mean Catra isn't totally warmed up, but her fur is still damp and Adora doubts she wants to get into the bed like this. Catra confirms her suspicions when she shivers and pulls back, offering Adora a small, almost *nervous* smile before she turns around and shows Adora her back.

“Take this off for me? I might slice the strings if I try,” Catra says, clearly trying to inject humour in her voice, but it trembles a little from her nerves. Adora’s own heart pounds as she realizes just a few strings stand between her and *naked Catra*. Adora swallows, raising her hands and carefully undoing the tie beneath Catra’s shoulder blade so she can easily pull the bikini top off over her shoulders.

Adora is infinitely grateful she put the room in night mode first as Catra reaches up to do just that, undoing her ponytail for good measure. It means the room is dim and the shutters have closed off most reflective surfaces in which she could see *completely topless Catra*. Catra hesitates, her back still turned to Adora, before she takes a half step back to nudge herself beneath Adora’s hands.

Adora blows out a breath and sets to carefully petting down Catra’s back, trying to soothe and warm her. Catra is *nervous* in a way she hasn’t been up until now. Adora really doesn’t know what to make of that. Catra has been leading them forward for the most part, and Adora isn’t confident in her ability to take charge, or if she even *should*.

“Are we doing this?” Catra asks, her voice quiet. She sounds nervous definitely, but also hopeful. Adora draws in a breath, blinking at the back of her mane for a moment before she steps forward and presses up against Catra’s back, wrapping her arms around her.

“I want to, but not here. As much as I want to touch you… You don’t deserve a hotel rendezvous,” Adora tells her the decision she came to out in the hot tub, when she felt the non-existent eyes on her. That showed her she is *ready* – she wants this too badly to keep holding back for no good reason – but right now she is going to keep holding back for a very good one. One with an *expiration* date.

In her arms, Catra shivers a little, purring as she presses back into Adora’s embrace. Adora squeezes her close for a moment before she slides her hands down to her bikini bottoms.

“We’ll change into pajamas and cuddle?” she offers, toying with the strings. She feels Catra’s body relax against her. Adora can only hope that Catra got the right message from all that – she is ready now, at least she thinks, but she wants to wait until they are at home, in a familiar and comforting bed.

Catra lets her slip her bikini bottoms down, Adora’s desire not *fading* as Catra saunters across the room to the closet and pulls on underwear and flannel pajamas *slowly*, teasing Adora with all the naked fur before her that she has been touching all night – that she could *still* be touching if the smirk on Catra’s face is anything to go by. Adora swallows and then flushes when it is her turn and Catra turns her back, climbing into bed to give Adora privacy that she didn’t ask for herself.

Adora changes quickly, the damp cold clinging to her bones beginning to fade as she pulls on the warm clothes and then, a bit cautiously, lifts the sheets on the same side Catra got into the bed on and cuddles up behind her. She spoons her for all of two seconds before Catra turns over and drapes across her chest, apparently unbothered by Adora’s presumptuous closeness.

Fuck, Catra had sounded so nervous though. What if she doesn’t actually want to do this? She definitely liked what was happening out in the pool, but that was already so much further

than they have gone before. Adora can't ignore her sudden nervousness when they reached the bedroom, or how it dissipated when she confirmed they weren't going to-

"Adora?" Catra mumbles into her chest. Her words are muffled by her positioning, but Adora can tell she is still wide awake. Actually, from the tenseness creeping back into her shoulders, she has been having her own spiral.

"Yeah?" Adora responds, trying to keep her heartrate under control and voice casual, well aware Catra can feel her beating heart. There is a moment of silence as Catra's tail sways uncertainly over their legs.

"Fuck me when we get home?" she asks, her voice low. All the air leaves Adora's lungs. That is the absolute last way she would have phrased it, but she has had a crush on Catra since middle school probably, and Catra is just talking about having sex. Still, she can't stop herself from asking.

"Do you want that?" she asks, her voice just as soft. To her surprise, Catra snorts with amusement.

"*Obviously*, Adora. I thought that was what you were bringing us inside to do," Catra assures her, turning her head and nudging the collar of Adora's shirt aside to drop a kiss against her shoulder. Adora's entire chest soars as she eagerly nods. She has been looking forward to this trip for weeks, but suddenly all she cares about is Sunday, when they will return to the penthouse.

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Catra usually struggles waking up in a strange place. She spends the entire month of the Christmas break getting shitty, unrestful sleep in hotel rooms that feel unsafe and largely *are*. She didn't struggle at all on the first night she slept at Adora's – nor any night after – but the entire place smells like Adora and thus safety. She wasn't really *surprised* she felt safe there.

She wakes up sleepy, but in a content, sleep-is-great-and-I-want-to-keep-doing-it way. She is in the bed beside Adora, curling around her and clinging on like a koala. Adora has one arm draped over her back, the hand slipped beneath the hem of Catra's pajama top to absently pet through her fur. Her other hand is propping her phone up as she scrolls through it.

She is really absorbed, missing when Catra first cracks an eye open, but when Catra slowly blinks at her, Adora notices she is awake. She lights up a little, bending her head down to press a kiss to the top of Catra's head. Catra releases a soft *mrrph*, pressing up into the attention for a moment before dropping her head back to Adora's shoulder and setting to marking it emphatically.

"Is the sleepy kitty finally awake?" Adora teases, kissing each of her ears in turn. Catra doesn't mean to trill, she just *does*. Smug satisfaction rolls off of Adora as Catra huffs.

“What are you doing?” she asks, ignoring *everything* that just happened. Adora pulls back to give her a *you aren’t bullshitting me* look, but then she angles her phone screen so Catra can see it. Ah, right. Adora did say she *has to know* if she knows there are going to be articles.

She has so many tabs open the tab counter has been changed to a *smiley emoticon*, but from the ones Catra can see, it is mostly a smattering of articles and then twitter threads. Currently she is reading a BubblePOP article that, from what Catra can see, is surprisingly realistic. It mentions how this is the first concrete example of Adora being in a relationship since being outed, citing their shared suitcase that the paparazzi managed to snag pictures of.

“My favourite is the article that claims to have an inside source on the resort staff talking about how disgustingly flirty we are when we went straight to the room after checking in,” Adora tells her, voice amused. Catra snorts, turning her head to look away from the phone and instead stare up at Adora.

“It doesn’t bother you that they’re still lying about you?” she asks. She isn’t trying to *incite* that emotion in Adora, but she knows her best friend, and Adora’s default state is putting on a brave face. Adora pauses, cocking her head a little as she glances back down at her phone, but then she shakes her head.

“No. Probably because it’s kind of true, even if they made it up. I know they’re still spreading lies, but we *are* together, so it really doesn’t bother me like it does when they do it about me and Mermista or something,” Adora tells her, shifting her thumb up to close the tab. Catra flushes, hurriedly returning to marking Adora if only to hide her face. Why does she have to make it sound like they’re really *in love*? Yes, they are “dating”, but it is far from a real relationship.

Okay, they do everything they *would* if they were in a relationship, but that’s just because Adora doesn’t feel comfortable letting down her barriers for anyone else. Adora doesn’t feel the same about Catra, but the way she says shit like that really makes it seem like she does. Moments like this are the exact kind of torture Catra was worried about when she was trying to convince herself not to do this.

At the same time, Catra is warm and safe in Adora’s arms. Adora holds her and kisses her in a way no one else ever has. Catra wouldn’t – she *couldn’t* – trade this for the world. All the uncomfortable dates, lecherous clients, and pervasive sense of discomfort as she allowed touches that she never wanted are reduced down to a memory in Adora’s embrace.

Last night they nearly had sex. They were certainly headed that way, and though Catra was nervous, she was *excited*. She would have been happy for her first time to have gone like that, Adora undressing her from her cold swimsuit and then warming her up in the bed. It would have been better than anything Catra realistically thought she would get.

But it wasn’t better than what she had *dreamed*. That is still coming when they get home. Something soft, she hopes, in a bed they share surrounded by the safety of Adora’s apartment. Sure, the word *love* won’t be hanging in the air between them, but it will be what Catra has always wanted in every other way. She is still going to be nervous – of *course* she is, she is entering unknown territory – but she is ready to go there with Adora by her side.

“You slept late enough they’re going to stop serving breakfast soon. Ready to get up?” Adora asks, dropping her phone on the sheets to wrap both her arms around Catra. Catra grumbles, pulled out of her thoughts, but also not wanting to leave the warm comfort. Adora chuckles. “Food, Catra,” she reminds. Catra remembers the abalone from last night.

Alright, *fine*.

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Glimmer, Bow, and Perfuma are all at the morning stretching and yoga routine designed to relax the body before a day of spa treatments. Mermista and Sea Hawk, by contrast, haven’t even woken up yet, or if they are awake, they aren’t answering their phones. Adora isn’t about to knock on their door and check. When those two are alone, they’re either goofing off together, inciting chaos that may require emergency services being called, or having passionate sex. Adora isn’t inviting the latter two options into her life.

She takes Catra to her favourite of the three restaurants on the resort. It isn’t the seafood restaurant, but Adora doubts they have much in the way of breakfast options anyway. They get a table for two, but Adora frowns when Catra sits down across from her. It is a good set up for talking, sure, but-

“Come over here, dummy. You don’t have to *sulk*,” Catra tells her, rolling her eyes as she motions Adora closer. Adora can’t deny that she lights up, scooting her chair around the edge of the table so they can sit beside each other. Amusement is written across Catra’s face as she drapes her tail across Adora’s lap. Adora pets it happily, humming to herself as they wait for the waiter to bring their orders.

This weekend has been *amazing* so far. It feels like a romantic getaway, even if it is technically supposed to be a birthday celebration. They snuggle all through breakfast, talking and just fucking around as they eat. They are in public, technically, but Adora can relax here. There aren’t any cameras, and as an ex-celebrity she isn’t interesting enough to draw attention from the other patrons.

When they finish eating, Adora decides that Catra has to experience some of the fur conditioning treatments – the fact that it will leave her fur soft for Adora to touch is *irrelevant* – and drags her off to one of the couple’s rooms. They have a number of rooms here designed for interspecies couples, and the pair of them strip down to their bikinis again so Catra can get the treatment while Adora gets a full-body skin mask.

She kind of likes it. It’s almost comforting. Or maybe that is just Catra laying a few feet away, purring softly in the darkened room.

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Alright, Catra can admit she likes being pampered. Her fur feels light and soft after the powders and products that were brushed into and then out of it. The fact that Adora got jealous halfway through because someone else was brushing her just made it more fun. Even the technicians found it funny, once they figured out what was going on from Catra sniping at Adora across the room. Catra asks if they have ever had that happen with a couple before and they admit that they haven't with a laugh.

Catra is relaxed enough she isn't even worried when they decide to go meet up with Adora's friends afterwards. The technician that Catra saw handed Adora the finishing brush at the very end, letting Adora delight in brushing Catra as she told Catra the treatments she recommends for her to go through over the weekend, based on her fur and mane's "problem areas" which, *shockingly*, she is informed are likely due to stress.

"Wonder where that could be coming from," Catra jokes, rolling her eyes. Adora looks up, her eyes soft and expression filled with affection. Catra thuds her tail against the table, feeling herself flush, though she doesn't know *why*. She just isn't used to anyone looking at her so lovingly.

"You're going to be a fantastic lawyer," Adora promises her, softly, before ducking to drop a kiss to her bare shoulder. Catra flushes crimson and decides yes, it is definitely time to go find Adora's friends, if only so *strangers* aren't the one shooting them amused looks as Adora continues to be an utter fucking *sap*.

Adora's friends are, it turns out, at the soaking pools, which are also apparently a thing that exists.

"There are indoor hot tubs, and you made us use the one in the courtyard last night?" Catra demands in a hiss as they make their way to the pools. Adora rolls her eyes, squeezing the arm she has wrapped around Catra's back.

"It was late, they were closed, and these aren't *private*. They aren't normal either. They have different products in them that are good for your skin or whatever. We'll soak and then go to lunch," Adora promises her. Catra is far from convinced, but she can admit when they arrive that she preferred the privacy of their own hot tub, especially given what they got up to in it.

They find the rest of their group soaking in an antioxidant bath and join them. One of the attendants wandering the area warns Catra that her coat won't get much of anything out of it, but Catra isn't inclined towards soaking in general anyway, and especially not after that treatment that made her fur feel amazing. The attendant rushes off to get her one of the waterproof floor cushions they apparently keep for this exact scenario so she can hang out on the sidelines of the tub.

She ends up sat on the edge of the tub while Adora settles inside just in front of her so Catra can lean on her head and shoulders. The cushion is comfortable enough, and the entire room is warm with a nice floral scent. Catra doesn't mind just lounging on her oversized pillow as Adora greets her friends again. Bow is wearing a swim shirt today – Catra can't help but remember what Adora said about him not wanting to be out to the general public and realizes

he is covering his top surgery scars – and they have a new addition in Perfuma, but the group dynamic is pretty much the same from last night.

Perfuma is also sitting on a cushion beside the pool, fully dressed in a flowing skirt and a baby doll-style top. She isn't dressed for the activity, but apparently she can't really partake in it anyway without risking some sutures getting soaked or something. She has a pair of pink slides sat beside her and her skirt scrunched up in her lap so she can soak her legs in the water at least.

Perfuma zeroes in on them immediately. Catra's ears pin back when Perfuma picks up her cushion and pads around the edge of the hot tub to settle closer beside her. Adora raises a hand, reaching back for Catra's tail and pulling it around to drape the tip of it over her shoulder so she can pet and squeeze it to comfort her while Catra braces herself.

"How have you been, Perfuma? I feel like I haven't seen you in ages," Adora greets, craning her head back to look at the blonde woman Catra has only ever seen in a photo before.

"You *haven't*. Too busy with your new girlfriend to make it out to Long Island, Adora?" Perfuma asks. Her tone is teasing, but Catra kind of wants to jump into the soaking tub so she can duck under the water and never come up. Great, Adora's friends are blaming Catra for taking up her time, apparently. She wasn't aware she was *doing* that. Adora still went out for lunch plans with Glimmer and Bow while she was staying over. She had no reason to think Adora was canceling anything. Adora just gives a half shrug in response, still toying with Catra's tail.

"I've just been in one of my reclusive moods. You know how I get whenever there are more articles written," Adora returns. Catra is a bit relieved to see Perfuma's expression soften with sympathy as she nods her understanding. Catra is starting to get *really curious* what those articles said after the charity event, but given what Adora let slip during their lunch with Hope, she suspects reading them would only incense her.

"I remember the ones you sent to the group chat. I don't blame you for wanting to keep your head down when they paint you that way. Have you enjoyed your time in the penthouse, at least? Gotten some good songs written?" Perfuma asks. Catra forces herself not to react. She didn't know Adora wrote songs at *all*. She definitely didn't write the songs on her discography and they generally avoid talking about music or those five years.

Catra could tell she still played – or at least maintained – her piano, but Adora hasn't touched it once while she was staying over. Probably because Catra usually takes over the office as her study area, but she is kicking herself for not asking anything about music. She has been curious, but she just assumed it would be a sore subject. Clearly there are still positives to talk about, based on the stories Adora's friends were telling last night and now *this*.

"A bunch of half starts that mostly weren't worth writing down. You know how it is," Adora dismisses with a wave of her left hand. Catra's heart squeezes. She didn't fucking *know*. She hasn't even met this other woman before, and yet she knew something about Adora that Catra didn't. A bitter feeling is clawing at her throat, but Catra forces herself to swallow it down. She certainly isn't asking *now*, when it would mean admitting to a stranger that she didn't know something about her "girlfriend."

Perfuma looks to Catra, offering her a broad smile.

“Well, I’m glad you have someone to *distract* you now,” Perfuma tells Adora. She doesn’t wink, but her voice says enough. Catra flushes, her tail lashing and immediately slipping from Adora’s shoulder and landing in the water. Catra hisses, reaching down to grab it and curl it back into her lap. Adora turns around in the hot tub, clearly concerned, but Catra waves her off with a roll of her eyes. They are both wearing their bikinis and complimentary robes anyway, so it isn’t like her tail is going to get her clothes wet.

She takes a breath, reminding herself it is *okay* if people think they are having sex. People in relationships do that. It isn’t accusing her of sex work – especially not when Perfuma says it, seeing as she *shouldn’t* know anything about the arrangement or Catra’s past. Catra is just so used to such an implication being dangerous – and blatantly wrong - that her gut instinct is to run.

“Ooo, someone’s flustered. Who was it getting handsy in the hot tub last night then?” Mermista calls, teasing and smug, from the other end of the soaking tub. Catra is glad she still has her hand on her tail or it would be going in the water again as she flushes crimson. Okay, that is true and she didn’t realize Mermista *saw* seeing as she didn’t react at all, but Catra really can’t handle being teased for this, not after living in fear of accusations like this for nearly three years.

“Alright, leave my girlfriend alone. She’s new,” Adora warns. Her tone is friendly, but she has on her intense face that means she isn’t going to accept arguing. It works. Catra breathes a sigh of relief as the topic moves on and Adora settles back to sitting on the bench properly. The group teases Glimmer about her age – apparently she is the youngest by almost two whole years and it is a sore spot.

Catra does her best to focus, trying to remember details about Adora’s friends and even finding herself caught up at points – she especially enjoys trading barbed quips with Glimmer, it turns out – but in the back of her mind, a thought is starting to permeate from her earlier fluster. It isn’t even her embarrassment from today – last night she got nervous too, and it clearly worried Adora.

When they all get up to go to lunch, Catra grabs Adora’s hand and pulls her aside while everyone is drying off.

“I have something I need to tell you. Not out here, but tonight,” Catra tells her. She realizes her mistake as panic flashes across Adora’s face. “It isn’t bad, or probably even surprising, it’s just private. I don’t want to be overheard,” Catra clarifies for her. Adora eases, nodding once before sending her a cautious smile.

“Not leaving me for your secret crush on Mermista, are you?” she teases. Catra rolls her eyes, batting at Adora’s arm before she takes it up to hang off of it.

“Please, she couldn’t handle me,” Catra returns. Adora, for some reason, *flushes*, just blinking at her for a moment before Catra raises a brow. “Lunch, Adora?” she reminds. Adora startles out of her trance, sending Catra a sheepish look before she starts moving to lead them back to their friends.

Catra is nervous. She doesn't know why. She thinks Adora already *knows*, and even if she doesn't, it isn't like she isn't in the same boat. That's just the issue though: Adora has good reason to be in her position. Catra's reason is that she has always been in love with Adora, and she isn't sure what she is supposed to say when Adora asks.

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The day goes really well. They all get lunch together and then split off for couples' massages, reconvening at the salon afterwards to get their hair done together. Catra is uncomfortable being such a center of attention seeing as her mane needs to be handled entirely differently than everyone else's hair, but Adora runs interference, and at the end Catra's hair is tangle free, almost curly from the treatments to restore its damage.

Adora and Catra both pull a face when the technician mentions the chemical damage she can see. Apparently Catra was getting it chemically relaxed a few times a year, and though she doesn't tell the technician why, Adora knows. She luxuriates in petting Catra's hair while they are all getting their nails – and claws – cared for at the nail salon afterwards. She makes a point to mention how she likes Catra's hair like this to her. Not that she thinks Catra would ever assume Adora liked her better with her hair treated, but she wants her to *know*.

The rest of the day goes like that, with them meeting up for whatever treatments they can get as a group together and then splitting off, largely in pairs, for more individual treatments. Catra spends a good third of the day purring as she is pampered, and by the time they are returning back to their room after dinner, Adora can't keep her hands off Catra. She is soft in a way she never has been and Catra was already soft as a *default*.

"You should close the shutters if you're going to get this handsy," Catra teases as Adora pulls open her robe to run her hands down her sides. Catra is wearing her bikini still – they both are, the standard attire around the resort being a swimsuit and loose clothes or a robe – but she sees her point. She puts the room into night mode and they end up lying in bed together, Adora burying her face in every inch of Catra she can reach, humming as she pets along her sides.

"I think you might be enjoying my spa treatments more than I am," Catra teases, reaching a hand down to run it through Adora's hair. She has had her hair down ever since the salon, where her stylist warned her that she needed to wear it down more or her ponytail would start ruining her hairline. Adora reached a compromise with her that she could still wear her loose half-ponytail up top to keep it out of her eyes - that style pulls a lot less and is easier to throw up - but she's kept it down since.

Adora just hums in response, nosing into the soft fluff of Catra's stomach. Catra loves being pampered and Adora doubts she would deny it, but Adora knows what her point is and she is right. She can't help it that her girlfriend is so soft. She can't believe she went *ten years* without the peace that spreads through her as she snuggles Catra.

“Adora?” Catra prompts above her. She still sounds amused, but also a little nervous. Adora lifts her head, shooting her a curious look. Catra flushes, ears twitching as she looks quickly away. “That thing I wanted to tell you, back at the soaking pools,” she reminds. Adora draws in a breath. Even with a whole day between now and then, she instantly knows what Catra is talking about. She nods, slow and a little cautious. Catra seems embarrassed, not upset, and she said it wouldn’t be surprising, but Adora really can’t imagine what it could be.

“You might already know this. It might seem so obvious that I don’t even need to say it. But you were nervous last night, and I think it was because *I* was nervous, so I just want to tell you so we’re both on the same page,” Catra explains, lifting her hand out of Adora’s hair to gesture a bit nervously. Her claws are out and her cheeks are red. Adora’s nervousness instantly skyrockets, but she just nods, trying to wait before she jumps to the worst conclusion. Catra looks back to her, drawing in a slow breath.

“I’m a virgin. I’ve never- What we did last night is further than I’ve gone ever with anyone,” Catra tells her, still flushed. Adora stares at her, a little shocked, by both the sudden topic and the *information*. She blinks at Catra for a few long moments.

“It, um, wasn’t obvious. To me, at least,” she replies, because she doesn’t know what else to *say*. She knew that Catra didn’t do this with clients as a rule, but she didn’t know she had *never* done it before. Her nerves last night suddenly make sense, but now Adora is worried about how far she has pushed her. Catra huffs, an attempt at a laugh, but she is a little too flustered for it.

“I want to do this with you, at least when we get home. It’s just that I’ve been the one leading us through all this, and I’ll still do that as best I can, but I need you to know I’m inexperienced here too,” Catra tells her, cheeks blazing. Adora softens, nodding to her.

“Okay. You know we can wait if you aren’t ready,” she has to add, has to be *sure*. Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes before she sends Adora a leer.

“Princess, I’m planning for us both to be naked the second we’re unpacked,” Catra returns. Adora turns bright red.

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They leave the resort late on Sunday morning. Their checkout time is noon, so they get breakfast as a group, one last set of couples’ massages – sans Perfuma, who goes it alone – and then depart the hotel after getting lunch together as a group.

Catra can admit she likes the group. She may or may not have spent the weekend subtly testing Mermista and Sea Hawk, but they pass all her attempts. Glimmer is an annoying little shit and Catra was uneasy with her and Bow at first, but Bow turns out to be a total sweetheart, and Glimmer’s assholery is endearing in its own way. Catra didn’t start with a vendetta against Perfuma and the woman never gives her one.

Even the spa was fun. Catra was worried when Adora described the pools and soaking tubs to her while describing the resort, and apparently they usually spend more time at those locations, but between Perfuma healing from some surgery and Catra not being inclined towards water, they geared their weekend towards other things.

Catra lays down her seat on the drive home and naps, burrowed down in her coat. Her purr feels like it could be rattling the windows, but Adora *likes* it, so she isn't inclined to stop. As fun as the weekend was, Catra is glad when they return to the city that is so familiar to her. She rouses slowly from her drowsy state as they make their way to SOHO.

There has been a sense of anticipation building between them ever since they went back to their room to get their bags. It is strong as they pull into the parking garage and head up to the penthouse, Adora carrying the suitcase in one hand while holding Catra's with her other. Catra takes care of swiping them in and getting the elevator going, her fur ruffling a little as she does so from the mix of nerves and excitement.

"Are you sure about this?" Adora asks her when they make their way up to the bedroom, the suitcase abandoned on the floor. Catra swallows, nodding to her partner. Yeah, she *definitely* wants this. She has pictured this so many ways, but what is happening right here is her *favourite* – Adora approaching her with desire in her eyes, her hands coming up to rest on Catra's waist and pull her in.

The kiss is passionate, Adora's hands roaming over her body and sparking desire within her. Catra *wants* this – more than anything, she wants Adora. She pulls back from the kiss to nip at Adora's lower lip, reveling in the groan it earns her. She loves that sound. She wants to hear all the noise Adora is willing to make for her, but that isn't the only reason she pulls back to gaze up at Adora, her heart beating fast.

She has been thinking about this for the whole drive. Truthfully, she has been thinking about it ever since Friday night, when she thought it was going to happen for the first time. She hadn't expected the *elation* she felt then, finally able to let her fear of this go now she knew it would actually be good for her. A request formed in her mind then, a way to make this the antithesis of everything she feared it should be and just have it be *good* for both of them.

"Adora, can I take care of you?" Catra asks her, voice soft. She is pretty sure she knows where Adora's alignments fall, just based off her behaviour when they have made out, at least ever since Adora got comfortable with it. She knows how Adora was likely picturing this. She has to ask, to make sure it is okay with Adora, and communicate what *she* wants in case Adora just assumed she would top herself.

From the way Adora blinks at her, Catra can tell she did. She rolls her eyes a little, pressing closer to wrap her arms around Adora. Yes, they may both be virgins, but this was never an even playing field given the experience Catra has over her when it comes to everything else intimate. It just makes sense for Catra to top, even if *logic* isn't the reason Catra is asking. After a moment of blinking, Adora gives her a small, encouraging smile.

"Of course. Can we switch after? I'd like to touch you too," Adora asks. Catra flushes, her tail lashing behind her as she nods. Adora's expression is soft as she raises one hand to cup her cheek, the other wrapping around her lower back to hold her close. Adora cradles her like

she is something *precious*, her eyes shining and fond of her despite how Catra is so flustered she doesn't know if she can manage a reply.

"I always assumed- it seemed like my first time would just be me getting fucked," Catra elaborates, wording it ever-so-delicately, but she doesn't need to say more. Adora's expression tinges with sadness as she gives a small nod. She knows what Catra means, or she can at least take a guess towards what she feared. Adora's hand on her cheek shifts a little to frame her jaw, gentle pressure encouraging her to tilt her head up.

Catra leans gladly into the kiss, her heart hammering with both nerves and the joy of knowing this *is* going to be good. Adora's lips are soft, the kiss gentle like Catra is something *delicate* Adora fears her breath alone could shatter. It has Catra shivering, pressing into Adora gladly. She wants nothing more than to lay this woman down and *worship* her, showing Adora all the care she has given to Catra. Adora pulls back from the kiss, her eyes still shining.

"It will be whatever you want it to be," she promises her. Catra's entire body relaxes, a peaceful *acceptance* spreading through her.

It will be. She knows that. Catra slides her hands down to Adora's hips and turns them, slowly backing Adora to the bed and encouraging her to lay back. Adora just smiles up at her as she lays back, letting Catra take the reins.

Chapter End Notes

I've added a tentative chapter count. I expect the final count to be that plus or minus 1-2. Next chapter: I mean, you know they're gonna fuck, but also, karma.

Sunday

Chapter Notes

Filth.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora isn't nervous. She is pretty sure that is weird. She knows she would be nervous if she were the one in charge, worried about if she could make Catra feel good, but right now Catra is straddled over her lap, smiling down at her encouragingly as she tosses Adora's shirt aside. She still has on a sports bra, but apparently Catra is in no rush, because she just leans down to kiss her, lips soft even as she nips at Adora's bottom lip.

Adora releases a soft whine, propping herself up on her elbows to kiss her back. Catra purrs a little, one of her hands landing on Adora's shoulder to insistently push her back to once again be lying flat on the bed. Adora huffs a little, causing Catra's lips to quirk in amusement as she kisses her again, but she lets herself be pushed back. Catra drags her hand from her shoulder slowly *down*, feeling along the lines of Adora's body as she goes. Adora finds herself arching into the touch, completely unconsciously.

She can't help it. She has always had a thing for Catra's hands, and despite most of her fantasies focusing on finally being able to touch Catra in every way, there were some that were just getting to feel Catra touch her, intent tracing along her skin. Apparently Catra shares that fantasy. She shifts back to kneel between Adora's legs, shooting her a questioning look as she reaches for her waistband.

"Can I take this off?" she asks, her voice soft. Adora doesn't know of a reality where she would say *no*. She nods, already reaching down to help Catra shove it down. Catra's eyes dance with amusement, her tail swaying behind her as if *delighted* as she shifts to discard Adora's fleece-lined pants. She should probably be cold without them, but the penthouse is warm, and her desire is beginning to burn beneath her skin.

Catra's eyes drag along her body for a moment as she bites her lip, seemingly unconsciously. Adora knows she should probably be embarrassed by how turned on she is just seeing *Catra* turned on by her, but she can't be bothered to as Catra shifts up and sets to fulfilling her fantasy. Catra straddles her hips and drags her hands down her arms, squeezing and feeling out the lines of her muscles that Adora works so hard to maintain.

It feels good when anyone appreciates them, but having Catra's hands on her is a whole other level of experience. Adora has had hands on her all weekend, between skin treatments and massages and the resorts other services, but she feels energy thrumming through her body as Catra sweeps her hands down.

Catra leans down to nip at her neck as she feels up her sides. Her teeth are harsh, but the licks with her tongue are soothing, and the kisses she follows each bite up with are gentle. Adora finds herself sighing with content, shifting just a little beneath Catra's hands and *teeth*. She was turned on before they even reached upstairs, well aware of what was coming, and now she feels a bit desperate beneath Catra's touch.

She knew what they were going to do, but she didn't know it would be *this*, and she realizes her breathing has turned uneven by the time Catra has shifted down to kiss her collarbones. As good as her mouth feels on her, Adora *really* wants to kiss her again. Cautiously, Adora reaches up to thread a hand through Catra's mane, tugging lightly to get her attention without hurting her sensitive scalp.

Catra understands her immediately. She chuckles, but she shifts up and kisses Adora on the mouth, causing her to sigh as a bit of the energy building in her releases, temporarily contented by Catra's lips. Catra's hands are sweeping back up again, following the line of her abs and reaching her chest. Catra massages her through her bra, finding her nipple and pinching it through the fabric. Adora moans quietly, arching up into the touch. She is sensitive, but she also likes it a bit *rough*.

"Harder," she pants out before kissing Catra again, hungry and a bit desperate now. Her underwear is clinging to her, her entire body beginning to tense from how wound up she feels. She wants to flip them, roaming greedy hands over Catra and then touching her. She wants to earn those soft cries from Friday night, but she keeps one hand fisted in the sheets and the other threaded through Catra's hair.

Catra has clearly been nervous for her first time. Adora can guess she was afraid that it would be with a client – which Adora may be *technically*, but not like her others. Catra deserves a good experience, and this is good for Adora too, she just isn't used to feeling consumed by her desire like this. Her entire body is flushing – she is even beginning to sweat – despite how they haven't even gotten naked yet. She usually just touches herself long before this point, but Catra seems determined to touch her body rather than where Adora needs her.

Catra follows her request, kneading roughly against her chest and pinching Adora just short of *painfully*. Adora cries out, arching up into the touch as heat shoots through her. Her body is desperate for more, trembling just a little beneath Catra's hands as Catra shifts her hands up so her fingers can curl around the edge of Adora's sports bra.

"Want me to take this off?" Catra asks, pulling back just far enough to make eye contact, gaze questioning until she catches sight of how *visibly* turned on Adora is. Immediately, her eyes blow out, her ears twitching with interest and tail swaying again. Adora is too turned on to be embarrassed by the way Catra sniffs the air, especially when Catra *licks her lips* in response.

"Please. Can I undress you too?" she asks, already sitting up so Catra can pull the offending garment off. She *really* wants Catra naked, but she also doesn't know if Catra will feel better staying dressed. Catra grins a little in response, reaching down to pull on Adora's bra band.

"Yes, princess," she promises her. Adora can't help but groan as she raises her arms over her head to aid in the removal of the bra. As soon as it is gone, she drops her hands to the hem of

Catra's shirt. Catra lets her tug it over her head, leaving them both completely topless, and then Catra shifts off of her to kick off her own pants.

Oh. And her underwear. Adora is going to *catch fire* before Catra even touches her, apparently. Catra smirks at her as she returns to straddling over her. Adora is still wearing her underwear – which is *ruined*, considering even her thighs are wet at this point – but she can feel Catra pressing against her. Catra is wet too, the realization causing Adora hands to fly up to her hips without her commanding them to. Catra sends her an amused look as Adora leans up and kisses her hungrily. She is so wound up, twenty-five years leading up to this moment when she finally has the girl of her dreams in her lap-

Fuck. She isn't supposed to think that. She has been trying to kill those thoughts ever since they first started edging at her mind in high school. She has never even let them fully form until this moment. She didn't *realize* that was the thought she has been suppressing, but she can't deny it now, not when *I love you* echoes through her chest as Catra slides a hand into her hair, fisting it and then *pulling* her head back to change the angle, claiming her mouth and making Adora hers.

Adora has known she has a crush on Catra for years. When she was staring down the barrel of two more years in the music industry without Catra, it was clear that Catra was more than a friend she found hot. She realized that anything, even stardom, could be bearable if only Catra was with her. Once she realized that much, Adora tried to bury it. It didn't help anything when Catra wasn't in her life anymore, and it could actively *hurt* if she ever came back into it.

Catra is in it now. She is *naked in Adora's arms* now, rolling her hips a little just to torture her. Adora whimpers, unsure if it is in response to the way Catra is taking her apart right now or the fact that her heart is crying out *thank you* in response. Catra is making Adora *hers*, and it makes it impossible to deny how much she wants that to be true. Seven years of careful denial and repression, and all of it is undone by Catra tightening her grip in Adora's hair and holding her in place as she pulls back to smirk down at her.

"Hands on the bed, princess. It isn't your turn yet," she tells her. Adora groans, forcing herself to let go of Catra's hips and fist the sheets on either side of her. Catra purrs, low and satisfied, as she leans even further back. "Good girl. You want a reward?" Catra tells her. Adora, despite the rioting emotions in her chest, nods eagerly, tightening her grip on the sheets as if to prove how good she is being.

She loves Catra. She shouldn't. In this moment though, when it is just her, Catra, and the sheets beneath them, she can't deny it. Every inch of her is screaming out for her best friend, desperate for Catra in a way she never has been for anyone else. As much as she wants to kill the thoughts, she *can't*. The emotion in her chest makes it feel profound as Catra places a light hand on her shoulder, encouraging Adora to lay back before she shifts down and finally pulls down her underwear.

Her guilt wants to resurface. Somehow, it doesn't. Maybe it is the hunger in Catra's eyes, or the light groan she gives as she pulls the ruined underwear away and Adora's scent hits the air. Catra leans down, burying her face in Adora's stomach as her hands grip Adora's thighs, flexing uselessly as she just takes a moment to gather herself. Seeing Catra that undone over

turning Adora on is enough for Adora to think about nothing except how she loves this woman – how she *wants* her.

Perhaps, for an evening, she can indulge in the fantasy that Catra wants this the same way Adora always has. She is going to get to touch Catra soon, and she doesn't think she *could* do that without thinking about how much she loves her.

She loves her. She knows that thought alone isn't dirty or harmful – it is just the part where it gets romantic that threatens to pull them apart. Catra has always enjoyed when Adora showed her love though, even if she thought it was platonic. Adora can love her today, and given what they are doing, it wouldn't really *matter* if it were platonic or romantic. She is going to be touching her regardless.

Today, Adora can just love Catra how she has always wanted.

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Catra was nervous on Friday night, when she thought Adora was going to lay her down in some random hotel room and finally *do* this. She wanted it – she was even *disappointed* when she realized Adora didn't actually want to do anything – but she was still nervous. She has been anxious about the scenario when this finally happened for years and it wasn't going to suddenly vanish.

Except apparently it *is*, because with Adora spread out beneath her, all Catra feels is raw desire. The scent of Adora's arousal is *overwhelming*, driving her a bit mad as she buries her face in Adora's abdomen, wanting to be closer to the scent that is almost mouthwatering. She isn't confident enough to eat Adora out for their first time – there are *some* nerves – nor does she think Adora would want that right now, but she has to just breathe her in for a moment.

When Catra has gathered herself enough to sit up properly and push Adora's legs apart, Adora is twitching with anticipation beneath her. Catra can't make her wait any longer – she can't make *herself* either. She lands one hand on Adora's inner thigh to keep her legs spread and then finally traces her fingers over her, feeling out her folds and parting them. Adora gasps out, twitching her hips into the touch, though she is clearly *trying* to contain herself.

Catra traces her fingers lower and rubs them against Adora's entrance. She earns Adora wiggling her hips, but her desire doesn't spike the same way Catra's does when she does that on herself. She shifts her hand, gently grinding her palm against Adora's clit. Adora's reaction is instant, gasping out and rolling her hips down, seeking more.

When Catra shifts her fingers up to properly rub against her clit, Adora moans, her voice loud and desperate. She isn't holding anything back, jerking her hips roughly down onto Catra's hips and panting out. Remembering how hard Adora liked it on her chest earlier, Catra cautiously ups the roughness of her movements.

The broken way Adora cries out *Cat-ra*, holding out the final syllable in a moan, makes her own hips roll down involuntarily. Catra wants her – she wants to have her, fuck her, make her come *screaming*. She releases Adora's hip with the hand still holding her down, shifting to rub against her entrance again. This time, Adora rolls down onto her fingers eagerly.

"Two fingers okay, princess?" she asks, because the question isn't *if* she is going to fuck her, but how hard. Adora gasps, nodding eagerly as she makes eye contact with Catra. Her gaze is *pleading*, desperate for Catra to follow through. Catra presses in eagerly, unsurprised to find only a moment of resistance before she is sliding into Adora's velvet heat.

She is *soaking*. She takes Catra's fingers eagerly, panting out soft *ah*s on every thrust of her fingers and rough circle of her fingers pressed against her clit. Adora is *ruined,* soaking from her slick and sweat, her entire body flushed and her head thrown back as raw desire pours off of her, the scent intoxicating. Catra watches the tension build in her body. A few times, she thinks Adora is about to come, her body tensing and holding, and then the tension releases as Adora whines and moans, setting back to twitching her hips down into Catra's touch.

"What do you need?" Catra asks her, her own voice a little ragged. She is soaking herself, her own entrance twitching from how badly her body is crying out for Adora, but she is more than willing to wait her turn, especially with this sight spread out before her. Adora moans in response, slitting her eyes open to watch Catra through hooded eyes for a moment as she pants, trying to get a hold of herself.

"So much. So close. I think- just keep going, please?" she asks. If her skin wasn't already flushed, she would be blushing. Catra licks her lips, nodding. She can do that. Watching Adora's eyes screw shut on a rough thrust as she *groans* is far from a chore.

Her body tenses and lets go one more time before it tenses and *holds*, Adora crying out weakly and almost arching off the bed before she goes limp and collapses *panting*, utterly spent. Catra quickly halts her movements as Adora's walls begin rolling down in waves, contractions surrounding her fingers. Catra swallows, her mouth utterly dry as she slowly slides her fingers out.

Absently, she uses the hand that was on Adora's clit to stroke Adora's thigh, trying to soothe her. The other she raises to her lips, groaning softly as she sucks Adora's slick off her fingers. Yeah, she tastes as good as she smells.

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Catra ends up draped over her chest, purring to soothe her as Adora just relaxes into the endorphins, limp in the sheets. She nuzzles her, marking and licking her in equal measure, apparently enjoying the taste of her skin laced with desire.

"You make such beautiful sounds," Catra murmurs to her, maybe her dozenth assurance, but Adora hasn't been counting so much as moaning weakly when she says them. She gathers

enough strength to raise her arms, wrapping them around Catra and pulling her in tighter to her chest. Adora feels fucking *incredible*.

She never thought she would enjoy bottoming like that considering it rarely got her off to think about and she never enjoyed it when other people have wanted her over the years, but it turns out *Catra* wanting her is a different story. She isn't most people and she doesn't behave like them. After fucking her so roughly, Catra spreads out on top of her so Adora can feel her fur along every inch of her skin and purrs, soothing her. She runs her hands over Adora, motion calming and voice soft as she praises her.

Adora doesn't know how long they lay like that. Several minutes, definitely, but she wants to just soak in the feeling of Catra against her. Still, she has something else on her mind, and as good as she feels, she wants to make Catra feel the same. Cautiously, she tightens her arm around Catra's back and lifts her head to press a kiss into her hair.

"Are you okay with me flipping us?" Adora asks, running a hand down her back, petting along the curve of her spine. She wants Catra, but she also doesn't want to push her. Catra rumbles softly, nudging against Adora's throat.

"Yeah. I've been turned on for like an hour, Adora," Catra assures her. Her voice is *rough*, betraying how turned on she is. Her tail is already moving side-to-side in slow, stiff lashes just from anticipation. Adora swallows, nodding and raising her arms to carefully cradle Catra against her chest before she flips them over. She lays Catra out on the bed carefully, opting for lying down beside her.

She thought about this during the weekend. Lying beside Catra will make the angle as similar to what Adora is used to when she touches herself. The more familiarity, the more confidence she has. She was nervous then, though she isn't now, in the moment. Catra is already stretching out, sinking into the sheets and watching her with lazy eyes, her pupils round. She is turned on and relaxed, sending Adora a small, encouraging smile as she reaches for Adora's shoulder and pulls her closer.

"I want you against me," she encourages her. Adora nods, not really *surprised*. She wraps one arm around Catra, just holding her close for a moment before she lets her hand wander over her body. She feels along her arms, sides, even thighs, before she works her hand back up to her chest, massaging it directly like she did on Friday night. Catra clearly liked it then, and she does now, releasing the tiniest moan of content before turning her head and sending Adora wide eyes.

Adora doesn't need any more encouragement to lean in and kiss her. Catra immediately relaxes, sighing softly into the kiss and arching her chest up into Adora's hand. When they part for air, Adora ducks her head down, kissing Catra's collarbone before she works her way lower. She hears – and *feels* – Catra draw in a breath as she presses a kiss to the top of her breast. Adora doesn't really *know* what to do, just what she wants. Catra's hand threading through her hair feels like encouragement, so she continues onto her objective and presses an open-mouthed kiss against Catra's nipple.

Catra arches up into her, her breathing starting to pick up again. It isn't a failure at least. Cautiously, Adora takes Catra's nipple into her mouth, sucking and running her tongue over

the hard nub. Catra *cries out*, shooting a spike of heat through Adora. Okay, scratch not a failure – that is a *definite* success. Adora repeats the motion, earning another cry, this one a bit desperate.

“Other- other side. Too much,” Catra pants out. Adora quickly releases her, pressing a soft kiss against the spot before she shifts to the other side, repeating the motion, though this time she makes a conscious effort to suck more lightly. It seems to work – Catra moans and squirms beneath her, only moaning louder when Adora repeats the motion.

She doesn’t want to overwork her though, and she doesn’t want to drag this out into the sweet torture Catra put her through. It felt amazing, but right now she just wants to make the woman she loves feel good and give her exactly what she wants. Adora nuzzles against her chest, nipping lightly just above her nipple and earning a soft, almost inaudible moan. Adora catches it – she is desperately listening for every one of the noises Catra releases.

“What do you want right now? What makes you feel good?” Adora asks, running her hand down Catra’s side and squeezing her hip a little. Catra blinks down at her for a moment before her expression softens and she purrs gently. She reaches for Adora’s hand, covering it with her own and directing her touch lower. Adora knows what she is doing. She can’t help the warm feeling in her chest as Catra guides her where she wants her and begins touching herself, showing Adora how she likes it.

Adora watches, taking mental notes before she shifts her fingers to touch Catra herself directly. Catra’s breath stutters and her hand falls away to grip the sheets instead.

“I, ah, like it firm. Steady. Not as rough,” Catra explains, flexing her hips down into Adora’s hand. Adora nods, well aware that the way she likes it can cause small spikes of pain. She *likes* that, but Catra wouldn’t. Catra begins to gasp and stutter out purrs as Adora works her with firm circles, like Catra touched her with at first and just used herself. The sounds make Adora’s heart burst, *love* thrumming her veins again.

She was right. She can’t hope to contain it, not when Catra sounds like *this* when Adora has barely gotten the hang of it. It is different from what she likes, but not totally alien to her. She shifts so she can press her body closer and watch Catra’s face, which is already flushing. Catra blinks at her, eyes dilated and lips parted as she pants softly, gentle *ah*s that drive Adora a little wild.

She wants to press harder, faster, driving Catra over the edge and watching her fall apart, but that isn’t going to *work*. Instead, she moves her hand in steady motions and watches Catra slowly unravel beneath her. It is almost better, watching the changes overcoming her body as her tail lashes over the sheets. Her hips start twitching, tension gathering in her body. Her sounds get louder and more desperate until she is screwing her face up and bending forward, nuzzling against Adora a bit desperately. Adora kisses her face, murmuring to her.

“There you go. I’ve got you. Just let go,” Adora assures her, gentle promises between kisses. Catra whimpers, needy and desperate. The sound alone is enough to make Adora groan, tilting their mouths together in a hungry kiss. Catra is *squirming* beneath her now, desperate as she ruts her hips into Adora’s hand.

Catra, splayed out and flushed, her fur beginning to stand on end and moans desperate, is the most beautiful sight Adora has ever seen in her life. She has dreamed about it for years, but she never knew how soft and warm Catra would be beneath her touch, or how mesmerizing sound of her moans is. Adora kisses her, drinking down every sound she makes greedily. At least until Catra is too far gone to kiss back, *whining* as her movements turn jerky.

Catra's breathing is ragged as her body goes stiff for several seconds and then *limp*. She begins purring almost instantly, her tail swaying back in forth. Adora stares down at her, propping up on her elbow to watch. Catra's chest is heaving a little as she tries to bring her breathing back under control, her eyes closed and face slack. She is utterly relaxed, contentment written across every inch of her body as Catra lazily blinks her eyes open. Her pupils are still dilated, but a content smile spreads over her face as she makes eye contact with Adora.

"Kiss me," she requests, tilting her head back a little. Adora is more than happy to fulfill the request.

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Even after both getting off, they end up making out for an hour before Adora's hand sneaks down and she pulls back, a hopeful look in her eye. Catra isn't about to say *no*. The second time is longer, Adora working her up into a desperation before her orgasm finally takes her. She ends up curled up on Adora's chest, purring as Adora pets her and peppers her with kisses.

They can't stay in bed having sex all day. Well, they definitely *could*, but they shouldn't. They have things to do after being away for two days. Adora needs a shower. Her phone has been chiming intermittently and they both know who the texts are from.

"How much longer before she sends a search party, do you think?" Adora asks, her tone teasing as she glances at the buzzing pocket of her discarded pants. Catra rolls her eyes, shoving Adora towards the bathroom.

"Thirty minutes, so go *shower*," Catra orders her. She kind of ruined Adora earlier, and she isn't fit to be seen by other people. Not that they have any plans to leave the apartment, but Hope might want to video chat. Neither of them really knows. Adora has never had a PR situation like this to go over before. Adora rolls her eyes, bending down to kiss Catra's forehead, but then she heads into the bathroom to finally get washed up.

Catra unpacks while Adora showers. She also gets dressed again, pulling on a pair of joggers and then opting to steal Adora's inexplicable Yale t-shirt. It is loose – it is probably loose on Adora, given *how* loose it is Catra and their sizes aren't that far off – and Catra kind of likes the way it slips off her shoulder. When Adora finds her down in the kitchen, she draws to a halt, flushing as her eyes trail down Catra's body.

“I think this would look a lot cuter as a crop top,” Catra tells her, conversationally, grinning a little when Adora huffs and sends her a glare. She knows what Catra is doing, but Catra is also *right*.

“That would cut off the logo. Glimmer would yell at me,” Adora tells her, apparently gathering herself enough to start moving again. She walks over to Catra, slowly backing her up against the counter with her hands on either side of her. Catra raises an eyebrow at her, turning her body to face Adora and ignoring the way her tail is swishing against the cabinets behind her.

“You can’t still be horny,” she challenges, though she is smiling. Adora rolls her eyes, leaning forward to kiss her. The embrace is slow and gentle, the exact kind that makes Catra’s toes curl. She sighs happily, wrapping her arms around Adora’s shoulders and parting her lips to make way for Adora when she nips at her lip, asking for entrance. For several long moments, they embrace – until the microwave beeps, signaling it is done. Adora chuckles when Catra grumbles as she pulls back.

“No, I’m not. It’s just… you. You’re amazing. That was, I mean,” Adora rambles, intelligently, squeezing at Catra’s sides for a moment before releasing her. Catra flushes, grateful for the excuse to turn away and get the leftovers out of the microwave. Unfortunately, it gives Adora a clear view of her tail swaying happily behind her, so it doesn’t do much to hide her reaction.

“Everything you wanted?” Adora asks behind her, tone teasing. Catra *wants* to get flustered, call Adora an idiot, maybe punch her on the shoulder, and shove her away. She can’t. Not for this. It is important enough that all she wants to do is deny it, but she can’t actually *do* that. She reaches up, taking the plate out of the microwave and setting it on the counter. She braces her hands on either side of it, taking in a deep breath.

“… Yes,” she breathes, her back still turned to Adora. Her ears swivel back to listen to the sharp intake of breath Adora gives in response. Catra hunches her shoulders a little, waiting for *something*, but it never comes. She listens as Adora begins to move, coming up behind her and hugging her tightly. Catra’s next breath comes out a little shaky, the tension that was gathering in her body easing.

It really *was*. Adora was cautious and exploratory, wanting to learn the things Catra likes. She didn’t go for anything too intense, despite knowing some of the spots that make her fall apart already. As much as she liked when Adora found her sweet spots, it would have been overwhelming for their first time. Adora took care of her, straight forward but caring. She went *again*, never showing a sign of stopping despite how much longer it took.

She delighted in every noise Catra released, seeming to get off on them herself. Above all, every time Catra asked for something, even silently or subtly, Adora gave it to her until Catra was surrounded by nothing but Adora and her *care*. It was everything Catra could have hoped for. Adora drops a light kiss to her shoulder, squeezing her arms tightly around her.

“Good. I loved being able to take care of you,” Adora promises her, voice completely sincere. Catra purrs, pressing back into the embrace. Adora just shifts a little, bending to kiss the back

of her scruff now. Catra sighs, tilting her chin down and just enjoying the love in Adora's embrace.

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Adora texts Frosta when they're done eating to let her know they are back home and she's on-call again. Frosta responds with the swearing emoji.

"I like her," Catra decides, spying on Adora's phone screen from her position curled up beside her. Adora laughs and then texts Hope to let her know she is free. Hope is in a PR meeting and says she will call her later, which only worries Adora a *reasonable* amount. It isn't necessarily a PR meeting for her, but she can't shake the feeling that it is.

"Can I brush you?" she asks Catra, bending to kiss her head. Catra purrs, butting her head back into the attention. It makes her collide a little painfully with Adora's jaw, but she sucks up the pain. It's Catra's affection, and Adora will always gladly accept that. Besides, Catra is purring, which is a *yes*, and Adora could use the destressing while she waits.

She fetches Catra's mane brush, and Catra ends up splayed out on the couch with her head in Adora's lap while Adora brushes her. At first she kneads at the sofa, but that kneading eventually escalates to purring until Adora is *pretty* sure Catra has fallen asleep completely, her ears twitching a suspicious amount. She is dreaming about *something*, and still purring, so Adora just keeps brushing her until her phone vibrates as she is forced to put down the brush with a sigh.

"Catra's sleeping, so I'll be quiet," Adora says in lieu of greeting when she answers the call. It isn't *quite* a whisper, but it isn't far from it either. On the other end of the line, Hope chuckles.

"The weekend was good, then?" she questions. She didn't immediately tell Adora she has bad news, and that helps her relax. Adora smiles, looking down at Catra slumbering peacefully in her lap, purr rolling along with her gently twitching her ears. Her ears quiver when she is about to come, too. Okay, bad thought. Adora's chest is bursting again, remembering the way Catra trembled beneath her touch. It is making that *word* she isn't supposed to think pound loudly against her ribs again.

"Yeah, fantastic," Adora responds, forcing the thoughts down. The best part of the weekend was after they got home, but that is just for the two of them to know.

"I'm glad. Have you read the articles?" Hope responds, ever the pragmatist. Nothing that wasn't urgent enough for Hope to tell her right away could ruin Adora's mood right now. She lifts her hand and pets gently at Catra's twitching ears, the fur covering them unbelievably soft after two days of pampering.

“I read some on Saturday morning. The one I texted you about being a blatant lie, obviously, but a few others too. They didn’t bother me,” Adora tells her, shrugging despite how Hope can’t see it. She knows Hope probably won’t believe her, but it really feels different when it is *true* rather than lies made up about her for profit. Hope is silent for a moment, probably trying to figure out if this is another one of her brave faces.

“They identified Catra this morning. A student at NYU spotted you helping her move out on Thursday and posted a photo of you. They were just excited you were on their campus, but the tabloids found it and were able to find Catra’s information once they put together she was a student,” Hope tells her. Adora stills, her heart dropping at she stares down at Catra sleeping so *peacefully*.

“What do they know?” she asks, her voice a true whisper now. They always knew Catra was going to be identified, even not really having much in the way of personal social media, but the way Hope phrased that has her nervous.

“‘Catra is a third-year law student at the NYU School of Law in New York City,’” Hope rattles off, clearly reading directly from an article. Adora blows out a breath, relieved. Okay, so just the things they knew would get out and that Catra doesn’t care about. Her LinkedIn information is fine – it’s just her old job that isn’t.

“Okay. So it’s working,” Adora replies, absently beginning to play with Catra’s ears again. She can’t help it – the way she twitches them in her sleep is just so *cute*. On the other end of the line, Hope hums.

“It is gaining a surprising amount of traction. Your old fans started posting about how you’re finally happy with someone. The ones who fell for all the articles and the ones who never believed them before both started streaming your albums again. It won’t make the charts, but it seems to have triggered a nostalgia burst, especially for the second album,” Hope tells her. Adora blinks down at Catra in her lap.

She had expected a few articles – not many, given Catra isn’t known and thus less interesting than Adora supposedly sleeping with Mermista – and maybe some tweets. She didn’t expect people to go back to the album she released just a few weeks before being outed. It is seven years old, well-poised for nostalgia, but she never expected a resurgence of her fandom from this.

“I talked with the team. We came to the conclusion that it’s best if we get ahead of this and release a statement,” Hope says. Adora’s hand spasms, tugging on Catra’s ear in a way that must be uncomfortable if her small hiss is anything to go off of. Adora hates statements, but she wishes she had kept control of herself, because in her lap Catra twitches and then stills.

She is awake. Adora reluctantly shifts her hand to pet Catra’s head once and then goes about the delicate process of sliding out from underneath Catra. Catra, predictably, clutches to her for a moment, but then she seems to wake up enough to remember herself and lets Adora go, blinking at her sleepily as Adora shifts to the end of the couch.

“I’m going up to my office to talk to Hope. You can go back to sleep,” Adora tells her, tucking the phone away from her mouth, though it isn’t far enough that Hope can’t hear it

too. Catra blinks at her, narrowing her eyes. Adora rolls hers, trying to assure Catra it really is fine. “I have to write a statement. It will take awhile is all,” she promises her, reaching out and tousling Catra’s ears.

It seems to convince her. Catra’s expression softens and she stretches up, kissing Adora’s cheek before she drops down onto the couch again. Adora blushes, sending her a small, encouraging smile before she gets up and heads up the stairs.

“I’ve been retired for *five years*. Wouldn’t it be weird if I suddenly put out a press release?” Adora asks as she climbs to the second floor. The door of her office is just off the staircase. She is inside and closing the door before Hope has finished sighing in response. She knows Adora’s aversion to making statements well.

“Perhaps, but not acknowledging it would give more credit to the possibility of your past ‘relationships.’ We could put the statement out as a post on my social media to keep it more casual,” Hope offers. Adora scowls, turning to face her office at large. She hates everything about interacting with the press. As nice as the fans she usually met were – she hated that too.

None of them knew anything about her, despite gushing about how they *grew up together*. Just because they saw her on a screen for five years doesn’t teach them anything about her, but for some reason the strangers all feel like she is their friend. Meanwhile, she can count on her hands the number of people she actually trusts not to throw her under a bus. She doesn’t want to tell the public *anything*.

But Hope is right. The whole point of this was so they can control it somewhat. Also the part where Adora is apparently completely head over heels for her best friend, but she has been denying that for ten years and she can keep doing it. Adora glances around her study.

She doesn’t actually want to sit at her desk – if she does that, she is going to pull up the photos they took of her at NYU. The whole point of this is to give the paparazzi something else to do, but she also hates seeing photos of herself taken without her knowledge. Call it PTSD if you want – she doesn’t want to do it.

She settles in front of her upright piano instead, leaning on the closed case and staring at the half-written sheet of music propped up on it. Adora stares at the faint lines of music written out and then erased before her. Hope is just silent, waiting. They have sat in silence for twenty minutes on the phone before, waiting for Adora to be ready to acknowledge what Hope just told her.

“I’ll write a letter. You can post a photo of it on Instagram, and that will be the only public acknowledgement we give, okay?” Adora finally acquiesces. Hope makes a surprised sound down the line. Adora doesn’t usually write her own press releases. At times she hasn’t even looked at them before they went out, shoving interacting with the public off on Hope. Still, there is sheet music before her, and she kind of knows what *needs* to be said.

“Whatever you’re comfortable with,” Hope agrees. Adora is comfortable with none of this, but the last thing she wants to do is something the public views as confirming the rumours from over the years. She shakes her head to herself as she pulls out a blank sheet of music.

“I’ll text it to you tonight. Put it up immediately. And my decision is final on the wording,” Adora tells her, already picking up the soft mechanical pencil sitting atop her piano.

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Adora deliberates in her office for an hour. Catra tries to give her space – clearly she wants it, seeing as she shuts herself away – but after awhile she can’t fight her worry and she makes her way up the stairs. The office door is still closed. She would guess Adora has been stressing from the scent she can pick up through the door. Cautiously, Catra knocks on the door. On the other side of the door, she hears Adora startle.

“Come in,” Adora calls, her voice tired. Catra opens the door to find her sprawled across the couch she has shoved into a corner of the office. Adora is staring at a piece of paper in her hand, looking vaguely ill. Upon Catra’s entrance, Adora looks up to make eye contact and immediately winces, her gaze falling back down to the paper.

“Bad news?” Catra guesses, edging over to the loveseat so she can perch on its arm. Adora just sighs and holds the paper out to her, sitting up a little so Catra can reach it. She takes it hesitantly, flipping it over and blinking in surprise at Adora’s scrawl across the page of staff lines.

Adora has definitely been stressing. The scent is lingering in the air and written across the scrunch of her brow, but it is also on the *page*. Catra can see the traces of many attempts at writing this statement, false starts and changed words indented in the paper. The statement is brief, as far as these things go. Catra should know – she has probably read every press release Adora’s team has put out and known she wrote very few of them, not even the ones starting with *I*.

“*I have known her longer than you have known me*, huh?” Catra quotes, looking up from the page to meet Adora’s eye. To her surprise, a small smile ghosts across Adora’s face.

“My first album came out nine years ago. We knew each other for fourteen years before I was adopted,” she points out. Catra flushes a little, feeling her ears twitch as she holds out the paper to hand it back. Adora looks at it like it might bite her, but she takes it. “Is it okay? For you, and just in general?” Adora asks. Catra pauses. She has never *put out a statement* before, but she also isn’t even named.

Catra slips off the arm of the couch onto the seat proper. She tucks under Adora’s chin, nuzzling into her as she lets herself go limp, effectively pinning Adora to the couch. Adora doesn’t seem to mind, tightening the arm around her back and tucking her face down to bury it in Catra’s mane for a moment. When she drops her head back against the couch, she sighs. Catra shushes her gently.

“I’m fine with the statement. I think it implies more about why you left music than you said in your press release at the time, but if you’re okay with that, I’m all for telling people to fuck

off," Catra tells Adora, nuzzling in against her neck again. Adora lets out a slow breath before reaching for her phone, fiddling with it for a moment. Catra watches Adora lie the sheet music flat on the cushion and take a careful photo of the sheet of paper from above.

Adora leans against her as she crops the photo to a square and texts it to Hope. After a moment, Catra's ears twitch back to catch the *sent message* notification.

"Hope is going to post a photo of it on her Instagram. We're not saying anything more," Adora promises, tossing her phone onto the couch cushions despite the way it chimes with a new notification. She drops both her hands to Catra's back, petting down it. Adora's phone buzzes again. Adora reluctantly reaches for it, but Catra swats her with her tail and Adora smiles a little to herself as she returns her hands to Catra's back and resumes petting, ignoring her phone.

After a few moments, Adora relaxes beneath her again.

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Adora wakes up the next morning just feeling *warm*. It is a Monday and she has work, but she has plenty of time to cuddle with Catra first. She opens her eyes to a sleepy - but awake – Catra, licking at her neck to affectionately groom her in her half-awake state. Adora's chest feels like it might be bursting all over again. It seems like after the word *love* has broken through her ribs, there is no putting it back.

"Good morning," she tells Catra, wrapping one arm around her back and bringing the other up to cup her cheek. Catra smiles, soft and sleepy as she tilts her chin up to follow Adora's direction. Catra may still be waking up, but when she kisses Adora, it is open-mouthed, lazy and *sweet*. Her tail sways behind her, sweeping over their tangled legs.

Adora is feeling so much, love bursting out from her heart that she still isn't prepared to deal with. She wraps her arms around Catra's back, just needing to *have* her in her arms. The world knows now, and it is a bit more terrifying given her realization last night. She wants to wrap Catra up and never let her go. She doesn't want to *lose* her again.

The world can know – or *think* they know – about them. The world doesn't get this. The world has no place in this bed. Adora kisses Catra with passion, all the fiery emotions in her chest pouring out into her embrace. Catra sighs with contentment in response, shifting a little in her arms.

Cautiously, Adora starts tipping them over. Catra rumbles softly, approval and amusement, and Adora smiles a bit into the kiss as she rolls them over so Catra is spread out in the sheets beneath her. As soon as Adora shifts to brace herself above Catra, Catra sets to wriggling herself down into the mattress, getting comfortable.

Adora pulls back, just *watching* as Catra does her little contented wiggle and settles into the bed, still purring quietly. She is downright adorable, smiling happily up at Adora and tilting her head back a little, inviting her to kiss her. Adora takes the invitation happily, leaning down and burying one hand in Catra's mane as she kisses her again.

Catra is a bit more awake. She sighs softly into the kiss and nips at Adora's lip, licking into her mouth when Adora parts her lips to gasp. Her tail is still swishing back and forth against the sheet as she squirms a little, pressing up into the kiss. She can't keep still, apparently, nuzzling against Adora's cheek when she pulls back for air.

Catra rubs her cheek against Adora's, marking her as her hands begin to knead absently at the sheets. She wriggles again, but this time Adora realizes that she is *specifically* shifting her hips. Okay, so it took her a little bit to realize, but Catra is definitely turned on. She nips almost absently at the edge of Adora's jaw, teeth lightly scraping, before she shifts up to breathe into her ear.

"Fuck me?" she asks, voice soft and *hopeful*. One day, Catra is going to phrase it with a bit more romance and Adora is going to lose her shit, but she smiles as it is, disentangling her hand from Catra's hair to shift it up to her ear, tugging slowly at the tip to steadily build the pressure. Catra whimpers, immediately curling into her and burying her nose against her pulse point as her tail lashes on the mattress beneath her.

Adora blows out a slow breath, feeling the fire spark within her. She eases up, releasing the pressure and earning *another* whimper, this time disappointed. In response, she tugs again, faster this time but still careful not to be too rough. Catra moans softly, nipping at her neck and then *hanging on*, apparently too overwhelmed to let go. She tilts her head a little, raising her ear in a clear *again*. Adora tugs on it happily, watching Catra writhe just a little beneath her before she eases off on it again.

"I've been wanting to do this for weeks," Adora admits, her voice low to not disrupt the sleepy aura in the room. She *has*, Catra's ears on her mind ever since she tugged on them and realized it was a thing for Catra. Catra chuffs a little, rumbling with amusement as Adora releases her ear and strokes the back of it gently instead. She lets go of her neck, pressing a soft kiss against the indents her sharp teeth left on Adora's neck. Adora hums a little to herself, content but also wanting *more*.

"Turn over?" she requests, pressing a kiss against the base of the ear she was tugging. Catra's ear twitches and Adora pulls back to find Catra blinking up at her, clearly confused, though her pupils are blown out as her ears twitch with curiosity.

"Why?" she asks. She doesn't sound opposed, just confused. Her voice is a bit rough from the attention to her ears. Adora grins to herself, bending down to kiss her. She can't help it. Catra is so *cute* when she is comfortable and relaxed. Adora has dreamed about waking her up and kissing her so many times, and now she can *do* it. She is still smiling when she pulls back to see Catra looking decidedly less confused - not that the kiss answered her question, she just doesn't seem to care so much anymore.

"Your tail," Adora elaborates, watching Catra's eyes go a bit wide as she quickly flushes. Catra releases a soft trill, which only seems to embarrass her more, but she nods. Adora shifts

back, giving Catra the room to flip over and then wiggle down into the mattress to get comfortable again. As she settles, Adora runs one hand down her back. She pushes up Catra's sleep shirt when she reaches its hem, just stroking down her back for a long moment before she shifts her hand down to where Catra's tail is peeking out over the waistband of her shorts.

"What does it feel like?" she asks softly as she pets along Catra's tail once. Catra chuffs a little, burying her face in the pillow. Adora chuckles – it's *cute*, alright – and then rubs her fingers down against the base of Catra's tail the same way she has touched her last night. Catra's fur puffs up as she arches her back into the touch, *mewling* into the pillow.

Adora eases up, watching in awe as Catra drops her hips back down against the mattress, turning her face out from the pillow – and away from Adora – to pant a little. Her cheeks are flushed and eyes closed. Apparently *intense* is the answer. Adora rubs again, a slow and steady loop against the spot. Catra whines, shifting her hips back into it again as she clutches at the pillow with her claws. Adora repeats the motion, her mouth dry as she watches Catra relax into the sheets again.

"Like you're *touching* me, Adora," Catra pants out, her voice rough. Yeah, that tracks with her reactions to Adora touching her clit yesterday. Suddenly, all Adora cares about is seeing if Catra can come from this. She shifts down, pressing a kiss into Catra's scuff and earning a soft sound of approval from her partner.

"Let me know if it's too much or you need a break, okay?" Adora asks her, stroking her fingers over Catra's tail again. Catra nods a bit eagerly into the sheets. Adora grins to herself, setting to rub against the base of her tail again, keeping the motion constant. Catra immediately whimpers softly, squirming beneath the touch, but Adora isn't *done*.

She nuzzles against Catra's scruff for a moment, pressing a soft kiss there, before she parts her lips and nips at the back of her neck. She doesn't bother trying to be gentle – she knows Catra can take it, at least in this location. Catra gasps and *mewls* again, a beautiful sound that makes Adora groan, pressing more roughly with her fingers. That seems to be okay on this part of her body. It's an erotic spot for Catra, but it isn't generally sensitive, and she just arches up into Adora's hand.

Adora's chest feels tight, heat pulsing between her legs but her heart *full* as she watches Catra writhe beneath her fingers and the occasional nips or kisses to her scruff. Catra whimpers, whines, moans, *mewls* even, panting and desperate as Adora works her up. When her breathing gets too heavy, Adora shifts to stroking firmly against the base of her tail to ease off until Catra makes a soft, needy sound and arches into her hand again.

Adora has work to go to. She isn't going to have time for a shower, but getting *fired* would be worth getting to watch Catra writhe beneath her like this as her sounds turn ragged and broken. Despite all the writhing and moaning, all of Catra's movements are relaxed, the morning allowing for slow-building, lazy sex as Adora works her up.

She wants to ease off again, but she also *doesn't*. Catra seems so close and she just has to keep going. She needs to watch, desire pulsing through her entire body, as Catra begins to give broken gasps, escalating as her tail goes stiff and her back arches. Catra collapses against the bed whimpering softly as Adora shifts to just petting along her lower back and

tail, pressing kisses against her scruff. Catra is panting, a rumble kicking up in her chest as she shivers a little into the sheets.

“You’re so gorgeous, kitten,” Adora murmurs to her, nothing on her mind but how *hot* that was. Catra trills, surprised, as Adora’s words catch up with her. Adora flushes, realizing not only what she said but that Catra *probably* doesn’t want to be called her childhood nickname in bed.

Adora doesn’t know when it became a possessive thing for her, but it was probably the instant people stopped referring to Catra as *hers*. The first three years of their lives, they were an unbreakable unit. Catra was called *Adora’s kitty* more often than she was called her name. Looking back on it, it was the first thing to strip Catra’s agency from her, but that wasn’t what it felt like when they were small kids.

Their facility then was too full and overwhelmed, but everyone cared and was kind. Once they got sent to Shadow’s, Catra *couldn’t* be her kitten anymore. Adora used to whisper it to her when they were curled up in bed together, alone at night, as a way to assure her when Shadow was trying to break them apart. Over the years, how Adora felt about it changed until it started to feature in her fantasies. Catra turns over beneath her. Adora draws in a breath, blinking down at Catra’s flustered expression.

“I haven’t heard that one in years,” Catra says, her voice soft. She is going for *conversational*, but her voice is a bit too small for that and her tail is sweeping nervously on the bed. Adora sends her a sheepish smile, a bit relieved when Catra returns it. Okay, so Catra isn’t *turned off* by it, at least. Cautiously, Adora leans down and presses a kiss against her forehead.

“I thought about the good times a lot when we were apart,” she offers. The unspoken *back when you were my kitten* hangs in the air between them as Catra blinks up at her. After a moment, Catra blows out a shaky breath and smiles softly at her, reaching a hand up to cup her cheek.

“Me too,” she offers, quietly. Her heart is beating heavily, Adora can feel it where they are in contact. Relief is flooding through her body. She nuzzles into Catra’s hand happily, pressing a kiss against her palm. Catra begins to purr again, the sound having stuttered out at Adora slip-up.

“I- um- do you-” Adora manages to mumble out before Catra rolls her eyes and she cuts herself off, sending Catra her best puppy look.

“If you can be my princess, then I can be your kitten. As long as you don’t do it in public or get all possessive, I like it,” Catra promises her. Adora’s heart beats loudly as she nods, offering a smile to Catra. Catra smiles back, leaning up and nudging along Adora’s jaw for a moment before she relaxes back into the sheets.

“Besides, it will probably make that Buzzfeed article about our *disgustingly sappy love* if it gets overheard,” Catra adds on, her tone teasing.

Adora’s heart *falls*. Right. For a moment, she almost forgot.

Chapter End Notes

Karma’s a bitch, isn’t it, Adora?
Adora's full statement can be found on my tumblr.
Next chapter: Catra makes a life decision, and gets fucked. By life, or Adora? Who knows (I do).

Winterfest

Chapter Notes

> I've updated the chapter count now that I'm done with my first pass at the final chapter (the 10th). I always planned for this fic to be 10 chapters but was worried I wouldn't be able to fit it all in that, but it's turning out to work perfectly.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora only avoids being late on Monday morning due to Frosta's lack of fear – of speeding, of the law, of *death*. She arrives at work rattled but alive and walks into the building the minute she is supposed to be at her desk. It isn't *technically* on time, but it is close enough. She has to walk past Glimmer's desk to get to her office, and Glimmer sends her a look that forewarns her how bad lunch is going to be.

It ends up worse than expected. Glimmer and Bow both ambush her in her office the moment that lunch starts, giving the three of them privacy as long as they keep their voices down. That privacy gives them free reign to discuss anything, even the arrangement. Adora shrinks down in her chair when Glimmer and Bow march in, carrying three lunches between them so Adora can't *escape*.

"This is entrapment," Adora complains as Bow places a hot container of pho in front of her and Glimmer pulls up her two meeting chairs so they can stare her down.

"Ask Catra. It's really not," Glimmer responds, rolling her eyes and then placing her elbow on Adora's desk so she can lean on her hand while she stares her down. A slow grin spreads up Glimmer's face, predatory and alight with only slightly-malicious glee. "So, *hoe*," Glimmer addresses her. Adora promptly chokes on the pho she was *just* starting to eat as an excuse to be quiet.

After a minute of hacking and coughing while Glimmer cackles and Bow reaches over to pat her sympathetically on the back, Adora looks up to glare at Glimmer through watering eyes. Glimmer has calmed down to mere snickering, but she in no way looks apologetic. Adora huffs, slumping down in her seat a little.

"Like Mermista and Sea Hawk are any better," she returns. A vivid memory from last Halloween swims before her eyes and Adora cringes. "Like *you and Bow* are any better," she tacks on. Okay, normally they *are*, but sometimes they can be just as bad. Glimmer and Bow both send her flat looks. Adora hunches her shoulders, tucking her pho in against her chest and *sulking*.

"Mermista and Sea Hawk don't deny that they're dating. Or that they love each other," Glimmer responds. Adora outright gapes at her. Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Fine, *Sea Hawk*

doesn't, and no one is fooled when Mermista does it either," Glimmer adds. Adora, a bit desperate, looks to Bow. Bow has sympathy for her, but he just shakes his head to indicate that no, he's not buying it either.

The problem is, after Sunday, Adora *gets* it. She still can't do anything about it. Adora sighs dejectedly, taking another bite of her food just to stall. There is no waiting Glimmer out, but Adora can at least gather her thoughts.

"Listen, what I feel doesn't matter. She's my best friend, but this is just a job for her. So no, I'm not acknowledging it," Adora says, already admitting far too much. She immediately shoves food in her mouth so she doesn't have to deal with the way Glimmer is gaping at her and Bow looks a bit distraught.

"Adora, she was asking questions about what happened while she was gone all weekend. She was all over you. None of us saw her ever leave your side," Bow points out. Adora flushes. Bow is correct – technically – but he doesn't *get it*.

"Because I pay her to be with me and she's my friend? I asked her a lot of questions about those ten years too, she just doesn't like to address things directly, so she asked *you* instead of me. She's just like that," Adora returns, rolling her eyes. Glimmer doesn't buy it for a second, despite it being *true*.

"And the part where she starts getting handsy in front of your friends? Did you put exhibitionism into the arrangement?" Glimmer asks. Adora flushes scarlet, sinking down in her chair and hoping she will go through the *floor* too.

"That was just Catra being Catra," Adora squeaks out, way too flustered for a more complicated sentence. She was really hoping Glimmer would bring that up exactly *never* and they could all keep pretending that Adora was their innocent friend when, really, there isn't an *innocent friend* in their entire group. The closest they ever had was Bow, and he has been dating Glimmer for five years, so that ship has pretty much sailed.

Glimmer stares at her, expression intense and unwavering. Adora looks to Bow. Bow doesn't have sympathy left for her anymore. He is trying to appear supportive, but he looks incredulous and a bit exasperated.

"Adora, haven't you two already lost enough time?" he tries. Adora feels her heart thud in her chest, the sound rushing into her ears. Fuck. She is exhausted suddenly. She slumps in her chair, blinking down at her food. They have. They have lost so much time. Still, if she told Catra and lost her again, Adora thinks she would lose herself too.

She wasn't miserable before Catra came back in her life – well, not since she got out of music at least – but she didn't feel anything like what she does now *with* her. Having Catra love her back would be amazing – but she can make do just loving Catra and having her in her life. Besides, Catra needs the arrangement, and Adora doesn't know how she would feel about it after she knew. She doesn't want to pressure her.

"Adora?" Bow prompts from the other side of the desk. Adora looks up, blinking at him. Bow offers her a small smile, though both he and Glimmer have that *face* on that they get

whenever – well, whenever Adora gets like this. “I’m sorry, I thought that would help, not bring up bad memories. Do you need space?” he asks. Adora draws in a breath and nods gratefully.

Glimmer and Bow pack up their thus-far untouched lunches, offering Adora apologetic smiles as they go. It isn’t really *bad memories* paralyzing Adora right now, but she can’t say how much she feels or how it would *break* her to lose that. She already has Catra in every way that matters. She can be happy just loving Catra. It is so much more than she had before.

Catra just doesn’t necessarily love her back. That’s *fine*. If she is here, in Adora’s arms, anything could be okay.

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Technically, Catra is on break.

Law school also doesn’t have breaks, not if you’re doing it right. She sets aside time each day, mostly in the morning and afternoon, to work on studying for the bar and taking practice tests. It wasn’t until near the end of spring this year that she started to shift her focus towards civil disputes, so she feels like she has a lot of catchup after spending two entire years laser-focused on an area of law she likely won’t end up practicing in.

At least, that has been her attitude for the last few months. Catra is just beginning to figure out her system for studying now she is at Adora’s, but on Monday Adora comes home from work seemingly rundown. Catra quickly abandons her plans and they end up cuddling in the bed together, Catra’s shirt collar pulled down so Adora can bury her face directly in her fur.

“Catra?” Adora prompts, causing Catra to blink down at her. She has only said a few words since she got home. She used to get quiet in the same way when they were kids. It was one of the things Shadow liked about her – if she punished Adora, she would shut down and internalize it. Catra would fight *back*. “Have you thought about what we talked about when Hope visited?” she asks, a mumble muffled against Catra’s chest.

Catra’s heart beats as she nods her head a little. Not that Adora can see it when she is lying face down, but Catra’s chin is tucked into her hair and she can feel it. It is kind of all she has been thinking about *all day*. She didn’t have room to think about law school over the weekend, but now she – kind of – has all the time in the day and she can’t stop thinking about it. She went into law knowing exactly how she wanted to change the world, and she focused all her energy on that from the moment her second year started and she had the freedom to specialize.

Nothing changed her mind, really, but in the spring semester of her second year, she managed to secure a clerkship for over the summer. It was talking to the judge that she was going to be working for that planted the seeds of doubt. He talked about how most lawyers don’t make the money people think they do. He warned her against burn out, and how he sees many

promising starts go to waste. He was trying to help her *avoid* that, but instead he just instilled fear in her.

It wasn't until this past semester, her second year and clerkship completed, that she started to shift focuses officially. Sure, it would probably lead to a better future for her, and it would pay better, but the passion she once had is *gone*. Catra bites her lip, staring down at the top of Adora's head.

"I'm still thinking about it," she returns. She is, but she knows how to make the decision, even if it is going to *suck* to call on who she needs to go to for advice. Still, she has lost her passion for law, and she knows someone who is overflowing with it. Lonnie might not be a good person to go to for advice on any other topic, but getting into law for depressing reasons and maintaining a fiery passion for it? Lonnie knows her stuff. Whether or not it will help Catra still remains to be seen.

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Bow and Glimmer don't ask her about Catra again on Tuesday. Adora tenses up a few times when she thinks they are *going* to, but they leave it alone. Probably *because* of the tensing, but Adora will take it. She just had an epiphany on Sunday and she really isn't ready to confront it, especially not with the future already uncertain while Catra makes her decision. She knows she has Catra for the next two years, but she kind of wants her *forever*.

She wakes up every morning cuddling Catra while her chest overflows with emotion. Knowing how long she has left with Catra would help calm her rioting heart. At the same time, she knows it is a big decision, and she isn't trying to rush Catra into deciding what she wants from life or if she wants to keep the arrangement up beyond law school.

Still, Adora isn't above bribes. Catra blinks at her in shock when she comes home after work with a bouquet of flowers. Adora offers her a small smile, a bit sheepish as she holds them out. Before, she felt comfortable doing shit like this under the veneer of the arrangement. Now, it feels a little too real, but after a moment of blinking, Catra blushes furiously and takes the roses from her.

Catra is flustered, her tail lashing as her ears twitch. Her pupils are dilated as she pretends to eye the flowers and then sniffs at them. She immediately begins *purring*. All of Adora's uncertainty melts away as she breaks out into a grin, bouncing on her toes just a little. Suddenly, all the emotions falling out between the gaps in her ribs don't matter, not when she can do shit like this and Catra *likes* it.

"I noticed you seemed to like the rose in my office, so…" Adora trails off, shrugging as Catra blinks up at her with her eyes round. In truth, that rose on her desk gets changed out by Frosta every two weeks before it can die, but there is always *a* rose in her office. The corner of Catra's mouth quirks up, even as her tail continues to sway and her gentle rumbling fills the room.

“You know, if you wanted to fuck again, you could have just *asked*,” she jokes, even as she reaches up to stroke the flower petals. Adora flushes, but she huffs and rolls her eyes. She isn’t trying to hit on Catra and they both know it.

“I *assume* that will just happen naturally now. You seemed to like the last ones I got you is all,” she returns, because that is the only *real* reason. Catra liked it, and she likes it when Catra is happy – and flustered. Catra’s blush returns full force. She ducks her head, and for a moment Adora thinks she is going to bury her face in the roses, but instead she just does her best to hide behind them.

“What were those, by the way? I didn’t recognize them,” Catra asks, her tail still lashing. She is trying to change the direction of the conversation. Adora smiles a bit to herself, taking a step closer so she can sneak a hand around Catra’s back. Catra *squeaks*, a sound that Adora could shoot straight into her veins for a serotonin boost, but she allows Adora to pull her closer – as close as they can get with the flowers between them anyway.

“No idea. I just thought they were nice and would look pretty to you. That’s why I got white roses instead of red,” Adora informs her, leaning forward to press a kiss to the base of Catra’s ear. Catra scoffs a little, but she is still smiling. In fact, her smirk is turning a little sly.

“You do know what white roses mean, don’t you?” Catra asks, in a tone of voice that *probably* shouldn’t turn Adora on, but it’s the anticipation as Catra waits for Adora to confirm that she does not, in fact, have any clue what white roses mean. Adora narrows her eyes at Catra, watching her grin grow wider and a touch more feral.

“They’re roses,” Adora returns, because she knows you give roses to your partner and that is the end of her flower knowledge. Now Catra mentions it, she does kind of picture red or pink roses, but they’re just flowers. Catra’s tail smacks once against her thigh as it lashes to the side in anticipation. Catra just raises a brow at her for a moment, still grinning.

“*Innocence and purity*, you moron,” Catra informs her. Adora flushes red. *Oh*. That’s why Catra was talking about sex.

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Catra texted Lonnie on Tuesday asking if they could meet up to talk about school. Lonnie responded, but then Adora distracted the hell out of her with her little roses stunt. It led to them making out on the terrace until Catra got too cold, so she isn’t *complaining*, but it did mean that she forgot to reply to Lonnie.

Lonnie offered to meet on Wednesday, but seeing as Catra had *priorities*, she responds too late and they end up deciding to meet Thursday once Catra picks the conversation back up. Campus is closed for the most part, but Lonnie spends her breaks secretly living with her boyfriends and hoping their landlord doesn’t notice, so they arrange to meet up there.

Catra asks if Frosta can drive her, mostly because it seems like the only casual way to bring up the meeting. Adora immediately agrees to lend her Frosta while she is at work, seeming to perk up when Catra explains *why*. Apparently she is just happy that Catra is thinking about her offer, which is far too much for Catra to unpack over breakfast.

"Mi casa, etc," Lonnie greets her when she arrives just after lunch, stepping aside and gesturing inside the shitty apartment. It looks far dingier than Catra remembers it, but she knows it is exactly the same. The few times she was here before, it was over a summer or winter break, when the hotel she was staying at got raided, or had a murder happen, or one time even caught *fire*.

Catra has tried to never impose, and truthfully she hated staying here the few nights she had to do it, but Lonnie never questioned it when Catra called her, a bit desperate and at the absolute end of her rope. It was either make the call or sleep in the subway with her things each time. She always came from far worse conditions when she was coming here before – now she has spent the last week living in the lap of luxury, and the apartment is suffering by comparison.

Kyle is nowhere to be seen, which is for the best, but Rogelio is curled up in a giant ball in front of the apartment radiator. He isn't asleep – he has one eye slit open – but he doesn't stir under his blanket as Lonnie leads Catra to the couch.

"Hey, big guy. Hope the winter isn't being too harsh on you," Catra greets, waving at him before settling on the sofa facing away. She doesn't want him to think he has to respond. Lizardfolk aren't *coldblooded* or anything, but the cold isn't good for them. Rogelio usually spends the winter – essentially – sick. They just can't afford to crank the heat like he needs, even if all heaters are required by law to be able to handle it.

"It's been on the mild side so far, but a cold front is moving in tonight and Ro thinks it's gonna stay. What the hell did you want to talk about in the month we pretend we don't know each other?" Lonnie responds, shrugging before she eyes Catra. Catra's tail thuds against the side of the couch, but she ignores it. She huffs a little, thinking about how she wants to phrase this.

"You know how I got all disillusioned this year and switched focuses?" Catra asks. Lonnie actually looks surprised, but she nods. They might not really be friends, but they do share a single room, and they commiserate on the difficulties of law school a lot, as well as studying together and trading advice. Lonnie *looked* very judging as Catra was going through her shift, though she never challenged Catra to her face.

"I'm trying to find that passion again. That drive to do what I believe in even if the outlook is uncertain and depressing," Catra explains, gesturing vaguely with her hand. Lonnie just raises an eyebrow at her.

"When did you *lose* it? You always cared, you wanted to fix the system the same as me, you just let that judge drag you down with his pessimistic 'practicality'," Lonnie returns. Catra scowls a bit, but unfortunately, Lonnie is right – she never cared any less, other things just got in the way until it felt like too much to keep going after a life of battling her way up hill. For a moment – okay, for a few months – she grew too tired to keep fighting.

Lonnie doesn't have a better reason than her to care. She got into this whole thing to sue the shit out of her boyfriend's parents for being pieces of shit to Kyle all his life. The kid is a thin, fragile twink, but who knows what he could have been if he had actually gotten proper nourishment. Catra should be able to summon just as much fire to get justice for herself as Lonnie does to get it for her boyfriend.

She *does*, but other things got in the way. Money, discouragement, and exhaustion mostly. If she is truly honest with herself, it probably all comes back to escort work. It drained her in her free time, taking a toll on her on top of her schoolwork. She wanted to be *free* of it, so she was determined to have a career that provided for her. She was afraid of not making enough and being forced back into it.

The arrangement with Adora doesn't tire her. It feels *amazing* and makes her feel happy, safe, and energized in a way she hasn't been in years. Not having to worry about escort work is a weight off her shoulders. She has the energy back to fight, even if it makes her personal ability to support herself alone in the future more questionable.

"It was just- money, I guess. I couldn't take wondering about my next meal for the rest of my life," Catra says, to summarize her realization. She watches Lonnie glance to the side, making eye contact with her boyfriend before looking back to Catra.

"Well, as long as your sugar mommy is as into charity work as she seems to be, you're probably fine on that front," Lonnie says, completely *casually* as Catra's fur bristles and she outright snarls at the woman in front of her. Lonnie looks surprised as Catra fights to control the flexing of her claws.

"She's not my fucking sugar mommy. I'm not a goddamn *charity case*," Catra hisses at her, baring her fangs and resisting the urge to ball her hands into fists. She would stab herself with her claws that she can't seem to contract, but she is seething. This is what she gets for going to Lonnie for help. She didn't even do it once, but *multiple* times, and now she is being treated like this.

"Shit, calm down. I just meant she could cover the expenses while you do the noble work," Lonnie tells her, raising her hands and making a *calm down* gesture. Some part of Catra's pride is soothed, but *barely*. Still, she forces herself to retract her claws. Her fur stops bristling, even if it isn't lying flat.

"It isn't *like that*. We're dating," she returns through gritted teeth, even though it is *exactly* like that. She can't have Lonnie knowing she is right about that. Lonnie eyes her, looking dubious but cautious.

"She buys you shit constantly and you don't have a job to pay for your tuition. It's your business, but I never bought that 'partying' bullshit. I knew you were too settled down for it," Lonnie tells her in response. If Catra wasn't already grinding her teeth, she might have bit through her tongue clenching her jaw.

"You don't know her. *Us*. She fucking cares about me," Catra promises her, standing quickly. She never thought when someone finally accused her of something it would be like *this*. Her tail is lashing behind her. Lonnie eyes her from the couch, glancing between Catra and her

boyfriend, who is still balled up in front of the heater, but starting to unfurl a little like he is preparing to intervene. Yeah right, as if Catra is sticking around long enough for a fight to happen.

“Catra, it was supposed to be a *joke*. I wasn’t trying to say she doesn’t c-“ Lonnie starts. It wasn’t a joke, not after the first mention of it at least. Catra can’t take hearing Lonnie say *she doesn’t care*. She can’t take Lonnie being *right*.

“Thanks for the help. See you next year,” she grinds out, stalking to the apartment’s front door. Lonnie doesn’t try to stop her to explain herself again.

--

Adora gets a text from Frosta in the middle of work.

Your cat’s in a pissy mood

Explain?

I picked her up and she was snarly. I just dropped her off at the penthouse again

Adora frowns down at her phone screen. Catra hasn’t texted her all day, but she hasn’t really texted Adora during work for the entire week since she moved in. They see each other plenty when Adora gets off work, but if she is upset, Adora would have expected Catra to reach out. She sends Frosta a thumbs up emoji and then shifts over to her texts with Catra. The last one is from Tuesday, when Adora sent her a warning that she would be a little late getting home. She was picking up the flowers, but she didn’t say that. It was a surprise.

You okay?

Did the gremlin tell on me or something?

I’m fine

She said you were upset

Lonnie’s an asshole. Nothing new

Adora frowns down at her phone. It actually *is* new, at least to her. Catra has said her roommate is an asshole before, but she said it like it was a personality trait and not something that actually bothered her. She has told some fond stories of them goofing off while studying together, at least. Adora didn’t know that they *fought*.

I’m doing some shit for the new semester rn

We can talk when you get home

It is a clear *I need space*, but Adora doesn't like it. She texts Frosta that they're going to stop at the magicat bakery on their way home and does her best to return to her work. Her focus is kind of shot now though. All she can think about is getting back home to Catra. She tries to interrogate Frosta when she comes to pick her up in the evening, but the problem is she doesn't *know*. She just picked up a visibly upset Catra shortly after dropping her off. Adora has to stew the whole way home, the warm box of cookies in her lap.

"You deserve a treat after a rough day," Adora tells Catra when she blinks down at the box in Adora's hands upon her arrival at the penthouse. She expects Catra to soften like she did when she brought her flowers, but instead Catra just stares for a long moment before reaching out and taking the box from Adora, turning to set it on the coffee table. Then she turns back around and *throws* herself at her.

Adora squeaks a little, surprised, but she wraps her arms around Catra as Catra does her level best to climb into her arms while Adora is still standing. Catra nuzzles under her chin, her chest beginning to roll unsteadily as Adora clutches her close.

"Couch?" Adora prompts, because she really can't hold Catra up for that long. Catra nuzzles against her neck, which she takes as a *yes*, so she staggers over to the sofa and sits down heavily. Catra quickly makes herself at home in her lap, wrapping her arms and legs around her torso and burying her face in her shoulder. She purrs softly, but the embrace feels a bit desperate.

"I'm right here. I've got you. I'm not going anywhere," Adora assures her, holding Catra tightly with one arm while she pets her mane with the other, hoping to soothe her. She doesn't know what has upset Catra – truthfully, she can't even tell if this is positive clinging or a cry for assurance – but considering she was going to Lonnie to discuss an uncertain future and whether they would be keeping this whole thing up long-term, she suspects it is the latter.

Catra purrs softly, shifting her cheek to mark the side of Adora's neck. Adora relaxes, mostly because Catra seems a bit more at ease in her arms now. After a moment of marking, Catra shifts up, kissing her softly. Adora kisses back, trying to keep the embrace just as gentle as Catra started it. When they part, Catra gives a soft sigh and quickly ducks down into her neck to hide her face again.

"I know. It's just been a stressful day and I'm still not used to someone… caring," Catra tells her, voice quiet. Adora's heart *breaks* a little as she shifts to hug Catra close with both arms. She wants to say *I care*. Even more than that, she wants to say *I love you*, to prove to Catra that someone holds deep affection for her. She can't. She can't say I love you without potentially destabilizing their whole arrangement, and what Catra needs right now is *support*.

"What happened?" she asks softly, still cradling Catra close. Catra sighs in her arms, her purr dying out. Adora's heart stutters as worry floods through her.

"I talked to Lonnie, and I think I've made a decision, she just… She made a '*joke'* about you being my sugar mommy and it was too close to the truth," Catra admits, quietly. Adora's throat flexes. Yeah, that is the problem – it is true. Catra is her best friend, and her sugar

baby, and as much as she wishes otherwise, *not really her girlfriend*. Adora shifts her arms to return to petting down Catra's mane.

"I want to take care of you, but I'm your friend first, Catra," Adora assures her, bending to press a kiss against the base of her ear despite how that is decidedly *unfriend-like*. Catra still purrs in response, nuzzling a little into her. After a moment, Catra sighs and pulls back. Not far, she is still holding onto Adora and in her lap, but far enough for them to look at each other. She looks a little nervous. Adora watches her take a deep breath, steeling herself.

"I was looking at switching a few of my classes this afternoon. Lonnie *did* remind me that it really was just money and stress getting in the way. I don't have those issues now with you. In the end I will have only diverted for one semester. I'll get my J.D., my M.D., I'll take the bar, and then…" Catra trails off, biting her lip and sending Adora a hopeful look.

Adora's heart is *soaring*. Catra is planning on staying. Catra is going to do what she really wants, and she is going to stay in the penthouse. Adora is going to get to come home to her every day and wake up with her. Before she can stop herself, she reaches up and cups Catra's face on either side, pulling her down into a hungry kiss. Catra squeaks, but after a second she kisses back, rumbling a little as she does so.

Adora runs her hands along Catra, just a touch possessive, but she is so overwhelmed by the fact that Catra is *staying* that she doesn't care. When they part, they are both panting.

"And then it's us. Like we always wanted," Adora promises her. Catra blinks at her for a moment before her entire expression softens and she leans forward, kissing Adora again.

--

Catra wakes up on Friday evening to Adora crawling into the guest bed with her and peppering her with soft kisses. Catra didn't *mean* to nap up here, she was just kind of wandering around and there was a sunbeam. She isn't used to feeling so relaxed and comfortable over break. Normally she spends the month hyper alert of her surroundings, worried if she is going to get enough clients to pay for her hotel, *dealing with those clients*, and trying to study or search for a clerkship where she can.

She feels absolutely *spoiled*, especially with the relief of finally feeling like she is back on track with her career. She doesn't feel as rushed to study, either, knowing she is going to continue focusing on her true passion and that Adora will be helping her out until she has passed the bar and *beyond*.

Catra fell on asleep on top of the covers, and she wriggles a bit beneath Adora as she sets to kissing along Catra's body and burying her face in her fluff. Catra can't help but snicker a little as Adora pushes up her shirt and blows air on to her stomach, ruffling her fur. Adora seems to be in a good mood, giggling as she rubs her face against Catra.

“Mm, soft kitty,” Adora hums, seemingly to herself. Catra’s heart risks bursting. She hasn’t heard those words in probably fifteen years since Shadow beat them out of Adora. She stretches out, purposefully slow to give Adora as much room to touch her as possible. Adora happily runs her hands along her sides, Catra’s shirt ending up bunched up over her chest as Adora pets her.

“Have a good day at work, princess?” Catra asks, her tone a little teasing as she reaches down and threads her hands through Adora’s hair. Adora just hums an affirmation, seeming unwilling to either talk and get a mouthful of fur or to pull back so she actually can talk properly. Catra just squeezes her hands in Adora’s hair in silent acceptance of Adora’s affirmation.

For a while they just lay like that, Adora’s hands roaming over her as they cuddle together. The sunbeam has moved on, but Catra still likes this room, so she isn’t too fussed about it. Looking out the window, though, she spots snow beginning to fall. For a moment she just watches it, her tail flicking back in forth as she is entranced by the mesmerizing dance outside, but eventually the snow produces a niggling thought in the back of her mind that pulls on her attention.

“Hey, Adora? Do you want to do anything for Winterfest?” Catra asks, tugging on her hair a little to get her attention. Adora pauses against her, raising her head to blink up at Catra in surprise. The last week of the year is usually dedicated to friends and family, with traditions of giving gifts on New Year’s Eve to close out the year. It starts on Saturday, and they never really celebrated it before, but they were also broke kids who weren’t given a chance to.

“I forget, sometimes, that we don’t know everything about each other anymore,” Adora says, softly, lowering her head to rest her cheek on Catra’s stomach while craning her head back to look at her. Catra winces a little, but she nods. She knows what Adora means – she forgot that Catra wouldn’t just *know* her Winterfest traditions. Adora blows out a long breath, turning her head to place a kiss against Catra’s stomach and then pillowing her head again.

“I usually just try to visit all my friends over the week, and Hope and I have family dinner the day before New Year’s. Angella always hosts a big party at Gracie Mansion on New Year’s that I go to, but that’s about it,” Adora tells her, shrugging a little and peering up at her. Catra nods, thinking it over. Having dinner with Hope again will probably be awkward, but considering what came out of the last one, it might be good for them.

“Do you want me to come to the party?” she asks, petting through Adora’s hair. Adora offers her a small, hopeful smile that makes Catra roll her eyes. “Not like I had any other plans anyway,” she assures her. She has been to a few parties during Winterfest over the past two years, but they were all with clients as a minder. They were *stressful*. She is kind of looking forward to getting to just enjoy one.

Thinking of parties reminds her of the last time she was in public with Adora. Catra blinks down at Adora, tilting her head a little as she considers her. She seems content, and Catra would hate to ruin that, but at the same time it has been a *week* and she has thought of this many times during it, just never while Adora was home.

“At the resort, Perfuma mentioned you write music?” Catra prompts, watching Adora’s expression carefully. Adora blinks at her in surprise, probably due to the sudden topic shift, but she nods.

“Not anything I released, but I like to play piano. It’s just… satisfying on my hands. I write alternative-style lyrics in my free time,” Adora tells her with a shrug. Catra swallows, still staring down at her.

“I haven’t heard you play,” she points out. She isn’t asking Adora to, she just doesn’t know why Adora has never played when she was around. For a week now, Adora definitely hasn’t touched her piano. Adora pauses for a moment before sitting up, scooting over to the edge of the bed, and then reaching her hand back out for Catra to take.

“Come on,” she prompts, offering Catra a small smile. Catra draws in a breath, her ears and tail twitching for a moment before she reaches out and takes her hand.

--

Adora has, truthfully, had a song building in her all week, ever since her epiphany on Sunday. She can’t *write* that song though, not while Catra is around, so she just hasn’t sat down at her piano. Playing something else never crossed her mind until Catra asked.

“I don’t really like playing for people. My hands always shook way too much for live performances,” Adora admits as she slides back the cover for the piano keys. Catra, leaning against the side of the upright piano, frowns a little.

“You don’t have to-” she starts, but Adora cuts her off with a shake of her head, playing a few unconnected notes and then a single scale that is muscle memory at this point.

“I don’t mind playing for you. When you were visiting only when you had the time, I didn’t want to waste any of my time with you on piano,” Adora explains, before she plays a small chord progression – another practice set that is engrained in her fingers. It feels *good* to work her hands again. When she has felt her fingers twitching for the last week, she has buried them in Catra’s fur instead of turning to her piano, but they are *wildly* different sensations and urges, even if Catra’s fur is always soothing.

Adora hums along as she runs through a few simple songs she knows by heart. It isn’t anything she has written, but despite being willing to play for Catra, she is nervous. She has sung a few of her songs for her friends, and more often for Hope, but she will know if Catra doesn’t like them, and that would hurt. Catra closes her eyes and leans against the piano, seemingly focused on just *listening* until Adora feels her fingers starting to follow the familiar patterns of one of her early songs and she draws to a halt. Catra cracks an eye open, peering at her curiously, while Adora blushes.

“Uh, that last one I wrote, but it’s really old. The others are all just practice, or from one of the songs Hope bought for me,” Adora explains, looking down at her hands. Out of the corner of her eye, Catra straightens a little.

“You don’t have to play anything you wrote if you aren’t comfortable sharing it. Thank you for playing for me at all,” Catra tells her. Adora smiles at her, feeling a bit of the weight fall off her shoulders. Catra sees it, her eyes crinkling as she smiles back. “I like listening to you play. And when you are ready, even if it’s *unpolished* or whatever, I’ll still probably like it better than what Hope had you singing. It never felt like you,” Catra tells her, voice a little teasing. Adora laughs a little, shaking her head.

“I hate every single one of ‘my’ songs,” she admits, looking down at the keys and playing a few more notes, though she isn’t really intending to play any more songs. Catra, to her surprise, looks *relieved*.

“Oh, thank fuck. You know I love your singing voice, Adora, but I hate your discography. It isn’t you,” Catra tells her. Adora looks up at her, blinking for a moment. She is a bit surprised, but more about the fact that she isn’t bothered than by Catra’s words. She already knew her songs weren’t Catra’s taste in music. She always thought it would hurt her to find out Catra didn’t like her music, but in truth, she hates it too.

Catra is right – it *isn’t* hers, it is whatever Hope gave her to sing. Her own songs might not be *a good fit for her voice*, according to Hope, but they are *hers* and she likes them a lot better. It would be too much to play one for Catra tonight, but Catra seems content with just this for now. Adora feels better for having played, too, even if now her fingers are twitching to play a *specific* song, the arrangement beginning to build in her head again. Adora shoves it down.

--

Adora asks Catra what she wants for Winterfest and she says *a strap* mostly to watch Adora choke.

“What, princess? It would be a gift for *both* of us,” she teases. She is right, but that doesn’t seem to calm Adora down as she sputters. Still, three days into Winterfest, Adora drives herself out to visit Perfuma. She assures Catra she can stay home seeing as the drive is so long and it would eat up the time that she has budgeted for a practice test. When Adora comes back, she has a shopping bag with her.

“Wait, seriously?” Catra asks, her tail waving, when Adora’s only response to being prompted about the black bag is to blush. Catra immediately reaches for the bag, intending to open it, but Adora holds it up out of her reach. Catra sends Adora her best sad eyes, grinning a little as Adora *visibly* struggles with resisting her.

“You’ll get your Winterfest present on New Year’s,” Adora tells her, trying to sound authoritative and *failing*. Catra narrows her eyes at her, dropping her outstretched hand to

place it on her hip, cocking it out and giving Adora a wide grin.

“So you *don’t* want to fuck me?” she challenges. She grins as Adora turns scarlet. They had sex again on Saturday. Adora got turned on while they were making out and Catra couldn’t resist the way that scent made her mouth *water*. It was a bit soon for it, maybe, but when it had Adora moaning her name and she got to discover that she tasted as good as she smells, Catra doesn’t *care*. She’s pretty sure Adora didn’t even come from it, but she was still breathless and happy afterwards, so Catra was content.

“*Catra*,” Adora hisses, flustered but turned on. Catra smirks, stepping close to press their fronts together as Adora blinks down at her, still holding the bag above her head. If Catra wanted to, she could reach up with her claws and slit the bottom of the bag to obtain her prize, but she doesn’t want to damage it and her mind is already running through *other* possibilities.

“You want to wait until New Year’s? Come home from the party and bend me over? Or do you want *me* to have it on so you can ride it in the backseat for the drive there?” Catra asks, rapid-fire, her veins coming alive as Adora releases a small *whine* at the words alone, the scent of her desire building. She shivers a little against her.

“I- fuck,” she mutters, cheeks blazing. Her arm holding up the bag is shaking despite how she has held *Catra* up for longer than this. After a moment more, she seems to have gathered herself enough to attempts words again. “I do, uh, want that. Except the car thing, because Frosta would kill me, but- It seems fast, and I don’t want to rush you,” Adora manages, still flushed up to her ears. Catra pauses, blinking at her in surprise.

Rush her? Catra has been thinking about Adora while touching herself as long as she has been doing it. Sure, she has thought about other people and amorphous strangers over the years, especially after Adora left music and fell from the limelight, but any time she pictured something meaningful and not just a quick fantasy, she turned to Adora.

She would have thought eating her out on Saturday despite having no experience would have been all Adora needed to feel confident in how much Catra wants her. Catra continues to blink at Adora for several long moments before she reaches a hand up and fists it in the front of her shirt.

“Come on,” she orders, turning and pulling Adora towards the staircase. Adora scrambles a little, clearly uncertain what to do with the bag she is still holding over her head.

“Catra, what-“ she starts to ask. Catra turns around to raise a brow at her.

“I’m going to fuck you like I mean it, Adora,” Catra promises her. Adora stares back at her.

--

Catra was not exaggerating. She runs her hands and *tongue* over Adora, kissing and worshipping her body much like she did their first time together. When it comes time to actually touch her, Catra curls around her side, one hand between her legs and the other cradling her cheek. Catra never once breaks eye contact as she murmurs praises to her that have Adora *whining*.

That's it and *you're so beautiful* and *I love hearing your sounds, knowing I was the one who made you whimper*. Adora squirms beneath her hands, her entire body feeling like fire as her desire burns her inside out in a way that she didn't know it *could*.

"Princess, I love getting to touch you like this," is the one that ruins Adora, because she doesn't care that it isn't what she really wants Catra to say – it is close *enough*. Adora comes utterly undone. Once her orgasm has hit – once she is moaning Catra's name and gasping for air – Catra shifts both her hands to frame Adora's face and purrs to her as she *keeps going*, telling her how good she was for her.

"Catra," Adora whines, a bit lost as she nudges into her hands. She doesn't even know what she is asking for, but Catra somehow does, leaning down to kiss her gently. *Love, love, love* is thrumming through Adora's veins. The only thing making it possible to hold the words back is how difficult it is to speak when she feels this wrecked.

"I'm right here, princess. I'm not going anywhere," Catra assures. Adora swallows, her throat suddenly feeling tight as she reaches up to wrap her arms around Catra's shoulders. Catra drapes over her chest, snuggling and purring as Adora tries to gather herself. She doesn't know how she is *supposed* to. Her entire body is singing with how much she loves Catra, overflowing with joy over the fact that Catra is here in this moment and planning to stay for an infinite number of moments *after*.

Adora realizes she is tapping her fingers against Catra's back, blushing as she forces her hands still and buries her face in Catra's mane. She is kind of used to having feelings for Catra she can't say, even if she didn't realize how deep they went, and for years music was the only way she let them out. She hums to herself, trying to calm her heart as she breathes Catra in. It's okay. Catra is here. She can nuzzle Catra's mane and pepper her with kisses instead. Adora's hum turns softer, *calmer* as she breathes Catra in.

It takes on a melody. Dammit.

--

Adora spends the week of Winterfest talking to her friends – in-person or on the phone – and cuddling with Catra, taking occasional breaks to play her piano now Catra has brought it up. After watching her play, Catra realizes the way she occasionally taps her fingers on things is a mirroring how she drums her fingers across the keys. She thought it was just a way of fidgeting she picked up over the years without Catra's tail to play with, but it turns out it represents a specific urge.

Adora plays about every other day, sometimes two in a row. Sometimes she pokes around on the keys for a few minutes, and other times she spends an hour running through songs. On Tuesday, blushing and looking unsure, Adora asked her if she could go up to the conservatory for a while. Catra was confused, but she went. A few minutes later, she picked up Adora's distant singing as she sang, of all things, *You Are My Sunshine*.

She has been singing as she plays a bit since then, though all of them were melodies that Catra recognized. On Thursday, Hope comes over for their holiday dinner. It is a lot less awkward than the last meal now that she and Adora are more comfortable and established. After dinner, Adora sends her the look she gave her before she asked her to go and Catra pulls on her coat to go for a short stroll around the terrace as Adora leads Hope into her study.

Catra doesn't want to stay inside. Adora told her that the true reason Hope adopted her in the first place was that her singing voice was similar to how her wife's sounded when she was younger. Catra catches Adora singing one of "her" songs – a song on her discography – before she makes it out to the terrace. She doesn't want to *listen* to that.

Hope has been kind all day, even if she is a bit stilted. She was friendly with Catra and pleased when she informed her that she was going to be switching some of her classes once the university reopened so she could pursue the side of law she really wanted. Catra is just still bitter. She can't help feeling, as she stands out on the terrace and stares at the ice encrusted on the high privacy fence, like Hope used Adora to work through her own grief without caring about the damage she inflicted on a *child* in turn.

Hope cares. Catra has *watched* her care, in her own special way, but her heart is still bitter. She comes back inside after fifteen minutes to find Adora still playing, but this time it is a Winterfest song. Catra quickly sheds her coat, shaking a few snowflakes from her hair, and makes her way back to the study. Hope has gotten her chance to hear the songs she wanted by now.

Adora misses a few notes and has to backtrack when Catra enters the room, but aside from blushing and sending Catra a small smile, she doesn't comment on her reappearance. She finishes the song out, starting another, this time an instrumental of a classic rock ballad. When she finishes, she turns around and offers them both a hopeful smile.

"You always sing beautifully," Hope compliments her. Catra's tail twitches. She has *so much* she wants to say in response to that, but she forces herself to keep her thoughts to herself. She crosses the room, watching Adora light up a little as she draws near. Adora shifts a little on the bench and Catra settles beside her, leaning into her side while Adora wraps an arm around her.

"I like when you play," Catra assures her, stretching up a little to kiss her cheek. She can't compliment her singing, she only heard her sing the absolute last songs she wants to hear, but she thinks Adora would prefer her playing complimented anyway. It feels more special, something only a few have heard and something Adora actually likes. Not that she doesn't enjoy singing, but she doesn't like *those* songs.

Adora lights up, turning to kiss the backs of each of her ears. She hums a small melody, the same one she has been humming all week, seemingly just delighted. Hope smiles at them

both and, after a moment of just looking, mentions how late it is and that she should be getting home. Catra is a bit relieved. She wants Adora to herself again.

--

"So, when do I get to open my present?" Catra teases as they drive to Gracie Mansion on Friday night. In the front seat, Frosta pretends to gag and immediately rolls up the divider between the driver and the backseat. Frosta doesn't even know what it *is*, but maybe it was just the way Catra said it – or the way Adora blushed in response.

"You can have it when we get home," Adora responds. Catra's eyes dance with amusement as she places a hand on Adora's thigh and then somehow manages to scoot closer without undoing her seatbelt.

"Not that I don't *love* you in a suit, but if you had worn a dress I could have had some fun before midnight," Catra tells her, grinning slyly as Adora's blush progresses from *light* to *crimson*.

"I wouldn't *survive* it," Adora points out, flustered, both grateful they are almost at the mansion and *not* because she has to look collected once they get there. She has to ditch dresses for the foreseeable future. She pretty much only wears them to red carpet affairs or anywhere she has to sing anyway, the waist of pants restricting her diaphragm too much to sing when she is out of practice. Catra *pouts* for a moment before eyeing Adora, slipping her hand up from her thigh to instead slide it beneath her suit jacket and palm her abs.

"I can admit I might prefer you like this," she tacks on, because she doesn't want to go to the New Year's party, clearly, and she is trying to *murder* Adora before they arrive. Catra has been a bit handsy ever since Monday, and they had sex again on Wednesday night when Adora's quest to snuggle got a little too intimate until her hands were *finally* snaking beneath Catra's clothes like she had picture so many times.

Maybe they are just starting to build up their intimacy in general, now the first hurdle is crossed. Adora doesn't want to hold herself *back* from Catra, so perhaps Catra is experiencing the same thing. She certainly doesn't seem to have any qualms about sending Adora an almost *predatory* grin as Frosta calls loudly through the divider *we're here* without ever taking the risk of lowering it.

"Can you behave for the party?" Adora asks her as they get out of the car and Frosta pulls away to park it. She will be attending the party as Adora's guest too, though she expects Frosta will go off and do her own thing. It is what she has done in years past and Adora doubts she is going to want to *stick around* her and Catra. Catra, in response, gives her a grin that is all fangs. In her new tailored suit, it makes Adora a little weak at the knees.

"Now that you've said that, princess? Absolutely not," Catra returns. Adora shouldn't be turned on by that, but *should* was never a factor in the equation.

--

They start kissing when the ball drops, and they kind of never stop. They had to be a certain level of professional for the party – there were politicians, cameras, and business leaders all present – but after midnight hits and everyone is filtering out of the party, there is the illusion of safety in the crowd. They kiss, and then part to keep walking, and then they have to pause for whatever reason and end up kissing again.

When they get in the car, Adora pulls Catra into her lap and sets to kissing her immediately. The only thing that keeps their clothes *on* is Frosta's presence in the front seat. Despite there being champagne and wine readily available all night, they both avoided picking up a glass. They never discussed it, but she suspects both of them were set on staying sober so they could do this when they got home without worry or a delay to sober up.

Catra pins Adora against the wall of the elevator with a hungry kiss the moment the doors close behind them. Catra can admit she has had a dirty thought or two about the private elevator, and after a night of teasing Adora – only occasionally, Adora really couldn't *handle* more – she can't keep her hands off her once they are alone. She opens up Adora's suit jacket, running her hands over her dress shirt and drinking in the satisfied groan Adora gives.

Adora lets Catra pin her against the wall with heated kisses and roaming hands until they reach the top floor and the elevator doors slide open. Catra could *easily* take her right here, but they do kind of have plans, so when Adora pulls back from the kiss and pants "Bed?", Catra follows her without question. Adora leads her to the bedroom, encouraging Catra to sit, and then pulls back with a hopeful smile.

"Wait here?" she asks, her voice hopeful. Catra blinks at her for a moment before she remembers that Adora stowed the strap in the secret walk-in closet in her office. It is mostly filled with Adora's gowns and costumes from performances over the years, but Adora had to shove the box somewhere it wouldn't be too *tempting*.

Getting into the closet involves awkwardly shimmying around the back of Adora's piano, so it really wasn't worth it when Catra knew Adora wouldn't let them play yet even if she fetched the strap. Catra nods, a bit eagerly, grinning to herself when Adora perks up just as much and hurries away to the study. Catra is left alone, glancing down at herself and debating if she should undress. She decides to shuck off her jacket, laying it out on the ground beside the bed.

A dangerous location, sure, but less dangerous than *on* the bed – or worse, *on her*. Catra has just decided to start undoing her shirt buttons – Adora tends to struggle with them, which might explain why she usually wears dresses to formal occasions – but has only undone one by the time that Adora returns. Catra freezes in the middle of grabbing her second button, her jaw going *slack* as she gapes at Adora.

Adora didn't just fetch the strap – she put it *on*, and she left her clothes on too. Adora is still dressed in her suit, though the jacket is open, as is her *fly* so the strap can come out of her mostly-undone and partially-sagging dress pants. Heat floods through Catra's body and suddenly all of her internal debate about which one of them would wear it tonight flies out the window because she *needs* Adora to fuck her when she looks like this.

"Holy shit," Catra whispers, her fur standing on end a little as her tail thuds against the bed. She caught a half-second of Adora's unsure expression when she first entered the room before she got distracted by the sight of the *gorgeous* woman before her, but when she finally manages to tear her eyes off the toy - and the line of Adora's body beneath the suit - she finds that uncertainty has been replaced with a smirk.

"I didn't want to assume, but I also thought you would like this," Adora tells her, *sauntering* just a little as she approaches the bed and reaches out to cup her hand around the back of Catra's neck. Catra is still sporting the ponytail she put her hair up in to make it a littler tamer for the party, giving her easy access. Catra licks her lips unconsciously, reaching up to place her hands on Adora's hips as she eyes the toy. She can feel the straps of the harness beneath her suit pants, but it seems Adora ditched her underwear in the study because Catra can smell her desire clearly around the open fly and, aside from the harness, all she sees is *skin*.

Fuck, Catra *likes* it alright. Her mouth is watering a bit and, despite knowing it won't taste like Adora, she finds herself leaning down towards the strap. Adora draws in a sharp breath, the hand in Catra's hair spasming as she hesitates just above it, sending a glance up in Adora's direction. Adora look down at her, face flushed and eyes darkened with lust. It is all Catra needs to see to part her lips and take the toy experimentally in her mouth.

It isn't that big. Adora was reasonable with her purchase. It is black – as least to Catra, and she has learned enough about viewing her world that she is pretty certain that this is a true black – and only a few inches. It is smooth all the way down, nothing too realistic or intimidating. Catra sucks carefully against where the head *would* be for a moment, listening to Adora's laboured breathing and luxuriating in the way her scent is absolutely flooding with desire.

She likes actually getting to taste Adora a lot more, but her scent is so thick when Catra is this close to her that she practically *can* taste her – at least if it weren't for the slightly plasticky taste on her tongue. Catra pulls back off the toy, sitting up straight again and grinning up at Adora as she gapes down at her.

"I'm going to want a turn with it eventually too, but this is a gorgeous sight in its own right," Catra purrs to her. Adora's gaze is distant as she swallows and nods, her hand on the back of Catra's head flexing a bit uselessly for a moment. Catra quirks a brow at her. "Kiss me?" she prompts. Adora's brain seems to have derailed, and while she is *proud* of it, she also would like for them to keep going. She is going to soak through her suit pants if Adora doesn't take them off her soon.

The words seem to snap Adora into motion. Her eyes light up and she bends down, kissing Catra. She can't describe the kiss as anything but *firm*. Adora's hunger is clear, but she isn't forceful and she doesn't try to devour her. She presses against her slowly licking into her

mouth and along her fangs for a long moment as Catra moans softly, squeezing her thighs together. When they part, both of them are panting.

“Can we get on the bed? I have a way I’ve been envisioning this,” Adora asks her. Catra gives Adora her best encouraging smile. The answer is, of course, *yes*.

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When Adora was envisioning this, they were both naked, but she kind of likes them both in their suits more. Her suit pants end up shoved around her upper thighs, wrinkles the last thing on her mind as she is pulling Catra’s pants down completely, along with her underwear. She still has her dress shirt on and Adora still has her suit jacket even, but Catra looks fucking *sexy* like this and neither of them can wait any longer.

Adora ends up propped against the headboard, sitting up with Catra in her lap as Catra carefully lowers herself down onto the toy, whining a little as it first presses in. She stops after only a moment, her thighs trembling as Adora does her best to hold her up by her hips alone. Adora bites her lip, looking to her with concern as Catra breathes heavy.

“It feels good, I just need to adjust,” Catra assures her, her face flushed as she offers Adora a small smile. Their faces are only a few centimeters apart, their breathes mingling as Catra starts to slide down on the toy again, gasping softly until she lands in Adora’s lap, snug against her hips.

“There you go. Take as long as you need,” Adora assures her, running a hand down her back. The main reason she wanted to do it like this is because she couldn’t get the *intimacy* of it out of her head after Catra suggested something similar. She has Catra in her lap, Catra’s arms wrapped around her shoulders as she leans forward and nuzzles against Adora, still trying to relax her body.

Adora holds her as she breathes in and out, letting herself get used to the intrusion for what must be *minutes*. Adora is in no rush, petting her hands down Catra’s back and nuzzling her cheek while she waits for her to feel comfortable.

“Take as long as you need. If it’s too much, we can wait,” Adora assures her, kissing her cheek. To her surprise, Catra trills, happily nuzzling her back. When she pulls back, just far enough to make eye contact, her expression is soft. Her tail is swaying behind her and the tension that entered her body as she sunk down is easing, so Adora is hopeful that she is feeling more comfortable.

“It doesn’t hurt. Just want to wait until it will only feel good,” Catra explains, leaning forward and kissing her. Adora squeezes her hands on Catra’s shoulder blades, holding her close as she kisses her back. It feels like a fantasy to have Catra in her arms, her breathing going a bit ragged as her hips *twitch* down on the strap she is settled on. Heat is pooling between Adora’s legs just at *having* Catra against her like this.

Catra's hips twitch again as she shifts unconsciously, ready for *more* and no longer willing to wait. Adora keeps kissing her as she drops her hands back to Catra's hip so she can help her move. Their lips never part as Catra clings onto her, raising her hips up before she thrusts down. Catra moans unsteadily at the same time that Adora *groans*. She can't stop herself, not when she feels the harness press down as Catra lowers herself onto it.

"Fuck," Catra mutters into the kiss, nipping at her lip and *tugging,* seeming a bit desperate. Adora feels like her skin is burning with desire, nothing better than the rough quality of Catra's voice when she is turned on like this. Catra raises up again, this time setting a rhythm as she begins to properly *ride* her.

Adora has never been so turned on in her life, leaning back a little to watch Catra as she works her hips down, whining and whimpering, if not outright moaning. Catra pants, her face screwed up with desperation and pleasure. Her breaths puff against Adora's face as she watches hungrily, drinking in every twitch of Catra's expression. Catra doesn't seem able to take it any longer, whining and then leaning forward to kiss her, desperate and needy.

Adora kisses her back, just as eager to taste her as she is to *watch*. She can still feel Catra's hips meeting hers, giving her stimulation, though nowhere near enough. It doesn't matter to her, she just *wants* this. Adora kisses Catra until she makes a small whimpering sound and she has to lean back to just *watch* again. She feels greedy watching Catra shaking with desire, but when Catra manages to slit her eyes open, she moans at Adora's expression.

They keep going like that, kissing until Catra's breathing goes too ragged or Adora just needs to see her, resting their foreheads together instead during the gaps so they can stay close. Adora doesn't feel like she could stand to be more than a few centimeters apart as Catra devolves into writhing down on the toy as she moans and whimpers.

"I- I need," Catra pants out, voice breathless. She seemingly gives up, surging forward and kissing Adora messily. They may still be new to *this*, but Adora knows her best friend and she can hear the *more* even without words. Adora kisses her back, tugging on Catra's hips to bring her down to rest in her lap, the toy buried in her. Catra whines, but she lets Adora hold her with one hand on her hip as the other trails down to touch her.

The *relief* in Catra's answering moan makes Adora groan. Adora touches her, working her clit as Catra tries and fails to stay still, wriggling on the toy to still get the stimulation while Adora works her over. She doesn't think she could keep touching her while Catra was riding the toy properly, but apparently this is enough. It only takes a few moments of touching her before Catra's moans become broken. She clutches to her, burying her face in Adora's shoulders and shifting her hips as Adora works her over until her tail is lashing stiffly and then her entire body tenses.

"*Adora*," Catra whines as she comes, ruining Adora in a single word. Adora lets go of her hip, wrapping that arm around her back instead to hold her close, kissing her temple.

"I'm right here. I've got you, kitten," Adora promises her. Catra whimpers, shaking her head a little as she seemingly tries to burrow her face into Adora's collar bone. Adora shifts her hand out from between her legs, raising it to run up and down her back to soothe her as Catra trembles and comes back to herself. "It's alright," she adds, her voice soft.

This time, she is greeted by Catra beginning to purr gently.

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Adora holds her for a while before she carefully lifts Catra off the toy and lays her out on the bed. Catra doesn't particularly *want* Adora to go, but Adora makes sure she is comfortable and tucked in before she leaves for the bathroom, taking off the harness and cleaning it quickly. When Adora returns, she shucks off her clothes and discards them with little care to their cost.

Catra purrs as Adora fumbles her way through undoing Catra's shirt buttons and pulls it off her shoulders, tossing it aside and gathering Catra, now naked, in her arms. They end up cuddled together in the bed, Adora wrapped around her as Catra happily lets herself be cradled in Adora's arms. She hasn't stopped purring, but the sound rolls louder in the room as Adora scatters kisses against her ears.

"Happy new year, Catra," Adora murmurs to her, voice soft and heavy with affection. Catra shifts her head a little to rub her cheek against Adora's shoulder, purring as her tail sways with content.

"Gonna be the best year," she mumbles, sleepy but honest. Adora hums, apparently happy with that response as she cuddles her close. Catra means it. The happiness thrumming through her chest isn't just the endorphins. She doesn't feel like this when she gets off on her own. The intimacy of having Adora cradling her the whole time, and then cuddling her afterwards, has not only her body but her *heart* content.

She falls asleep in Adora's arms, in *their* bed, well past midnight. She is entering the new year knowing that this small slice of heaven is not only her present, but it will be her future too, likely for the next several years. Catra doesn't even care to look beyond that, not when everything is so *right* now, and she knows Adora is still going to want her around.

Nothing else matters.

Chapter End Notes

Are you sure about that, Catra? There isn't anything else you could want, hmm??
No, Catra isn't completely nailing the meaning of white roses, but she's got the spirit.

The Prestige

Chapter Notes

> A note for the British/colonized folks: “jelly” is similar to jam (just made differently). It is *not* gelatin (we call that Jello), it is real fruit you spread on stuff.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Winterfest, Catra has one week of break left. The School of Law starts a week ahead of the rest of the university, so her break is shorter. At first she was a little consumed with her career drama and then her time was taken up by Winterfest. She expects to spend the rest of her break just relaxing until she is almost eager for school to start again if only to give herself something to do other than take the same practice test for the tenth time.

She is wrong. She spends the last week of break having sex. Not *exclusively*, of course, in fact Adora spends just as much time petting her as she does writhing in the sheets, but it seems Adora’s guilt over her desires is finally abating. Beneath that guilt was a *lot* of repressed sexuality. On Saturday, Adora asks to pet her until that somehow devolves to her touching Catra. On Sunday, she asks Catra if she would like to use the strap again.

From the way her cheeks blaze, Catra knows she means the *other* way. Every day of the week goes like that, until on Thursday Catra isn’t at all surprised when Adora plasters around her back upon returning from work, her hands already roaming as she kisses at her scruff. Catra *was* in the middle of putting the desk back in order after finishing studying for the day, but she quickly abandons it as Adora sneaks a hand beneath the hem of her shirt.

“Want something?” Catra asks, amused, as Adora’s hand reaches her chest and squeezes. She can feel Adora’s grin against her neck. She hums, pretending to think it over as she presses another kiss there.

“Maybe,” Adora teases, pinching lightly at her nipple. Catra gasps, her back arching without her thinking about it. Adora has gotten the pressure she likes *down*, setting to lightly rubbing against her with the pad of her thumb to keep from overworking her. Adora isn’t usually horny out the gate when she gets home – they just naturally end up here over the course of the evening – but she smells like desire right now. Catra can guess her mind was *wandering* on the drive home.

“Mm. Care to share with the class?” Catra returns, feeling her tail begin to sway as Adora switches sides to toy with her other nipple. Her breath stutters as Adora nips lightly against the back of her neck.

“Want to have sex in the guest room?” Adora asks, causing Catra to promptly flush. She wasn’t expecting Adora to be that blunt, and she clearly hasn’t even gotten to what she is

thinking about. Catra is pretty sure having sex in your guest bed is a faux pas, but it isn't like Adora has had call to use it for guests anyway.

"And?" Catra prompts, because she knows Adora isn't this worked up over *changing beds*. If that is the only difference, then her answer is actually *no*. She wants to have sex in the bed that is theirs – the one she is familiar with, that is comfortable and safe. The guest bed doesn't actually feel less safe than theirs, but she would prefer the bed with all the positive associations to it, even if they have made out in the guest room before.

"I've kind of always wanted to fuck someone while they watched in the mirror there," Adora admits, embarrassment in her voice as she slides her hand down to Catra's ribs, leaving it in a more respectful location while she waits for Catra's response to that. Catra flushes crimson, thinking of the large mirror – like, *mattress size* large mirror – propped up against the wall of the guest room. Her mouth is dry as she nods her agreement.

Against her neck, she feels Adora grin again.

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Adora is losing her mind. Her body feels too small for the emotions in it almost *daily*. Yes, she wants to have sex with Catra – and Catra is the one to steer them towards sex almost as often as she is – but a big part of it is just what sex allows her. She can touch Catra with tenderness and whisper sweet nothings to her without it *meaning* anything.

That is why this specific fantasy is on her mind – she can tell Catra how gorgeous she is, splayed out over her lap and watching in the mirror, and as long as she follows it up with *look at yourself*, it just seems like a kink thing rather than words that have been choking her throat every morning they wake up together. Catra whines in her lap, trying to shift back onto Adora's fingers, but that makes the hand Adora has on her scruff tug at it.

Catra goes limp, almost dropping facedown onto the mattress if it weren't from the pillow Adora tucked under her chin when she laid out on her stomach in Adora's lap. Adora is sat with her legs over the edge of the bed, Catra settled over her lap and watching in the mirror at the foot of the bed. They are both naked – *might as well give me a show too, princess,* Catra told her – and Adora's eyes roam hungrily over Catra, both in her lap and in the mirror.

Catra's face is flushed, her eyes blown out and hooded, hazy with lust. She *loves* this. Adora isn't sure which part it is – the position, or the mirror, or the gentle praises, but the latter *definitely* gets a reaction from her. Adora works her hand in smooth thrusts, a motion already becoming familiar to her, as she scratches her nails lightly down Catra's back and finishes with a rolling scratch against the base of her tail.

Catra *mewls*, her tail lashing as she rolls her hips back onto Adora's fingers again. She pants heavily in the wake of the sound that sends a bolt of pleasure straight between Adora's legs knowing *she caused that*.

“Your sounds are just as beautiful as you, kitten,” Adora continues her string of praises that have erred just a little more *sweet* than *dirty*. Catra’s pupils are round as she pants out a hazy sound of happiness, hips shifting once again. Adora presses in a little firmer on her next thrust, earning a soft moan. Okay, Catra is worked up enough that she can take a bit more.

“You feel incredible. So wet for me,” Adora adds, ducking to press a soft kiss against the top of Catra’s head. Catra whines – she doesn’t *stop* whining as Adora keeps using that firmer pressure to thrust deeper. “I love having you like this,” Adora adds. The *like this* is redundant, Adora loves having Catra in any and every way, but the guise of what they are doing can only cover so much.

She is pretty sure even half the things she has been saying fall under *going too far*, but Catra isn’t calling her on it – she is shifting her hips back and panting out soft *ha*s with every breath, her lips parted as she struggles to contain herself.

“*Adora*,” Catra whines. It is a request – she wants to come, clearly, but Adora is pretty sure she can’t come just from this. She knows *she* can’t anyway, and she assumes the same is true for Catra, even if Catra seems to enjoy being fucked more than she does. Adora bends down, gently taking the end of Catra’s ear in her teeth and tugging lightly, earning another mewl. Adora kisses against the spot after she releases it.

“I love the way you say my name,” she adds, whispering into her ear as she pulls her fingers out. Catra actually *growls*, which probably shouldn’t be hot, but it totally is. Adora quickly wipes her hand on the sheets – it is totally soaked and would just slide around if she tried to use it without wiping it off first – and then returns her hand between Catra’s legs to work her clit.

Catra gasps out a stuttering purr, going a bit limp again just from her relief. Touching her from this angle is awkward – she is basically upside down from what she is used to, and she can’t *see* what she is doing – but Catra seems to be so far gone that it doesn’t matter. Adora finds a pressure that is steady enough and, after a few moments, Catra gasps out as her entire body tenses. For a few seconds she is suspended like that, her body locked up, and then she collapses face down into the pillow, beginning to purr.

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Catra has never in her *life* been worked up like that. Hearing Adora’s filthy praises and seeing the hunger in her eyes had everything inside her crying out. When Adora finally touches her clit, it barely takes anything to bring her over. Adora cradles her in the bed afterwards until Catra can’t *take* it anymore and flips them. She grabs Adora by the hips, dragging her down to the edge of the bed, and turns her over as she gasps in surprise.

Despite her surprise, no part of Adora resists as Catra bends her over the edge of the bed and touches her. She wishes she had the strap, her hands free to touch and *grab*, but her whole body is thrumming too much for her to step away to go get it. She ends up with one hand

fisted in Adora's hair, pulling her head *back* so she can't stifle her moans in the sheets while Catra touches her with the other. She buries her teeth in Adora's shoulder, groaning in unison with Adora.

To have Adora beneath her fangs is to have *her*. She can dig her teeth in - bruising and a little painful, but Adora likes it – and mark her as her own. Sure, Adora will have to cover up the marks at work, but outside of that she will have pointed bruises that make it clear she belongs to someone – that she is *Catra's*. The fact that she can taste the salt of her sweat-slick skin is only a bonus.

Every word Adora told her while she was splayed over her lap drove her wild. It was Adora's fantasy, likely with an amorphous nobody that Catra filled the role of, but it was *sweet* even when Adora was complimenting her filthy moans and telling her how good it feels to fuck her. She sucked Catra into the world where Adora wants her, loves her, *needs* her, and she isn't eager to leave it just yet.

She forces herself to release Adora's shoulder, worried about seriously hurting her. She ends up with her forehead pressed between Adora's shoulder blades, licking against her skin when she isn't panting or groaning herself as Adora moans beneath her touch. It doesn't take long for Adora to come, not after all the build up of fucking Catra first.

Catra releases her hair aa Adora goes limp, quickly sliding her hand around to cup her jaw and direct her to lay her cheek on the mattress. Adora's ribs expand and contract rapidly beneath her, causing her back to rise and fall, as she tries to get ahold of herself again. Catra didn't end up fucking her – it doesn't do as much for her anyway – but Adora was worked up enough her hand still got plenty slick, and she sucks her fingers clean as Adora comes back to herself.

"Nap?" Adora asks, still breathless but starting to catch up on her air. Her voice is laden with content. Catra nods, shifting off of Adora so she can pull her up into the bed properly. They cuddle together on top of the sheets, both naked but neither of them *caring* as Catra quickly curls up on Adora's chest and begins to purr.

She never thought the sex would be so *incredible*. Sure, they are still figuring out how exactly to make the other feel good and sometimes Adora ends up edging her for twenty minutes because Catra is *so close* and just needs a touch to her clit to finally come, but that isn't even the important part. The important part is the way having Adora beneath her hands – naked and eager and *hers* – makes her fur stand on end.

The *most* important part is the way Adora is totally oblivious and says things that make this all seem real while they are fucking, pouring praise on her because she is just so eager to have someone like this. Catra was afraid this would break her heart, but instead she finds that it is *healing* it. She is starting to truly feel like Adora wants her. When Adora touches her like that, it feels like she loves her.

It is an amazing feeling. Catra can't believe she was ever *unsure* about the arrangement. It is everything she hoped a relationship with Adora would be, only she actually gets to have it. She isn't looking forward to the semester starting again and having to go back to her little

dorm. The mattress isn't comfortable, but what she really cares about is that Adora isn't there.

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On Friday evening, Catra rolls over in the bed and blinks at her slowly. They are supposed to be sleeping, but Adora was actually watching the subtle ruffle of Catra's fur in the "breeze" produced by the central heater. She was resisting the urge to reach up and pet the swaying fur, but clearly she didn't have to worry about waking Catra up. Catra's face is only a few inches away, her eyes catching the haze of the city lights spilling through the windows. She watches Adora for a long moment as Adora blinks back, surprised. Catra doesn't seem upset, but her expression is a bit tense as she watches Adora.

"I'm supposed to move back in on Sunday," she says, her voice just above a whisper like they are back in their old bunk at the group home, not ready to go to sleep yet despite how they will still be together when they wake up in the morning. It was still *different* once everyone else was awake too. It shattered their little world together, and they had Shadow to dodge.

Adora just blinks at Catra, waiting for a long moment before the words *supposed to* hit her and she draws in a sharp breath. Catra bites her bottom lip, expression nervous. Adora forces herself to raise her hand, cupping Catra's cheek and giving her a small, encouraging smile. Catra's next breath is a bit relieved.

"I don't have any really early classes this semester. I'll still have to spend time at my dorm and on campus studying and stuff, but I like being able to sleep with you. I wanted to… stay," Catra asks, her voice soft. Her expression is questioning, but it softens as she speaks and *Adora* softens, her heart hammering.

"I'd love that," she breathes in response, watching all the tension in Catra's body slip away in response. Catra purrs softly, shifting closer and nuzzling against her cheek.

Okay, the second she has a moment alone in the penthouse, she knows what she is doing. She has to, or she is going to blurt out *I love you* over breakfast. Even with Catra staying here, Adora will have some time alone once the semester starts to finally write out the song that has been building in her for three weeks now. When Catra isn't home, she can play it to let out the feelings in her chest. She loves Catra more than words can say, but she can hold it in for a few more days.

Adora tilts her chin up, closing the gap and kissing her. She has to keep her mouth occupied before the truth comes spilling out of it.

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Catra thought she was dreading Sunday because she didn't want to return to the dorm and deal with Lonnie again. That is definitely *true*, but she is going to have to go back there regardless of where she ends up spending most of her time. She still has shit in the dorm, even if none of it is that essential.

And yet Catra finds, as she is laying in bed with Adora the last few nights, that she doesn't want to go back – she doesn't want it to *stop*. It feels weird to ask to stay – part of her says she is being too obvious and vulnerable. Another part says Adora will instantly say yes, given how much and how *blatantly* she has invited Catra into the penthouse. When she manages to forces herself to ask, and the latter is proven right.

She still has to go back to the dorm on Monday. Okay, she doesn't *have* to, but she can't keep running indefinitely. She spent all of Sunday with Adora instead of showing up for move-in, but on Monday she has a two-hour gap between classes. She isn't going back to the penthouse for it, and she doesn't want to lounge in the library avoiding her problems.

She can hear shifting inside as she unlocks the dorm's front door. Lonnie is home. Catra takes a breath to steel herself before she pushes the door open and walks inside. Lonnie is in the kitchenette, a bagel half with cream cheese on it in one hand and the other half covered in strawberry jelly in the other. She blinks at Catra, clearly surprised. Catra's tail twitches uncertainly as she eyes Lonnie. Lonnie, for her part, returns to chewing and swallowing her bite of bagel before slowly and calmly turning around and placing both half-eaten bagel halves on the cutting board.

"I didn't know if you were going to come back," she admits when she turns back around. Her voice is neutral. She glances over towards Catra's bed, still made up with slight wrinkles from when she and Adora made out on top of it what feels like *forever* ago now. Catra's tail lashes once, but she succeeds in not outright glowering at her roommate.

"I pay rent," she points out, starting into the main room. Lonnie is in the kitchen; Catra doesn't have to shoulder past her to get into the main space, but it still feels like that is what she is doing. She expects Lonnie to return to her gross cream-jelly-cheese bagel that she loves so much, but to her surprise, Lonnie *follows* her.

Catra hunches her shoulders as she shrugs off her backpack and drops down into the uncomfortable desk chair that digs into the base of her tail. She can feel Lonnie gearing up behind her. Her fur bristles uncomfortably, waiting for the inquisition. Lonnie isn't cruel or anything, but she has a tendency to *dig*, and there has never been a more sensitive subject matter for her to poke at. After several moments, Lonnie sighs.

"Listen, I googled it afterwards. I saw that she had to make a statement and everything. I didn't realize you were already getting bombarded online. I thought I was teasing you like we normally do," Lonnie tells her. Catra fights the urge to flex her claws, her tail lashing uncomfortably through the gap between the back of the chair and the seat.

It isn't *I'm sorry*, but she and Lonnie have a big fight at least once a semester and they have never apologized with those words before. Catra blows out air, leaning back in her chair and

forcing her shoulders to relax. Lonnie was an asshole, but Catra definitely overreacted, at least on the surface. The truth was that Lonnie was far too right and the mention of sugar *anything* sent Catra into panic mode.

Lonnie was definitely sure she was right - at least when she said it, who knows now she has seen Adora's statement – but she wasn't actually trying to accuse Catra of sex work. Catra glares down at her lap for a long moment. She doesn't want to just forgive and forget, but at the same time she knows it would be way more suspicious if she stayed mad, and she will have plenty of space from Lonnie now that she is staying at Adora's.

She sighs and turns around. Lonnie is standing kind of awkwardly near the foot of her bed. They are both kind of hard asses and apologies were never their thing. Catra looks away and waves her hand vaguely.

"She's my best fucking friend and people make it out to be something else," she says. She has read some of the articles, and especially the *tweets*. It includes speculation about how they met and the relationship. Most people have decided the obvious – Adora pays for her law school, but that is a *recent* development.

As much as Catra doesn't want people to know about her old career, having two years of hard and even traumatizing work being discounted as "Adora paid for it" stings at her pride. She can never correct them, but despite the arrangement, this isn't some superficial thing. She can at least correct Lonnie on *that*. Lonnie relaxes a little, recognizing Catra's words as the acceptance of her apology that they are. She nods, eyeing Catra for a moment.

"I always I thought it was weird you never mentioned who was providing for you, but I get why you wanted to keep that a secret. I recognized her the instant I saw her, even after five years since her last album," Lonnie tells her. Catra bites on her tongue and nods. It may wound her pride, but it is better for Lonnie to think that than the truth. Lonnie seems to realize that Catra still didn't like that, hesitating for a moment.

"I can't believe you managed to stay quiet that you knew her the entire time Kyle was gushing about going to her concert," Lonnie tacks on. Catra, to her own surprise, *laughs*. That had been an incredibly painful afternoon at the time, Catra curled up on her bed and trying to ignore the music filtering from the other side of the room as Kyle, suddenly excited by Adora coming up on his Spotify, began gushing about managing to go see one of her last concerts.

Now, she thinks about Kyle desperately jumping to get a clear look over the crowd until Rogelio picked him up and chuckles, leaning back in her chair again. She knows it probably isn't healthy, but it is a massive ego-boost knowing Adora couldn't give half a shit about some stranger like Kyle going to such lengths to see her – meanwhile, she was practically falling over herself to speak to Catra when she ran into her again.

"If I told Kyle I had slept in the same bed with her, I'm pretty sure he would have passed out. Besides, we fell out of touch for a few years thanks to the music thing. Everything to do with Adora was private. Now people know, I'll mostly be staying at her place," Catra tells her, shrugging as she folds her arms behind her head and grins a little. She wasn't expecting it,

but it feels kind of *good* to brag about Adora. It feels a lot better than dealing with the thorny feelings of her pride and fear, at least. Lonnie snorts, crossing her arms.

“Well thanks for not killing my boyfriend, I guess,” she returns, rolling her eyes. She hovers for a moment more, seemingly assessing Catra before she decides things are okay and gives her a somewhat curt nod. Lonnie turns on her heel and walks back to the kitchenette, returning to her terrible bagel habits that she picked up from her twink boyfriend.

Catra turns back to her desk. That went a lot better than she expected. She feels okay and she thinks they will be alright too. Spending time back at her dorm won’t be as bad as she feared.

--

Catra has late classes on Tuesday and Thursday, the trade-off for not having any morning classes. It turns out to be good for Adora. She has a guaranteed hour, maybe two, to herself twice a week. Adora rushes home after work and goes straight to her piano.

She expects it to take awhile. It can take her days, weeks, or even months to write one song. This one isn’t like that – this one she has *already* been writing for three weeks. She sits down and it flows, an outpouring of everything she has been thinking, feeling, *repressing* for years. She had a melody and some words already, but it comes out even more raw and honest than it was in her head.

She is too caught up to censor herself. She barely manages to stop herself when her phone alarm goes off to warn her that Catra is going to be home soon. One sitting and the lyrics are *done*. The music still needs work – it is her weakness – but she picks up the sheets she has scrawled the contents of her heart across and realizes this is the first song she has ever actually *wanted* to sing for somebody.

She hurries to hide the papers within one of her larger music theory books, but she still can’t stop herself. She returns to the piano, playing just the melody and humming as she waits for the tell-tale dinging of the elevator. She feels better having written it – calmer. Still, the music is calling to her from its hiding spot.

Maybe if she played it for somebody. Not Catra – *obviously* – and if she let any of her friends hear it, they would roast her over an open fire. Hope, then. She doesn’t head back to LA again until after Adora’s birthday. Hope won’t judge or pressure her. Hope will be *level-headed* about this, whereas Glimmer would probably yell at her for being gay.

If she plays it for Hope, she can also finally explain to her adopted guardian what Catra means to her. She never had the words before. She still doesn’t, but she has the lyrics, she has the way her voice *breaks* on a few lines, and she has a heart beating too loudly to keep it all to herself.

She will show it to Hope. Maybe then her chest will fall silent.

--

Adora is watching her sleep. Not that Catra *is* asleep, but she is curled up on the lounge in the conservatory resting. Her chest rumbles with every breath as Adora, lying down beside her, steadily pets down her mane. She is watching where Catra has her cheek pillowed on her chest, soaking in the warmth and safety of Adora beneath her. Catra slits an eye open and watches Adora flush crimson, well aware she is caught. She blinks down at Catra, offering her a sheepish smile as she shifts a hand up to rub at the base of her ears as if in apology.

“Can I take you to dinner this weekend?” Adora asks, still embarrassed. Catra *stares* at her, but Adora just sends her a small smile, equally hopeful and apologetic.

“Like a date?” Catra has to ask, her tail flicking behind her. They did mention *public dates* when they were planning the arrangement, but something about the way Adora asked was vulnerable. Her ears are red as she nods.

“I’ve never been on one,” she admits. Oh. Right. Getting the dating experience without having to actually *date*. Catra forces her tail to still and nods. Adora lights up a little, grinning at her for a moment before leaning down and kissing the top of her head. Catra, despite the reminder of the truth at the exact moment she was starting to *hope*, trills in response. She can’t help that she likes Adora’s affection.

“I wanted to do something that was just us before my birthday,” she elaborates when she pulls back. Catra gives a small nod against her chest. Adora’s birthday is on Tuesday. Birthday parties weren’t allowed at Shadow’s – they encouraged *ego,* according to Shadow – but she and Adora used to always try to do something. Usually it amounted to sneaking out or Catra making some small craft for Adora, but it was their tradition.

It has been ten years. Adora has new traditions, and the fucking Rolls Royce was one of her presents one year. They are going out with all her friends next weekend, and Hope is coming over on her birthday itself to celebrate with her. They have already decided Catra will stay on campus an extra hour so Adora can have some time just with her mom before she comes back and they all have dinner together.

“I’d like that,” Catra agrees. She can just pretend it’s a real date and not Adora *trying it out* or whatever she is actually doing.

--

Adora realizes she is testing boundaries around the time that she steps out of the restaurant with Catra and pulls her in, asking if she can give her a goodnight kiss.

“You’re supposed to do that before we go separate ways, idiot,” Catra pointed out, but they *weren’t* going separate ways, so she lets Adora kiss her on the sidewalk in full view of the velvet-rope line to get into the restaurant. People definitely saw, and maybe they even took pictures, but Adora didn’t *care*. She got to kiss Catra on the sidewalk after a romantic dinner for two. It was one of her *dreams*.

She is trying out just about every aspect of being in a real relationship, and Catra is accepting all of them eagerly. The only thing she is holding back from is saying her feelings, and even that is *barely*. Adora whispers sweet nothings to Catra while they are in bed together and she *loves* it. She can’t help but wonder – but *hope* – what Catra would do if Adora said them outside of the heat of the moment.

If she whispered *you’re beautiful* to Catra when they are laying in bed together in the morning, sunlight dancing across Catra’s fur, what would she do? Would she take it as a compliment? Would she like it? Would she understand all the depth there is to that statement, and if she did, would it make her run away or press closer, curling into her arms and whispering *I love you too, dummy* to her?

Adora has spent so long clouded by fear of her own emotions and guilt over her desires, she has never let herself fully explore them as *possibilities* before. If Catra hadn’t immediately and readily accepted every boundary that Adora has pushed, she still wouldn’t be thinking about it now. She practically crushes Catra against herself before going to work on her birthday, unable to process her emotions and just needing her as close as she can be.

Her coworkers – well, namely Glimmer and Bow – throw a mini birthday party for her in the breakroom, and Adora has a lot of fun with it, but chief on her mind is when she is going to get home. She texts Hope as she leaves work, letting her know to head over, and Adora has barely been home for twenty minutes when her guardian arrives. She has had time to change and prepare her piano, putting her hair up in a half-ponytail to keep it out of her eyes as she plays.

“Happy birthday, Adora. I trust you’ve had a good day-“ Hope greets her, bending to hug her. Adora hugs her quickly, squeezing her close for a moment before she steps back and grabs her hand.

“I have something I need to show you,” she tells her, single-mindedly focused as she drags Hope through the living room and to the stairs. She has been waiting a *week* since she first wrote the song and she can’t stop having realizations. She needs to show it to someone, to let it out of her chest before she blurts out *I love you* at the wrong moment.

“What are you showing me?” Hope asks, changing tracks to accommodate her as Adora guides her up to the study. Hope had to *learn* how to deal with Adora when she gets like this. At first she would try to force Adora to focus, just like Shadow and all her teachers had, but the instant Hope started giving in to Adora’s whims, she found it made them both more productive overall. Let Adora get it out and she may be able to return to her task – force her to “focus” and there is no hope of anything getting done.

Adora doesn’t reply with words, just leading Hope to the couch and sending her an imploring look. Hope, after a moment’s hesitation, sits down. Adora immediately turns and hurries over

to her piano. She glances back at Hope as she settles and sees understanding cross her face as Hope turns a little to be facing her as she plays.

“I’d love to listen to what you have,” Hope promises her. Adora blows out a breath and offers her a small smile, turning back to the keys and resting her hands on them. A performance for Hope isn’t the same thing as a public one, but it still feels noteworthy that her hands don’t shake as she plays the first few notes and then launches into the lyrics.

Hope has heard most of her songs. Adora didn’t start showing them to her until her second album was mostly complete, and Hope realized then how much Adora would have preferred another genre, but they also weren’t about to go through rebranding her when and she was only planning on sticking around for one album.

Adora isn’t that skilled of a lyricist, in general. She has learned a bit from the songwriters she has worked with on adapting the songs Hope bought for her, but she is mostly an amateur. Still, Hope assures her she is above average, and good enough to hire under the right circumstances. Hope avoids giving her any professional critiques after the first time she did it, just trying to help Adora improve, and Adora struggled to hold back tears.

She didn’t want her music polished and perfected – she wanted it to be *hers*. She had already lost so much striving to be a good daughter, a good musician, just *good*. After that, Hope just listened and told her when she liked a particular song. She is a non-judgmental presence Adora can unload her music onto. She might have started writing at sixteen hoping to one day show Hope a song that was good enough she would let her switch genres, but since then it has become a cathartic tool for her.

Adora’s voice cracks three times while singing her song for Catra. She knows she should probably be ashamed of what all the practice and vocal lessons have amounted to, but she doesn’t care. Her heart is pounding against her ribs like a hammer as she plays the last refrain of notes, trailing off into silence. Her shoulders are heaving a little despite the exertion not warranting it as she stares down at the piano in the quiet that fills the room.

Hope says nothing for a long moment.

“Do you want to record it?” she offers into the silence, her words a little rough. Adora’s heart pounds. Hope has never, *ever* offered to record one of her songs. She turns around on the bench to face her. To her shock, Hope’s eyes are watering a little. All the air leaves Adora’s lungs as she looks up to Hope. Hope offers her a small smile.

“I’ve never heard your voice sound like that, Adora,” is the only explanation she offers. Adora’s hands were fine for the performance, but now they shake as she raises them to wrap around herself. She doesn’t know what Hope means by *record*. She doesn’t want to come back to music. That isn’t what this, or even her writing in general, is about. Her music isn’t meant to be seen, it’s there to be *felt*.

“It’s the only way I can explain what she means,” Adora responds. *I don’t want to come back, I want you to understand*. Hope blinks a little rapidly as she nods her understanding.

“I know. Your voice never sounded like that, even at your prime. I would like to be able to listen to it, if you are willing. It reminds me so much of Mara,” Hope assures her. Adora’s hands shake as she clutches her arms, hugging herself. She wishes Catra were here to hold her and stroke her hair, but she can’t be, not when they are talking about *this* song.

Adora swallows, her mind racing. Hope isn’t talking about releasing it, probably. Just booking time in a studio, maybe producing it a bit and recording it for their personal use. She doesn’t know how she could get away with that without Catra knowing. If she were to do it, she would actually want Catra *there*. It would be a chance to replace all the old memories and bad connotations with something she is truly passionate about. It would be reclaiming her childhood before moving on.

If she does this, she is never performing again, no matter the cause. This would be finally closing the door on the most painful chapter of her life. She swallows, looking up to Hope. That is only *if* she does this. The mistiness is starting to clear from Hope’s eyes. Her face is largely blank, but it always is. Apparently she struggled to show emotion even before the Botox.

“I also understand if you want to keep this to yourself. I think you should play it for her, though. It is beautiful. I can’t imagine her reacting badly to a declaration like this,” Hope adds. Her voice is still a bit rough. Adora blinks rapidly, nodding a little. It isn’t agreement, just acknowledgement. It is personal, she wants Hope to be able to have a recording if she likes it that much, and-

And she would have to play it for Catra first. Fuck. Her feelings are already spilling out of her chest as is. Now the thought is planted in her head, she doesn’t know how much longer she can *last*.

“Think about it,” Hope tells her, voice quiet. Adora nods, still staring down at the floor. Oh, she is *definitely* thinking.

--

When Adora asked Catra to give her and Hope a little time to themselves, Catra agreed if only so she didn’t have to hear Adora sing *those songs* for her again. She doesn’t know anything about having a parental figure in her life, and she just assumed one-on-one time with them is a normal thing to want. She is a bit more dubious about that when she returns to the penthouse to find Adora *weird*.

They all have dinner together. Nothing happens, but Adora seems a bit preoccupied. Hope leaves shortly afterwards, wishing Adora happy birthday and hugging her before she goes, and Adora smiles in response, but Catra can’t ignore how quiet she has been all evening. Once they are alone, she takes Adora’s hand without a word and leads her up to her bedroom.

Adora watches her curiously but lets herself be lead without asking any questions. Catra directs her to sit, watching Adora light up a bit when she goes to fetch her coat brush from the vanity. She takes the brush from Catra happily, only blushing a little when Catra pulls off her shirt and stretches out on the bed beside her.

They've had sex enough times at this point that Catra has little concern for being topless or even naked around Adora. She lays down on her back, giving Adora access to her stomach and also giving *herself* a clear view of Adora's face. After a moment's hesitation, in which Adora glances between the brush in her hand and Catra's belly, she shifts on the bed to sit right beside her and begins to run the brush through her fur.

"The visit with Hope went okay?" Catra prompts as, despite herself, her hands begin to knead into the mattress. To her surprise, Adora blushes and smiles a little to herself before glancing up to make eye contact with her.

"I played her some songs and then we went out on the terrace and just kind of reminisced about the better times while I was touring," she explains with a small shrug. Catra blinks at her. Adora hasn't been *distant* or anything, but she has been in one of her quiet moods for most of the evening. Catra worried about what they talked about while alone. She wasn't expecting it to be something that makes Adora smile.

Maybe even the good times are a bit much to recall considering what they are surrounded by. Adora has seemed *happy* all evening, just quiet. She hums to herself as she brushes Catra's stomach, seemingly content as she uses her free hand to pet through the fur she has just softened with the brush. Catra's fur is thick right now thanks to her winter coat and Adora has plenty to pet and brush.

"Good twenty-sixth birthday?" Catra settles on asking her. Adora looks up to meet her eyes again. For a moment, she just watches her, expression softening as she smiles gently at her.

"Yeah," she breathes, "the best."

--

Catra realizes something is up *immediately*, which bodes well for Adora's ability to keep a secret. Still, she can't help herself, getting caught up as she listens to Catra talk or watches her gesture with her hands. Her ears twitch and Adora wants to lean over and kiss them. Catra purrs gently in her arms while they *are* kissing and Adora has to turn the kiss hungry to keep herself from pulling back and spilling out her feelings.

Staying silent was never an option, Adora realizes as she watches Catra sleep on Friday morning. She is actually asleep this time – her ears are twitching and it is before eight AM – and how cute she is when she is totally relaxed is pulling at Adora's heartstrings.

“I love you,” she whispers. One of Catra’s ears – the one closest to her – twitches slightly. The world keeps turning. The words aren’t such a sin that they jolt Catra awake and she storms from the room. Adora feels a little lighter for having spoken them, but she knows this isn’t *sustainable*. She can’t keep whispering her feelings to Catra and hoping she actually is asleep.

Adora reaches out, brushing a lock of Catra’s bangs back out of her face. Catra’s face switches slightly, but she doesn’t stir. Adora understands now why she locked these feelings away. Now she is letting herself know them, they threaten to overwhelm her. She has to tell Catra before she fucks up and lets it slip in a way that might place pressure on her.

She can play her the song. That will be easiest. She can promise her that she can live here and Adora will still pay for her school no matter how she feels about it. The guest room is there, empty and waiting for her, as long as the memory of when they had sex in it doesn’t haunt Catra too much. Adora just has to tell her.

When Catra wakes up, she nuzzles into Adora’s arms and purrs. She lets Adora kiss her ears and run her hands down her back before she forces herself to get out of bed with a reluctant sigh. She has work to go to, but Catra stays in bed with a small smile of contentment on her face. She is *comfortable* in Adora’s bed – their bed.

It is either a good sign, or something Adora is about to ruin. She is afraid to find out which.

--

Adora’s birthday ends up being a small event at what *appears* to be a combination restaurant and club. It has a dancefloor where music is being played at an reasonable volume on the first floor. There is a bar near the dance floor, it looks like, but they are up on the second floor and Catra doesn’t have a clear view. The restaurant looks down on the first floor, with tables and booths for the people with reservations. Waiters roam the area to serve at a whim, in addition to those assigned to tables, and the whole place is just a bit *weird*.

The food is fucking incredible, though, so Catra doesn’t really give a shit. They get a round corner booth and she cuddles into Adora’s side the whole time as the same group from the weekend getaway chats around her. Adora apparently likes having Catra against her side, because she starts feeding Catra her food for her so she doesn’t have to let go of her arm.

It does *wonders* to stroke Catra’s ego. Adora also uses it as an opportunity to steal some of her food, but Catra is willing to make some sacrifices if it means the entire table can see how whipped Adora is for her. Mermista makes *gagging* sounds watching the display and then immediately demands Sea Hawk does the same for her, acting as her “manservant”. Catra cackles when Sea Hawk manages to poke her in the cheek on only his third try.

“Thank you for staying your hand,” Catra tells Adora, sending her wide eyes and grinning as Mermista complains loudly from the other side of the table. Glimmer snorts and Perfuma

giggles, but Adora just looks down at her with soft eyes.

“You know I’m always gentle with you,” she returns, her voice low as she picks up Catra’s fork and holds out another bite for her. Catra flushes a violent shade while Glimmer *boos* in the background.

“Oh hush, it’s cute,” Perfuma chastises her as Mermista and Sea Hawk continue to have their argument. Catra tucks down a bit deeper into Adora’s side, wanting to sink through the floor but not quite capable of phasing through objects at the moment. Adora’s eyes are bright, sending Catra a questioning look that she knows means *was that okay*.

Catra tucks her flushed face into Adora’s shoulder and ignores that way her tail lashes on the seat behind her. Adora knows her tells – she will be able to see that Catra is flustered but not *upset*. Adora shifts her arm out from where Catra was wrapped around it, instead draping it over her back and ducking her head to press a kiss between her ears.

“You staying in there?” she asks, a teasing whisper into her ear. Catra nips at her shoulder in retaliation. *Yes*, she is. Adora’s breath hitches at the bite, but she chuckles and squeezes the arm around Catra’s back. “You can’t eat while hiding in my neck,” she points out. Dammit. With a sigh, Catra pulls back and levels Adora with a glare. Adora just smiles back, her eyes soft.

Catra settles back in against her side and tilts her head up. Still smiling, Adora reaches down for her fork again to get Catra another bite that she takes with only a little bit of grumbling. Adora just looks stupidly fond the entire time.

--

They end up making out in the back seat on the drive back. The Rolls was never Adora’s favourite, but now she is using it pretty much every time she and Catra go out. It is almost inevitable they end up in this position, and Adora doesn’t want to inflict it on Frosta, so the divider between the front and back seat is critical. Adora catches herself humming a melody that she knows well at this point as they kiss.

She draws back, resting their foreheads together and closing her eyes. She focuses on breathing, her heart racing in her chest. Does she really have the courage for this? She still has no idea what Catra will do. She has responded well to everything romantic that Adora has tried, but the arrangement looms heavy over her head.

She doesn’t know why she needs to say it so badly when she already has so much without the words, but the hope is getting to her. She nuzzles against Catra’s cheek, still not opening her eyes, and Catra nuzzles back. Today, Adora tried just *being* how she would act if they were in a relationship, only holding her tongue from the most obvious of comments. Catra responded well. She got flustered, but she never shied away.

Catra tilts her head, kissing Adora's cheek softly before she returns to resting their foreheads together. Adora wants to bite Catra's lip, to call her kitten, to call her *hers*. She wants to tenderly cup her face and tell her she loves her, she always did, she always *will*. She wants to scream, and the closest she can come is singing.

"I want to play something for you when we get home," Adora whispers to her. She swallows. It's too late to take back now. She feels Catra pause, and then she is shifting to kiss Adora's other cheek.

"I'd love to hear it," Catra assures, her voice soft.

Don't be so sure.

--

Adora is nervous as she takes Catra's hand and leads her into the study. Catra could feel her getting nervous on the drive back, but it all clicked into place when she mentioned playing. Adora has *maybe* played some of her original songs while Catra was vaguely around before – she has heard a few songs and melodies coming from the study that she didn't recognize, but that could just mean she didn't know the song – but she has never sat Catra down and played an original for her before.

That is clearly what she is doing now as she pulls the desk chair close to the piano – though still positioned behind the bench – and gestures to it nervously. Catra sits graciously, watching as Adora hurries over to the bookshelf and pulls out a book there.

"I've been working on this for almost two weeks. Well, longer actually, but that's when I started writing it," Adora explains, pulling some sheets of paper out of the book and sending Catra an anxious glance. Catra blinks in surprise, nodding. Adora puts the book away, taking a deep breath before she heads over to the piano and sets up the loose sheets of music. Adora settles on the piano, pushing up the keyboard cover and resting her hands on the keys. Catra watches her take a deep brief before playing a small refrain-

Adora's hands freeze. She heaves a sigh, resting her hands on the keyboard. She turns and sends Catra a bit of a pleading look.

"This is- a lot. I'm going to run through just the music first once before I sing it too, okay?" Adora tells her, but it really feels like she is *asking*. Catra nods, giving Adora her best encouraging smile.

"I don't care if you mess up, Adora. You can always do it again. I'm not an audience, I'm your friend," Catra promises her. Adora blows out a shaky breath.

"That's not what I'm worried about," she admits, quietly, turning back to the keys before Catra has time to be confused. Adora begins playing the same refrain again. Catra settles

back in her chair, closing her eyes and just *listening*. Piano music, on its own, isn't really her thing. She can still acknowledge it is *pretty*, even if it sounds a bit sad to her. She wouldn't choose to listen to it while studying, but echoing through the room, out from Adora? That she enjoys.

She thinks she identifies the end of the song once, but Adora just keeps playing without any pause or beginning to sing, so she must be wrong. She thinks she hears it again, a quiet moment of just a few notes, but Adora just keeps playing.

And then she draws in a breath and begins to sing, her words filling the room.

Oh my blood, once was my own,

But in one touch you made it yours.

What have you done?

Catra swallows. That could be about Shadow, or Hope, or any number of things-

But Adora keeps going.

Yeah I know I went and left you all alone,

Please don't think that I let you go.

I never let go.

'Cause I could touch a hundred thousand souls,

But none of them would ever feel like home.

And no matter how far and wide I roam,

You're the only one I'll ever know.

I don't belong to anyone else.

--

The song is repetitive. The chorus, the refrain, they all repeat, but they *have* to. It hammers in the circles she has run in, mentally exhausting herself until she can't hold back, can't *lie* any

longer. She sings to Catra, but then also to Hope and to Shadow, who tried to mold her into the shape they wanted but she didn't *fit* in because she was never theirs to define. She had given herself away and made Catra a part of her long ago.

Her shoulders shake as she plays the final refrain. She missed a few beats here and there and her voice cracked apart on those same three points it did before, but it didn't sound *bad*, just emotional. Raw. Her hands still on the keys and then fall into her lap as silence fills the room. If she turned her head just a little, she could see Catra's face. She doesn't.

Catra's breathing is a bit laboured behind her. Adora's hands tremble in her lap. She swallows, feeling a bit lightheaded as she waits.

"Adora…" Catra breathes, her voice soft but *wrecked*. Adora flinches, hunching her shoulders and wrapping her arms around herself- "Stop that, princess," Catra orders her, voice just as soft as before. The chair creaks and then Catra's arms are wrapping around her. Catra plasters against her back, squeezing her like a vice as she presses a gentle kiss to the top of her head, her breath still shaking. Adora is either going to scream, cry, or pass out. She needs Catra to say something.

"If you don't feel the same-" Adora manages to get out, her voice shaking. Catra squeezes her arms tighter, threatening to squeeze the life out of her, and Adora falls silent. She had a whole fucking *speech* planned about how this was no pressure. They could keep up the arrangement or stop it and Adora will keep paying for her school. They could add limits. Catra could stay in her bed or shift up to the guest bedroom.

Adora can't say any of it. Catra releases another trembling breath against her.

"I do, Adora," she whispers. Adora's heart stops. Shakily, she tries to twist around on the bench. The lightheadedness isn't helping, but she needs to see Catra's face, to know that she really means it like Adora does. When she meets Catra's eyes, she finds them laced with tears. Her expression is open and raw, somewhat stunned still as she stares down at Adora and offers her a trembling smile. Adora's chest is pounding like a drum now.

"I love you," she breathes, because she never put the words into the song itself. Catra spasms a little, tears pricking fresh against her eyes as she breaks out into a trembling smile.

"I love you too, dummy. I always did," she returns. Adora reaches up, her hands shaking as she frames Catra's face and guides her down into a kiss, messy and wet with the tears on their cheeks, but still *perfect*.

Chapter End Notes

Lyrics via the official video description on Rise Records' upload of the music video (also linked in the fic). For a piano/instrumental version (I couldn't find any that were piano-focused with the lyrics), check here.

Anyone Else

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"How long?" Catra asks Adora when they're lying in bed together that night. They have cried, and kissed, and very nearly *fucked*, but they were both a little strung out for that. They ended up mostly naked anyway, curling around each other in the bed as they kissed. Adora kept whispering *I love you* into her lips as Catra struggled not to start crying again.

"Years? It was a long process. I think it was *always*, even if I only realized recently," Adora admits. Catra pauses, pulling back to blink at Adora. Adora blinks at her, blushing a little and offering her a small, hopeful smile. Catra narrows her eyes at her girlfriend.

"*When*," she intones, watching Adora's flush darken in splotches as she quickly looks away. She tightens her arms around Catra, as if to keep her from pulling away.

"I've known I had a crush on you since I was eighteen," she says, a *dodge*. Catra snaps her tail forward to smack against Adora's thigh and Adora huffs, finally making eye contact again. Her cheeks are *blazing*. "I realized it was love when we first had sex, okay? I was repressing it and-" Adora starts, defensive. She has the right to be considering Catra bursts out laughing.

Adora huffs, pouting as she pulls Catra closer and pinches her shoulder lightly. Catra forces herself to suppress her laughter down to snickering, sending Adora an unimpressed look. Adora continues to pout as Catra leans forward to kiss the bridge of her nose. Adora, despite herself, lets out a small, happy sound and leans forward into it. When Catra pulls back, she smirks at Adora. Adora musters a petulant expression again.

"Well, when did *you* realize?" she asks. She sounds a bit smug about the question, as if she expects it to be a *victory*. Catra only smirks wider, her tail thumping against the bed in satisfaction.

"I decided I wanted to marry you when we were *eight*, Adora," Catra returns, watching Adora freeze from how *stunned* she is, blinking at her slowly. Catra is stupidly fond of this idiot. It took her seventeen more years to realize it than Catra needed, but she got there eventually, and Catra doesn't doubt her sincerity. You don't make a declaration like *that* about something you are unsure of – at least Adora doesn't. She reaches a hand up, stroking Adora's cheek as the shock wears off and is just replaced by *softness*.

"I love you so much," Adora breathes. Catra's fur stands a little on end, her tail thudding against the bed as a rumbling purr begins in her chest.

"I love you too," she returns. Adora lights up, just like she has every time Catra has said it. In the blink of an eye, they are kissing again.

--

Adora is so glad she got her shit together on Saturday night because it gives them all the time in the world together on Sunday morning. Adora wakes up to Catra grooming her chest – she is still in just her underwear from last night, and Catra is in *nothing* – swiping her tongue in long strokes over her sternum until she realizes Adora is awake. Catra blinks at her for a moment before she nuzzles lower down, looking up to make eye contact with Adora.

She grins right before she takes Adora's nipple in her mouth and laves her tongue roughly over it. Adora gasps out, her head tilting back as she arches up into the attention. Catra *purrs*, the vibrations running straight into her nipple and causing Adora to whimper. The sensation is so *much* this early in the morning, leaving her struggling a bit for her air. Catra releases her chest with a slick *pop*, shifting up a little to grin down at her.

"Good morning, beautiful," she purrs. Adora flushes, a bit stunned as she stares up at her. They can say shit like that now, but she still wasn't expecting it. She swallows as the fact that she is *allowed* permeates through her body. Without thinking about it, she reaches up and wraps her arms around Catra, pulling her in and kissing her.

"I love you. You're so gorgeous when you're sleeping," Adora murmurs to her, between kisses. Catra chuckles, but she keeps kissing her back as Adora threads a hand through her hair.

"Creep," she accuses, between kisses, before nipping gently at Adora's lower lip. Adora gasps, then hums, accepting both the bite and the title. If watching Catra sleep is creepy, then she's a creep. Catra is too *adorable* to resist.

"You're all relaxed, and your *ears* twitch when you're dreaming. Your claws flex a little too. And sometimes you purr, all content," Adora streams out, having kept it in for far too long. Catra flushes and seems to decide she needs to shut her up. She surges forward and kisses Adora. Adora smiles into it, wrapping her arms around Catra's back and humming again. She can't help it – she's *happy* and, despite trying several times over the years, she lacks the vocal folds to purr. Humming is the best she has.

"I love you," she breathes the next time they part for air. Sure, it has been all of thirty seconds since she last said it, but she still needs to say it again. Catra trills, ducking her face down and hiding it in Adora's neck. She nips there lightly, her tail lashing behind her from her fluster.

"I love you too, idiot," Catra mutters. Adora grins, bending her head a little to kiss the top of Catra's head. Apparently Catra doesn't want to acknowledge how flustered she has gotten from just a few sentences, because she sneaks a hand between them and pinches Adora's nipple between her fingers. Adora gasps.

Well, if it's going to be like *that*.

--

They turn sex into a competition, somehow, and if that isn't the most *them* thing they've ever done, Catra doesn't know what is. She works her way down Adora's body, nipping and sucking and *licking*. Adora threads her hands through her mane, watching her through lidded eyes and spilling forth praise and fucking *sweet nothings*. They are both trying to take the other apart in very different ways.

"Fuck, you're the most beautiful thing in this world. I don't care if it's a cliché," Adora tells her, tightening her grip in her hair as Catra's eyes fall closed and she whines into the bruise she is leaving on the underside of Adora's breast. Adora is going to *feel* it when she puts her sports bra on, which is Catra's goal – to leave a mark that Adora can feel all day, reminding her who she belongs to.

Catra is worshipping her physically, with her mouth and hands, but Adora praises her like she has a goddess on top of her. Catra squeezes Adora's thighs in her hands as she finally releases her chest, dropping her forehead to rest on her ribcage. She just needs to take a moment to *breathe*. Her tail is lashing behind her as Adora's hand in her hair softens, shifting a little to rub at her scalp with the pads of her fingers.

"I always wanted this with you. I daydreamed about it, sometimes," Adora tells her, still massaging her gently. Catra whines again, shifting a little to press a soft kiss against Adora's abs before she shifts her hands, dragging them slowly *in* until she can push Adora's thighs open and settle firmly between them, her face still buried in Adora's stomach. Adora gasps softly as Catra walks her fingers up to meet her.

"I, ah, always love the way you touch me. I didn't know I would even *like* this until you did it," Adora tells her. Catra nips at her abs lightly as she sets to work over her clit, ramping up the pressure steadily as Adora gives soft, broken off moans and flexes down into the touch that is quickly turning harsh. Adora's hand in her hair tightens, but Catra suspects that is completely unconscious.

"I love touching *you*. Seeing you lost in pleasure, the way you *writhe* when you really get into- *fuck*," Adora cuts off as Catra nips her and latches on, sucking a bruise against her side. Catra's tail is lashing behind her and she is kind of soaking, but Adora is going to come *first*. Adora whines softly, flexing her hips up into Catra's hand.

"You're everything I dreamed you'd be," Adora manages, her voice breathless. It takes Catra *out*, causing her to release Adora's side and whine, quickly burying her face in her girlfriend's warmth. That sentence is so *much*, implies so many dreams that yes, Adora already admitted to having, but it still turns Catra's breath shaky as she works her fingers against Adora.

Adora finally seems satisfied with her praises, or maybe she is just too worked up to do more than moan and gasp as Catra works her over. She hasn't been touching her long, but the room has smelled of her desire ever since she first woke up. Catra has been leaving nips and

bruises across her body for a while now and that drives her wild enough on its own. It doesn't take much longer, Adora shifting up into her touch and sighing, gasping, moaning *her name*.

"*Catra*," is the last thing she breathes before she tenses and begins whining. Catra immediately stills her hand, holding it steady for Adora to flex her hips up into to get *enough* without Catra accidentally hurting her when she is oversensitive from her orgasm. Adora likes it rough, but after she comes it can be too much. They are still finding the balance. When Adora touches herself, it is easy to know what is too much, but Catra has to learn her still.

"Right here, princess. I've got you. I've always got you," Catra assures, kissing her ribs as Adora pants out a soft whimper. Her body goes lax beneath Catra, though she is still panting a little as Catra shifts up and curls into her side, surrounding her without crushing her. Adora wraps her arms around her weakly, seemingly happy to cradle her as she comes back to herself.

"You're amazing," Adora says, a bit nonsensically. Catra snorts, turning her head to look up at Adora from her spot on her chest. To her surprise, Adora is gazing down at her with that soft, loving expression that can only mean she is completely serious. Catra flushes, feeling her ears twitch as she quickly tucks into Adora's neck.

"I love you too. Now just enjoy it," Catra orders her. Adora hums, apparently happy to comply.

--

Adora gets to return the favour. Catra lets her roll them over and touch her, slowly working her over while she whispers how *grateful* she is for this into Catra's fur. She gets to see Catra do that writhe she loves so much until they are both spent, curled in the bed together as Catra's chest rolls with her content, post-orgasm purr. Eventually Catra yawns, loud and raspy, and Adora decides it is time for her to get a shower in.

"You can nap," Adora assures her girlfriend, pressing a kiss against her forehead. She is *trying* to slip from the bed, but Catra is doing a pretty effective job of pinning her down by clinging to her. Catra grumbles even as she nuzzles into the touch.

"Don't want you to go," she mumbles, nipping gently at Adora's shoulder. Adora's chest bursts with love as she gazes down at the magicat on her chest.

"I love you, but I don't think you want to get in the water with me either," Adora points out, reaching up to ruffle her ears. Catra turns her head, nipping half-heartedly at Adora's hand and missing by several inches. She growls lowly as she leans down to mark Adora's jaw.

"Don't assume," she returns. Adora blinks at her in surprise.

That is how they end up in the shower together. Catra is clingy, wrapping around Adora and showing her fangs to the spray of water as if to intimidate it, but she lets Adora lead her under it once it has warmed up. She actually begins to *purr* once Adora is cradling her in the steamy shower, apparently unbothered as long as she is warm and being held.

“Better?” Adora asks, pressing a soft kiss against Catra’s damp ear, despite the smell of wet fur. Catra grumbles a little, but she nuzzles against Adora in turn.

“Let’s get this over with. It takes my marks away,” Catra complains. It shouldn’t make Adora so happy- actually, fuck that, Catra is her real girlfriend now and Adora can be as happy as she wants that Catra doesn’t like her scent marks washing off Adora.

“Of course,” Adora agrees, holding her tighter for a moment before she reaches over for Catra’s fur shampoo. She kind of loves the intimacy of working Catra’s products into and out of her fur, warmth and steam surrounding them as Catra eagerly presses into her touch and nuzzles into her embrace. When they step out of the shower, Adora insists on brushing and blow-drying Catra’s coat out herself.

Catra seems happy to luxuriate in the pampering, but the moment Adora is done, she pounces and sets to refreshing her scent marks.

--

Catra is lying on the lounge in the conservatory, watching Adora as she texts excitedly with her friends. She asked if she could tell people about them before she pulled her phone out, so Catra assumes she is texting Glimmer and Bow. She has a thousand-watt grin on her face as she texts, though she occasionally rolls her eyes or huffs as she no doubt gets ribbed.

Catra is just looking. If Adora can watch her sleep, she can watch her text. She likes seeing her girlfriend so *happy* over her feelings. Catra’s tail is swaying behind her as she watches Adora. She is sprawled out as if to nap, but she isn’t tired. They didn’t get out of bed until it was noon, and Catra may be a napper, but she doesn’t sleep *all day*.

Adora smiles softly down at her phone and Catra pretends her ears don’t twitch in response. Adora bites her lip, seeming torn, and then she looks up and blinks in surprise to find Catra watching her. Catra blinks back, slow and content in her position. After a moment, Adora smirks a little.

“Creep,” she points out. Catra rolls her eyes and doesn’t move anything but her ears, twitching them back to send Adora an unimpressed look. Adora smiles a little, reaching out and petting the top of her head between her ears. Catra let her eyes slip closed, just enjoying Adora’s hand in her hair for a moment. Adora stills her hand, squeezing lightly in a silent request. Reluctantly, Catra opens her right eye and peers up at Adora, twitching the same ear forward as well.

The look is *I'm listening, but I want to go back to petting*. Adora smiles softly, shifting her hand to scratch behind Catra's raised ear, immediately prompting her tail to start swaying again as she lifts them both up. Adora's expression is soft and fond as she gives Catra the attention she wants.

"Hope wants me to record the song," she says, immediately flooring Catra. Catra stares at her, wide-eyed and feeling the slight burn of her pupils narrowing just a little too quickly. Adora seems surprised, titling her head a little. "You don't want me to?" she asks, sounding a bit confused, but at least she isn't put out. Catra swallows, her tail thudding against the side of the lounger.

"Why *would* you? I thought you wanted to put the music industry behind you," Catra asks. She is trying not to sound accusatory, but they have had such a good few weeks and she would hate to have that *ruined*. She knows Adora had some good times during her career, but all the stories made it seem like that was *in spite of* music. Adora pauses, then shakes her head. Her hand has gone a bit limp against Catra since she first startled her with this bombshell.

"I wrote that song for you, and to process myself. It's not for the public, but I do want to finish it, and I'm not producer. Hope has the connections to let me record it even with no intent to release it," Adora explains, a bit haltingly. Catra draws in a slow breath, considering her girlfriend. It makes sense. Adora clearly poured her heart into that song, and if she feels it is unfinished, she understands getting help with it. It worries her, but if this is what Adora wants, she'll support her for it.

"Okay. I just worry about you feeling pressured to come back," Catra agrees, her ears pinning back with the admittance. Adora looks down at her, her eyes soft as she shifts her hand to pet over Catra's mane again. She has a small smile on her face, seemingly touched.

"I kind of want to go back into the studio and make *good* memories there. Reclaim it. Make something selfish and never let the public see it. I'm happy where I am now," Adora promises her. Catra draws in a sharp breath, staring up at Adora's loving expression. Her words are *loaded*. "I'm happy with you," she adds, in a small whisper.

Catra's heart threatens to burst through her chest to do a victory lap around the entire island of Manhattan. She pushes herself up to wrap her arms around Adora's shoulders and kisses her with all the emotion in her chest.

--

Adora's phone is still buzzing intermittently as the group chat tears her to pieces, but she is mostly ignoring it now.

So I told Catra I love her and she said it back.

Mermista

IT HAS BEEN TWO MONTHS

Perfuma

Congratulations Adora! I'm so glad you have found someone who matches your aura so well

Glimmer

I FUCKING TOLD YOU. I TOLD YOU, YOU STUPID LESBIAN

The roasting is only multiplied by the members of the chat knowing different things about the details of their relationship, so the whole thing is a clusterfuck, and she would much rather just make out with Catra. As they settle in for lunch, entire inches between them for the first time all day, Catra pauses and tilts her head, staring off into the distance.

"The arrangement," she prompts, looking back to Adora. Adora just stares back, waiting for the rest. Catra sighs, rolling her eyes. "What happens to it now that I'm actually just your girlfriend?" she asks, giving Adora a pointed look. Adora pauses. She thinks she knows what Catra is getting at, but she also doesn't want to disrupt anything if she doesn't have to.

"You're my trophy wife," she returns, offering Catra a smile. It makes Catra smile at least, chuffing and rolling her eyes. She tries to look exasperated, but she is blushing.

"Not yet, I'm not," she points. Adora feels herself brighten, humming happily at the way Catra just *accepts* the long-term intent of the statement. Catra flicks her tail against Adora's legs, but after a moment her smile settles into a serious expression. "You're not paying me for anything anymore, Adora," she points out, raising a brow at her. Adora frowns. She doesn't know why that matters.

"I'm going to keep paying for your things, Catra. Partners support each other. I want you to be able to focus on law, and I promised," Adora points out. Catra doesn't like that answer. She frowns and looks away, her tail twitching tensely. Right. Catra's pride. Adora *gets it*, Shadow always told her she was nothing and she feels the need to prove herself, but Adora also couldn't take not helping her. "Listen, I respect your old career, but my jealousy and guilt couldn't take watching you return to it," Adora adds, her voice soft.

She is pretty sure Catra doesn't want to hear that either, but it's the truth. Catra worked hard for her money – from the things she has implied, Adora fears she was a bit traumatized by the work – but Adora doesn't want her to work like that *anymore*, not when she could easily take care of her. Catra is silent, frowning into the distance for a long moment.

"No gifts," she says. Adora blinks at her, confused. She doesn't know what that means. Catra turns back to her, sighing when she catches Adora's expression. "Partners support each other

through school, sure, *fine*. I still have fucking pride, Adora. I want to earn the things that I have. No more cufflinks or suits or anything else. Just my expenses," Catra explains, gesturing a bit wildly with her hand. Her claws are out.

Adora bites her lip. That is *reasonable*, even if all she wants to do with every cent she has is pamper Catra. Catra has a line, and she can respect that. What she really cares about at the end of the day is that Catra is safe, happy, and provided for. She is allowing Adora to keep doing that much. It isn't like they had *anything* growing up together anyway, and they still showed their love for each other without the need for gifts.

"… Can I still buy you flowers?" Adora asks. Catra's ears twitch, along with the corner of her mouth as she blushes and looks away. Catra heaves a dramatic sigh.

"I *guess*," she agrees, like she is acquiescing to a big request. She is smiling. Adora squeaks a little, half-standing from her seat to lean over and hug her girlfriend. Catra purrs, her tail flicking happily as she raises her arms and hugs Adora back. "You're a big fucking sap," Catra accuses, her voice warm. Adora hums, pressing a kiss against her forehead.

"Yours, though," she points out. She grins as Catra flushes crimson in response.

--

Catra watches Adora, hunched over the panel of a thousand sliders and switches that Netossa is using. Apparently Adora used to work with her wife and the woman has a very different personal sound that Hope thought was a better fit for the new song. They'll record it and then Adora will have a personal master of the song. Hope had asked her what she wanted to do with the song and Adora's response was *keep it*.

Catra had tensed at Adora's side, expecting Hope to fight her on it. Instead, Hope just nodded and launched into the logistics of getting Adora into a studio with one of her producers with no intent to release the single. They can't use her old studio, it is only for those signed to Hope's label, but there are other studios that *aren't* in LA they can use. Hope paid for Netossa to fly out to produce the song.

Adora was anxious about handing over her song to Netossa, but Netossa pointed out that they can just do whatever they want without needing to worry about producing a song that will do well on the radio. If Adora doesn't like something, she has complete veto control. Adora's face set with determination and they immediately set to work on the other instruments and the music. Catra watches them. Occasionally Adora gets excited about something and looks up to her.

Every time, Catra smiles and rises from her seat, tucking into Adora's side as Adora wraps an arm around her and excitedly explains the changes to the song. The lyrics never change – it isn't Netossa's department, and she seems to know that is a line she can't cross anyway – but

after a weekend in the studio, they walk out with a finished song, produced and layered and kind of *devastating*.

Adora beams with pride, overjoyed to have finally done this on *her* terms. Five years ago, she fled music with an open wound. As Catra watches her greet Frosta back at the car with a grin, Catra can't help but feel like today she finally stitched it closed.

--

Catra does *mostly* live at the penthouse – she spends most of her time out of class there, and she sleeps there almost every day – but occasionally she spends more time on campus or crashes there. Adora gets off work to a text from Catra that she will be ready to leave campus in probably another hour. Of course Adora offers to pick her up. It is a fifty-fifty chance if Catra will let her, but this time Catra agrees.

Adora can hear voices inside as she knocks on the dorm door. Another student had taken one glance at her and let her in, so she didn't bother to text Catra when she arrived. Catra knows she is coming, but it is still a *little* surprise. Adora will take them where she can get them considering she isn't allowed to spend money on Catra anymore outside of necessities.

When the door opens, Catra's voice filters in clearly above the others as she throws a barb at Lonnie. Adora is face to face with a short blonde twink, but her gaze skates right over him as his eyes go wide and he squeaks. Over his shoulder, Adora can see that Catra is lounging on her bed, grinning in Lonnie's direction. Their friendship seems to be very antagonistic, but they get along beneath it all. A lizardfolk is sitting on Lonnie's bed as Lonnie sits at her desk, so Adora assumes that is Rogelio.

The blonde – Kyle, *definitely* – begins stammering, but Adora ignores him. She doesn't know how she could pay any attention to him when Catra lights up upon seeing her, raising her arms up from the bed in blatant invitation. Adora breezes through the door, grinning herself as she quickly crosses the room and climbs up onto the bed, reaching for Catra and cuddling her close against her chest. Catra's tail sways beneath her as she nuzzles into Adora, purring instantly.

Adora's chest feels like it is bursting as she cradles Catra against her chest, but Catra also made her promise not to make any more undying love declarations in public after Adora flustered the hell out of her while they were out shopping in SOHO. Adora presses a kiss against her temple, smiling when Catra butts her head up into it.

"My soft kitten," Adora murmurs to her, kissing her again. She says it low, but Catra still flushes scarlet as Lonnie begins cackling on the other side of the room. Catra makes a noise, a confused *mrrp* with a growl in the middle of it, but she doesn't pull back, quickly burying her face in Adora's neck. She swats Adora with her tail in the process – or maybe she is just lashing it wildly.

“That *counts*,” she hisses, despite how she is purring. Adora chuckles, kissing the top of her head before she pulls Catra in tighter against her chest. Okay, yes, probably, but it wasn’t in the *letter of the rule*, so she maintains it was fair usage. Lonnie is still trying to recover from her laughing fit and Adora is pretty sure Kyle is still standing by the door, stunned, but she doesn’t particularly care.

All that matters to her is that Catra in her arms, cuddling her close despite her protests.

--

Catra is looking forward to when spring finally settles in and starts thawing the city. There is still plenty of warmth down on the city streets from the bustle and heat working up through the sidewalk grates, but up here on the rooftop, the winds and cold in the air make a coat a necessity every time she wants to go out on the terrace.

She still *goes*. She wraps her coat tightly around herself and goes up to the third story terrace, heading over to the privacy fencing to look out over it. Frost is all around her, but she is dressed in sweats and warm slippers on top of her coat, so she can deal with it. Adora should be home soon to warm her up, anyway. Catra just came out here on a whim, wanting to look out over the city.

Sometimes she still can’t believe she is here, living above New York City, studying her passion and returning home to the arms of the woman she loves. Law school is stressful as hell, but in a way, she doesn’t have a care in the world. If something goes wrong, it is a setback, but it doesn’t doom her to a life of not being able to afford her next meal.

Her worries these days are just her homework and hissing at any fans who recognize Adora on the street. Catra has been able to ensure she hasn’t had a fan interaction – outside of Kyle nearly passing out upon being in the same room as her, anyway – since they began dating. Catra doesn’t have to worry about finding enough clients to make her payments, or what those clients may *do*. She can just crawl into Adora’s arms at the end of the day.

Her ears twitch as she hears a door slam on the lower level. She pauses, glancing down at her watch – an old gift from a client, but she still quite likes it – and sees that it is around the time Adora should be home.

“Up here!” Catra calls over her shoulder before turning back to the cityscape. After a few moments of silence and the wind rushing around her, the door from the conservatory opens and she hears the footfalls of Adora’s boots. Catra is still staring out at the city skyline when Adora presses up against her back, nuzzling against her and pressing a soft kiss against the base of her ear.

“Hey, Adora. Have a good day, beautiful?” Catra purrs to her, earning a happy hum of affirmation. Catra smiles to herself as she turns in Adora arms, gazing up at her fondly.

Adora's expression is melted with affection, her arms wrapping around Catra and holding her close.

"Good enough. This is the best part of it," she tells her before leaning in to kiss her. Catra blushes – it's fucking *cheesy*, but it turns out Adora is just like that in a relationship – but she kisses Adora back, purring a little as she relaxes into Adora's embrace. She always feels comfortable here.

It makes sense for Adora to be safe. Her arms are home.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for coming along for this ride of a fic! I've been wanting to write it for like five months, but it's finally done. Fic notes can be found on my tumblr!
My next big fic (I'm going to do some edits to an old one first) probably won't start for another week, but it's going to be In Service of Her Majesty, my "Historical" Arranged Marriage AU.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!